

The Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines

Ārya-aṣṭasāhasrikā-prajñāpāramitā · Toh 12 · Derge Kangyur

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The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines (Sanskrit:

Āryāṣṭasāhasrikāprajñāpāramitā; Tibetan: Phags pa shes rab kyi pha rol tu phyin pa brgyad stong pa) is one of the foundational scriptures of the Mahāyāna. It is a sūtra that presents the bodhisattva path through the perfection of wisdom, the understanding of the emptiness of all phenomena, and describes how bodhisattvas should practice, what they should realize, and how this wisdom relates to the other perfections. It opens in the traditional manner, with the Buddha teaching at Rājagṛha on Vulture Peak before a great assembly of arhats. The text is Toh 12 in the Kangyur, belonging to the Prajñāpāramitā class of sūtras, and it is widely regarded as the oldest and most central of the Perfection of Wisdom scriptures, standing as the basis from which many longer and shorter versions were developed.

In the language of India: Ārya-aṣṭasāhasrikā-prajñāpāramitā. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines. First volume.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas, and to all the noble hearers and solitary buddhas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling at Rājagṛha, on the mountain called the Vulture Peak, together with a great community of monks, twelve hundred and fifty monks. All of them were arhats, with defilements exhausted, free from affliction, masters of their minds, their minds fully liberated and their wisdom fully liberated, of noble lineage, great elephants. They had done what was to be done, accomplished their task, laid down their burden, attained their own aim, and utterly exhausted the fetters that bind to existence. Through perfect knowing their minds were completely freed, and they had reached the far shore of supreme mastery over all mind. All of them were of this kind, with the exception of one person, namely the venerable Ānanda.

Then the Blessed One addressed the elder, the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, taking as your subject the perfection of wisdom of the bodhisattvas, the great

beings, speak with confident eloquence, so that the bodhisattvas, the great beings, will come to go forth definitively in the perfection of wisdom.

Then the venerable Śāriputra thought: Will the venerable Subhūti, through the power of his own eloquent wisdom, generating it by himself and empowering it, teach the perfection of wisdom of the bodhisattvas, the great beings? Or is it through the power of the Buddha?

Then, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Subhūti knew in his mind this very thought in the mind of the venerable Śāriputra, and said to the venerable Śāriputra: Venerable Śāriputra, whatever the Blessed One's hearers speak, teach, explain, expound, clarify, and thoroughly clarify, all of it should be understood as the power of the Tathāgata, the supreme person. Why is that? When they train in the Dharma taught by the Tathāgata, they realize the nature of reality directly and hold it. Having directly realized and grasped that nature of reality, whatever they declare, teach, explain, expound, clarify, and thoroughly clarify, all of it is in no way contrary to the nature of reality. Venerable Śāriputra, sons of good family such as these, who explain the nature of reality in this way without contradicting it, are also in accord with the causes of the Dharma taught by the Tathāgata.

Then, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, you have declared: Subhūti, taking as your subject the perfection of wisdom of the bodhisattvas, the great beings, speak with confident eloquence, so that the bodhisattvas, the great beings, will come to go forth definitively in the perfection of wisdom. Blessed One, when one says "bodhisattva, bodhisattva," what is this word "bodhisattva," Blessed One, a designation for? Blessed One, I do not truly see, as an actual phenomenon, any dharma that is called "bodhisattva."

Blessed One, that dharma called the perfection of wisdom, too, I do not truly see as an actual phenomenon. Blessed One, I neither apprehend nor find, nor truly see, either a bodhisattva or the dharma of a bodhisattva; and the perfection of wisdom, too, I neither apprehend nor find nor truly see. Since this is so, which bodhisattva is to be instructed and taught in which perfection of wisdom?

And yet, Blessed One, if, when this is spoken, taught, and explained, the bodhisattva, the great being, is not discouraged in mind, not utterly disheartened, not timid, and does not become faint-hearted; if the mind does not turn back from this, is not broken, and does not retreat; if one is not

terrified, not utterly afraid, and does not come to be possessed of fear, then this itself is how the bodhisattva, the great being, is to be taught in the perfection of wisdom. This itself is to be recognized as the perfection of wisdom of that bodhisattva, that great being. This itself is the instruction in the perfection of wisdom. If one abides in this way, that very thing is the instruction and the teaching of this bodhisattva.

Blessed One, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, who practices the perfection of wisdom and cultivates the perfection of wisdom, should train in such a way that he does not become conceited even about this awakening mind. Why is that? Because that mind is no mind; the intrinsic nature of mind is luminosity.

Then the venerable Śāriputra said this to the venerable Subhūti: Venerable Subhūti, does that mind which is no mind exist?

When he had said this, the venerable Subhūti said this to the venerable Śāriputra: Venerable Śāriputra, with respect to that very state of no-mind, is there existence or non-existence in it? Can either be found or apprehended?

Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, that is not so.

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, if in that no-mind neither existence nor non-existence is present or apprehended, then, venerable Śāriputra, how could your challenge, when you asked, "Does that mind which is no mind exist?", be reasonable?

When he had said this, the venerable Śāriputra said this to the venerable Subhūti: Venerable Subhūti, then what is that very no-mind?

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, that no-mind is changeless and free of conceptual thought.

Then the venerable Śāriputra gave his approval to the venerable Subhūti, saying "Excellent!": Venerable Subhūti, excellent, excellent! Just as the Blessed One declared you to be supreme among those who abide in freedom from affliction, so you teach well.

Therefore, too, the bodhisattva, the great being, should be understood as irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And it should be understood that the bodhisattva, the great being, is never separated from the perfection of wisdom.

One who wishes to train in the stage of the hearers, too, should listen to this very perfection of wisdom, take it up, hold it, recite it, thoroughly understand it, and study it aloud. One should train in this very perfection of wisdom and apply oneself to it in practice.

One who wishes to train in the stage of the solitary buddhas, too, should listen to this very perfection of wisdom, take it up, hold it, recite it, thoroughly understand it, and study it aloud. One should train in this very perfection of wisdom and apply oneself to it in practice.

One who wishes to train in the stage of the bodhisattvas, too, should listen to this very perfection of wisdom, take it up, hold it, recite it, thoroughly understand it, and study it aloud. Endowed with skillful means, one should apply oneself in practice to this very perfection of wisdom, in order to attain all the qualities of a bodhisattva. Why is this so? Because all the qualities of a bodhisattva in which the bodhisattva, the great being, should train and apply himself in practice are taught extensively in this very perfection of wisdom.

One who wishes to train in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, too, should listen to this very perfection of wisdom, take it up, hold it, recite it, thoroughly understand it, and study it aloud. Endowed with skillful means, one should apply oneself in practice to this very perfection of wisdom, in order to attain all the qualities of a buddha. Why is this so? Because all the qualities of a buddha in which the bodhisattva, the great being, should train and apply himself in practice are taught extensively in this very perfection of wisdom.

Then the venerable Subhūti addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, this very name "bodhisattva" I do not find, I do not apprehend, I do not perceive in truth. The perfection of wisdom, too, I do not find, I do not apprehend, I do not perceive in truth. Blessed One, if I neither find nor apprehend nor perceive in truth this name "bodhisattva," and likewise neither find nor apprehend nor perceive in truth the perfection of wisdom, then what bodhisattva am I to counsel and instruct, and in what perfection of wisdom? Blessed One, since I neither find nor apprehend nor perceive in truth any real entity, to apply and designate the mere name, "bodhisattva," as I do, is a hindrance weighing upon my heart.

Yet, Blessed One, that name too is neither abiding nor not abiding, and it is neither separate from abiding nor not separate from abiding. Why is that? Because that name does not exist. Thus that name neither abides nor does not abide, and it is neither separate from abiding nor not separate from abiding.

Blessed One, when the perfection of wisdom, so profound, is explained, taught, and expounded in this way, the mind of the bodhisattva, the great being, does not become stiff, does not become dejected, does not become anxious, does not become timid. His mind does not turn back or recoil from it. He is not alarmed and not terrified, and does not become possessed by dread. Such a bodhisattva, a great being, who has faith through lofty intention, should be understood as not separated from the perfection of wisdom. He abides on the stage of the irreversible bodhisattva, and he abides well in the manner of not abiding.

Blessed One, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, who practices the perfection of wisdom and cultivates the perfection of wisdom, does not abide in form. Likewise he does not abide in feeling, nor in perception, nor in formations, nor in consciousness. Why is that?

If he were to abide in form, he would be engaging in the mental construction of form, and would not be practicing the perfection of wisdom. Likewise, if he were to abide in feeling, perception, and formations, and if he were to abide in consciousness, he would be engaging in the mental construction of consciousness, and would not be practicing the perfection of wisdom.

Why is that? If he engages in mental construction, he does not take hold of the perfection of wisdom, he does not apply himself in yoga to the perfection of wisdom, and he does not bring the perfection of wisdom to completion. And if the perfection of wisdom is not brought to completion, then by grasping what is not to be grasped, he will not emerge into omniscience.

Why is that? Because in the perfection of wisdom there is no grasping of form. Likewise, in the perfection of wisdom there is no grasping of feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness. That which is the absence of grasping at form is not form. Likewise, that which is feeling, that which is perception, and that which is formations, and that which is the absence of grasping at consciousness, is not consciousness. And the perfection of wisdom itself is likewise not grasped.

In just this way, the bodhisattva, the great being, should practice this perfection of wisdom. This is the absorption of the bodhisattva, the great being, called the absence of grasping at all phenomena. It is vast, pioneered by the immeasurable, definitive, and not shared with any of the hearers or solitary buddhas.

Omniscience itself is also not grasped; it is not grasped as a sign. If it were grasped as a sign, then the one who wanders in the cycle of existence would not have faith in it. But the one who wanders in the cycle of existence, having devotion to this wisdom of omniscience, follows it with faith, and enters by way of a wisdom directed to a single purpose. Having entered, he does not grasp at form. Likewise he does not grasp at feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness.

Regarding this, that knowing does not rightly perceive joy or bliss. That knowing does not rightly perceive itself as belonging to inner form. It does not rightly perceive itself as belonging to outer form. It does not rightly perceive itself as belonging to form both inner and outer. It does not rightly perceive itself as something other than form. Likewise, that knowing does not belong to inner feeling, perception, or formations. It does not rightly perceive itself as belonging to inner consciousness. It does not rightly perceive itself as belonging to outer consciousness. It does not rightly perceive itself as belonging to consciousness both inner and outer. It does not rightly perceive itself as something other than consciousness.

By this manner of expression, the one who wanders in the cycle of existence has devotion. He follows this wisdom of omniscience everywhere with faith, taking the nature of reality as his authority, and this is what is called devotion. By him no phenomenon whatsoever is grasped. No phenomenon that is to be grasped or to be relinquished is apprehended at all. And he does not even entertain pride in having reached nirvāṇa.

Blessed One, this too should be known as the perfection of wisdom of a bodhisattva, a great being: such a one does not fully grasp form. In the same way, such a one does not fully grasp feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness. And such a one does not pass fully into nirvāṇa midway, before having perfected the ten powers of the Tathāgata, the four fearlessnesses of the Tathāgata, and the eighteen unmixed qualities of a buddha. Therefore, Blessed One, this too should be known as the perfection of wisdom of a bodhisattva, a great being.

Blessed One, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the perfection of wisdom and meditates on the perfection of wisdom, should examine and reflect with certainty in this way: What is this perfection of wisdom? Whose is this perfection of wisdom? Is it that which is the absence of any phenomenon, that which is not apprehended, that is the perfection of

wisdom? If one examines in this way and reflects with certainty in this way, and is not obstructed, not discouraged, not embarrassed, not faint-hearted; if one's mind does not turn back, is not broken and does not recoil; if one does not tremble, is not terrified, and does not come to be possessed of terror, then that bodhisattva, that great being, should be known as one who is not separated from the perfection of wisdom.

Then the venerable Śāriputra spoke these words to the venerable Subhūti: Venerable Subhūti, when form itself is devoid of the essential nature of form; and likewise, when feeling itself, perception itself, and formations themselves, and likewise consciousness itself, are devoid of the essential nature of consciousness; when the perfection of wisdom itself is devoid of the essential nature of the perfection of wisdom; when omniscience itself is devoid of the essential nature of omniscience, then why should a bodhisattva, a great being, be known as one who is not separated from the perfection of wisdom?

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said to the venerable Śāriputra: Venerable Śāriputra, it is just so. It is just so. Śāriputra, form itself is devoid of the essential nature of form. In the same way, feeling itself, perception itself, formations themselves, and consciousness itself, venerable Śāriputra, are devoid of the essential nature of consciousness. Venerable Śāriputra, the perfection of wisdom itself is devoid of the essential nature of the perfection of wisdom. Venerable Śāriputra, omniscience itself is devoid of the essential nature of omniscience. The perfection of wisdom is also devoid of the defining characteristic of the perfection of wisdom. The defining characteristic is also devoid of the essential nature of a defining characteristic. The basis of the characteristic is also devoid of the essential nature of the basis of the characteristic. The essential nature is also devoid of the defining characteristic of an essential nature.

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Śāriputra said to the venerable Subhūti: Venerable Subhūti, will whatever bodhisattva, great being, comes to train in this surely emerge into omniscience? The venerable Subhūti replied: Venerable Śāriputra, it is just so. It is just so. Whatever bodhisattva, great being, comes to train in this will surely emerge into omniscience. Why is that?

Venerable Śāriputra, all phenomena are without any definitive emergence, and they are unborn. Venerable Śāriputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in this way comes close to omniscience. And as he comes ever closer to omniscience, so too, in order to bring beings to full maturity, his body and

mind become fully purified, his marks become fully purified, and the buddha-field becomes fully purified, and he also comes close to the buddhas. Venerable Śāriputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom in this way is close to omniscience.

Furthermore, the venerable Subhūti spoke as follows with reference to the bodhisattva, the great being. If he practices in form, he practices in signs. If he practices in the sign of form, he practices in signs. If he practices thinking, "Form is a sign," he practices in signs. If he practices in the arising of form, he practices in signs. If he practices in the cessation of form, he practices in signs. If he practices in the destruction of form, he practices in signs. If he practices thinking, "Form is empty," he practices in signs. If he practices thinking, "I am practicing," he practices in signs. If he practices thinking, "I am a bodhisattva," he practices in signs. If he thinks, "I am a bodhisattva," he practices in that very fixation on an object.

In the same way, if he practices in feeling, in perception, in the formations, or in consciousness, he practices in signs. If he practices in the sign of consciousness, he practices in signs. If he practices thinking, "Consciousness is a sign," he practices in signs. If he practices in the arising of consciousness, he practices in signs. If he practices in the cessation of consciousness, he practices in signs. If he practices in the destruction of consciousness, he practices in signs. If he practices thinking, "Consciousness is empty," he practices in signs. If he practices thinking, "I am practicing," he practices in signs. If he practices thinking, "I am a bodhisattva," he practices in signs. If he thinks, "I am a bodhisattva," he practices in that very fixation on an object.

And if it occurs to him, "Whoever practices in this way practices the Perfection of Wisdom; this is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom," then he is practicing in signs themselves. This bodhisattva should be recognized as lacking skillful means.

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the venerable Subhūti: Venerable Subhūti, how then does a bodhisattva, a great being, practice so as to practice the Perfection of Wisdom? When he had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said to the venerable Śāriputra: Venerable Śāriputra, if a bodhisattva, a great being, does not practice in form, does not practice in the sign of form, does not practice thinking, "Form is a sign," does not practice in the arising of form, does not practice in the cessation of form, does not practice in the destruction of form, does not practice thinking, "Form is empty," does not practice

thinking, "I am practicing," does not practice thinking, "I am a bodhisattva," and does not practice in fixation on an object thinking, "I am a bodhisattva"; and likewise, if he does not practice in feeling, nor in perception, nor in the formations, if he does not practice in consciousness, does not practice in the sign of consciousness, does not practice thinking, "Consciousness is a sign," does not practice in the arising of consciousness,

does not practice in the cessation of consciousness, does not practice in the destruction of consciousness, does not practice thinking, "Consciousness is empty." He does not practice thinking, "I am practicing." He does not practice thinking, "I am a bodhisattva," and does not practice in fixation on an object thinking, "I am a bodhisattva." Moreover, he does not think, "One who practices in this way is practicing in the Perfection of Wisdom; this is cultivating the Perfection of Wisdom."

A great bodhisattva who practices in this way is practicing in the Perfection of Wisdom. Yet even while practicing, he does not fully conceive, "I am practicing." He does not fully conceive, "I am not practicing." He does not fully conceive, "I practice, and yet I do not practice," nor "I neither practice nor do not practice." He does not fully conceive, "It should be practiced," nor "It should not be practiced," nor "It both should and should not be practiced," nor "It is neither what should be practiced nor what should not be practiced." Why is this so? Because all phenomena are neither fully realized nor grasped.

This is called the meditative absorption of the great bodhisattva, "the absence of any grasping at all phenomena." It is fixed in its certainty with the Vast One placed before it, and it is not shared in common with any of the hearers and solitary buddhas. The great bodhisattva who abides in this meditative absorption will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Then, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Elder Subhūti spoke thus: Blessed One, that great bodhisattva who abides in this meditative absorption is one who has been prophesied by the Tathāgatas of the past, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Yet I do not see that meditative absorption at all, not even in any way that is correct. Nor do I give rise to pride about the absorption, thinking, "I am in equipoise," or "I enter into the absorption," or "I am settled in the absorption," or "I have entered the absorption." For one such as that, there is not, in any way, in every respect, anything at all.

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Śāriputra said to the venerable Subhūti: Venerable Subhūti, are you able to teach that meditative absorption by which a great bodhisattva abides, and through which the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, prophesy his unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?

Subhūti replied: Venerable Śāriputra, I am not. Why is that? Because that son of good family does not know that meditative absorption, does not know it truly.

The venerable Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, do you say "does not know, does not truly know"?

The venerable Subhūti replied: Venerable Śāriputra, I do say "does not know, does not truly know." Why? Because that meditative absorption does not exist, he does not know and does not truly know. And that meditative absorption too is not known and not truly known.

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti, "Excellent!" and continued: Subhūti, in whatever way you teach, through the power of the Tathāgata, through the eloquence given by the Tathāgata and through the Tathāgata's blessing, it is excellent, Subhūti, excellent! Subhūti, it is so, it is just so.

A bodhisattva, a great being, should train in just this way. Why is that? Because when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in this way, he trains in the Perfection of Wisdom.

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in this way, is he training in the Perfection of Wisdom?

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāriputra: Śāriputra, when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in this way, he is training in the Perfection of Wisdom.

When this had been said, the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in this way, in what phenomena does he train?

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāriputra: Śāriputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way does not train in any phenomenon at all. Why is that? Śāriputra, those phenomena do not exist in the way that ordinary, foolish beings, untaught, are fixated upon them.

The venerable Śāriputra said: Blessed One, then how do they exist?

The Blessed One said: Śāriputra, they truly exist just as they do not exist, and because they do not exist in that way, they are called ignorance. Ordinary, foolish beings who are untaught become fixated on them, and they impute that all phenomena exist where they do not. Having imputed them, they cling to the two extremes, and so they do not know and do not see those phenomena. Therefore, although those things do not exist, they conceptualize about all phenomena. Having imputed, they become fixated on the two extremes. Resting on the basis of that fixation, in the focusing of the mind, they conceptualize about past phenomena, they conceptualize about future phenomena, and they conceptualize about present phenomena. Having imputed in this way, they become fixated on name and form. They impute all phenomena that do not exist. Because they impute all those non-existent phenomena, they do not know and do not see the true path as it really is. Because they do not know and do not see the true path as it really is, they do not emerge definitively from the three realms and do not penetrate the true limit, and for that reason they are counted among those called fools. They have no faith in the true Dharma.

Moreover, Śāriputra, bodhisattvas, great beings, do not become fixated on any phenomenon at all.

When he had said this, the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in this way, is he training in omniscience?

The Blessed One said: Śāriputra, when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in this way, he trains in omniscience. Śāriputra, when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in this way, he trains in all phenomena. Śāriputra, when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in this way, he will be training in omniscience, he will draw near to omniscience, and he will definitively emerge into omniscience.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, if someone were to ask, "Will this illusory person train in omniscience, or draw near to omniscience, or definitively emerge into omniscience?" — if one were thus to inquire, Blessed One, how should it be taught to him?

When he had said this,

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, in this matter I shall question you, and you should answer as best you can. Subhūti said, "Excellent, Blessed One," and listened to the Blessed One, who spoke as follows.

Subhūti, what do you think? Is the illusory person different from form? And likewise, is the illusory person different from feeling, or from perception, or from the formations? Subhūti, what do you think? Is the illusory person different from consciousness?

Subhūti replied: Blessed One, it is not so. The illusory person is not different from form. Blessed One, form itself is illusion, and illusion itself is form. In the same way, Blessed One, the illusory person is not different from feeling, nor from perception, nor from the formations. Feeling, perception, and the formations themselves are illusion, and illusion itself is feeling, perception, and the formations. Blessed One, the illusory person is not different from consciousness. Consciousness itself is illusion, and illusion itself is consciousness.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Regarding these five aggregates of clinging, is there the perception, the full knowing, the conscious awareness, and the conventional designation "bodhisattva"?

When he had said this, the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: So it is, Blessed One; so it is, Sugata. Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in the Perfection of Wisdom will train in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening just like an illusory person. Why is that? Blessed One, because these five aggregates of clinging themselves are to be understood as the illusory person. Why is that? Blessed One, because the Blessed One has taught that form is like an illusion, and whatever is form is just the six sense faculties and these five aggregates. Blessed One, the Blessed One has taught that feeling, perception, and the formations are like an illusion, and the Blessed One has also taught that consciousness is like an illusion; and whatever is consciousness is just the six sense faculties and these five aggregates.

Blessed One, when bodhisattvas, great beings, who have newly entered the Great Vehicle hear this teaching, will they not tremble, become thoroughly terrified, and be seized by terror?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, if bodhisattvas, great beings, who have newly entered the Great Vehicle have fallen into the hands of evil friends, they will tremble, become thoroughly terrified, and be seized by terror. Subhūti, if

bodhisattvas, great beings, who have newly entered the Great Vehicle have come into the hands of virtuous spiritual friends, they will not tremble, will not be thoroughly terrified, and will not be seized by terror.

When he had said this, the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, who then should be recognized as the virtuous spiritual friends of a bodhisattva, a great being?

The Blessed One said: Those who instruct them in the perfections and teach them accordingly, and those who point out to them the works of Māra.

The faults of Māra should be recognized in this way: these are the faults of Māra; these are the works of Māra. You should understand these works of Māra and abandon them. Subhūti, those who speak in this way should be recognized as the virtuous spiritual friends of bodhisattvas, great beings, who have donned the great armor, who have properly entered the Great Vehicle, and who abide properly in the Great Vehicle.

When this had been said, the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, you have said that those who speak in this way should be recognized as the virtuous spiritual friends of bodhisattvas, great beings, who have donned the great armor and have properly entered and abide in the Great Vehicle. Blessed One, concerning what you call a bodhisattva, a great being, what is the meaning of the basis for the name "bodhisattva"?

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, the meaning of the basis for "bodhisattva" is that there is no basis. Why is that? Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in non-attachment to all phenomena. Subhūti, it is by being without attachment, for the sake of realizing all phenomena, that a bodhisattva, a great being, will manifestly and completely awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Subhūti, because he seeks awakening, he is called a bodhisattva, a great being.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, you have said "bodhisattva, great being." Blessed One, for what reason is one called a bodhisattva, a great being?

The Blessed One said: Because he thinks, "I will become the supreme one among the great mass of beings, the great multitude of beings." For that reason he is called a bodhisattva, a great being.

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, I too feel moved to speak on the meaning for which one is called a bodhisattva, a great being. The Blessed One said: Śāriputra, if you know that the time is right, then

speaking. The venerable Śāriputra said: He thinks, "I will teach the Dharma in order to abandon such great views as the view of a self, the view of a sentient being, the view of a life-force, the view of a person, the view of arising, the view of destruction, the view of annihilation, the view of permanence, and the view of the body as one's own." For that reason he is called a bodhisattva, a great being.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, I too feel moved to speak on the meaning for which one is called a bodhisattva, a great being. The Blessed One said: Subhūti, if you know that the time is right, then speak. Subhūti said: Blessed One, as for what is called a bodhisattva, a great being, Blessed One, he does not cling to, and is not seized by, the awakening mind, the omniscient mind, the undefiled mind, the incomparable mind, the mind that is both unequal and equal, the mind that is not shared with any hearers or solitary buddhas. Why is that? Because that omniscient mind is itself undefiled and is not something that can be seized.

That omniscient mind, which is undefiled and not seized, he does not cling to, and he does not seize it. For that reason he is counted as what is called a bodhisattva, a great being.

Then the venerable Śāriputra said this to the venerable Subhūti: Venerable Subhūti, for what reason does he not cling to that mind and not seize it?

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, because there is no mind, he does not cling to that mind and does not seize it.

Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, is there then that mind which is the mindlessness of mind?

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, does that mindlessness exist, or is it nonexistent? Can it be found as existing or as nonexistent?

Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, that is not so.

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, if in that mindlessness there is neither existence nor nonexistence, and it cannot be found, then, venerable Śāriputra, how can you say, "Is there that mind which is the mindlessness of mind?"

Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, in just this way you demonstrate what the Blessed One taught as the supreme abiding in freedom from affliction. Excellent!

Then the venerable Pūrṇa, son of Maitrāyaṇī, said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, one who is called a great being, a great being, is a being who has put on great armor, a being who has properly entered the Great Vehicle and properly abides in the Great Vehicle. For that reason he is counted as what is called a great being.

Then the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, since it is said, "one who has put on great armor, one who has put on great armor," Blessed One, in what way is a bodhisattva, a great being, one who has put on great armor?

The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, here a bodhisattva, a great being, thinks: "I shall lead immeasurable beings to complete nirvāṇa. I shall lead innumerable beings to complete nirvāṇa." And yet he thinks: "Those beings who have been led to complete nirvāṇa, and the one by whom they are led, do not exist." Thus he leads that many beings to complete nirvāṇa, yet there is no being at all who has been led to complete nirvāṇa, and no one by whom any being has been led to complete nirvāṇa. Why is that? Subhūti, because when one grasps the nature of an illusion, this is the nature of all phenomena.

Subhūti, suppose a skilled magician, or a magician's apprentice, conjured a great crowd of people at a crossroads on a great highway, and having conjured them, made that great crowd vanish. What do you think, Subhūti? In that case, is there anyone who has been killed, or died, or been destroyed, or been made to vanish, or anyone by whom this was done?

Subhūti replied: Blessed One, there is not.

The Blessed One declared: In just the same way, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, leads immeasurable and innumerable beings to complete nirvāṇa, yet there is no being at all who has been led to complete nirvāṇa, or by whom anyone will be led to complete nirvāṇa.

If a bodhisattva, a great being, hearing such a teaching as this, does not tremble, is not frightened, and does not become filled with terror, then, Subhūti, it should be known that this bodhisattva, this great being, has put on the great armor.

Then the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, alas! As I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has said, it should be known, Blessed One, that this bodhisattva, this great being, has put on armor that is no armor at all.

The Blessed One declared: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. This bodhisattva, this great being, should be known as one who has put on armor that is no armor. Why is that? Subhūti, omniscience is not made, not transformed, not fabricated. And those beings for whose sake this armor has been put on are likewise not made, not transformed, not fabricated.

When this had been said, the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: So it is, Blessed One; so it is, Sugata. Why is that? Blessed One, form is neither bound nor liberated. In the same way, feeling, perception, and the formations are neither bound nor liberated; and consciousness, Blessed One, is neither bound nor liberated. Blessed One, the suchness of form too is neither bound nor liberated. In the same way, the suchness of feeling, the suchness of perception, and the suchness of the formations are neither bound nor liberated; and the suchness of consciousness, Blessed One, is neither bound nor liberated.

Then the venerable Pūrṇa, son of Maitrāyaṇī, said this to the venerable Subhūti: Venerable Subhūti, do you say that form is neither bound nor liberated? In the same way, do you say that feeling, perception, and the formations, and consciousness, venerable Subhūti, are neither bound nor liberated? Venerable Subhūti, do you say that the suchness of form too is neither bound nor liberated? In the same way, do you say that the suchness of feeling, the suchness of perception, the suchness of the formations, and the suchness of consciousness, venerable Subhūti, are neither bound nor liberated?

Venerable Subhūti, then what is that form which you say is neither bound nor liberated? In the same way, what is that feeling, what is that perception, what are those formations, and what is that consciousness, venerable Subhūti, which you say is neither bound nor liberated? Venerable Subhūti, what is that suchness of form which you say is neither bound nor liberated? In the same way, what is that suchness of feeling, that suchness of perception, those suchnesses of the formations, and what is that suchness of consciousness, venerable Subhūti, which you say is neither bound nor liberated?

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said this to the venerable Pūrṇa, son of Maitrāyaṇī: Venerable Pūrṇa, whatever is the form of an illusory person, that is neither bound nor liberated. In the same way, whatever is the feeling of an illusory person, whatever is the perception of an illusory person, whatever are the formations of an illusory person, and, venerable Pūrṇa,

whatever is the consciousness of an illusory person, that is neither bound nor liberated. Venerable Pūrṇa, whatever is the suchness of the form of an illusory person, that is neither bound nor liberated.

In the same way, whatever is the suchness of the feeling of an illusory person, the suchness of the perception, and the suchness of the formations, and, venerable Pūrṇa, whatever is the suchness of the consciousness of an illusory person, that is neither bound nor liberated. Why is that? Because it is not real, it is neither bound nor liberated. Because it is secluded, it is neither bound nor liberated. Because it is unborn, it is neither bound nor liberated. This is the great armor of the bodhisattvas, the great beings, who have put on the great armor, who have fully entered the Great Vehicle and who abide firmly in the Great Vehicle: it is the great armor that is without armor.

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Pūrṇa, son of Maitrāyaṇī, fell silent.

Then the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, what is that Great Vehicle by which a bodhisattva, a great being who has put on the great armor, has fully entered the Great Vehicle and comes to abide in the Great Vehicle? How should one understand that one has fully entered that Great Vehicle? From where does one go forth by means of that Great Vehicle? By whom has one fully entered that Great Vehicle? Where does one come to abide by means of that Great Vehicle? And what is it that goes forth by means of that Great Vehicle?

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, this term "Great Vehicle" is a designation for the immeasurable. Subhūti, it is called "immeasurable" because it is without limit.

Subhūti, as for the question, "How should one understand that one has fully entered that Great Vehicle? From where does one go forth by means of that Great Vehicle? By whom has one fully entered it? Where does one come to abide by means of it? What is it that goes forth by means of it?": having fully entered by way of the perfections, one goes forth from the three realms. By that which is not apprehended, one has fully entered, and one comes to abide in omniscience. The bodhisattva, the great being, goes forth. And yet there is no going forth from anywhere, no one by whom one has fully entered, and no place in which one abides. Nevertheless, in the manner of non-abiding, one abides in omniscience. By that Great Vehicle nothing at all is led forth, nor does anyone go forth, nor is there any going forth. Why is that? Because both that which goes forth and that by which one goes forth are nonexistent and

unapprehended. Thus, when all phenomena are nonexistent and unapprehended, what phenomenon could go forth by means of what phenomenon?

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, this which is called the Great Vehicle, the Great Vehicle, is spoken of as overpowering the world with its gods, humans, and asuras, and going forth from it. Because it is equal like space, it is the Great Vehicle. Just as in space there is room for immeasurable, countless, boundless sentient beings, so too, Blessed One, in the Great Vehicle there is room for immeasurable, countless, boundless sentient beings. Blessed One, for this reason this is the Great Vehicle of the bodhisattvas, the great beings. In it no coming is seen, no going is seen, and no abiding is found.

Blessed One, in this Great Vehicle no earlier extreme is observed, no later extreme is observed, and no middle is observed either. Blessed One, that vehicle is equal in the three times. For this reason it is called the Great Vehicle, the Great Vehicle.

Then the Blessed One said "Excellent!" to the Venerable Subhūti. "Subhūti, excellent, excellent! Subhūti, it is just so, it is just so. Thus this is the Great Vehicle of the bodhisattvas, the great beings. Those bodhisattvas, great beings, who train in it have attained, are attaining, and will attain omniscience."

Then the Venerable Pūrṇa, son of Maitrāyaṇī, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, it seems to me that the Elder Subhūti, empowered by the blessing of the Perfection of Wisdom, intends to expound this Great Vehicle."

Then the Venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, is it not the case that I am teaching the Great Vehicle in a way that contradicts the Perfection of Wisdom?"

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, that is not so. Subhūti, you are teaching the Great Vehicle in accordance with the Perfection of Wisdom."

When this had been said, the Venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, it is through the power of the buddhas. Blessed One, furthermore, a bodhisattva is not fully realized at the earlier extreme, a bodhisattva is not fully realized at the later extreme, and a bodhisattva is not fully realized in the middle. Why is this not fully realized? Because form has no limit, it should be understood that the bodhisattva too has no limit. In the

same way, because feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness have no limit, it should be understood that the bodhisattva too has no limit. One does not fully realize form as 'bodhisattva,' for this too does not exist and is not observed. In the same way, one does not fully realize feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as 'bodhisattva,' for this too does not exist and is not observed.

"Blessed One, since I thus observe none of the phenomena of a bodhisattva in any way, in any respect, at all, Blessed One, I do not correctly see any phenomenon in which this name 'bodhisattva' exists. I also do not correctly see or observe the Perfection of Wisdom, and I do not correctly see or observe omniscience either. Blessed One, if I do not correctly see or observe any phenomena in any way, in any respect, at all, then what phenomenon, by means of what phenomenon, would I instruct and teach concerning what phenomenon?

"Blessed One, this which is called 'buddha' is merely a name. Blessed One, this which is called 'bodhisattva' is also merely a name. Blessed One, this which is called 'Perfection of Wisdom' is also merely a name. And that name too is not actually established. Blessed One, just as I speak of 'I, I,' yet, Blessed One, the self is not actually established at all, so it is. Thus, since all phenomena have no intrinsic nature, what is the form that cannot be grasped and is not actually established? What are feeling, perception, and formations? What is that consciousness that cannot be grasped and is not actually established?"

Thus, whatever is without intrinsic nature in all those phenomena is not actually established; and whatever is the non-establishment of all phenomena is also not a phenomenon. Therefore, since the Perfection of Wisdom is not actually established, what could be advised or taught regarding what is not actually established? Blessed One, apart from what is not actually established, no phenomena at all can be apprehended, neither the qualities of the buddhas, nor the qualities of the bodhisattvas, nor anyone who practices toward awakening.

Blessed One, when this is spoken, taught, and explained in this way, if the mind of a bodhisattva, a great being, is not stunned, does not sink into despondency, is not alarmed or made timid; if the mind does not turn back or turn away, and is not dismayed, not terrified, and does not become possessed of terror, then this bodhisattva, this great being, is practicing in the Perfection of Wisdom. This bodhisattva, this great being, is meditating on the Perfection

of Wisdom. This bodhisattva, this great being, is closely contemplating the Perfection of Wisdom. This bodhisattva, this great being, is reflecting with certainty on the Perfection of Wisdom. This is how it should be understood.

Why is that? Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, closely contemplates these phenomena in the Perfection of Wisdom, at that time he does not closely conceive of form, does not closely grasp form, and does not correctly perceive form as arising or form as ceasing. In the same way, he does not do so with feeling, with perception, or with formations. He does not closely conceive of consciousness, does not closely grasp consciousness, and does not correctly perceive consciousness as arising or consciousness as ceasing.

Why is that? Blessed One, that which is the non-arising of form is not form, and that which is the non-destruction of form is not form. Therefore, the non-arising and what is called form are not two, and cannot be made into two. Likewise, the non-destruction and what is called form are not two, and cannot be made into two. Whatever is called form is included in the category of the non-dual.

In the same way, it is so for feeling, for perception, and for formations. And that which is the non-arising of consciousness is not consciousness, and that which is the non-destruction of consciousness is not consciousness. Therefore, the non-arising and what is called consciousness are not two, and cannot be made into two. Likewise, the non-destruction and what is called consciousness are not two, and cannot be made into two. Whatever is called consciousness is included in the category of the non-dual.

Blessed One, thus, if one closely contemplates all phenomena in every respect in the Perfection of Wisdom, then one does not closely conceive of form, does not closely grasp form, and does not correctly perceive form as arising or form as ceasing. In the same way, it is not so with feeling, not so with perception, not so with formations.

Consciousness one does not closely conceive, consciousness one does not closely grasp, and one does not correctly perceive consciousness as arising or as ceasing. Why is this so? Because, Blessed One, that which is the non-arising of form is not form, and that which is the non-destruction of form is not form. Therefore, the non-arising and what is called form are not two, and cannot be made into two. Likewise, the non-destruction and what is called form are not two, and cannot be made into two. Whatever is called form is included in the

category of the non-dual.

In the same way, so it is with feeling, so it is with perception, and so it is with formations. And so it is with consciousness: that which is the non-arising of consciousness is not consciousness, and that which is the non-destruction of consciousness is not consciousness. Therefore, the non-arising and what is called consciousness are not two, and cannot be made into two. Likewise, the non-destruction and what is called consciousness are not two, and cannot be made into two. Whatever is called consciousness is included in the category of the non-dual.

Then the venerable Śāriputra spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows. "Venerable Subhūti, as I understand the meaning of what you have said, in that case the bodhisattva too is without arising. Venerable Subhūti, if the bodhisattva too is without arising, then what is there for the bodhisattva who practices difficult austerities, or who strives to experience whatever sufferings there are for the sake of sentient beings?"

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said to the venerable Śāriputra: "Venerable Śāriputra, I do not wish for bodhisattvas, the great beings, to practice difficult austerities. One who practices with the perception of difficulty does not even become a bodhisattva. Why is this so? Venerable Śāriputra, having given rise to the perception of difficulty, one cannot accomplish the welfare of immeasurable, innumerable sentient beings. Rather, making the perception of ease itself one's basis, the bodhisattva, the great being, gives rise toward all sentient beings to the perception of them as mother, as father, as son, and as daughter. Likewise, having formed these perceptions toward men and women, the bodhisattva, the great being, practices the bodhisattva's conduct.

"Therefore the bodhisattva, the great being, should give rise toward all sentient beings to the perception of them as mother, as father, as son, and as daughter, and even toward them as oneself. He should think: Just as I should be liberated from all suffering, completely, in every respect, entirely, so too all sentient beings should be liberated from all suffering, completely, in every respect, entirely. In this way he should give rise to this perception toward all sentient beings as well, thinking: I shall not abandon any of these sentient beings. I shall liberate all these sentient beings from the immeasurable mass of suffering. Even if my body were cut into a hundred pieces, I would not give rise to even a little harmful intent toward them. In this way the bodhisattva,

the great being, should generate the mind."

If a bodhisattva practices in this way, he is not practicing with the perception of hardship, and he does not abide in the perception of hardship.

Venerable Śāriputra, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, should generate the mind thinking: Just as I am altogether non-existent and unapprehendable, completely, in every respect, entirely, so too all phenomena are altogether non-existent and unapprehendable, completely, in every respect, entirely. In this way he should give rise to this perception toward all phenomena, both inner and outer. If a bodhisattva practices in this way, he is not practicing with the perception of hardship, and he does not abide in the perception of hardship.

Venerable Śāriputra said: "Venerable Subhūti, when it is said that a bodhisattva is also without arising, is that so?" Subhūti replied: "It is so, Venerable Śāriputra, it is so. The bodhisattva is without arising."

Śāriputra said: "Venerable Subhūti, is it only the bodhisattva himself who is without arising, or are the qualities of a bodhisattva also without arising?"

Subhūti said: "Venerable Śāriputra, the qualities of a bodhisattva are also without arising."

Śāriputra said: "Venerable Subhūti, are only the qualities of a bodhisattva without arising, or is omniscience also without arising?" Subhūti said: "Venerable Śāriputra, omniscience is also without arising."

Śāriputra said: "Venerable Subhūti, is only omniscience without arising, or are the qualities of omniscience also without arising?" Subhūti said: "Venerable Śāriputra, the qualities of omniscience are also without arising."

Śāriputra said: "Venerable Subhūti, are only the qualities of omniscience without arising, or are ordinary beings also without arising?" Subhūti said: "Venerable Śāriputra, ordinary beings are also without arising."

Śāriputra said: "Venerable Subhūti, are only ordinary beings themselves without arising, or are the qualities of ordinary beings also without arising?"

Subhūti said: "Venerable Śāriputra, the qualities of ordinary beings are also without arising."

When this had been said, the Venerable Śāriputra spoke to the Venerable Subhūti: "Venerable Subhūti, if the bodhisattva is without arising, and the qualities of a bodhisattva are without arising, and omniscience is without arising, and the qualities of omniscience are without arising, and ordinary

beings are without arising, and the qualities of ordinary beings are without arising, then, Venerable Subhūti, does the bodhisattva, the great being, attain omniscience?"

When this had been said, the Venerable Subhūti spoke to the Venerable Śāriputra: "Venerable Śāriputra, I do not assert that one attains an unarisen phenomenon, nor that one realizes it. Through an unarisen phenomenon, the unarisen would not come to be attained."

Śāriputra said: "Venerable Subhūti, would the arisen be attained through an unarisen phenomenon, or would the unarisen be attained through an arisen phenomenon?" Subhūti said: "Venerable Śāriputra, but is an unarisen phenomenon something that has arisen?"

"But is the unarisen phenomenon itself simply unarisen?"

Śāriputra said: "Venerable Subhūti, is the very nature of the arisen unarisen, or is the unarisen phenomenon unarisen?"

Subhūti said: "Venerable Śāriputra, I do not presume to speak of an arisen phenomenon or of an unarisen phenomenon."

Śāriputra said: "Venerable Subhūti, do you not presume even to speak of non-arising?"

Subhūti said: "Venerable Śāriputra, non-arising itself is what is disputed, and, Venerable Śāriputra, non-arising itself is what appears distinctly, each in its own way. Venerable Śāriputra, non-arising itself is what I dare to speak of, for, Venerable Śāriputra, it is just suchness that appears so very distinctly."

When this had been said, the Venerable Śāriputra spoke to the Venerable Subhūti: "Venerable Subhūti should be placed foremost among those who teach the Dharma. Why is that? Because whatever the Elder, the Venerable Subhūti, is asked about, he comes through to a definite answer on precisely that, and he neither stirs from the nature of reality nor contradicts that nature of reality."

When this had been said, the Venerable Subhūti spoke to the Venerable Śāriputra: "Venerable Śāriputra, this is the nature of the Blessed One's hearers, who are of a non-abiding nature: whatever they are asked about, they come through to a definite answer on precisely that, and they neither contradict the nature of reality nor transgress it. Why is that? Because all phenomena are non-abiding."

When this had been said, the Venerable Śāriputra spoke to the Venerable Subhūti: "Excellent, excellent, Venerable Subhūti! What, then, is this perfection of the bodhisattvas, the great beings, that abides in no phenomenon at all?"

Subhūti said: "Venerable Śāriputra, the Perfection of Wisdom itself, because it abides in no vehicle and in no phenomenon whatsoever, is the perfection that abides in no phenomenon at all. Thus, when a bodhisattva, a great being, is taught, shown, and closely instructed in this profound Perfection of Wisdom in this way, and his mind does not sink, does not become dejected, does not become bewildered, and does not turn to something else, you should know that this bodhisattva, this great being, abides in the abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom and is not separated from this attention."

Then the Venerable Śāriputra spoke to the Venerable Subhūti: "Venerable Subhūti, how is it that a bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in the abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom, is not separated from attention? Venerable Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, is not separated from attention, then he would be separated from the abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom. And, Venerable Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, is not separated from abiding in the Perfection of Wisdom, then he would be separated from that attention."

"Venerable Śāriputra, if a bodhisattva, a great being, were indeed not separated from attention and, because of that, were not separated from abiding in the Perfection of Wisdom, then, if that were so, all sentient beings too would be not separated from abiding in the Perfection of Wisdom. Why is this? Because all sentient beings also abide not separated from attention."

When he had spoken thus, the Venerable Subhūti said this to the Venerable Śāriputra: "Venerable Śāriputra, excellent, excellent! Yet even you are open to criticism, for the Venerable Śāriputra has taken up this very point and declared it as a correct statement. Why is this? Venerable Śāriputra, because sentient beings have no intrinsic nature, attention should be understood to have no intrinsic nature. Venerable Śāriputra, because sentient beings are without real substance, attention should be understood to be without real substance. Venerable Śāriputra, because sentient beings are secluded, attention should be understood to be secluded. Venerable Śāriputra, because sentient beings are inconceivable, attention should be understood to be inconceivable. Venerable Śāriputra, because sentient beings are not fully and completely

awakened, attention should be understood to be not fully and completely awakened. Venerable Śāriputra, because sentient beings are fully awakened to a meaning that is not the real as it is, attention should be understood to be fully awakened to a meaning that is not the real as it is. Venerable Śāriputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, wishes to abide through this attention of such a nature, and through this abiding."

This is the first chapter, called "The Conduct of Omniscience," from the noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

At that time, Śakra, the lord of the gods (Indra), together with forty thousand sons of the gods belonging to the class of the Thirty-Three, gathered in that very assembly and sat down. The four guardians of the world, together with twenty thousand sons of the gods of the class of the Four Great Kings, and Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, together with ten thousand sons of the gods of Brahmā's class, and five thousand sons of the gods of the Pure Abodes, also gathered in that very assembly and sat down. And whatever radiance was born from the ripening of the gods' own karma, all of it was outshone by the power of the Buddha, the splendor of the Buddha, and the blessing of the Buddha.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, spoke to the Venerable Elder Subhūti: "Noble Subhūti, these many thousands of sons of the gods gathered and seated in this assembly wish to hear from the noble Subhūti the instruction, the counsel, and the guidance on the Perfection of Wisdom for bodhisattvas, great beings. How should that bodhisattva, that great being, abide in the Perfection of Wisdom? How should he train? How should he practice?"

The Elder Subhūti said: "Kauśika, for that very reason I will give instruction through the power of the Buddha, the splendor of the Buddha, and the blessing of the Buddha. Those sons of the gods who have not yet generated the mind toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening should generate it. But those who have entered into the certainty of what is right have no opportunity to generate the mind toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Why is this?"

Because they have set a boundary to the stream of saṃsāra, they will turn through saṃsāra again and again, and they have no opportunity to generate the mind toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Even so, if they too should generate the mind toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, one should rejoice in them as well. I do not obstruct their virtue.

Rather, among the noble qualities, one should aim above all at those that are most excellent and noble.

Then the Blessed One said to the Elder Subhūti: "Excellent, excellent, Subhūti! That you inspire joy in the bodhisattvas, the great beings, is excellent indeed, Subhūti."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the Elder Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, we will repay the kindness of the Blessed One; we cannot fail to repay that kindness. Why is this? Blessed One, in the presence of the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas of the past, when the Blessed One was formerly a bodhisattva and practiced the holy life for the sake of awakening, for our sake, those hearers who exhorted and instructed others in the perfections, those hearers, through the Blessed One's practice, brought forth the unsurpassed wisdom. Just so, Blessed One, we too will take up and uphold the bodhisattvas, the great beings, and we will carry them forward; we will fully take them up, and we will fully carry them forward. Why is this? Blessed One, because in this way we take up the bodhisattvas, the great beings, and carry them forward, and fully take them up and fully carry them forward, they will swiftly become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening."

Then the Elder Subhūti said to Śakra, lord of the gods: "Kauśika, therefore listen well, attend carefully, and keep it in mind. I will explain to you how the bodhisattva, the great being, should abide in the Perfection of Wisdom. Kauśika, the bodhisattva, the great being, should abide in the Perfection of Wisdom by abiding in emptiness. Therefore, Kauśika, the bodhisattva, the great being, should become one who puts on the great armor.

He should not abide in form. He should not abide in feeling, nor in perception, nor in formations, nor in consciousness. He should not abide in the eye. He should not abide in forms. He should not abide in eye-consciousness. He should not abide in eye-contact, the coming together of eye, form, and consciousness. He should not abide in the feeling that arises from eye-contact. In the same way, he should not abide in the ear, the nose, the tongue, the body, or the mind. He should not abide in sounds, smells, tastes, tangibles, and mental phenomena; nor in ear-consciousness and so on up to mind-consciousness; nor in mind-contact, nor in the feeling that arises from mind-contact.

He should not abide in the earth element. He should not abide in the water element, the fire element, the wind element, the space element, or the consciousness element. He should not abide in the foundations of mindfulness. He should not abide in the right abandonments, the bases of miraculous power, the faculties, the powers, the limbs of awakening, or the path. He should not abide in the fruit of stream-entry."

He should not abide in the fruit of once-returning, nor in the fruit of non-returning, nor in the state of an arhat. He should not abide in the state of a pratyekabuddha. He should not abide in buddhahood.

Thus he should not abide in the thought, "This is form." Thus he should not abide in the thought, "This is feeling," nor "This is perception," nor "These are formations," nor in the thought, "This is consciousness." Thus he should not abide in anything from the eye up to the feeling that arises from mind-contact. Thus he should not abide in anything from the earth element up to the consciousness element. Thus he should not abide in the thought, "These are the foundations of mindfulness." Thus he should not abide in the thought, "These are the right abandonments, the bases of miraculous power, the faculties, the powers, and the limbs of awakening," nor in the thought, "This is a limb of the path." Thus he should not abide in the thought, "This is the fruit of stream-entry." Thus he should not abide in the thought, "This is the fruit of once-returning," nor "This is the fruit of non-returning," nor in the thought, "This is an arhat." Thus he should not abide in the thought, "This is a pratyekabuddha." Thus he should not abide in the thought, "This is a buddha."

He should not abide in the thought that form is permanent or impermanent. In the same way, he should not abide in the thought that feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are permanent or impermanent. He should not abide in the thought that form is blissful or suffering. In the same way, he should not abide in the thought that feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are blissful or suffering. He should not abide in the thought that form is empty or not empty. In the same way, he should not abide in the thought that feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are empty or not empty. He should not abide in the thought that form is self or selfless. In the same way, he should not abide in the thought that feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are self or selfless. He should not abide in the thought that form is agreeable or disagreeable. In the same way, he should not abide in the thought that feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are agreeable or disagreeable.

He should not abide through fixing his attention on form as "empty." In the same way, he should not abide through fixing his attention on feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as "empty."

He should not abide in the thought that the fruit of stream-entry is distinguished by the unconditioned. In the same way, he should not abide in the thought that the fruit of once-returning, the fruit of non-returning, and the state of an arhat are distinguished by the unconditioned. He should not abide in the thought that the state of a pratyekabuddha is distinguished by the unconditioned. He should not abide in the thought that buddhahood is distinguished by the unconditioned.

He should not abide in the thought, "The stream-enterer is a worthy recipient of offerings." He should not abide in the thought, "The stream-enterer, at most, will take rebirth seven more times." He should not abide in the thought, "The once-returner is a worthy recipient of offerings." He should not abide in the thought, "Because the once-returner has not fully reached the end, he will return to this world once more and then put an end to suffering." He should not abide in the thought, "The non-returner is a worthy recipient of offerings." He should not abide in the thought, "The non-returner will not return to this world, but will fully pass into nirvāṇa right there." He should not abide in the thought, "The arhat is a worthy recipient of offerings." He should not abide in the thought, "This arhat, in this very life, with no remainder of the aggregates left, will pass completely into the realm of nirvāṇa." He should not abide in the thought, "The pratyekabuddha is a worthy recipient of offerings."

He should not abide in the thought, "The pratyekabuddha will pass beyond the level of the hearers, and without attaining the level of a buddha, will pass completely into nirvāṇa." He should not abide in the thought, "The Buddha is a worthy field for giving." He should not abide in the thought, "The Buddha, having passed beyond the level of ordinary beings, the level of the hearers, and the level of the pratyekabuddhas, works for the benefit of immeasurable, innumerable beings. He leads immeasurable, innumerable hundreds of thousands of billions of beings to complete nirvāṇa. He establishes immeasurable, innumerable beings firmly in the paths of the hearers, the pratyekabuddhas, and the perfectly complete buddhas. Abiding on the level of a buddha, he performs the activities of a buddha, and then, in the realm of nirvāṇa without any remainder of the aggregates, he will pass completely into nirvāṇa through the nirvāṇa of a buddha." He should not abide even in this

way.

Then the venerable Śāriputra thought: "If one should not abide even in this way, in the thought that the Buddha, having passed beyond the level of ordinary beings, the level of the hearers, and the level of the pratyekabuddhas, works for the benefit of immeasurable, innumerable beings, leads immeasurable, innumerable hundreds of thousands of billions of beings to complete nirvāṇa, establishes them firmly as hearers, pratyekabuddhas, and perfectly complete buddhas, performs the activities of a buddha while abiding on the level of a buddha, and then passes completely into nirvāṇa without remainder, then how should such a bodhisattva abide in this, and how should he train?"

Then, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Subhūti knew the thoughts in the mind of the venerable Śāriputra, and said to him: "Venerable Śāriputra, what do you think? On what do the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha abide?"

The venerable Śāriputra replied: "Venerable Subhūti, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha does not abide on anything at all. Why is that? The mind of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha is utterly without abiding. It abides neither in the conditioned realm nor in the unconditioned realm, and yet it does not arise from them either."

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the venerable Śāriputra: "Venerable Śāriputra, just so. A bodhisattva, a great being, should abide in exactly this way and train in exactly this way. He should think: 'Just as the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha does not abide on anything, yet is not non-abiding, does not abide in disagreement, yet is not one who fails to abide in agreement, so I too shall abide.' And he should think: 'Just as the Tathāgata abides, so shall I abide, and so shall I train.' And he should think: 'If I abide just as the Tathāgata abides, then I abide knowing through the manner of non-abiding.' In this way he should train. A bodhisattva, a great being, should abide in this way and train in this way. A bodhisattva, a great being, who trains thus abides in this abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom, and is never separated from this attention."

Then, among that assembly, some sons of the gods thought:

"Whatever the yakṣas speak in the yakṣa language, in yakṣa sounds, yakṣa words, yakṣa discourse, and yakṣa expression, that can be understood. But what the Elder Subhūti explains, expounds, teaches, and demonstrates cannot

be understood at all."

Then, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Subhūti fully understood in his own mind the very nature of these thoughts in the minds of those sons of the gods, and said to them: "Sons of the gods, what is called 'not understandable, not understandable' is this: in it there is nothing whatsoever that is spoken, and in it there is nothing whatsoever that is heard."

Then those sons of the gods thought: "Ah! This noble Subhūti will make it clear! Ah! This noble Subhūti will make it clear! The noble Subhūti enters more deeply than the deep, more subtly than the subtle, more profoundly than the profound, and so he teaches and explains."

Again, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Subhūti knew in his own mind the thoughts of those sons of the gods, and said to them: "Sons of the gods, therefore, whoever wishes to attain the fruit of stream-entry, and whoever wishes to abide in the fruit of stream-entry, cannot succeed without relying on this patience. In the same way, whoever wishes to attain the fruit of once-returning, and whoever wishes to abide in the fruit of once-returning; whoever wishes to attain the fruit of non-returning, and whoever wishes to abide in the fruit of non-returning; whoever wishes to attain arhatship, and whoever wishes to abide in arhatship; whoever wishes to attain the awakening of a solitary buddha, and whoever wishes to abide in the awakening of a solitary buddha, cannot succeed without relying on this patience. And whoever wishes to attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and whoever wishes to abide in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, cannot succeed without relying on this patience."

Then those sons of the gods thought again: "What kind of nature should we look for in those who listen to the Dharma from this noble Subhūti?" Then, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Subhūti knew in his own mind the thoughts of those sons of the gods, and said to them: "Sons of the gods, those who listen to the Dharma from me should be sought among beings like illusions and magical emanations. Why is that? Because they do not listen, and they do not bring it to realization."

Then those sons of the gods said to the venerable Subhūti: "Noble Subhūti, are those sentient beings only like illusions? Are they not actually illusions?"

When they said this, the venerable Subhūti said to those sons of the gods: "Sons of the gods, those sentient beings are like illusions. Sons of the gods, those sentient beings are like dreams. Sons of the gods, in this way illusion

and sentient beings are not two; they cannot be made two. In this way dream and sentient beings are not two; they cannot be made two. Sons of the gods, all phenomena too are like illusions and like dreams. The stream-enterer is like an illusion, like a dream. The fruit of stream-entry is like an illusion, like a dream. In the same way, the once-returner and the fruit of once-returning, the non-returner and the fruit of non-returning,

The arhat too is like an illusion, like a dream. Arhatship itself is like an illusion, like a dream. The solitary buddha (pratyekabuddha) is like an illusion, like a dream. Solitary buddhahood itself is like an illusion, like a dream. The perfectly complete buddha is like an illusion, like a dream. Perfect buddhahood itself is like an illusion, like a dream.

Then those sons of the gods said to the Venerable Subhūti, "Noble Subhūti, do you say that the perfectly complete buddha is like an illusion, like a dream? Do you say that perfect buddhahood itself is like an illusion, like a dream?"

Subhūti replied, "Sons of the gods, if I speak of nirvāṇa too as like an illusion, like a dream, what need is there to speak of other phenomena?"

The sons of the gods said, "Noble Subhūti, do you say that nirvāṇa too is like an illusion, like a dream?"

The Venerable Subhūti replied, "Sons of the gods, even if there were some phenomenon more excellent than nirvāṇa, I would say that it too is like an illusion, like a dream. Sons of the gods, in this way illusion and this nirvāṇa are not two; they cannot be made two. In this way dream and this nirvāṇa are not two; they cannot be made two."

Then the Venerable Śāriputra, the Venerable Pūrṇa son of Maitrāyaṇī, the Venerable Mahākauṣṭhila, the Venerable Mahākātyāyana, the Venerable Mahākāśyapa, and other great hearers (śrāvakas), together with many thousands of bodhisattvas, said to the Elder Subhūti, "Venerable Subhūti, who will rightly uphold this Perfection of Wisdom as it has been taught?"

Then the Venerable Ānanda said to those elders, "Venerable ones, it will be irreversible bodhisattvas, great beings, or persons who have attained the perfect view, or arhats whose defilements are exhausted, who will rightly uphold this Perfection of Wisdom as it has been taught."

Then the Venerable Subhūti said to those elders, "Venerable ones, no one at all will arise who rightly upholds this Perfection of Wisdom as it has been explained. Why is that? Because in this teaching no phenomenon has been

mentioned, no phenomenon has been made manifest, and no phenomenon has been established. Therefore, just as in this teaching no phenomenon has been mentioned, made manifest, or established, so too no one at all will arise who rightly upholds this Perfection of Wisdom as it has been taught."

Then Indra, king of the gods (Śakra), thought, "Noble Subhūti has taught this exposition of the Dharma in such a way. For my part too, as an offering, I will conjure up flowers and scatter them over Noble Subhūti." Then at that moment Śakra conjured up flowers and scattered them over the Venerable Subhūti.

Then the Elder, the Venerable Subhūti, in order to respond to Śakra, thought, "These flowers that Śakra, king of the gods, has scattered are flowers I have never seen before, even in the realm of the Thirty-Three Gods. These flowers are conjured."

Thinking, "These flowers scattered by the lord of the gods are not born from trees, creepers, or vines; they are flowers that arose from the mind," then Śakra, lord of the gods, knowing with his own mind the thought in the mind of the Venerable Subhūti, said to him, "Noble Subhūti, these flowers are unborn. Why is that? There is no flower at all that is born of mind, and neither are they born from trees, creepers, or vines."

Then the Venerable Subhūti said to Śakra, lord of the gods, "Kauśika, when you say that these flowers are unborn, that these flowers are not born of mind and are not born from trees, creepers, or vines, then, Kauśika, what is unborn is not a flower."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, thought, "How marvelous! The noble Subhūti's wisdom is profound. He teaches what is designated by names and words, yet he does not contradict it. He makes that very thing clear, and that very thing he sets forth."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the Venerable Subhūti, "Noble Subhūti, so it is, so it is. Noble Subhūti, just as you have set forth, so should bodhisattvas, great beings, train in this."

When he had spoken thus, the Venerable Subhūti said to Śakra, lord of the gods, "Kauśika, so it is, so it is. Thus should bodhisattvas, great beings, train in this. Kauśika, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way does not train for the fruit of stream-entry. He does not train for the fruit of once-returning, does not train for the fruit of non-returning, does not train for

arhatship. He does not train for pratyekabuddhahood, and does not train for buddhahood. Yet one who does not train in these stages trains for buddhahood and omniscience. One who trains for buddhahood and omniscience trains in the immeasurable, innumerable qualities of a buddha. One who trains in the immeasurable, innumerable qualities of a buddha does not train for the sake of increasing or diminishing form. Likewise, he does not train for the sake of increasing or diminishing feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness.

"One who does not train for the sake of increasing or diminishing form, and does not train for the sake of increasing or diminishing feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness, does not train for the sake of grasping or abandoning form. Likewise, he does not train for the sake of grasping or abandoning feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness. He does not train for the sake of grasping any phenomenon at all; he does not train for the sake of arising, and does not train for the sake of ceasing. One who does not train for the sake of grasping any phenomenon, who does not train for the sake of arising or ceasing, does not train for the sake of grasping omniscience itself, and does not train for the sake of its arising or ceasing. A bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way trains in omniscience, and will truly emerge into omniscience."

Then the venerable Śāriputra spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows: "Venerable Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who does not train for the sake of grasping any phenomenon at all, who does not train for the sake of arising, and does not train for the sake of ceasing, does not train for the sake of grasping omniscience itself, and does not train for the sake of its arising or ceasing. Venerable Subhūti, does a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way train in omniscience, and will he truly emerge into omniscience?"

The venerable Subhūti replied: "Venerable Śāriputra, so it is, so it is. Venerable Śāriputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, who does not train for the sake of grasping any phenomenon at all, who does not train for the sake of arising, and does not train for the sake of ceasing, does not train for the sake of grasping omniscience itself, does not train for the sake of its arising or ceasing. He also does not train for the sake of grasping the qualities of a buddha, and does not train for the sake of their arising or ceasing. Venerable Śāriputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way trains in omniscience, and will truly emerge into omniscience."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, spoke to the venerable Śāriputra as follows: "Noble Śāriputra, from what should a bodhisattva, a great being, seek the Perfection of Wisdom?"

Śāriputra said: "Kauśika, a bodhisattva, a great being, should seek the Perfection of Wisdom in the chapter of the venerable Subhūti."

When he had said this, Śakra, lord of the gods, spoke to the venerable Śāriputra as follows: "Noble Śāriputra, this exposition of the Perfection of Wisdom that the noble Subhūti gives: by whose power should it be understood, and by whose blessing should it be understood?"

The venerable Śāriputra said: "Kauśika, this exposition of the Perfection of Wisdom that the venerable Subhūti gives should be understood as the power of the Tathāgata. It should be understood as the blessing of the Tathāgata."

Then the venerable Subhūti spoke to Śakra, lord of the gods as follows: "Kauśika, you say, 'This exposition of the Perfection of Wisdom that the noble Subhūti gives: by whose power should it be understood, and by whose blessing should it be understood?' Kauśika, this exposition of the Perfection of Wisdom that I give should be understood as the power of the Tathāgata. It should be understood as the blessing of the Tathāgata."

"And Kauśika, as for your question, 'From what should a bodhisattva, a great being, seek the Perfection of Wisdom?': Kauśika, a bodhisattva, a great being, should not seek the Perfection of Wisdom in form, nor should it be sought apart from form. In the same way, it should not be sought in feeling, nor in perception, nor in formations, nor in consciousness, and it should not be sought apart from consciousness."

"Why is that? Kauśika, because form is not the Perfection of Wisdom, and apart from form there is no Perfection of Wisdom."

In the same way, feeling is not the Perfection of Wisdom, perception is not, the formations are not, and consciousness is not the Perfection of Wisdom; and apart from consciousness there is no Perfection of Wisdom."

When this had been said, Śakra, lord of the gods, spoke to the venerable Subhūti: "Noble Subhūti, this Perfection of Wisdom is a great perfection. Noble Subhūti, this Perfection of Wisdom is an immeasurable perfection. Noble Subhūti, this Perfection of Wisdom is a limitless perfection. Noble Subhūti, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection."

The elder Subhūti replied: "So it is, Kauśika, so it is. This Perfection of Wisdom is a great perfection. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is an immeasurable perfection. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a limitless perfection. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection.

"Why is that? Because form is great, Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a great perfection. In the same way, because feeling, perception, the formations, and consciousness are great, Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a great perfection.

"Because form is immeasurable, Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is an immeasurable perfection. In the same way, because feeling, perception, the formations, and consciousness are immeasurable, Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is an immeasurable perfection.

"Because form is limitless, Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a limitless perfection. In the same way, because feeling, perception, the formations, and consciousness are limitless, Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a limitless perfection.

"Because form is unending, Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection. In the same way, because feeling, perception, the formations, and consciousness are unending, Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection.

"Kauśika, one does not become fixated on the idea of a 'great perfection.' In the same way, one does not become fixated on the idea of an 'immeasurable perfection,' nor on the idea of a 'limitless perfection,' nor on the idea of an 'unending perfection.'

"Therefore, Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a great perfection. It is an immeasurable perfection. It is a limitless perfection. Kauśika, it is an unending perfection.

"Kauśika, because the objects of focus are unending, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection. Kauśika, because sentient beings are unending, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection.

"And, Kauśika, in what way is it that, because the objects of focus are unending, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection?"

"Kauśika, it is like this: the beginning, middle, and end of all phenomena cannot be apprehended. Therefore, Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection. In this way, Kauśika, because the objects of focus are

unending, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection.

"Furthermore, Kauśika, because all phenomena are unending and without limit, and because no beginning, middle, or end of them can be apprehended, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection. And why is this so? Kauśika, no beginning, middle, or end of form can be apprehended. Likewise, Kauśika, no beginning, middle, or end of feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness can be apprehended. Thus, Kauśika, in this way too, because the objects of focus are unending, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection.

"Furthermore, Kauśika, sentient beings are unending and without limit. And why is this so? No beginning, middle, or end of sentient beings can be apprehended. Therefore, Kauśika, because sentient beings are unending, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), said this to the venerable Subhūti: "Noble Subhūti, in what way is it that, because sentient beings are unending, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection?"

The elder Subhūti replied: "Kauśika, it is because sentient beings are unending, being beyond any reckoning, or because they are reckoned as numberless, that this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection."

Śakra said: "Noble Subhūti, then how is it that, because sentient beings are unending, this Perfection of Wisdom is called an unending perfection?"

The elder Subhūti replied: "Kauśika, what do you think? The words 'sentient being, sentient being' are a designation for which phenomenon?"

Śakra said: "Noble Subhūti, these words 'sentient being, sentient being' are neither a designation for a phenomenon nor a designation for the absence of a phenomenon. This is a name that has been imputed, something that arose adventitiously. This imputed name has no real entity. This imputed name has nothing that belongs to a self. This imputed name 'sentient being, sentient being' is something that cannot be apprehended."

The elder Subhūti said: "Kauśika, what do you think? Is there any sentient being who has been established as such?"

Śakra said: "Noble Subhūti, there is not."

Subhūti said: "Kauśika, where no sentient being has been established, can there be unending sentient beings? Kauśika, suppose a Tathāgata, an arhat, a

perfectly complete buddha were to remain for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges, and with a profound voice and speech that makes known what lies beyond all limits, were to utter the words 'sentient being, sentient being.' Would any sentient being thereby be born, or come to be born, or be taking birth, or cease, or come to cease, or be ceasing?"

Śakra said: "Noble Subhūti, no. And why is this so? Because sentient beings are pure from the very beginning, and thoroughly pure from the very beginning."

Subhūti said: "Kauśika, in this way too, because sentient beings are unending, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unending perfection."

Kauśika, in this way too, because sentient beings are limitless, this Perfection of Wisdom should be known as limitless.

Then the gods, together with Indra, together with Brahmā, together with the lords of beings, together with the sages, together with the assembly of men and women, three times cried out in joyous exclamation: "Wondrous! The Dharma! Wondrous! The Dharma! Wondrous! The Dharma! The very nature of phenomena, the arising of the Tathāgata, has been well spoken by the noble elder Subhūti, and he has declared, shown, expounded, and established it.

Blessed One, from this day forth, we will hold that those bodhisattvas, great beings, who are not separated from this Perfection of Wisdom, and those bodhisattvas, great beings, who abide in this abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom, that this abiding is the Tathāgata himself."

Then the Blessed One spoke to those gods, together with Indra, together with Brahmā, together with the lords of beings, together with the sages, together with that assembly of men and women: "Sons of the gods, so it is, so it is. Sons of the gods, when I was in the midst of the market of the royal city called Dīpavatī, in the presence of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Dīpaṃkara, I was never separated from this Perfection of Wisdom. At that time the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Dīpaṃkara prophesied my unsurpassed, perfect awakening, saying: 'Young brahmin, in a future age, after countless eons, you will become the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha named Śākyamuni, perfect in knowledge and conduct, the Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed guide of persons to be tamed, teacher of gods and humans, the buddha, the Blessed One.'"

Then those sons of the gods said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, it is wondrous that this Perfection of Wisdom of bodhisattvas, great beings, brings about, and sustains them, all the way to omniscience. Sugata, it is truly wondrous."

Thus ends the second chapter, called "Śakra," of the noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines, the third bundle.

Then the Blessed One knew which sons of the gods had gathered and were seated in that assembly, and which assembly of monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen had gathered and were seated. Knowing that those sons of the gods had gathered and were seated, and knowing too that all four assemblies had gathered and were seated, he called as witnesses the sons of the gods who move in the desire realm and in the form realm, the sons of the gods of the Brahmā realm, and the sons of the gods of Luminosity, of Lesser Virtue, and of Akaniṣṭha. And he spoke to the sons of the gods who move in the desire realm, headed by Śakra, lord of the gods, to the sons of the gods of the Brahmā realm, headed by Mahābrahmā, and to the sons of the gods of Luminosity:

"Sons of the gods, if any son or daughter of good family holds, bears, reads, fully understands, or recites this Perfection of Wisdom, then Māra, or gods of Māra's retinue, who watch for an opening and seek an opening, will not find an opening. Sons of the gods, humans or non-humans who watch for an opening and seek an opening will not find an opening against that son or daughter of good family either."

Moreover, that son or daughter of good family will not die an untimely death, and will not do so without having first abandoned the faults of body and speech.

Sons of the gods, furthermore, those sons of the gods who have truly set out toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and those sons of the gods who have not held, borne, read, fully understood, or recited this Perfection of Wisdom, will wish to come into the presence of that son of good family. They will listen to that son of good family who holds, bears, reads, fully understands, and recites this Perfection of Wisdom; and having heard it, they too will come to hold it, bear it, read it, fully understand it, and recite it.

Sons of the gods, furthermore, whether that son or daughter of good family who holds, bears, reads, fully understands, and recites the Perfection of

Wisdom goes to a forest, or to the foot of a tree, or to an empty house, or to an open place without shelter, or goes upon a road, or strays from the road, or goes into a wilderness, or into the great ocean; and whether going, walking, sitting, or lying down in this place or that, no fear and no stiffening of terror will arise or occur in them.

Then the four great kings spoke to the Blessed One as follows: "Blessed One, it is wonderful that the son or daughter of good family who comes to hold, bear, read, fully understand, and recite this Perfection of Wisdom thereby trains beings through the three vehicles, and yet does not give rise to the notion of a being. Blessed One, we shall guard, protect, and shelter that son or daughter of good family who comes to hold, bear, read, fully understand, and recite this Perfection of Wisdom."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, spoke to the Blessed One as follows: "Blessed One, I too shall guard, protect, and shelter those sons or daughters of good family who come to hold, bear, read, fully understand, and recite this Perfection of Wisdom."

Then Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world-system, together with the sons of the gods of the Brahmā realm, also spoke to the Blessed One as follows: "Blessed One, we too shall guard, protect, and shelter that son or daughter of good family who comes to hold, bear, read, fully understand, and recite this Perfection of Wisdom."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, spoke to the Blessed One once more: "Blessed One, it is wonderful that the son or daughter of good family who holds, bears, reads, fully understands, and recites this Perfection of Wisdom will certainly obtain these qualities in this very life and will be fully embraced by them. Blessed One, then, when one holds this Perfection of Wisdom, are all six perfections held?"

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said to Śakra, lord of the gods: "Kauśika, so it is. So it is. Kauśika, by holding the Perfection of Wisdom, all six perfections are held."

Kauśika, furthermore, if a son or daughter of good family holds, bears, reads, fully understands, and recites this Perfection of Wisdom, listen well to all the qualities that such a person will come to hold in this very life, and keep them in mind. I shall explain them to you.

Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the Blessed One, "Excellent!" and listened as the Blessed One had instructed. And the Blessed One spoke thus:

Kauśika, whoever wishes to quarrel with this Dharma, to oppose it, or to contradict it, their quarrels, oppositions, and contradictions, though they arise, will subside again and will not endure. The intentions of those who wish to quarrel, to oppose, and to contradict will not be fulfilled.

Why is this so? Kauśika, it comes about in this way. When a son or daughter of good family holds, bears, reads, fully understands, recites, teaches, explains, expounds, and memorizes this Perfection of Wisdom, whatever grounds for dispute arise against them will subside again and will not endure. The intentions of those who wish to quarrel, to oppose, and to contradict will not be fulfilled.

Kauśika, a son or daughter of good family who holds, bears, reads, fully understands, recites, teaches, explains, expounds, and memorizes this Perfection of Wisdom will also come to hold these further qualities in this very life.

Kauśika, it is like this. Suppose there is a plant called *rtsi ma ghi*, which thoroughly pacifies all poisons. Now a venomous snake, hungry and seeking food, sees some living creature. Wishing to eat it, the snake follows the scent of that creature and pursues it. Then the creature goes to the place where the *rtsi ma ghi* grows and settles there. And the snake, at the mere scent of that plant, turns back. Why is that? The overpowering of the snake's venom should be seen as the medicinal power of that plant. So great is the potency of that plant.

In the same way, Kauśika, for a son or daughter of good family who holds, bears, reads, fully understands, recites, teaches, explains, expounds, and memorizes this Perfection of Wisdom, whatever grounds for dispute, opposition, and contradiction arise are quickly brought to nothing, right where they stand, by the majesty, strength, and power of the Perfection of Wisdom and by the strength that the Perfection of Wisdom generates. They are pacified and do not increase. Wherever they arose, right there they cease and vanish, and they do not endure.

Why is this so? Because the Perfection of Wisdom pacifies all clinging, from attachment and the rest up to *nirvāṇa* itself; it does not cause it to grow.

Kauśika, the Four Great Kings, Śakra, lord of the gods, Brahmā, lord of this world, the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, and all the bodhisattvas as well,

Kauśika, any son or daughter of good family who holds, bears in mind, reads, thoroughly understands, recites, teaches, explains, expounds, and memorizes this Perfection of Wisdom will be protected, defended, and sheltered. In this very life they will come to be endowed with these good qualities.

Furthermore, Kauśika, any son or daughter of good family who holds, bears in mind, reads, thoroughly understands, recites, teaches, explains, expounds, and memorizes this Perfection of Wisdom will have words worthy of being taken to heart. Their words will be gentle, fitting, and free of disorder. They will not be overpowered by anger, nor overpowered by pride.

Why is this so? Because the Perfection of Wisdom thoroughly tames them, and the Perfection of Wisdom thoroughly humbles them. So they do not let anger grow, and they do not let pride grow. They do not hold resentment, they do not harbor malice, and they do not let latent tendencies take hold.

Son or daughter of good family, in one who lives in this way, mindfulness and loving-kindness will arise. Such a one thinks: "If I were to give rise to malice, my faculties would be disturbed and the color of my face would change. I have properly entered upon unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and wish to train in this. It is not fitting for me to fall under the power of anger." And so they quickly regain mindfulness.

Kauśika, any son or daughter of good family who comes to hold, bear in mind, read, thoroughly understand, recite, teach, explain, expound, and memorize this Perfection of Wisdom will also take hold of these good qualities in this very life.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, it is wonderful how this Perfection of Wisdom abides for the sake of the bodhisattvas, the great beings, being thoroughly tamed and free of arrogance."

The Blessed One declared: "Furthermore, Kauśika, suppose a son or daughter of good family comes to hold, bear in mind, read, thoroughly understand, recite, teach, explain, expound, and memorize this Perfection of Wisdom. Suppose such a one, because of holding, bearing in mind, reading, thoroughly understanding, reciting, teaching, explaining, expounding, and memorizing this Perfection of Wisdom, were to be the first to enter the battle when armies

clash. Whether they are entering the battlefield, have entered it, have passed beyond it, or are walking, standing, or sitting within the battlefield, Kauśika, that a son or daughter of good family who keeps in mind, holds, reads, thoroughly understands, recites, teaches, explains, expounds, or memorizes this Perfection of Wisdom should meet with a danger to life is impossible and cannot happen. That they should meet with a danger to life through harm done by others is likewise impossible."

Kauśika, furthermore, if someone were to hurl a stick, a weapon, a clod of earth, or anything else at such a person, it would not strike their body. Why is that? Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a great knowledge-mantra (vidyā). Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is an immeasurable knowledge-mantra. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a boundless knowledge-mantra. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unsurpassed knowledge-mantra. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unequaled knowledge-mantra. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is the knowledge-mantra that equals the unequaled.

Why is that? Kauśika, a son or daughter of good family who trains in this knowledge-mantra does not think of harming themselves, does not think of harming others, and does not think of harming both.

Kauśika, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this knowledge-mantra will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and will attain the wisdom of omniscience. Having become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, they will behold the minds of all sentient beings. Why is that? Kauśika, for a bodhisattva, a great being, who has trained in this knowledge-mantra, there is nothing that is unattained, unknown, or not made directly evident. Therefore it is called the wisdom of omniscience.

Kauśika, a son or daughter of good family who keeps in mind, holds, reads, thoroughly understands, recites, teaches, explains, expounds, and memorizes this Perfection of Wisdom will, in this very life, also take hold of this excellent quality.

Kauśika, furthermore, suppose that in some place this Perfection of Wisdom is written down in a small form and made into a book, and is set down with offerings made beforehand and is honored and revered, but one does not keep it in mind, hold it, read it, thoroughly understand it, recite it, teach it, explain it, expound it, or memorize it. Even there, Kauśika, apart from the ripening of previous karma, humans and non-humans who watch for an opening will not find an opening, even if they look for one. That is impossible. Kauśika, that son

or daughter of good family will, in this very life, also take hold of this excellent quality.

Kauśika, it is just like this. Consider those who sit at the heart of awakening, who sit around the heart of awakening, who sit within the heart of awakening, or who sit at the foot of the tree of awakening, whether humans, non-humans, or even animals. Apart from the ripening of previous karma, humans and non-humans cannot oppress them, harm them, or bring them down. Why is that? Because the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas of the past, the future, and the present, who cultivate and teach fearlessness, freedom from enmity, and freedom from terror toward all sentient beings, have fully awakened there, are fully awakening there, and will fully awaken there, to complete awakening.

In the same way, Kauśika, wherever a son or daughter of good family upholds, retains, reads, masters, recites, teaches, explains, expounds, and memorizes this very Perfection of Wisdom, there, Kauśika, apart from the ripening of previous karma, sentient beings, whether human or non-human, cannot oppress them, harm them, or bring them down. Why is that? Kauśika, it is because this very Perfection of Wisdom has made that place a shrine for beings, a place to be honored, venerated, worshiped, adorned, attended, respected, and treated as a teacher, and has made it a protector, a refuge, a dwelling, and a support for those beings who come to it. Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family also receives these benefits in this very life.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, suppose one son or daughter of good family writes out this Perfection of Wisdom, puts it into book form, and keeps it, and honors it, respects it, treats it as a teacher, venerates it, worships it, adorns it, and attends it with divine flowers, divine incense, divine fragrances, divine garlands, divine unguents, divine powders, divine garments, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and divine pennants, with rows of divine lamps all around, and with many kinds of divine offerings. And suppose another receives and keeps the relics of the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas who have passed into final nirvāṇa, placed within a stūpa, and likewise honors, respects, treats as teachers, venerates, worships, adorns, and attends them with divine flowers, divine incense, divine fragrances, divine garlands, divine unguents, divine powders, divine garments, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and divine pennants, with rows of divine lamps all around, and with many kinds of divine offerings. Of these two sons or

daughters of good family, which one would generate the greater merit?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to Śakra, lord of the gods, as follows: "Kauśika, in that case I shall question you in turn, and you should answer as best you can. Kauśika, what do you think? That which is the realization of the very substance of the omniscience of the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, by training in which path did the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and omniscience, and become fully and completely awakened?"

When he had said this, Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, it was by training in this very Perfection of Wisdom that the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas attained unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and omniscience, and became fully and completely awakened."

The Blessed One said:

"Therefore, Kauśika, it is not by obtaining this physical body of mine that one is counted as a Tathāgata. It is by obtaining omniscience that one is counted as a Tathāgata. Kauśika, the omniscience of the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, arises from the Perfection of Wisdom. And this physical body of the Tathāgata, which has been obtained, also arises from the Perfection of Wisdom together with skillful means, for it has become the support of omniscient wisdom.

"Relying on this support, omniscient wisdom is made manifest. The body of the Buddha is made manifest as well. The body of the Dharma is made manifest, and the body of the Saṅgha is made manifest. Thus, since this physical body, obtained as the cause of omniscient wisdom, has become the support of omniscient wisdom, it becomes a shrine for all beings. It becomes an object of homage, reverence, and honor as one's teacher, an object of veneration, of offering, of adornment, and of devoted service. In the same way, even after I have passed completely beyond sorrow, offerings will be made to those relics as well.

"Therefore, Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to write out this Perfection of Wisdom, place it in a book, and keep it. And suppose they were to honor it with divine flowers, divine incense, divine perfumes, divine garlands, divine unguents, divine powders, divine garments, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and divine pennants, and with divine rows of lamps all around, and with many kinds of divine offerings; and

were to revere it, honor it as a teacher, venerate it, make offerings to it, adorn it, and serve it devotedly. Kauśika, those sons or daughters of good family would generate a very great deal of merit. Why is that? Because that son or daughter of good family will have made an offering to omniscient wisdom.

"But if a son or daughter of good family were to ask about this Perfection of Wisdom, and were to revere, honor as a teacher, venerate, make offerings to, adorn, and devotedly serve this very Perfection of Wisdom set down in a book, offering it many kinds of offerings, they would generate even more merit than the former. Why is that? Kauśika, because whoever makes offerings to the Perfection of Wisdom makes offerings to omniscient wisdom."

When the Blessed One had said this, Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, those people in this Jambudvīpa who do not ask about this Perfection of Wisdom, do not hold it, do not bear it in mind, do not read it, do not fully comprehend it, do not recite it aloud, do not teach it, do not explain it, do not give its transmission, and do not memorize it; who do not honor this Perfection of Wisdom with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, unguents, powders, garments, parasols, banners, bells, and pennants, with rows of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings; who do not revere it, do not honor it as a teacher, do not venerate it, do not make offerings to it, do not adorn it, and do not serve it devotedly..."

Blessed One, did you not understand that making offerings to the Perfection of Wisdom taught by the Blessed One is of such great meaning? Blessed One, did you not realize that making offerings to this Perfection of Wisdom taught by the Blessed One is endowed with such great benefit? Did you not know that its fruit is so great and its karmic ripening so great? Or, though you understood, realized, and knew it, did you nonetheless lack faith?

When this had been said, the Blessed One spoke to Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), saying: "Kauśika, what do you think? Among the people of Jambudvīpa, how many are there who have understood the Buddha and are endowed with faith, who have understood the Dharma and are endowed with faith, and who have understood the Saṅgha and are endowed with faith?"

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, among the people of Jambudvīpa, those who have understood the Buddha and are endowed with faith, who have understood the Dharma and are endowed with faith, and who have understood the Saṅgha and are endowed with faith are few."

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to Śakra, lord of the gods: "Kauśika, so it is, so it is. Among the people of Jambudvīpa, those who have understood the Buddha and are endowed with faith, who have understood the Dharma and are endowed with faith, and who have understood the Saṅgha and are endowed with faith are few.

"Kauśika, those who have attained the fruit of stream-entry are few, yet even fewer than these are those who have attained the fruit of once-returner and the fruit of non-returner. Fewer still than these are those who have attained arhatship. Fewer still are those who realize solitary awakening. Fewer still are those who give rise to the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. Fewer still are those who, having given rise to the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, bring that awakening mind to full growth. Fewer still are those who, having given rise to the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening and brought it to full growth, abide exerting diligence. Fewer still are those who apply themselves to the Perfection of Wisdom. Fewer still are those who practice the Perfection of Wisdom. Fewer still are those who, practicing the Perfection of Wisdom and striving in it, abide on the irreversible bodhisattva ground. Fewer still are those who, practicing the Perfection of Wisdom and striving in it, come to manifestly and completely awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. Fewer still are those who, practicing the Perfection of Wisdom and striving in it, have actually become fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

"Kauśika, there are great bodhisattvas who abide on the irreversible bodhisattva ground and have become fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. And when sons and daughters of good family, possessed of excellent superior intention, train and strive in the Perfection of Wisdom, those buddhas teach this Perfection of Wisdom to others, give them prophecy, and also lead them to take hold of it, and..."

and cause them to hold it, to read it, to fully comprehend it, to recite it, to teach it, to explain it, to give transmission of it, and to memorize it. And such beings are those who honor the Perfection of Wisdom with divine flowers, divine incense, divine perfumes, divine garlands, divine ointments, divine powders, divine garments, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and divine flags, and all around with divine rows of lamps, and with many kinds of divine offerings. They revere it, hold it as their teacher, make gains for it, make offerings to it, adorn it with fine decoration, and attend upon it with

respect.

"Moreover, Kauśika, there are immeasurable, innumerable beings who give rise to the awakening mind, and having given rise to the awakening mind, enlarge the awakening mind, and having fully enlarged the awakening mind, practice for the sake of awakening. Yet, Kauśika, of those immeasurable, innumerable beings who practice for awakening, perhaps only one or two come to abide on the irreversible bodhisattva ground. Why is that? Kauśika, unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening is hard to accomplish for those of feeble diligence, for the lazy, for those of lowly thought, lowly mind, lowly perception, lowly inclination, and lowly wisdom.

"Therefore, Kauśika, any son or daughter of good family who wishes to become fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening quickly and with ease should, without interruption, listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, take hold of it, hold it, read it, fully comprehend it, recite it, teach it, explain it, give transmission of it, memorize it, and inquire into it thoroughly. Why is that? Kauśika, those sons or daughters of good family should think thus: 'When the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas of the past were practicing the conduct of bodhisattvas, they trained in this very Perfection of Wisdom in this way. So we too shall train in it.' They should understand: 'This Perfection of Wisdom is our Teacher.' For, Kauśika, whether the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas remain or have passed into complete nirvāṇa, great bodhisattvas must rely on this very Perfection of Wisdom.

"Therefore, Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family, in order to honor a Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly awakened buddha who has passed into complete nirvāṇa, were to have made many millions of stūpas, made of the seven precious substances and containing the relics of the Tathāgata as their essence. And having made them, for as long as they lived they were to honor them with divine flowers, divine incense, divine perfumes, divine garlands, divine ointments, divine powders, divine garments, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and divine flags, and all around with divine rows of lamps, and with many kinds of divine offerings, revering them, holding them as their teacher, making gains for them, making offerings to them, adorning them with fine decoration, and attending upon them with respect. Kauśika, what do you think? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?"

Śakra (Indra) replied:

"Blessed One, it would be much. Sugata, it would be much."

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, yet this son or daughter of good family generates far more merit than that. Whoever has faith in this Perfection of Wisdom, reflects on it, is devoted to it, and, with a clear and confident mind, has generated the awakening mind; and who, with superior intention, listens to it, upholds it, bears it in mind, recites it, comprehends it thoroughly, reads it aloud, teaches it, explains it closely, gives its transmission, memorizes it, and also teaches it extensively and correctly to others; who explains its meaning, contemplates it with the mind, and examines it here with wisdom in accord with how it is established; and who does so thinking, 'May the lineage of the buddhas not be cut off, and may the sacred Dharma not vanish,' and thereby makes the sacred Dharma endure for a long time; and who, never separated from this approach, accomplishes benefit for the bodhisattvas, the great beings; who, even if it is only a short text, has it set down in a book and holds it, or places it in a shrine, and honors that Perfection of Wisdom with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, garments, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, and all around with rows of lamps and many kinds of offerings; who reveres it, holds it as a teacher, makes gains for it, makes offerings to it, adorns it with fine decoration, and attends upon it with respect. Kauśika, this very son or daughter of good family generates a far greater mass of merit than that.

"Kauśika, let alone many millions of stūpas made of the seven precious substances and containing relics of the Tathāgata. Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to have this entire Jambudvīpa filled with stūpas made of the seven precious substances, containing relics of the Tathāgata. And having done so, for as long as they lived they were to honor them with divine flowers, divine incense, divine perfumes, divine garlands, divine ointments, divine powders, divine garments, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and divine flags, and all around with divine rows of lamps, and with many kinds of divine offerings, revering them, holding them as their teacher, making gains for them, making offerings to them, adorning them with fine decoration, and attending upon them with respect. Kauśika, what do you think? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?"

Śakra (Indra) replied: "Blessed One, it would be much. Sugata, it would be much."

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, yet this son or daughter of good family generates far more merit than that. Whoever has faith in this Perfection of Wisdom, reflects on it, is devoted to it, and, with a clear and confident mind, has generated the awakening mind; and who, with superior intention, listens to it, upholds it, bears it in mind, recites it, comprehends it thoroughly, reads it aloud, teaches it, explains it closely, gives its transmission, memorizes it, and also teaches it extensively and correctly to others; who explains its meaning, contemplates it with the mind, and examines it here with wisdom in accord with how it is established; and who does so thinking, 'May the lineage of the buddhas not be cut off, and may the sacred Dharma not vanish,' and thereby makes the sacred Dharma endure for a long time;"

and who, not departing from the proper way, does what benefits bodhisattvas, the great beings; who writes this Perfection of Wisdom in a small scroll or book and keeps it, or places it respectfully, and honors it with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, unguents, powders, robes, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, and with rows of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings; who shows it reverence, treats it as a teacher, esteems it, makes offerings to it, adorns it with fine decoration, and attends upon it with respect: this son or daughter of good family generates far greater merit than that.

Kauśika, let alone this Jambudvīpa filled with stūpas that are made of the seven precious substances and contain the relics of the Tathāgatas. Kauśika, suppose that all the beings who dwell in a world system of the four great continents were each made to build a stūpa of the seven precious substances containing the relics of the Tathāgatas. And suppose that, for as long as they lived, they honored those stūpas with divine flowers, divine incense, divine perfumes, divine garlands, divine unguents, divine powders, divine robes, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and divine flags, and with rows of divine lamps all around, and with many kinds of divine offerings; and showed them reverence, treated them as teachers, esteemed them, made offerings to them, adorned them with fine decoration, and attended upon them with respect. Kauśika, what do you think? Would all those beings generate great merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra) replied: Blessed One, they would generate much. Sugata, they would generate much.

The Blessed One declared: Kauśika, even more merit than that is generated by this son or daughter of good family who has clear faith in this Perfection of Wisdom, who reflects on it and is inclined toward it with a serene mind, who has generated the awakening mind, and who, with superior intention, listens to it, upholds it, bears it in mind, reads it, comprehends it thoroughly, recites it aloud, teaches it, explains it closely, gives its transmission, and memorizes it; who also teaches it extensively and correctly to others, explains its meaning, contemplates it with the mind, and examines it here with wisdom in accord with how it is established; who does so thinking, "May the lineage of the buddhas not be cut off, and may the sacred Dharma not vanish," and thereby makes the sacred Dharma endure for a long time; and who, not departing from the proper way, does what benefits bodhisattvas, the great beings; who writes this Perfection of Wisdom in a small scroll or book and keeps it, or places it respectfully, and honors it with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, unguents, powders, robes, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, and with rows of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings; who shows it reverence, treats it as a teacher, esteems it, makes offerings to it, adorns it with fine decoration, and attends upon it with respect: this son or daughter of good family generates far greater merit on that basis.

Kauśika, let alone all the beings of a world system of the four great continents. Kauśika, suppose that all the beings who dwell in a thousandfold world system were each made to build a stūpa of the seven precious substances containing the relics of the Tathāgatas.

And suppose that for as long as they lived, these beings were to honor those stūpas with divine flowers, divine incense, divine perfumes, divine garlands, divine unguents, divine powders, divine garments, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and divine flags, and with divine rows of lamps all around, and with many kinds of divine offerings; and suppose they showed them reverence, treated them as a teacher, esteemed them, made offerings to them, adorned them with fine decoration, and attended upon them with respect. Kauśika, what do you think? Would all those beings generate much merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra) replied: Blessed One, it would be much. Sugata, it would be much.

The Blessed One declared: Kauśika, a son or daughter of good family generates far greater merit than that. This is the one who has faith in this

Perfection of Wisdom, who considers it and inclines toward it, whose mind is clear and confident, and who, having generated the mind of awakening, with a superior intention listens to it, upholds it, retains it, reads it, comprehends it fully, recites it, teaches it, instructs others in it, gives its transmission, memorizes it, and expounds it extensively and correctly to others as well. Such a one explains its meaning, reflects on it with the mind, and examines it thoroughly with the wisdom that has been attained. Thinking, "May the lineage of the buddhas not be cut off; may the sacred Dharma not vanish," that person makes the sacred Dharma endure for a long time. Not departing from the proper way, that person accomplishes benefit for the bodhisattvas, the great beings. Or, if it is a small version, that person has it written down in a book and keeps it, or places it somewhere, and honors that Perfection of Wisdom with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, unguents, powders, garments, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, and with rows of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings; shows it reverence, treats it as a teacher, esteems it, makes offerings to it, adorns it with fine decoration, and attends upon it with respect. Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family generates far greater merit on that basis.

Kauśika, let alone all the beings of a thousandfold world system. Kauśika, consider also the beings in the middle, twofold thousandfold world system, however many there may be. Suppose that each and every one of them were made to build a stūpa of the seven precious substances, each with the relics of the Tathāgatas as its core. And suppose that for as long as they lived, they were to honor those stūpas with divine flowers, divine incense, divine perfumes, divine garlands, divine unguents, divine powders, divine garments, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and divine flags, and with divine rows of lamps all around, and with many kinds of divine offerings; and suppose they showed them reverence, treated them as a teacher, esteemed them, made offerings to them, adorned them with fine decoration, and attended upon them with respect. Kauśika, what do you think? Would all those beings generate much merit on that basis?

Śakra replied: Blessed One, it would be much. Sugata, it would be much.

The Blessed One declared: Kauśika, a son or daughter of good family generates far greater merit than that. This is the one who has faith in this Perfection of Wisdom, who considers it and inclines toward it, whose mind is clear and confident, and who, having generated the mind of awakening,

with superior intention listens to it, holds it, bears it in mind, reads it, comprehends it, recites it, teaches it, expounds it closely, gives its transmission, memorizes it, and also explains it widely and rightly to others, who unravels its meaning, reflects upon it with the mind, and examines it thoroughly with wisdom, as it is truly established; who, thinking, "May the lineage of the buddhas not be cut off; may the sacred Dharma not vanish," works to make the sacred Dharma endure for a long time; and who, in a way that is not divorced from the proper manner, brings about benefit for the bodhisattvas, the great beings. And if, even in small measure, such a person has it set down in a book and keeps it, or places it in a shrine, and makes offerings to that Perfection of Wisdom with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, robes, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, with rings of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings, showing reverence, treating it as a teacher, esteeming it, making offerings to it, adorning it, and attending upon it with respect, then, Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family generates, on that basis alone, extremely great merit.

Kauśika, set aside all the beings of a middle world system of two thousand worlds. Kauśika, consider also all the beings there are in the world system of the great trichiliocosm, the three-thousandfold great thousand. Suppose each one of those beings were made to build a stūpa made of the seven precious substances, each containing relics of the Tathāgata at its heart. And suppose that for as long as they lived, they made offerings to those stūpas with divine flowers, divine incense, divine perfumes, divine garlands, divine ointments, divine powders, divine robes, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and divine flags, with rings of divine lamps all around, and with many kinds of divine offerings, showing reverence, treating them as a teacher, esteeming them, making offerings to them, adorning them, and attending upon them with respect. Kauśika, what do you think? Would all those beings generate much merit on that basis?

Śakra replied: Blessed One, it would be much. Sugata, it would be much.

The Blessed One declared: Kauśika, a son or daughter of good family generates far greater merit than that. This is the one who has faith in this Perfection of Wisdom, who considers it and inclines toward it, whose mind is clear and confident, and who, having generated the mind of awakening, with superior intention listens to it, holds it, bears it in mind, reads it, comprehends it, recites it, teaches it, expounds it closely, gives its transmission, memorizes it, and also explains it widely and rightly to others, who unravels its meaning,

reflects upon it with the mind, and examines it thoroughly with wisdom, as it is truly established; who, thinking, "May the lineage of the buddhas not be cut off; may the sacred Dharma not vanish," works to make the sacred Dharma endure for a long time; and who, in a way that is not divorced from the proper manner, brings about benefit for the bodhisattvas, the great beings. And if, even in small measure, such a person has it set down in a book and keeps it, or places it in a shrine, and makes offerings to that Perfection of Wisdom with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, robes, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, with rings of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings, showing reverence, treating it as a teacher, esteeming it, making offerings to it, adorning it, and attending upon it with respect.

Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family generates, on that basis, far greater merit. Kauśika, suppose that every being in the world-system of a great trichiliocosm were each to have built a stūpa made of the seven precious substances, each holding at its core relics of the Tathāgata. And suppose that, for as long as they lived, they honored those stūpas with divine flowers, divine incense, divine perfumes, divine garlands, divine ointments, divine powders, divine robes, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and divine flags, with rings of divine lamps all around, and with many kinds of divine offerings; and that they showed reverence, treated them as a teacher, esteemed them, made offerings to them, adorned them, and attended upon them with respect. Let that stand.

Further, Kauśika, suppose that all the beings there are in the world-system of a great trichiliocosm were counted up, and that all of them, without exception, obtained human bodies. And suppose that each one of those beings in turn had caused to be built a stūpa made of the seven precious substances, holding relics of the Tathāgata at its core. And having had them built, suppose that each being placed all those stūpas before them and, for an eon or more than an eon, honored them with all cymbals, all songs and melodies, all dances, all music and instruments, with divine flowers, divine incense, divine perfumes, divine garlands, divine ointments, divine powders, divine robes, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and all divine flags, with rings of divine lamps all around, and with all the many kinds of offerings of gods and humans; that they showed reverence, treated them as a teacher, esteemed them, made offerings to them, adorned them, and attended upon them with respect. And suppose that, by the merit of that very nature, all those beings had caused immeasurable and countless stūpas to be built, and had made

offerings of such a nature as well.

Kauśika, what do you think? Would all those beings generate great merit on that basis?

Indra said: Blessed One, they would generate much. Sugata, they would generate much.

The Blessed One declared: Kauśika, even so, that son or daughter of good family generates far greater merit than that. It is the one who has faith in this Perfection of Wisdom, reflects on it, and is drawn to it; who, with a joyful mind, has given rise to the mind of awakening; who, with a superior intention, listens to it, upholds it, explains it, reads it, comprehends it fully, recites it, teaches it, instructs others in it, gives transmission of it, memorizes it, and expounds it extensively and correctly to others; who unfolds its meaning, contemplates it with the mind, and examines it here with wisdom as it is truly established. It is the one who does so with the thought, "May the lineage of the buddhas not be cut off; may the sublime Dharma not vanish," that is, so that the sublime Dharma may remain for a long time; and who, in a way that is not divorced from the proper manner, brings about benefit for the bodhisattvas, the great beings. And if, even in small measure, such a person has it set down in a book and keeps it, or places it in a shrine, and makes offerings to that Perfection of Wisdom with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, robes, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, with rings of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings.

honors it, reveres it, esteems it, makes offerings to it, depicts it in paintings, and serves it with respect, then, Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family generates abundant great merit on that basis.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, Śakra, the lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One: "So it is, Blessed One. So it is, Sugata. Blessed One, that son or daughter of good family who honors this Perfection of Wisdom, reveres it, esteems it, makes offerings to it, depicts it in paintings, and serves it with respect, will thereby have deeply honored, revered, esteemed, made offerings to, depicted, and served with respect all the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, past, future, and present, who dwell in all the world systems fully known by the buddha wisdom of the buddhas.

"Blessed One, setting aside all the sentient beings of a world system of a great trichiliocosm, consider this further, Blessed One. Suppose that in as many great trichiliocosmic world systems as there are grains of sand in the River

Ganges, there were as many sentient beings as exist, and each one of those beings were to be given a stūpa of the Tathāgata, made of the seven precious substances and containing relics at its heart. And having been given these, suppose each of those beings were to place all those stūpas before them, and for an eon or longer were to make offerings with all kinds of cymbals and music, with all kinds of song, with all kinds of dance, with all kinds of instruments and rhythmic clapping, and with all divine flowers, divine incense, divine perfumes, divine garlands, divine ointments, divine powders, divine robes, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and all divine flags, with rings of divine lamps all around, and with many kinds of divine offerings, honoring, revering, esteeming, offering to, depicting, and serving them with respect.

"Blessed One, this son or daughter of good family would generate far more merit than that. For such a person has firm faith in this Perfection of Wisdom, takes it up with understanding, conviction, and a clear mind, and has generated the awakening mind toward awakening. With superior intention that person listens to it, holds it, retains it, reads it, comprehends it fully, recites it, teaches it, instructs others in it, gives its transmission, and memorizes it. That person also expounds it extensively and correctly to others, explains its meaning, contemplates it in the mind as a real object, and examines it thoroughly with wisdom, according to how it is established. With the thought, 'May the lineage of the buddhas not be cut off; may the sublime Dharma not vanish,' that is, so that the sublime Dharma may remain for a long time, and in a way that is not divorced from the proper manner, that person brings about benefit for the bodhisattvas, the great beings. And if, even in small measure, such a person has it set down in a book and keeps it, or places it in a shrine, and makes offerings to that Perfection of Wisdom with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, robes, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, with rings of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings, honoring it, revering it, esteeming it, making offerings to it, depicting it, and serving it with respect, then, Blessed One, that son or daughter of good family generates far more merit than that."

Then the Blessed One said this to Śakra, the lord of the gods: "Kauśika, so it is, so it is."

Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family generates, on that basis, a great deal of merit. Kauśika, on that basis that son or daughter of good family generates immeasurable merit. Kauśika, on that basis that son or daughter of

good family generates incalculable merit. Kauśika, on that basis that son or daughter of good family generates inconceivable merit. Kauśika, on that basis that son or daughter of good family generates incomparable merit. Kauśika, on that basis that son or daughter of good family generates limitless merit.

Why is that? Kauśika, the omniscience of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, is born from the Perfection of Wisdom, and the offerings made to the body of a Tathāgata are likewise born from omniscience.

Therefore, Kauśika, suppose a son or daughter of good family has genuine faith in this Perfection of Wisdom, reflects on it, is drawn to it, and with a clear and serene mind has generated the mind of awakening. With a superior intention, that person listens to it, holds it, retains it, reads it, comprehends it fully, recites it aloud, teaches it, instructs others in it, receives its transmission, memorizes it, and extensively and correctly explains it to others as well. That person also explains its meaning, reflects on it in the mind, and examines it thoroughly here with wisdom as it truly is. With the thought, "May the lineage of the buddhas not be severed; may the sacred Dharma not vanish," that person works so that the sacred Dharma may endure for a long time. And in order that benefit may be accomplished for the bodhisattvas, the great beings, through the Dharma not being separated from its proper manner of presentation, that person has it set down in a book and keeps it, or places it in a shrine, and makes offerings to that Perfection of Wisdom with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, robes, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, with rings of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings. If that person honors it, reveres it, esteems it, makes offerings to it, depicts it, and serves it with respect, then, Kauśika, compared with the merit produced by honoring a stūpa of the seven precious substances that holds the relics of the Tathāgata as its core, that earlier merit does not approach even a hundredth part of this, nor a thousandth part, nor a hundred-thousandth part, nor a ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-ten-millionth part, nor a thousand-ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-thousand-ten-millionth part, nor even a hundred-thousandth of a vast multiple of ten million. It does not approach it in number, nor in fraction, nor in calculation, nor in analogy. It cannot be shown by comparison, and it cannot bear comparison as a basis or as a cause.

Then forty thousand sons of the gods, who had gathered in that assembly and were seated there together with Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to Śakra, lord of the gods: "Friend, take up the Perfection of Wisdom! Friend, the Perfection

of Wisdom is to be taken up. Friend, the Perfection of Wisdom is to be held. Friend, the Perfection of Wisdom is to be read. Friend, the Perfection of Wisdom is to be fully comprehended. Friend, the Perfection of Wisdom is to be recited aloud. Friend, the Perfection of Wisdom is to be taught. Friend, the Perfection of Wisdom is to be explained to others. Friend, the Perfection of Wisdom is to be received through transmission. Friend, the Perfection of Wisdom is to be memorized."

Then the Blessed One said this to Śakra, lord of the gods: "Kauśika, take up this Perfection of Wisdom! Kauśika, hold the Perfection of Wisdom! Kauśika, read the Perfection of Wisdom! Kauśika, fully comprehend the Perfection of Wisdom! Kauśika, recite the Perfection of Wisdom aloud! Kauśika, teach the Perfection of Wisdom! Kauśika, explain the Perfection of Wisdom closely to others! Kauśika, receive the Perfection of Wisdom through transmission! Kauśika, memorize the Perfection of Wisdom!

"Why is this? Kauśika, whenever such a movement of mind arises among the asuras, and they think, 'Let us fight the gods of the Thirty-Three! Let us wage war together with the gods of the Thirty-Three,' then, Kauśika, you should bring to mind this Perfection of Wisdom and recite it aloud, and those very movements of mind in the asuras will subside."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom is a great spell of knowledge (vidyā). Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom is a spell of knowledge that is immeasurable. Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom is a spell of knowledge that is limitless. Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom is a spell of knowledge that has nothing higher. Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unsurpassed spell of knowledge. Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom is a spell of knowledge that has no equal. Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom is a spell of knowledge that is equal to the unequaled."

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to Śakra, lord of the gods: "So it is, Kauśika, so it is. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a great spell of knowledge. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a spell of knowledge that is immeasurable. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a spell of knowledge that is limitless. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a spell of knowledge that has nothing higher. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is an unsurpassed spell of knowledge. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a spell of knowledge that has no equal. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is a spell of knowledge that is

equal to the unequalled.

"Why is this? Kauśika, it is in dependence on this spell of knowledge, the Perfection of Wisdom, that the buddhas of the past, the Tathāgatas, arhats, fully and perfectly awakened ones, became fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening."

Kauśika, as many tathāgatas, arhats, fully and perfectly awakened buddhas as will appear in the future, and who will become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, all of them, Kauśika, will become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening in dependence on this very spell of knowledge, the Perfection of Wisdom.

Kauśika, as for the blessed buddhas who at present, in immeasurable and countless world systems, the great thousand of the three thousand, are becoming fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, they too, Kauśika, become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening in dependence on this very spell of knowledge, the Perfection of Wisdom. And I too, Kauśika, became fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening in dependence on this very spell of knowledge, the Perfection of Wisdom.

Kauśika, in dependence on this spell of knowledge, the paths of the ten virtuous actions are also made known in the world. The four meditative concentrations, which possess the factors of awakening, are made known in the world. The four immeasurables, which possess the factors of awakening, are made known in the world. The four formless absorptions, which possess the factors of awakening, are made known in the world. The six higher knowledges, which possess the factors of awakening, are made known in the world. The thirty-seven factors that lead to awakening are also made known in the world. In short, the eighty-four thousand aggregates of Dharma are also made known in the world. The wisdom of the buddhas, the self-arisen wisdom, and the inconceivable wisdom are also made known in the world.

This is the end of the fourth section of the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Kauśika, even at a time when tathāgatas, arhats, fully and perfectly awakened buddhas do not appear in the world, then too, Kauśika, in dependence on this very spell of knowledge, the Perfection of Wisdom, bodhisattvas, great beings, come to possess skillful means through having heard, in the past, what accords with the cause of the Perfection of Wisdom. Kauśika, those who are

endowed with loving concern for sentient beings, out of that concern, rely on this world and make known in the world the paths of the ten virtuous actions. They make known in the world the four meditative concentrations that do not possess the factors of awakening. They make known in the world the four immeasurables that do not possess the factors of awakening. They make known in the world the four formless absorptions that do not possess the factors of awakening. They make known in the world the five higher knowledges that do not possess the factors of awakening.

Kauśika, it is just as, in dependence on the disk of the moon, all the medicinal herbs and stars become visible, each according to its strength and power, and the moving stars too shine, each according to its strength and power. In the same way, Kauśika, when the tathāgatas, arhats, fully and perfectly awakened buddhas have passed away and the sacred Dharma has disappeared, and when tathāgatas, arhats, fully and perfectly awakened buddhas have not appeared in the world,

Whatever practice in conformity with the Dharma, whatever peaceful practice, and whatever virtuous practice is taken up and cultivated in the world, all of it arises from bodhisattvas and is distinguished by bodhisattvas. It proceeds from the skillful means of bodhisattvas, and that skillful means of bodhisattvas should be understood as arising from the Perfection of Wisdom.

Furthermore, Kauśika, sons and daughters of good family who hold this Perfection of Wisdom, bear it in mind, read it, thoroughly understand it, recite it, teach it, explain it, expound it, memorize it, write it down, reflect on it, and remember it, may expect many benefits in this very life on that basis.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, what are the benefits in this life that those sons and daughters of good family will possess?

The Blessed One said: Kauśika, those sons and daughters of good family will not die before their time. They will not die from poison. They will not die from weapons. They will not die from fire. They will not die from water. They will not die from a staff. They will not die from harm inflicted by others. Even if a king, a prince, a great minister, or a minister should try to harm them, the harm will turn back from those who remember and recite this Perfection of Wisdom. And if any who watch for an opening or seek an opening against those who repeatedly remember and recite this Perfection of Wisdom should approach that king, prince, great minister, or minister, they will not find an opening. This

is because those sons and daughters of good family are upheld by the Perfection of Wisdom.

Even when kings, princes, great ministers, or ministers come near them, they will wish to speak and converse, and will think, "I shall bring them true delight." Why is that? Kauśika, because this Perfection of Wisdom abides in the presence of all sentient beings, accomplishing loving-kindness with a mind of loving-kindness and accomplishing compassion with a mind of compassion.

For that very reason, Kauśika, when sons or daughters of good family go into a wilderness filled with many fierce beasts and venomous snakes, then humans or nonhumans who watch for an opening or seek an opening against them will find no opening, Kauśika, except through the ripening of previous karma.

Then some non-Buddhist wanderers, with the intention of finding fault, came at that time to where the Blessed One was. Then Śakra, lord of the gods, saw those non-Buddhist wanderers coming from afar, and he considered in his mind: "These non-Buddhist wanderers are coming to where the Blessed One is with the intention of finding fault. Somehow I must see to it that these wanderers do not come near to the Blessed One."

"Whatever portion of this Perfection of Wisdom I have received from the Blessed One, I shall keep in mind, reflect upon, recite from memory, and recite aloud. If I do so, there will be no obstacle to the teaching of this Perfection of Wisdom." So he thought.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, kept in mind, reflected upon, recited from memory, and recited aloud whatever portion of this Perfection of Wisdom he had received from the Blessed One. And those other non-Buddhist wanderers, who had been roaming about, circled the Blessed One from a great distance, even farther than far, and turned back by the very gate and the very road by which they had come, and went away.

Then the venerable Śāriputra thought: "Why is it that these other non-Buddhist wanderers, from a great distance, even farther than far, circle the Blessed One and turn back by that same gate and that same road, and go away?"

Then the Blessed One, knowing with his mind the thought in the mind of the venerable Śāriputra, spoke to him in this way: "Śāriputra, Śakra, lord of the gods, saw the minds of those other non-Buddhist wanderers, who were intent on finding fault. He thought, 'It would not be right if they were to obstruct the teaching of this Perfection of Wisdom. May those other non-Buddhist

wanderers not come while the Perfection of Wisdom is being taught.' So, in order to turn back those wanderers who wished to quarrel, who wished to dispute, who wished to contradict, he kept this Perfection of Wisdom in mind, reflected upon it, recited it from memory, and recited it aloud. And I too have given my approval, just as Śakra, lord of the gods, did. Why is that? Śāriputra, I have not seen a single one of those other non-Buddhist wanderers who possesses even a white, wholesome quality. Śāriputra, all of them wished to come with the intention of finding fault and with a mind of hostility."

Then the evil Māra thought: "These four assemblies of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, are gathered and seated before the Tathāgata. And these sons of the gods who move in the desire realm and the form realm are also present. Surely here the bodhisattvas, the great beings, will be prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. So that their eyes may not be set at ease, I shall draw near and disturb them." Then the evil Māra conjured up an army of four divisions and approached the place where the Blessed One was.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, thought: "Alas! This is the evil Māra, who has conjured up an army of four divisions and has come to where the Blessed One is. But this array of an army of four divisions is not the array of the four-division army of King Bimbisāra. It is not the array of the four-division army of King Prasenajit. It is not the array of the four-division army of the Śākya. It is not the array of the four-division army of the Licchavis. This has been conjured up by the evil Māra.

"The evil Māra has long been watching for an opening against the Blessed One, seeking an opportunity, and bearing ill will toward sentient beings. Now I shall reflect on this Perfection of Wisdom with mindfulness, I shall commit it to memory, and I shall recite it aloud." So he thought.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, reflected on this very Perfection of Wisdom with mindfulness, committed it to memory, and recited it aloud. As Śakra, lord of the gods, reflected on the Perfection of Wisdom with mindfulness, committed it to memory, and recited it aloud, so the evil Māra turned back, going away by that very gate and that very road.

Then the sons of the gods of the Thirty-Three conjured up divine mandārava flowers. Remaining in the open space of the sky, they scattered those divine mandārava flowers abundantly toward the place where the Blessed One was. And they joyfully exclaimed: "Ah! This Perfection of Wisdom has appeared,

after a long time, among the people of Jambudvīpa!" Then, taking up more divine flowers, they scattered them abundantly over the Blessed One, and said:

"Blessed One, those beings who explain the Perfection of Wisdom, who meditate on it, and who practice the Perfection of Wisdom will not be given an opening by Māra or by the gods of Māra's host. Blessed One, those beings who listen to this Perfection of Wisdom, who hear it and hold it, who bear it in mind, read it, fully comprehend it, recite it aloud, teach it, explain it, expound it, and commit it to memory, are not endowed with roots of virtue that are poor or lowly. Blessed One, even those beings in whose ears this Perfection of Wisdom has merely resounded have, surely, done service to the buddhas of the past. How much more so those who hold it, bear it in mind, read it, fully comprehend it, recite it aloud, teach it, explain it, expound it, and commit it to memory, and who train in accord with suchness, practice in accord with suchness, and apply themselves to yoga in accord with suchness! Blessed One, those beings have honored and attended the Tathāgata.

Why is this? Because from this Perfection of Wisdom omniscience is distinguished, and it is from this that omniscience is to be sought. Blessed One, it is just as with any precious jewels or great precious jewels whatsoever: all of these are revealed by the great ocean, and all of them are to be sought from the great ocean. In the same way, Blessed One, the great precious jewel of omniscience is to be sought from the great ocean of the Perfection of Wisdom of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas."

When they had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to Śakra, lord of the gods: "Kauśika, so it is, so it is. The great precious jewel of omniscience of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, is born from this great ocean of the Perfection of Wisdom."

Then the venerable Ānanda said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, you do not speak in praise of the perfection of generosity, nor do you proclaim its name far and wide. Nor that of the perfection of moral discipline, nor of the perfection of patience, nor of the perfection of diligence. Blessed One, you do not speak in praise of the perfection of meditative concentration, nor do you proclaim its name far and wide. Yet the Blessed One speaks in praise of the Perfection of Wisdom alone, and proclaims its name far and wide."

The Blessed One said: "So it is, Ānanda, so it is. I speak in praise of the Perfection of Wisdom alone and proclaim its name; I do not do so for the other perfections. Why is that? Ānanda, the Perfection of Wisdom goes before the other five perfections, and it is for this reason that they obtain the name of perfection.

"Ānanda, what do you think? Could a gift that has not been fully dedicated to omniscience obtain the name of the perfection of generosity?"

Ānanda replied: "Blessed One, it could not."

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, what do you think? In the same way, could moral discipline that has not been fully dedicated, patience that has not been fully dedicated, diligence that has not been fully dedicated, or meditative concentration that has not been fully dedicated obtain the name of perfection? And Ānanda, what do you think? Could wisdom that has not been fully dedicated to omniscience obtain the name of the Perfection of Wisdom?"

Ānanda replied: "Blessed One, it could not."

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, what do you think? Is the wisdom that fully dedicates all roots of virtue to omniscience inconceivable?"

Ānanda replied: "So it is, Blessed One. The wisdom that fully dedicates all roots of virtue to omniscience is inconceivable. Blessed One, it is supremely inconceivable."

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, therefore, because it is so excellent, it obtains the name of the Perfection of Wisdom; and it is through it that the roots of virtue fully dedicated to omniscience obtain the name of perfection. Therefore, Ānanda, because all roots of virtue are fully dedicated to omniscience, the Perfection of Wisdom goes before the five perfections and leads them fully onward. In this way the five perfections are gathered within the Perfection of Wisdom alone.

"Ānanda, the term Perfection of Wisdom is a designation for the full completion of all six perfections. Therefore, Ānanda, when the Perfection of Wisdom is proclaimed, all six perfections are proclaimed.

"Ānanda, it is like this. When seeds are sown in the great earth and meet with the right gathering of conditions, they grow. The great earth is the ground of those seeds, and so it is in reliance on the great earth that those seeds grow. In just the same way, Ānanda, the five perfections, being held fully by the Perfection of Wisdom, rely on omniscience; and in reliance on the Perfection of

Wisdom the five perfections come to arise. Because they are held fully by the Perfection of Wisdom, they obtain the name of perfection."

"Ānanda, therefore this very Perfection of Wisdom goes before the five perfections, and leads them, and fully guides them."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, when a son or daughter of good family takes up and holds this Perfection of Wisdom, reads it, comprehends it fully, recites it aloud, teaches it, expounds it, gives the transmission of it, and rehearses it from memory, whatever qualities such a person comes to possess, have not all those qualities of the Perfection of Wisdom been proclaimed by the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened Buddha? And yet I myself have taken up and recited only one portion of this Perfection of Wisdom, which I received directly from the Blessed One."

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika (Indra), excellent, excellent! And yet, Kauśika, it is not only those who take up, hold, read, comprehend, recite, teach, expound, give the transmission of, and rehearse this Perfection of Wisdom to whom these qualities come. Kauśika, consider a son or daughter of good family who, thinking, 'May the lineage of the buddhas not be severed; may the sacred Dharma not vanish,' and wishing the sacred Dharma to endure for a long time, and so that benefit may be accomplished for bodhisattvas, the great beings, without departing from the proper way, writes out this Perfection of Wisdom, places it in a book, and holds it or keeps it. That person honors that Perfection of Wisdom with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, cloth, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, with rings of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings. They show it reverence, regard it as their teacher, esteem it, make offerings to it, adorn it with paintings, and attend upon it with respect. Kauśika, the qualities of that son or daughter of good family, even in this very life, I have already described."

When this had been said, Śakra, lord of the gods, spoke to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, whoever, thinking, 'May the lineage of the buddhas not be severed; may the sacred Dharma not vanish,' and wishing the sacred Dharma to endure for a long time, and so that benefit may be accomplished for bodhisattvas, the great beings, without departing from the proper way, writes out this Perfection of Wisdom, places it in a book, and holds it or keeps it, and honors that Perfection of Wisdom with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, cloth, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, with rings of

lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings, showing it reverence, regarding it as their teacher, esteeming it, making offerings to it, adorning it with paintings, and attending upon it with respect: I shall guard, protect, and shelter that son or daughter of good family. And what need is there to speak of those who also ask about this Perfection of Wisdom, take it up, hold it, read it, comprehend it fully, recite it aloud, teach it, expound it, give the transmission of it, and rehearse it from memory, and who honor it with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, cloth, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, with rings of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings, showing it reverence, regarding it as their teacher, esteeming it, making offerings to it, adorning it with paintings, and attending upon it with respect?"

The Blessed One said: "Excellent, excellent, Kauśika! Furthermore, Kauśika, when that son or daughter of good family recites this Perfection of Wisdom aloud, then and there many hundreds of gods' sons will come. Many thousands of gods' sons, and many hundreds of thousands of gods' sons, will come close in order to hear the Dharma. As those gods' sons listen to the Dharma, they will think, 'Let us support the eloquence of this speaker of the Dharma.' And whenever that speaker of the Dharma wishes to fall silent, even then, through their very reverence for the Dharma, those gods' sons will resolve to support that son or daughter of good family with eloquence, according to the way the speaker is inclined to speak.

"Kauśika, the son or daughter of good family who holds, bears in mind, reads, comprehends fully, recites aloud, teaches, expounds, gives the transmission of, and rehearses from memory this Perfection of Wisdom will in this very life take hold of these further qualities as well.

"Furthermore, Kauśika, when that son or daughter of good family teaches this Perfection of Wisdom, they will not become timid before the assembly, thinking, 'Someone might challenge me, intending to find fault.' Why is that? Because the Perfection of Wisdom guards, protects, and shelters them. One who abides in the Perfection of Wisdom does not perceive, in truth, any fault-finding. One who abides in the Perfection of Wisdom does not perceive, in truth, anyone who finds fault. Nor does such a one perceive, in truth, anyone to be found fault with. And the Perfection of Wisdom itself they do not perceive, in truth. In this way, no challenge whatsoever arises, by any line of argument, against the son or daughter of good family who is held by the Perfection of Wisdom. Nor will that person be possessed of dread, either of others or of self, or of any thorough fear.

"Kauśika, the son or daughter of good family who holds, bears in mind, reads, comprehends fully, recites aloud, teaches, expounds, gives the transmission of, and rehearses from memory this Perfection of Wisdom will in this very life take hold of these further qualities as well.

"Furthermore, Kauśika, such sons and daughters of good family will be dear to their parents, friends, ministers, kinsmen, blood relations, and to ascetics and brahmins. Should opponents arise, they will have the strength and the ability to refute them in accordance with the Dharma, and when others raise objections, they will be able to give a reasoned reply to the objection.

"Kauśika, the son or daughter of good family who holds, bears in mind, reads, comprehends fully, recites aloud, teaches, expounds, gives the transmission of, and rehearses from memory this Perfection of Wisdom will in this very life take hold of these further qualities as well.

"Furthermore, Kauśika, in whatever place that son or daughter of good family writes out this Perfection of Wisdom, places it in book form, and sets it down with offerings made beforehand, Kauśika, among the gods of the class of the Four Great Kings, those gods' sons who have truly set out toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening will also think of coming to that place.

Those gods' sons too, having come there, will look upon this Perfection of Wisdom set down in book form; they will pay homage to it and bow down to it; they will take hold of it, bear it in mind, read it, comprehend it fully, recite it aloud, teach it, expound it, give its transmission, and rehearse it from memory. Having looked upon it, paid homage, bowed down, taken hold of it, borne it in mind, read it, comprehended it fully, recited it, taught it, expounded it, received its transmission and rehearsed it from memory, they will think of returning again.

Kauśika, among the gods of the Thirty-Three, those gods' sons who have truly set out toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening will also think of coming to that place. Having come there, those gods' sons too will look upon this Perfection of Wisdom set down in book form; they will pay homage to it and bow down to it; they will take hold of it, bear it in mind, read it, comprehend it fully, recite it aloud, teach it, expound it, give its transmission, and rehearse it from memory. Having looked upon it, paid homage, bowed down, taken hold of it, borne it in mind, read it, comprehended it fully, recited it, taught it, expounded it, received its transmission and rehearsed it from memory, they will think of returning again.

Kauśika, among the gods of the Free from Strife (the Yāma gods), those gods' sons who have truly set out toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening will also think of drawing near to that place. Having come there, those gods' sons too will look upon this Perfection of Wisdom set down in book form; they will pay homage to it and bow down to it; they will take hold of it, bear it in mind, read it, comprehend it fully, recite it aloud, teach it, expound it, give its transmission, and rehearse it from memory. Having looked upon it, paid homage, bowed down, taken hold of it, borne it in mind, read it, comprehended it fully, recited it, taught it, expounded it, received its transmission and rehearsed it from memory, they will think of returning again.

Kauśika, among the gods of Tuṣita, the Joyous Realm, those gods' sons who have truly set out toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening will also think of coming to that place. Having come there, those gods' sons too will look upon this Perfection of Wisdom set down in book form; they will pay homage to it and bow down to it; they will take hold of it, bear it in mind, read it, comprehend it fully, recite it aloud, teach it, expound it, give its transmission, and rehearse it from memory. Having looked upon it, paid homage, bowed down, taken hold of it, borne it in mind, read it, comprehended it fully, recited it, taught it, expounded it, received its transmission and rehearsed it from memory, they will think of returning again.

Kauśika, among the gods who Delight in Emanation (the Nirmāṇarati gods), those gods' sons who have truly set out toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening will also think of coming to that place. Having come there, those gods' sons too will look upon this Perfection of Wisdom set down in book form; they will pay homage to it and bow down to it; they will take hold of it, bear it in mind, read it, comprehend it fully, recite it aloud, teach it, expound it, give its transmission, and rehearse it from memory.

Having looked upon it, paid homage, and bowed down; having taken hold of it, borne it in mind, read it, comprehended it fully, recited it aloud, taught it, expounded it, given its transmission, and rehearsed it from memory, they will think of returning again.

Kauśika, among the gods who Wield Power over Others' Emanations (the Paranirmitavaśavartin gods), those gods' sons who have truly set out toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening will also think of coming to that place. Having come there, those gods' sons too will look upon this Perfection of Wisdom set down in book form; they will pay homage to it and bow down to it;

they will take hold of it, bear it in mind, read it, comprehend it fully, recite it aloud, teach it, expound it, give its transmission, and rehearse it from memory. Having looked upon it, paid homage, and bowed down; having taken hold of it, borne it in mind, read it, comprehended it fully, recited it aloud, taught it, expounded it, given its transmission, and rehearsed it from memory, they will think of returning again.

In the same way, Kauśika, among all the gods who move in the form realm, up to and including the gods' sons of the Brahmā Assembly in the world of Brahmā, those gods' sons who have truly set out toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening will also think of coming to that place. Having come there, those gods' sons too will look upon this Perfection of Wisdom set down in book form; they will pay homage to it and bow down to it; they will take hold of it, bear it in mind, read it, comprehend it fully, recite it aloud, teach it, expound it, give its transmission, and rehearse it from memory. Having looked upon it, paid homage, and bowed down; having taken hold of it, borne it in mind, read it, comprehended it fully, recited it aloud, taught it, expounded it, given its transmission, and rehearsed it from memory, they will think of returning again.

Kauśika, you should not understand this only as it applies to the Brahmā Assembly. Just as with the Brahmā Assembly, so too among the gods who stand before Brahmā, whatever gods' sons there are, the same text is to be supplied as before.

In the same way, it applies to the gods of Great Brahmā, of Limited Radiance, of Immeasurable Radiance, of Clear Light, of Limited Virtue, of Immeasurable Virtue, of Increasing Virtue, of Cloudless, of Merit Increase, of Great Fruit, to the beings without perception, and to the gods of Not Great, Not Afflicted, Fine Appearance, and Perfect Vision. And Kauśika, among the gods of Akaniṣṭha, those gods' sons who have truly set out toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening will also think of coming to that place. Having come there, those gods' sons too will look upon this Perfection of Wisdom set down in book form; they will pay homage to it and bow down to it; they will take hold of it, bear it in mind, read it, comprehend it fully, recite it aloud, teach it, expound it, give its transmission, and rehearse it from memory. Having looked upon it, paid homage, and bowed down; having taken hold of it, borne it in mind, read it, comprehended it fully, recited it aloud, taught it, expounded it, given its transmission, and rehearsed it from memory, they will think of returning again.

Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family should generate the following thought: Toward all those gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, and non-human beings who dwell in the immeasurable, innumerable world systems of the ten directions,

From this volume, look upon the Perfection of Wisdom, pay homage to it, bow down to it, take hold of it, bear it in mind, read it, comprehend it fully, recite it aloud, teach it, expound it, give its transmission, and rehearse it from memory. Having looked upon it, paid homage, and bowed down; having taken hold of it, borne it in mind, read it, comprehended it fully, recited it aloud, taught it, expounded it, given its transmission, and rehearsed it from memory, return once more to your own dwelling. Let this very gift of the Dharma be given to them. This is what that son or daughter of good family should think.

Kauśika, in this regard you might think: "Among the sons of the gods who move in the desire realm and the form realm of this very world system of the four great continents, only those who have properly entered upon unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening will come there." You should not suppose that, Kauśika; it is not to be regarded in that way.

Kauśika, rather, in the world system of the great thousand of the three thousand, all the sons of the gods, however many there are, who move in the desire realm and the form realm and who have properly entered upon unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, will also think of coming there. Having come there, they will look upon this Perfection of Wisdom set down in a volume, pay homage to it, bow down to it, take hold of it, bear it in mind, read it, comprehend it fully, recite it aloud, teach it, expound it, give its transmission, and rehearse it from memory. Having looked upon it, paid homage, and bowed down; having taken hold of it, borne it in mind, read it, comprehended it fully, recited it aloud, taught it, expounded it, given its transmission, and rehearsed it from memory, they will think of returning again.

Moreover, Kauśika, the house, dwelling, and residence of that son or daughter of good family will be thoroughly protected. Except for the ripening of previous karma, no one at all will be able to harm them. Kauśika, this is so because gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, and non-human beings, who are called "the greatly majestic," will think of coming there. Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family will also acquire these qualities in this very life.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, when that son or daughter of good family is there, how should I understand the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, or non-humans who come there in order to listen to this Perfection of Wisdom, look upon it, pay homage to it, bow down to it, take hold of it, bear it in mind, read it, comprehend it fully, recite it aloud, teach it, expound it, give its transmission, and rehearse it from memory?"

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to Śakra, lord of the gods: "Kauśika, if that son or daughter of good family sees great radiances there, then that son or daughter of good family should know: certainly gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, or non-humans have come and arrived here.

"Furthermore, Kauśika, if that son or daughter of good family smells a fragrance of a non-human kind never smelled before, and becomes delighted by it,"

and having smelled that fragrance, that son or daughter of good family should know: certainly gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, or non-humans have come and arrived here.

"Furthermore, Kauśika, if that son or daughter of good family becomes careful in conduct and becomes pure in conduct, then through that careful and pure conduct, gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, and non-humans will think of coming there. And whichever gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, and non-humans have come there, they will be pleased and greatly delighted by that careful and pure conduct, and contentment and mental ease will arise in them.

"Then the gods of little majesty who dwell there will also think of departing from that place. Why is that? Because they cannot bear the splendor, majesty, and dignity of those gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, and non-humans of great majesty. Thus the gods of little majesty think of departing.

"Moreover, Kauśika, just as those gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, and non-humans of great majesty think of coming there constantly, in just that way, that son or daughter of good family will also become one of great faith. Kauśika, that son or daughter of

good family will also take hold of these qualities in this very life.

"Furthermore, Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family should not engage in impure or careless conduct in the vicinity of that place of the Dharma's way, for the sake of regarding it as a teacher, showing it reverence, and bringing it to completion.

"Furthermore, Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family will not become bodily weary or mentally weary. He will sleep happily and will go about happily. Even when he falls asleep, he will not see evil dreams; and if he does dream, he will see the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas themselves; he will see stūpas; he will see bodhisattvas; he will see the śrāvakas of the Tathāgata. If he hears sounds, he will hear the very sounds of the perfections. He will hear the teachings of the factors that lead to awakening. He will see the trees of awakening themselves. And at those trees he will see the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, as they attain manifest and complete awakening.

"Likewise, he will see those who have become fully awakened turning the wheel of Dharma. He will see many bodhisattva mahāsattvas who delight in discussing the Perfection of Wisdom, discussing this very Perfection of Wisdom, and he will see them skillfully showing: 'In this way omniscience is to be embraced; in this way the buddha-fields are to be purified.' And he will also hear the great resounding proclamation that the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, have become fully awakened."

In such and such a direction, in such and such a quarter, in such and such a world-realm, there is a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly awakened buddha named so-and-so. He is surrounded and honored by many śrāvakas and bodhisattvas, by many hundreds of śrāvakas and bodhisattvas, by many thousands, by many hundreds of thousands, by many millions, by many hundreds of millions, by many thousands of millions, by many hundreds of millions, indeed by countless billions of śrāvakas and bodhisattvas, and he is teaching the Dharma before them. Such is the great resounding proclamation of the Buddha that he will also hear.

"Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family will see such dreams as these. He will sleep in comfort and awaken in comfort. Radiance will be established within his body, and he will experience great bodily ease, a lightness and spaciousness of the body. Because of this, a craving for food will not arise in his mind, and his perception of food will diminish.

"Kauśika, it is just as when a monk who practices yoga rises from meditative absorption, and, thoroughly moistened by the mental engagement of that absorption, no strong craving for food arises in him and his perception of food diminishes. In the same way, Kauśika, in that son or daughter of good family no strong craving for food will arise, and his perception of food will diminish.

"Why is that? Kauśika, it is because the more that son or daughter of good family strives in the yoga of meditating on the Perfection of Wisdom, the more non-human beings will think of bringing radiance to his body. Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family will also take hold of these qualities in this very life.

"Furthermore, Kauśika, there is a son or daughter of good family who writes out this Perfection of Wisdom, puts it into book form, and places it with offerings as the foremost act, making offerings to it, but who does not hold it, does not bear it in mind, does not read it, does not fully comprehend it, does not recite it, does not teach it, does not explain it, does not give its transmission, and does not memorize it. Yet, Kauśika, a son or daughter of good family who has faith in this Perfection of Wisdom, who reflects on it, is inclined toward it, and has a serene mind, and who has generated the mind of awakening, produces more merit than that one. With a superior intention, such a person listens to it, holds it, bears it in mind, reads it, comprehends it, recites it, teaches it, explains it, gives its transmission, and memorizes it. He also expounds it extensively and correctly to others, elucidates its meaning, follows its sense with his mind, and examines it thoroughly here with wisdom, according as it is established. He does so with the wish: 'May the lineage of the buddhas not be cut off. May the sacred Dharma not vanish.' Thus he makes the sacred Dharma endure for a long time. And since he is not separated from the proper way, he accomplishes benefit for the bodhisattva mahāsattvas. At the very least, he puts it into book form and keeps it or sets it in place.

Such a person should also honor that Perfection of Wisdom with flowers, incense, fragrances, garlands, unguents, powders, robes, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, with rows of lamps set all around, and with many other kinds of offerings. If he reveres it, venerates it, treats it as his teacher, gives it gifts, makes offerings to it, depicts it in painting, and serves and honors it, then, Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family will thereby generate an exceedingly great store of merit.

Therefore, Kauśika, a son or daughter of good family who wishes to uphold these exceptional qualities in this very life should have faith in this Perfection

of Wisdom, examine it closely, and be devoted to it. Having generated the awakening mind with a clear and serene heart, with higher resolve he should listen to it, grasp it, retain it, read it, fully comprehend it, recite it, teach it, explain it closely, receive its transmission, and memorize it. He should also expound it extensively and correctly to others, elucidate its meaning, follow its sense with his mind, and examine it thoroughly here with wisdom, according as it is established. He should do so with the wish: "May the lineage of the buddhas not be cut off. May the sacred Dharma not vanish." Thus he should make the sacred Dharma endure for a long time. And since he is not separated from the proper way, he will accomplish benefit for the bodhisattva mahāsattvas. At the very least, he should put it into book form and keep it or set it in place. He should also bestow it correctly upon those sons and daughters of good family who seek its meaning. He should dedicate the merit: "May I and other virtuous beings never be separated from the great vision of the buddhas' way." To it he should always make offerings of divine flowers, divine incense, divine fragrances, divine garlands, divine unguents, divine powders, divine robes, divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, and divine flags, with rows of divine lamps set all around, and with many other kinds of offerings. He should revere it, venerate it, treat it as his teacher, give it gifts, make offerings to it, depict it in painting, and serve and honor it.

This is the third chapter of the noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines, called "Upholding the Immeasurable Qualities of Honoring the Perfection and the Stūpa."

Furthermore, the Blessed One said to Śatakratu (Indra), lord of the gods: "Kauśika, suppose this Jambudvīpa were completely filled with bodies of the Tathāgata, as thick as a mass of clustered grains, and were given to you. And suppose this Perfection of Wisdom were also written out and entrusted to you, and then one were to divide the offering and set before you one of the two portions. Kauśika, which portion would you take?"

Indra replied: "Blessed One, if this Jambudvīpa were filled with bodies of the Tathāgata, as thick as a mass of clustered grains, and were bestowed on me, and if this Perfection of Wisdom were also written out and entrusted to me, and one portion were to be set aside from the two, then, Blessed One, I would take this very Perfection of Wisdom. Why is that? It is for the sake of depicting the Tathāgata's way, for this is the Tathāgata's body of true meaning. Why so? Because the Blessed One has said: 'The buddhas, the blessed ones, are the Dharma body. Monks, do not regard this physical body as the supreme body.

Monks, look upon me as fully perfected in the Dharma body.' Since this was taught, the Tathāgata's body should be seen as distinguished by the ultimate limit, namely the Perfection of Wisdom. Yet, Blessed One, I do not lack reverence for those bodies of the Tathāgata."

Blessed One, I do hold those bodies of the Tathāgata in reverence. Yet, Blessed One, it is from this very Perfection of Wisdom that those bodies of the Tathāgata arise and receive offerings. Therefore, Blessed One, when offerings are made to this very Perfection of Wisdom, offerings to those bodies of the Tathāgata are thereby fully accomplished as well. Why is that? Because the bodies of the Tathāgatas have come forth from the Perfection of Wisdom.

Blessed One, it is like this. When I am in the presence of the gods of the Dharma hall, and I sit upon my own divine seat, then the sons of the gods come to attend upon me. And when I am absent, even then the sons of the gods, out of reverence for me, pay homage to that seat of mine, circumambulate it, and then depart again. Why is that? Because they think: "Śakra, the lord of the gods, having sat upon this seat, taught the Dharma to the gods of the Thirty-Three."

In the same way, Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom, renowned as powerful and become the cause and the condition, is what brings about the omniscience of the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha. The bodies of the Tathāgata are the basis of omniscience, but they are not the cause that gives rise to wisdom, nor are they its condition. Thus, Blessed One, the offering made to the body of the Tathāgata arises from the cause that is omniscient wisdom.

Therefore, Blessed One, of those two portions, I take this very Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, I am not lacking in reverence for those bodies of the Tathāgata. Indeed, Blessed One, I hold those bodies of the Tathāgata in reverence. Yet the bodies of the Tathāgata receive offerings because they are thoroughly pervaded by the Perfection of Wisdom.

Blessed One, set aside Jambudvīpa filled with bodies of the Tathāgata like a thicket of sugarcane or reeds; set aside the world system of the four great continents so filled; set aside the thousandfold world system so filled; set aside the second, the middle, two-thousandfold world system so filled. Blessed One, suppose this entire great thousandfold world system of the three-thousandfold was filled with bodies of the Tathāgata like a thicket of reeds, and it were set down as one portion; and suppose this Perfection of Wisdom, written out as a

book, were set down as the second portion; and suppose someone, offering one portion, said: "Of these two portions, take whichever you wish." Then, Blessed One, I would take this very Perfection of Wisdom.

Blessed One, I am not lacking in reverence for those bodies of the Tathāgata. Indeed, Blessed One, I hold those bodies of the Tathāgata in reverence. Yet the bodies of the Tathāgata also receive offerings because they are thoroughly pervaded by the Perfection of Wisdom. The bodies of the Tathāgata are the basis of omniscient wisdom, and that omniscient wisdom itself issues forth from the Perfection of Wisdom.

Therefore, Blessed One, of those two portions, I take this very Perfection of Wisdom.

Blessed One, it is not that I lack reverence for the body of the Tathāgata. Indeed, Blessed One, I hold those bodies of the Tathāgata in reverence. Yet, Blessed One, those bodies of the Tathāgata are born from this very Perfection of Wisdom, and those bodies of the Tathāgata receive offerings because they are thoroughly infused by the Perfection of Wisdom.

Here ends the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines, fifth section.

Blessed One, suppose there were a priceless, precious jewel endowed with qualities of this kind. Wherever it is placed, neither humans nor nonhumans can find an opening to harm that place. Whenever a man or a woman is seized by a nonhuman, then the moment that great precious jewel is brought near, the nonhuman departs from there. If the jewel is placed on a body swollen and tormented by wind disorder, that wind disorder is cut off, ceases to increase, and is pacified. If it is placed on a body made feverish by bile, that bile too is cut off, ceases to increase, and is pacified. If it is placed on one swollen and tormented all over by phlegm, that phlegm too is cut off, ceases to increase, and is pacified. If it is placed on one who suffers from a combined disorder of the humors, that combined disorder too is cut off, ceases to increase, and is pacified. In the pitch darkness of the night it gives light. In hot weather, wherever it is placed, that place becomes cool. In cold weather, wherever it is placed, that place becomes warm. In any place where there are venomous snakes and other tiny creatures, if one holds it and sets it down there, those venomous snakes and tiny creatures go away. Blessed One, if a man or a woman is bitten by a venomous snake and the precious jewel is shown to that person, then the very moment the jewel is seen, the venom is overcome and vanishes. Blessed One, that precious jewel is also endowed with these and

other such qualities.

Blessed One, if that precious jewel is placed upon the eyes of those who have a film, or blurred vision, or eye disease, or a cataract, then the very moment it is placed there, those afflictions of the eye are cleared and pacified. Blessed One, that precious jewel is endowed with these and other such qualities.

If it is dropped into water, the water takes on its own color. If it is wrapped in white cloth and dropped into water, the water turns white. In the same way, if it is wrapped or bound in blue, yellow, red, or crimson cloth, or in any of the various kinds of cloth, and dropped into water, the water takes on the very color of each of those cloths. And whatever turbidity there was in that water becomes clear. Blessed One, that precious jewel is endowed with qualities of this kind.

Then the venerable Ānanda said this to Śakra, lord of the gods: "Kauśika, do such precious jewels exist only in the world of the gods, or do those precious jewels exist among the people of Jambudvīpa as well?" Śakra replied:

"Noble Ānanda, those precious jewels exist among the gods. Among the people of Jambudvīpa there are also precious jewels, but they are heavy, small, and coarse, and their qualities are incomplete, for they do not possess such essential qualities. They do not approach even a hundredth part of those jewels of the gods, nor a thousandth part, nor a hundred-thousandth part, nor a ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-thousand-ten-millionth part, nor even a hundred-thousand-times-a-hundred-thousand-ten-millionth part. They cannot be reckoned by number, shown by comparison or by example, nor can they serve as a basis or come close as a cause. For those precious jewels of the gods are refined and perfectly complete in every aspect of quality. If that precious jewel is placed in any vessel of food or drink, then even after the jewel is taken out, the food and drink is rendered pleasing to the heart. By those very qualities of the precious jewel, a deep and heartfelt delight arises toward that food and drink."

Then, speaking to the Blessed One, Śakra continued: "Blessed One, in the same way, even though the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa, the offerings received by the bodies of the Tathāgata are due to the qualities of the Perfection of Wisdom and of omniscient wisdom. These bodies of the Tathāgata have become vessels of omniscient wisdom. And, Blessed One, just as the buddhas, the Blessed Ones,

who teach the Dharma in all world systems are to be honored because they were born from the Perfection of Wisdom, so too the Dharma teacher who expounds the Dharma is to be honored because he was born from the Perfection of Wisdom.

"Blessed One, just as the son of a king, through the king's power, is revered fearlessly by great multitudes of people, so too that Dharma teacher, through the power of the Dharma body, is honored fearlessly by great multitudes of beings. Just as the Dharma teacher who proclaims the Dharma receives honor, so too the relics of the Tathāgata's body have received honor.

"Blessed One, therefore, to say nothing of a great trichiliocosm, which is filled to the brim with the bodies of the Tathāgata like a bubbling mass, consider this, Blessed One: suppose one placed in one pan of a scale world systems as many as the sand grains of the river Ganges, filled to the brim in this way with the bodies of the Tathāgata, and in the other pan one placed this Perfection of Wisdom, written down in a book. Blessed One, if someone were to offer me the choice, saying, 'Of these two portions, take whichever one you wish,' then of those two portions I would take this very Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, it is not that I lack reverence for those bodies of the Tathāgata; I too hold those bodies of the Tathāgata in reverence. But, Blessed One, omniscience has been disclosed from the Perfection of Wisdom, and the offering made to the body of the Tathāgata has arisen from omniscient wisdom. Therefore, Blessed One, if one honors this Perfection of Wisdom, one will have made offerings to the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, the future, and the present."

Blessed One, furthermore, in countless, innumerable world systems there are buddhas, Blessed Ones, who at this very time are present, living and sustained. A son of good family or a daughter of good family who wishes to see those buddhas in the nature of reality should practice this Perfection of Wisdom, should apply themselves to this Perfection of Wisdom, and should meditate on this Perfection of Wisdom.

When Śakra had spoken in this way, the Blessed One said to Śakra, the lord of the gods: "Kauśika, so it is, so it is. Kauśika, those Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas who appeared in the past also relied on this very Perfection of Wisdom, and so fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. Kauśika, those Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas who will appear in the future will likewise rely on this very Perfection of Wisdom, and so will attain full awakening to unsurpassable, perfectly

complete awakening. Kauśika, those buddhas, Blessed Ones, who at the present time are present, living and sustained, in countless, innumerable world systems have also relied on this very Perfection of Wisdom, and so have fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. And, Kauśika, I too, the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha of this present time, have relied on this very Perfection of Wisdom, and so have fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening."

When he had spoken in this way, Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom is indeed the great perfection. For the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha, thoroughly knows and rightly sees the mental conduct of all sentient beings."

The Blessed One said: "Kauśika, so it is, so it is. Kauśika, if a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the Perfection of Wisdom for a long time, then by means of the Perfection of Wisdom he rightly knows and rightly sees the mental conduct of all sentient beings."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, does a bodhisattva, a great being, practice only the Perfection of Wisdom, and not the other perfections?"

The Blessed One said: "Kauśika, a bodhisattva, a great being, practices all six perfections. Nevertheless, Kauśika, it is the Perfection of Wisdom of the bodhisattva, the great being, that goes before them all. The giving of gifts, the keeping of moral discipline, the cultivation of patience, the undertaking of diligence, the settling of the mind in meditative concentration, and the discerning of phenomena: it is the Perfection of Wisdom of the bodhisattva, the great being, that goes before each of these."

Kauśika, the six perfections are embraced by skillful means, and they are dedicated through the Perfection of Wisdom and dedicated toward omniscience. Among these there is no distinction, and no separate division is perceived. Kauśika, it is like this. The various trees of Jambudvīpa differ in color, differ in shape, differ in leaves, differ in flowers, differ in fruit, and differ in the richness of their size and abundance. Yet the shadows of those trees show no distinction and no separate division; otherwise they could not be counted simply as "shadow, shadow." In just the same way, Kauśika, the six perfections are embraced by skillful means, dedicated through the Perfection of Wisdom, and dedicated toward omniscience, and among them no distinction and no separate division is perceived.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom possesses great qualities. Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom possesses immeasurable qualities. Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom possesses limitless qualities."

This is the fourth chapter, called "Praise of the Qualities," from the noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, suppose a son of good family or a daughter of good family has faith in this Perfection of Wisdom, reflects on it and inclines toward it with a clear and confident mind, and has generated the mind of awakening. With a superior intention, such a person listens to it, holds it, retains it, reads it, comprehends it, recites it, teaches it, explains it, gives instruction in it, learns it by heart, and expounds it extensively and correctly to others. Such a person also explains its meaning, reflects on it in mind, and examines it here with the wisdom of one who has truly understood it. Thinking, 'May the lineage of the buddhas not be cut off, and may the sacred Dharma not vanish,' such a person makes the sacred Dharma endure for a long time. Inseparable from this way of practice, such a person brings about benefit for the bodhisattvas, the great beings. Even if only in small part, such a person has it written down in a book, and keeps it or sets it in place. Having heard this teaching, such a person thinks: 'How wonderful! This Perfection of Wisdom is of such great meaning. How wonderful! This Perfection of Wisdom is of such great benefit. How wonderful! This Perfection of Wisdom is of such great effect. How wonderful! This Perfection of Wisdom is of such great ripening. How wonderful! This Perfection of Wisdom possesses so many qualities. I must not abandon this Perfection of Wisdom. I must guard this Perfection of Wisdom. I must keep this Perfection of Wisdom hidden. This Perfection of Wisdom is exceedingly hard to find.' With such deep devotion, that person honors this Perfection of Wisdom with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, cloth, parasols, banners, bells, and pennants, and with rows of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings. That person reveres it, venerates it as a teacher, esteems it, makes offerings to it, adorns it with painted images, and attends it with respect.

And suppose another person, having even put it into book form, makes offerings to it. Then a son or daughter of good family, for the sake of others, gives, bestows, presents, and freely offers it to those who seek it and request

it with eager wish. Blessed One, of these two, the one who has the intention of giving and the one who does not, which of them produces the greater merit? When he had asked this, the Blessed One spoke to Śatakratu, the lord of the gods (Indra): "Kauśika, I ask you this very question here, so answer as best you are able. Kauśika, what do you think? Suppose a son or daughter of good family treats the body of the Tathāgata who has passed into nirvāṇa with honor, serves it and keeps it, honors it, holds it as a teacher, esteems it, makes offerings to it, adorns it with painted images, and attends it with respect. And suppose another son or daughter of good family, thinking, 'If I myself honor the body of the Tathāgata, hold it as a teacher, esteem it, make offerings to it, adorn it with painted images, and attend it with respect, the offerings will be vast,' out of compassion for sentient beings also teaches others extensively and correctly, gives it to them, and spreads it widely. Kauśika, of these two sons or daughters of good family, which produces the greater merit? Does the one who himself makes offerings, and also teaches others extensively and correctly, gives to them, and spreads it widely, produce the greater merit? Or does the one who alone makes offerings to his own self produce much merit?"

Śakra replied: "Blessed One, the son or daughter of good family who thinks, 'If I myself honor the body of the Tathāgata, hold it as a teacher, esteem it, make offerings to it, adorn it with painted images, and attend it with respect, the offerings will be vast,' and who, out of tender compassion for sentient beings, also teaches others extensively and correctly, gives it to them, and spreads it widely, this one, of the two, produces the greater merit."

The Blessed One said: "Kauśika, so it is, so it is. Kauśika, suppose a son or daughter of good family writes out this Perfection of Wisdom in this way and puts it into book form, and holds it, bears it in mind, reads it, comprehends it, recites it thoroughly, teaches it, explains it closely, gives its transmission, and memorizes it. And suppose that, for other sons or daughters of good family who seek it and request it with eager wish, he even puts a small part of it into book form, and gives, bestows, presents, and freely offers it. Kauśika, of these two, the son or daughter of good family who takes up the cause of others and who has the intention of giving freely produces, on that basis, the greater merit.

"Moreover, Kauśika, suppose a son or daughter of good family goes to whatever place a son or daughter of good family who is a worthy vessel for this Perfection of Wisdom is staying, and gives this Perfection of Wisdom to

them and spreads it among them properly. Kauśika, this son or daughter of good family produces even greater merit than that."

"Moreover, Kauśika, suppose a son or daughter of good family were to establish and settle all the sentient beings there are in Jambudvīpa firmly upon the path of the ten virtuous actions. What do you think, Kauśika? Would that son or daughter of good family produce a great deal of merit on that basis?"

Śakra (Indra) replied: "Blessed One, a great deal. Sugata, a great deal."

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, even more merit than that is produced by this son or daughter of good family who takes this Perfection of Wisdom, even a small portion of it, and puts it into book form, and then gives it with a pure intention to a bodhisattva. That bodhisattva is one with faith through faith, with discernment through discernment, with deep confidence through deep confidence, with a serene mind through a serene mind, with excellent and complete higher aspiration through excellent and complete higher aspiration, and one who has generated the awakening mind through generating the awakening mind.

"Further, the giver strives diligently to have that bodhisattva practice even the smallest part of it, such as asking questions about it and reading it. He causes that bodhisattva to take it up, teaches it properly, establishes it properly, praises it properly, and delights that bodhisattva properly. He explains it through words, through indications, and through further indications, and he teaches that bodhisattva its meaning properly. He says to that bodhisattva: 'Child of good family, come here. Train in this path of the bodhisattvas in this way. If you train in this path, practice it, and strive, you will quickly come to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And having become fully awakened, you will bring to discipline, through the unsurpassed exhaustion of the aggregates, the countless realms of sentient beings, that is, through the analysis of the true limit.' By speaking in this way, he purifies that bodhisattva's mind and frees it from doubt.

"Kauśika, this son or daughter of good family, who has such a mind of complete relinquishment, produces even more merit than the former son or daughter of good family.

"Moreover, Kauśika, set aside all the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa. By the same reasoning, Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish and settle firmly upon the path of the ten virtuous actions all the sentient beings there are in the world system of the four great continents. And

further, Kauśika, set aside all the sentient beings of the four great continents. By the same reasoning, suppose all the sentient beings there are in the world system of the small chiliocosm, the thousandfold world, were so established upon the path of the ten virtuous actions by some son or daughter of good family. And further, Kauśika, set aside all the sentient beings of the thousandfold world. By the same reasoning, suppose all the sentient beings there are in the world system of the middling dichiliocosm, the twice-thousandfold world, were so established by some son or daughter of good family. And further, Kauśika, set aside all the sentient beings of the middling twice-thousandfold world. By the same reasoning, suppose all the sentient beings there are in the world system of the great trichiliocosm, the thousand-thousand-thousandfold world, were so established by some son or daughter of good family. And further, Kauśika, set aside all the sentient beings of the great trichiliocosm."

In the same way, Kauśika, suppose all the sentient beings there are in as many world systems of the great trichiliocosm as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges were established and set firmly in the ten paths of virtuous action by some son or daughter of good family. What do you think, Kauśika? Would that son or daughter of good family produce a great deal of merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra) replied: "Blessed One, a great deal. Sugata, a great deal."

The Blessed One said: "Kauśika, even more merit is produced by this son or daughter of good family who does the following. Even if only in a small measure, they have this Perfection of Wisdom written down in a book, and with faith they bring a person of faith to it, with discernment a person of discernment, with devoted conviction a person of devoted conviction, with a clear and serene mind a person of clear and serene mind, with excellent higher intention a person of excellent higher intention, and they give it with higher intention to a bodhisattva who has generated the mind of awakening with the mind of awakening. Even if only in a small measure, they apply themselves without laxity to writing and reading it. With diligence they urge that person to take it up, they teach it correctly, establish the person in it correctly, encourage the person correctly, and bring the person correct delight. They explain it through words, through definitions, through further elaborations, and they teach its meaning correctly. And they speak to that person thus: 'Child of good family, come here. Train in this path of the bodhisattvas. If you train and practice this path and make effort, you will swiftly become fully and completely awakened in unsurpassable, perfect

awakening. And having become fully awakened, you will bring about the complete exhaustion of the unmeasurable realms of sentient beings, the unsurpassed discerning of the true limit.' Speaking thus, they purify that person's mind and make it free of doubt. Kauśika, this son or daughter of good family, who possesses a mind of complete renunciation, produces much more merit than the former son or daughter of good family.

Further, Kauśika, suppose all the sentient beings there are in Jambudvīpa were established in the four meditative concentrations by some son or daughter of good family. What do you think, Kauśika? Would that son or daughter of good family produce a great deal of merit on that basis?"

Śakra replied: "Blessed One, a great deal. Sugata, a great deal."

The Blessed One said: "Kauśika, even more merit is produced by this son or daughter of good family who does the following. Even if only in a small measure, they have this Perfection of Wisdom written down in a book, and with faith they bring a person of faith to it, with discernment a person of discernment, with devoted conviction a person of devoted conviction, with a clear and serene mind a person of clear and serene mind, with excellent higher intention a person of excellent higher intention, and they give it with higher intention to a bodhisattva who has generated the mind of awakening. Even if only in a small measure, they apply themselves without laxity to writing and reading it. With diligence they urge that person to take it up, they teach it correctly, establish the person in it correctly, encourage the person correctly, and bring the person correct delight. They explain it through words, through definitions, through further elaborations, and they teach its meaning correctly. And they speak to that person thus: 'Child of good family, come here. Train in this path of the bodhisattvas.'"

"If you train in this path, practice it, and strive, you will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And having become fully awakened, you will bring to discipline, in the supreme exhaustion of the aggregates, immeasurable realms of sentient beings, that is, in the thorough discernment of the true limit." Speaking in this way, they purify that person's mind and free it from doubt.

Kauśika, set aside all the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa. Kauśika, in just that way, consider all the sentient beings in a world system of four great continents. Suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish every one of them in the four meditative concentrations. And set aside,

Kauśika, all the sentient beings of a world system of four great continents. In the same way, consider all the sentient beings in a "small thousand" world system. Suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish every one of them in the four meditative concentrations. And set aside, Kauśika, all the sentient beings of the small thousand world system. In the same way, consider all the sentient beings in a "middling second thousand" world system. Suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish every one of them in the four meditative concentrations. And set aside, Kauśika, all the sentient beings of the middling second thousand world system. In the same way, consider all the sentient beings in a great thousand of thousands, a threefold-thousand world system. Suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish every one of them in the four meditative concentrations. And set aside, Kauśika, all the sentient beings of that threefold-thousand great-thousand world system. In the same way, consider all the sentient beings in as many threefold-thousand great-thousand world systems as there are grains of sand in the River Gaṅgā. Suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish every one of them in the four meditative concentrations.

Kauśika, what do you think? Would that son or daughter of good family generate abundant merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra) replied: "Many, Blessed One (the Buddha)! Many, Sugata!"

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, even more abundant is the merit generated by the son or daughter of good family who, even in a small measure, commits this Perfection of Wisdom to writing in a book. With faith they have faith in it. With discernment they discern it. With devotion they are devoted to it. With a clear and joyful mind they delight in it. With excellent and complete higher intention they hold it with excellent higher intention. And they give it with higher intention to a bodhisattva who has generated the mind of awakening. Even if only in a small measure, they apply themselves without laxity to writing and reading it. With diligence they urge that person to take it up, they teach it correctly, establish the person in it correctly, encourage the person correctly, and bring the person correct delight. They explain it through words, through definitions, through further elaborations, and they teach its meaning correctly. And they speak to that person thus: 'Child of good family, come here. Train in this path of the bodhisattvas. If you train in this path, practice it, and strive, you will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.'"

"Having fully awakened, I shall bring to complete discipline the immeasurable realms of sentient beings, through the unsurpassed exhaustion of the aggregates, that is, through the thorough distinction of the true limit." Speaking thus, they purify that person's mind and remove all doubt.

Kauśika, consider further. Suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the beings who live in Jambudvīpa in the four immeasurables, and likewise, just as with the immeasurables, in the four formless absorptions and the five higher knowledges, so that they were established in the meditative concentrations, the immeasurables, the formless absorptions, and the higher knowledges without exception. Kauśika, what do you think? Would that son or daughter of good family generate a great deal of merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra) replied: "Blessed One, a great deal! Sugata, a great deal!"

The Blessed One said: "Kauśika, even more merit than that is generated by the son or daughter of good family who takes up this Perfection of Wisdom, even if only a small portion of it, and commits it to a book. With faith, they are devoted to those who have faith; with careful discernment, to those who discern carefully; with firm conviction, to those who are firmly convinced; with a serene mind, to those whose minds are serene; with an excellent and superior intention, to those whose intention is excellent and superior. They give it, with superior intention, to a bodhisattva who has generated the mind of awakening. Even if it is only a little, they apply themselves without laxity to writing and reading it. With diligence they urge that person to take it up, they teach it correctly, establish the person in it correctly, encourage the person correctly, and bring the person correct delight. They explain it through words, through definitions, through further elaborations, and they teach its meaning correctly. And they speak to that person thus: 'Child of good family, come here. Train in this path of the bodhisattvas. If you train in this path, practice it, and strive, you will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Having fully awakened, you will bring to complete discipline the immeasurable realms of sentient beings, through the unsurpassed exhaustion of the aggregates, that is, through the thorough distinction of the true limit.' Speaking thus, they purify that person's mind and remove all doubt.

Kauśika, let alone the merit produced by establishing all the beings of Jambudvīpa in the meditative concentrations, the immeasurables, the formless

absorptions, and the higher knowledges. Kauśika, in the same way, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the beings who live in the world system of the four great continents in the meditative concentrations, the immeasurables, the formless absorptions, and the higher knowledges. Let alone, Kauśika, the merit produced by that establishing of all the beings of the world system of the four great continents in the meditative concentrations, the immeasurables, the formless absorptions, and the higher knowledges. Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the beings who live in the thousandfold world system, the small chiliocosm, in the meditative concentrations, the immeasurables, the formless absorptions, and the higher knowledges, and so on."

Kauśika, let alone the merit produced by establishing all the beings of the world system of the thousandfold world, the small chiliocosm, in the meditative concentrations, the immeasurables, the formless absorptions, and the higher knowledges. Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the beings in the second thousand, the middling world system, in the meditative concentrations, the immeasurables, the formless absorptions, and the higher knowledges. Let alone the merit produced by establishing all the beings of that middling world system in them.

Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the beings who live in the great thousand of the third thousand, the great chiliocosm, in the meditative concentrations, the immeasurables, the formless absorptions, and the higher knowledges. Let alone the merit produced by establishing all the beings of that great chiliocosm in them.

Kauśika, in the same way, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the beings who live in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the river Ganges, each a great chiliocosm, in the meditative concentrations, the immeasurables, the formless absorptions, and the higher knowledges. What do you think, Kauśika? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?

Indra said: "Blessed One, it would be much. Sugata, it would be much."

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, even so, this son or daughter of good family generates far more merit. Whoever writes this Perfection of Wisdom, even in a small volume, and gives it to a bodhisattva who has generated the awakening mind, one who has faith through faith, discernment through discernment, devotion through devotion, a serene mind through serenity of

mind, and an excellent higher intention through excellent higher intention, giving it with a higher intention; and who, even if the person only writes and reads it, undertakes it without laziness, with effort and diligence, and has that person take it up; who teaches it rightly, establishes the person in it rightly, praises it rightly, and gladdens the person rightly; who explains it with words, with detailed expression, and with further indications; who rightly explains its meaning to that person; and who says to that person, 'Son of good family, come here. Train in this path of the bodhisattvas. If you train in this path, practice it, and exert yourself, you will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And having become fully awakened, you will bring immeasurable realms of sentient beings to discipline in the unsurpassed exhaustion of the aggregates, that is, in the discernment of the true limit,' and who thus purifies that person's mind and frees it from doubt.

Kauśika, furthermore, suppose some son or daughter of good family writes this Perfection of Wisdom, reads it himself or herself, and also, having written it, gives it to others as before."

Kauśika, this son or daughter of good family generates far more merit than the previous one.

Furthermore, Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family who is skilled in the meaning reads this Perfection of Wisdom, and having written it, gives it to others as before, and teaches it to them together with its meaning and its words, and makes it thoroughly clear. Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family generates even far more merit than the former.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, should this Perfection of Wisdom also be taught to those who do not understand it?"

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to Śakra, lord of the gods: "Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom should indeed be taught to a son or daughter of good family who does not understand. Why is that? Kauśika, in the future there will appear a semblance of the Perfection of Wisdom. Those sons and daughters of good family who do not understand it, and who wish to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, must not be allowed to hear that semblance of the Perfection of Wisdom and thereby be ruined."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how should one recognize, in the future, that what is taught is the semblance of the

Perfection of Wisdom, and say, 'This is that semblance'?"

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to Śakra, lord of the gods: "Kauśika, in the future there will be some monks whose bodies are undeveloped, whose moral discipline is undeveloped, whose minds are undeveloped, and whose wisdom is undeveloped. Their wisdom will be corrupt, they will be mute and dull like sheep by nature, and their discernment will be utterly ruined. Thinking, 'We are teaching the Perfection of Wisdom,' they will teach its semblance.

"Kauśika, how will they teach the semblance of the Perfection of Wisdom? They will teach that the destruction of form is the impermanence of form. In the same way, they will teach that the destruction of feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness is the impermanence of consciousness. They will also expound in this way: 'Whoever searches thus will be practicing the Perfection of Wisdom.' Kauśika, this should be recognized as the semblance of the Perfection of Wisdom.

"Moreover, Kauśika, one does not view the destruction of form as the impermanence of form. In the same way, one does not view the destruction of feeling, perception, and formations as their impermanence, and, Kauśika, one does not view the destruction of consciousness as the impermanence of consciousness. If one sees in this way, one is practicing the semblance of the Perfection of Wisdom.

"Therefore, Kauśika, a son or daughter of good family should teach the meaning of this Perfection of Wisdom. If one teaches the meaning of the Perfection of Wisdom, that son or daughter of good family generates far greater merit.

"Furthermore, Kauśika, suppose someone were to establish all the sentient beings that exist in Jambudvīpa in the fruit of stream-entry. Kauśika, what do you think? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?"

Śakra (Indra), the lord of the gods, replied, "Blessed One, it would be much. Sugata, it would be much."

The Blessed One declared, "Kauśika, even more merit is generated by that son or daughter of good family who writes this Perfection of Wisdom, even in a small measure, into a book; who, with faith, gives it to one who has faith; with discernment, to one who has discernment; with deep conviction, to one who

has deep conviction; with a clear and serene mind, to one whose mind is clear and serene; with a superior and perfect intention, to one whose intention is superior and perfect; and who, having generated the mind of awakening, gives it with a superior intention to a bodhisattva who has generated the mind of awakening.

"Even in a small measure, such a person applies themselves to writing and reading it without neglect. With diligence they cause others to hold it. They teach it rightly, establish others in it rightly, praise it rightly, and bring others to rightful delight in it. They explain it through words, through distinct expressions, and through successive indications, and they rightly explain its meaning to them. They say to that person: 'Son of good family, come here. Train in this path of the bodhisattvas. If you train in this path, practice it, and make effort, you will quickly become fully awakened in unsurpassable, perfect awakening. And having become fully awakened, you will establish beings, whose realm is immeasurable, in the utter exhaustion of the aggregates, the unsurpassable, that is, in the discernment of the ultimate limit.' In this way they purify that person's mind and free it from doubt, and they say, 'Son of good family, attain precisely those qualities that accord with the Perfection of Wisdom.'

"Kauśika, this son or daughter of good family generates far more merit than the former one. Why is that? Kauśika, because through this teaching the fruit of stream-entry is clearly distinguished.

"Furthermore, Kauśika, leave aside the merit produced by establishing all the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa in the fruit of stream-entry. Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the sentient beings that exist in the world system of the four great continents in the fruit of stream-entry. Leave aside, Kauśika, the merit produced by establishing all the beings of the world system of the four continents in that fruit.

"Kauśika, suppose someone were to establish all the sentient beings that exist in a world system of one thousand, the small chiliocosm, in the fruit of stream-entry. Leave aside, Kauśika, the merit produced by establishing all the beings of the small chiliocosm in that fruit.

"Kauśika, suppose someone were to establish all the sentient beings that exist in the world system of the second thousand, the middle chiliocosm, in the fruit of stream-entry. Leave aside, Kauśika, the merit produced by establishing all the beings of the middle chiliocosm in that fruit.

"Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the sentient beings that exist in the world system of the third thousand, the great thousand, the great chiliocosm, in the fruit of stream-entry."

Kauśika, leave aside the merit produced by establishing all the sentient beings of the world system of the great chiliocosm, the third thousand, in the fruit of stream-entry. Kauśika, suppose that some son or daughter of good family were to establish in the fruit of stream-entry all the sentient beings that exist in as many world systems of the great chiliocosm as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā. What do you think, Kauśika? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra) replied: "Blessed One, much! Sugata, much!"

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, even more merit is generated by that son or daughter of good family who, having committed this Perfection of Wisdom even to a book, however small, gives it with an exalted intention to a bodhisattva who has the confidence of faith, the discernment of careful reflection, the inclination of deep conviction, a serene mind, and the perfection of an exalted intention, a bodhisattva who has given rise to the awakening mind by means of the awakening mind. And even if it is only a small matter of writing and reading, that person, striving with diligence and with nothing less than full commitment, causes that bodhisattva to grasp it, teaches it correctly, establishes the bodhisattva in it correctly, praises it correctly, and brings correct delight. By means of words, by signs, by distinct characterizations, and by further indications, that person explains its meaning correctly, and says to the bodhisattva: 'Child of good family, come here. Train in this path of the bodhisattvas. If you train in this path, practice it, and make an effort, you will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And having become fully awakened, you will bring to discipline the immeasurable realms of sentient beings, so that the aggregates are completely exhausted, unsurpassed, which is to say, within the discernment of the true limit.' In this way that person purifies the bodhisattva's mind and removes doubt, and says: 'Child of good family, obtain these very dharmas that accord with the Perfection of Wisdom.'

"Kauśika, this person generates far more merit than the former son or daughter of good family. Why is that? Kauśika, because from this the fruit of stream-entry is distinguished.

"Furthermore, Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the sentient beings that exist in Jambudvīpa in the fruit of once-returning. What do you think, Kauśika? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?"

Śakra replied: "Blessed One, much! Sugata, much!"

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, even more merit is generated by that son or daughter of good family who, having committed this Perfection of Wisdom even to a book, however small, gives it with an exalted intention to a bodhisattva who has the confidence of faith, the discernment of careful reflection, the inclination of deep conviction, a serene mind, and the perfection of an exalted intention, a bodhisattva who has given rise to the awakening mind by means of the awakening mind. And even if it is only a small matter of writing and reading, that person, striving with diligence and with nothing less than full commitment,

Such a person encourages that bodhisattva to take hold of this Perfection of Wisdom, instructs him, establishes him in it, praises him, and fills him with joy. Through words that indicate, that fully indicate, and that follow upon the indication, the person truly explains the meaning of this to him. And the person says to him: "Noble son, come here. Train yourself in this path of the bodhisattvas. If you train in this path, practise it, and make an effort, you will swiftly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And having become fully awakened, you will bring to discipline immeasurable realms of sentient beings, until the aggregates are completely exhausted, that is, in the unsurpassed manifestation of the true limit." Speaking in this way, the person purifies that bodhisattva's mind and frees it from doubt. And the person says these words: "Noble son, strive to attain those very qualities that accompany the Perfection of Wisdom."

Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family generates even more merit than the former one. Why is that? Kauśika, from this the fruit of the once-returner is distinguished.

Kauśika, set aside the merit produced by someone who establishes all the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa in the fruit of the once-returner. Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish in the fruit of the once-returner all the sentient beings there are in a world system of the four great continents. And set aside, Kauśika, the merit produced by establishing all the sentient beings of that world system of four continents in

the fruit of the once-returner.

Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish in the fruit of the once-returner all the sentient beings there are in a small thousandfold world system. And set aside, Kauśika, the merit produced by establishing all the sentient beings of a small thousandfold world system in that fruit.

Kauśika, suppose someone were to establish in the fruit of the once-returner all the sentient beings there are in a middling twice-thousandfold world system. And set aside, Kauśika, the merit produced by establishing all the sentient beings of a middling twice-thousandfold world system in that fruit.

Kauśika, suppose someone were to establish in the fruit of the once-returner all the sentient beings there are in a great thousandfold world system of three thousand. And set aside, Kauśika, the merit produced by establishing all the sentient beings of a great three-thousandfold world system in that fruit.

Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish in the fruit of the once-returner all the sentient beings there are in as many great three-thousandfold world systems as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā. What do you think, Kauśika? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra) replied: "Much, Blessed One (the Buddha). Much, Sugata."

The Blessed One said: "Kauśika, even more merit than that is generated by this son or daughter of good family."

Suppose someone writes out this Perfection of Wisdom, even in a small book, and then, with faith, gives it to one who has faith; with careful discernment, to one who discerns carefully; with strong devotion, to one of strong devotion; with a serene mind, to one of serene mind; with excellent superior intention, to one who has excellent superior intention; and, having generated the mind of awakening, gives it with superior intention to a bodhisattva who has generated the mind of awakening. And suppose that even for the writing and reading of it, that person does not remain content with mere inclination, but applies himself with diligence and earnest effort. He has others take it up, teaches it properly, sets it forth properly, praises it properly, and brings others to proper delight in it. He explains the meaning of this text by way of words, by designations, by detailed indications, and by following expositions. And he says to that person: "Son of good family, come here. Train in this path of the

bodhisattvas. If you train in this path, practice it, and strive, you will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And having become fully awakened, you will bring to maturity immeasurable realms of sentient beings, and you will bring them to the supreme exhaustion of the aggregates, that is, to the discernment of the ultimate limit." In this way he purifies that person's mind and removes doubt, and he says: "Son of good family, you should attain just those qualities that accord with the Perfection of Wisdom."

Kauśika, this son or daughter of good family generates much more merit than the earlier one. Why is that? Kauśika, because from this the fruit of the once-returner is clearly distinguished.

This is the sixth section of the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Furthermore, Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish in the fruit of the non-returner all the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa. What do you think, Kauśika? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?

Śakra replied: "Much, Blessed One. Much, Sugata."

The Blessed One said: "Kauśika, even more merit than that is generated by this son or daughter of good family who writes out this Perfection of Wisdom, even in a small book, and then, with faith, gives it to one who has faith; with careful discernment, to one who discerns carefully; with strong devotion, to one of strong devotion; with a serene mind, to one of serene mind; with excellent superior intention, to one who has excellent superior intention; and, having generated the mind of awakening, gives it with superior intention to a bodhisattva who has generated the mind of awakening. Even for the writing and reading of it, he does not remain content with mere inclination, but applies himself with diligence and earnest effort. He has others take it up, teaches it properly, sets it forth properly, praises it properly, and brings others to proper delight in it. He explains its meaning by way of words, by designations, by detailed indications, and by following expositions. And he says to that person: 'Son of good family, come here. Train in this path of the bodhisattvas. If you train in this path, practice it, and strive, you will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.'"

"Having fully awakened, he will also bring to maturity the immeasurable realms of sentient beings, in the unsurpassed exhaustion of the aggregates, that is, in the full distinction of the limit of reality." Saying this, he thus purifies

that person's mind and removes his doubt, and says these words: "Son of good family, you should attain precisely those qualities that accompany the Perfection of Wisdom."

Kauśika, such a son or daughter of good family generates far more merit than the former. Why is that? Kauśika, it is because this person fully discerns the fruit of the non-returner.

Kauśika, set aside the merit of establishing all the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa in the fruit of the non-returner. Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the sentient beings of the world-system of the four great continents in the fruit of the non-returner. And set aside, Kauśika, the merit of establishing all the sentient beings of the world-system of the four great continents in that fruit.

Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the sentient beings in a world-system of a thousand worlds, the small chiliocosm, in the fruit of the non-returner. And set aside, Kauśika, the merit of establishing all the sentient beings of that small chiliocosm in that fruit.

Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the sentient beings in the world-system of the middle, twice-thousandfold chiliocosm in the fruit of the non-returner. And set aside, Kauśika, the merit of establishing all the sentient beings of the middle chiliocosm in that fruit.

Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the sentient beings in the world-system of the great thousandfold world-system, the threefold-thousand great chiliocosm, in the fruit of the non-returner. And set aside, Kauśika, the merit of establishing all the sentient beings of the great chiliocosm in that fruit.

Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the sentient beings in as many great chiliocosms as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā in the fruit of the non-returner. Kauśika, what do you think? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra) replied: "Much, Blessed One. Much, Sugata."

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, a son or daughter of good family who does the following generates even far more merit than that. Having even copied this Perfection of Wisdom in a book, in a small form, he gives it with a lofty intention to a bodhisattva who has generated the mind of awakening: one who has faith through true faith, discernment through thorough discernment,

devotion through superior devotion, serene confidence through serene confidence, and who, through the excellence of a lofty intention, has an excellent lofty intention. Or he does not remain content with mere inclination toward even the small act of writing and reading it, but applies himself with diligence, has others take it up, teaches it properly, sets it forth properly, praises it properly, and brings others to proper delight in it."

He explains the meaning of it to him properly, through indication in words, through detailed indication, and through further indication. And he says to him: "Noble son, come here and train in this path of the bodhisattvas. If you train in this path, practice it, and strive, you will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And having become fully awakened, you will bring to complete discipline, through the unsurpassed exhaustion of the aggregates, the immeasurable realms of sentient beings, which is to say, through the definitive distinguishing of the true limit." Speaking in this way, he purifies that person's mind and removes his doubt. And if he says these words: "Noble son, may you attain those very qualities that accord with the Perfection of Wisdom," then, Kauśika, this noble son or noble daughter produces far more merit than the former one. Why is that? Kauśika, because from this the fruit of the non-returner is distinguished.

Furthermore, Kauśika, suppose that some noble son or noble daughter were to establish in arhatship all the beings who live in Jambudvīpa. Kauśika, what do you think? Would that noble son or noble daughter generate much merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra) replied: "Blessed One, much indeed. Sugata, much indeed."

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, even more merit than that is generated by this noble son or noble daughter, who takes this Perfection of Wisdom, even in small measure, and sets it down in a book; and who, to a bodhisattva who has generated the mind of awakening, one who has faith through true faith, discernment through thorough discernment, devotion through superior devotion, serene confidence through serene confidence, and an excellent lofty intention through the excellence of a lofty intention, gives it with a lofty intention. Or he does not remain content with mere inclination toward even the small act of writing and reading it, but applies himself with diligence, has others take it up, teaches it properly, sets it forth properly, praises it properly, and brings others to proper delight in it. He explains the meaning of it to him properly, through indication in words, through detailed indication, and through

further indication. And he says to him: 'Noble son, come here and train in this path of the bodhisattvas. If you train in this path, practice it, and strive, you will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And having become fully awakened, you will bring to complete discipline, through the unsurpassed exhaustion of the aggregates, the immeasurable realms of sentient beings, which is to say, through the definitive distinguishing of the true limit.' Speaking in this way, he purifies that person's mind and removes his doubt. And if he says these words: 'Noble son, may you attain those very qualities that accord with the Perfection of Wisdom,' then, Kauśika, this noble son or noble daughter produces far more merit than the former one. Why is that? Kauśika, because from this arhatship is distinguished as well.

In this regard, noble son, to whatever extent you train in the Perfection of Wisdom, to that extent you will gradually attain the qualities of a buddha and draw near to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening."

If you train in this training and practice it with effort, you will come to distinguish the fruit of stream-entry. You will come to distinguish the fruit of once-returning. You will come to distinguish the fruit of non-returning. You will come to distinguish arhatship. You will come to distinguish the state of a pratyekabuddha. You will come to distinguish the state of a perfectly complete buddha." In this way he will cause joy to increase.

Kauśika, let alone the merit produced by some noble son or noble daughter who establishes all the beings of Jambudvīpa in arhatship. Suppose, Kauśika, that some noble son or noble daughter were to establish in arhatship all the beings there are in the world-system of the four great continents. And let alone the merit of establishing in arhatship all the beings of the world-system of the four continents. Suppose, Kauśika, that someone were to establish in arhatship all the beings there are in a world-system of a thousand, a small thousand. And let alone the merit of establishing in arhatship all the beings of a small thousandfold world-system. Suppose, Kauśika, that someone were to establish in arhatship all the beings there are in a world-system of the second thousand, the intermediate one. And let alone the merit of establishing in arhatship all the beings of that intermediate world-system. Suppose, Kauśika, that someone were to establish in arhatship all the beings there are in a world-system of the third thousand, the great thousand, the great trichiliocosm. And let alone the merit of establishing in arhatship all the beings of the great trichiliocosm. Suppose, Kauśika, that some noble son or noble daughter were to establish in arhatship all the beings there are in as many

great trichiliocosm world-systems as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges. What do you think, Kauśika? Would that noble son or noble daughter produce much merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra) replied: "Blessed One, much! Sugata, much! Blessed One, that mass of merit is not easily reckoned. Blessed One, that mass of merit cannot easily be counted, nor illustrated by an example, nor shown by a simile, nor taken as a basis, nor made a close approximation."

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, even so, this noble son or noble daughter produces far more merit than that. Namely, one who writes out this Perfection of Wisdom, even if only in a small volume, and with faith gives it to one who has faith, with careful investigation to one who investigates carefully, with eager devotion to one who is eagerly devoted, with a clear and serene mind to one whose mind is clear and serene, with excellent and perfect intention to one of excellent and perfect intention, to a bodhisattva who has generated the awakening mind, with a lofty motivation. Or, even if only in small measure, he takes up writing it and reading it without any laxity, and with diligence causes others to grasp it. He shows it properly, establishes others in it properly, praises it properly, and gladdens others in it properly. He explains it through words, through indications, and through follow-up explanations, and properly expounds its meaning to them.

To such a one he says: "Noble son, come here and train in this path of the bodhisattvas. If you train in this path, practice it, and strive in it, you will swiftly awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. And having become fully awakened, you will bring to maturity the countless realms of sentient beings, through the unsurpassable exhaustion of the aggregates, that is, through the discernment of the true limit." In this way he speaks, purifying that person's mind and removing all doubt. And if he says these words: "Noble son, strive to attain those very qualities that accord with the Perfection of Wisdom," then this very act brings forth far greater merit. Why is that? Kauśika, from this the state of an arhat is discerned.

To him he says: "Noble son, as you train in the Perfection of Wisdom, so, step by step, you will attain the qualities of a buddha and draw near to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. If you train in this, practice it, and strive, you will realize the fruit of the stream-enterer. You will realize the fruit of the once-returner. You will realize the fruit of the non-returner. You will realize the state of an arhat. You will realize the state of a pratyekabuddha.

You will realize the state of a perfectly complete buddha." In this way he increases the other's joy.

Furthermore, Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish all the beings of Jambudvīpa, as many as there are, in the state of a pratyekabuddha. What do you think, Kauśika? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra) replied: "Much, Blessed One, much, Sugata."

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, even more merit than that is generated by the son or daughter of good family who does the following. Even if only in small measure, he puts this Perfection of Wisdom into a book, and gives it, with lofty motivation, to a bodhisattva who has generated the awakening mind: one who has faith, to one who has faith; one who has keen discernment, to one who has keen discernment; one who has deep conviction, to one who has deep conviction; one whose mind is serene, to one whose mind is serene; one with excellent and perfect lofty intention, to one with excellent and perfect lofty intention. Or, even if only in small measure, he takes up writing it and reading it without any laxity, and with diligence causes others to grasp it. He shows it properly, establishes others in it properly, praises it properly, and gladdens others in it properly. He explains it through words, through indications, and through follow-up explanations, and properly expounds its meaning to them.

"To such a one he says: 'Noble son, come here and train in this path of the bodhisattvas. If you train in this path, practice it, and strive in it, you will swiftly awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. And having become fully awakened, you will bring to maturity the countless realms of sentient beings, through the unsurpassable exhaustion of the aggregates, that is, through the discernment of the true limit.' In this way he speaks, purifying that person's mind and removing all doubt. And if he says these words: 'Noble son, strive to attain those very qualities that accord with the Perfection of Wisdom,' then this very act brings forth far greater merit. Why is that? Kauśika, from this the state of a pratyekabuddha is discerned."

To such a one he should say: "Noble son, to the degree that you train in the Perfection of Wisdom, to that very degree you will gradually obtain the qualities of a buddha. You will draw near to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. If you train in this discipline, practice it, and strive, you will come to discern the fruit of a stream-enterer. You will come to discern the fruit of a

once-returner. You will come to discern the fruit of a non-returner. You will come to discern the state of an arhat. You will come to discern the state of a pratyekabuddha. You will come to discern the state of a perfectly complete buddha." In this way he should increase that person's joy.

Kauśika, setting aside the merit produced by establishing all the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa in the state of a pratyekabuddha, consider the following. Suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish in the state of a pratyekabuddha every sentient being in the world-realm of the four great continents. Setting aside even that merit, suppose they were to establish in the state of a pratyekabuddha every sentient being in a world-realm of the small thousandfold system. Setting that aside too, suppose they were to establish in the state of a pratyekabuddha every sentient being in the middling twofold thousand world-realm. Setting that aside as well, suppose they were to establish in the state of a pratyekabuddha every sentient being in the great threefold thousand world-realm.

Now, Kauśika, suppose some son or daughter of good family were to establish in the state of a pratyekabuddha as many sentient beings as there are in world-realms, each a great threefold thousand world-system, as numerous as the grains of sand in the river Ganges. Kauśika, what do you think? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra) replied: "Blessed One, it would be much. Sugata, it would be much."

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, even so, a son or daughter of good family who does the following generates far more merit than that. Suppose one commits this Perfection of Wisdom to writing, even in a small volume. Then, with faith toward one who has faith, with careful discernment toward one who discerns carefully, with deep conviction toward one who is deeply convinced, with serene confidence toward one who has serene confidence, with excellent and superior intention toward one whose intention is excellent and superior, one gives it, with superior intention, to a bodhisattva who has generated the awakening mind. Even for so small a matter as writing and reading it, one practices without negligence and with diligence. One causes that person to take it up. One shows it correctly, sets it forth correctly, praises it correctly, and brings correct delight. One expresses it through words, through full characterization, and through further indication. And one explains its meaning correctly to that person."

To that person one says: "Child of good family, come here. Train in this path of the bodhisattvas. If you train in this path, practice it, and make effort, you will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. And once you have fully awakened as a buddha, you will bring about the taming, within the unsurpassable exhaustion of the aggregates, of beings whose realms cannot be measured, so that they are distinguished in the true limit." One speaks in this way, thereby purifying that person's mind and removing all doubt. And if one says these words: "Child of good family, strive to attain just those qualities that accompany the Perfection of Wisdom," then this gives rise to far greater merit than the former.

Why is that so? Kauśika, from this very practice one distinguishes the state of a solitary buddha. Child of good family, to whatever degree you come to train in the Perfection of Wisdom, to that degree you will gradually attain the qualities of a buddha and draw near to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. If you train in this training, practice it, and make effort, you will distinguish the fruit of stream-entry. You will distinguish the fruit of once-returning. You will distinguish the fruit of non-returning. You will distinguish the state of an arhat. You will distinguish the state of a solitary buddha. You will distinguish the state of a perfectly complete buddha. In this way one makes that person's joy increase.

Furthermore, Kauśika, suppose that some son or daughter of good family were to bring all the beings that exist in Jambudvīpa to generate the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. And suppose, Kauśika, that some other son or daughter of good family, having brought all of them to generate that mind, were to write out this Perfection of Wisdom and give it to them. And suppose, Kauśika, that some other son or daughter of good family, thinking, "This one will train in this Perfection of Wisdom and apply himself to it; through this very practice, by meditating on this Perfection of Wisdom, and by its growth, increase, and expansion, he will bring the qualities of a buddha to complete fulfillment," were to entrust this Perfection of Wisdom to an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being. This latter son or daughter of good family generates far greater merit than the former. Why is that so? Because this great being will certainly awaken fully to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening and bring the suffering of beings to an end.

Kauschika, let alone the merit of generating the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening in all the beings of Jambudvīpa. Kauśika, consider rather the case where some son or daughter of good family brings all

the beings that exist in the world system of the four great continents to generate the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. And again, Kauśika, set aside even the merit of generating that awakening mind in all the beings of the world system of the four great continents.

Kauśika, consider next a world system of a thousand worlds. Suppose some son or daughter of good family were to bring all the beings who dwell there to generate the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. And yet, Kauśika, set aside even the merit of generating the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening in all the beings of that world system of a thousand worlds.

Kauśika, consider a world system of a second thousand, the middle one. Suppose some son or daughter of good family were to bring all the beings who dwell there to generate the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. And yet, Kauśika, set aside even the merit of generating that awakening mind in all the beings of that middle world system of a second thousand.

Kauśika, consider a world system of a third thousand, the great thousand of thousands. Suppose some son or daughter of good family were to bring all the beings who dwell there to generate the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. And yet, Kauśika, set aside even the merit of generating that awakening mind in all the beings of that great world system of three thousand.

Kauśika, consider now as many great world systems of three thousand as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā. Suppose some son or daughter of good family were to bring all the beings who dwell in them to generate the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. And suppose, Kauśika, that some other son or daughter of good family, having brought all those beings to generate the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, were to write out this Perfection of Wisdom and give it to them. Suppose that person thinks: "They will study this Perfection of Wisdom and practice it in yoga. In this way, through meditating on it intensely, this Perfection of Wisdom will grow, increase, and expand, and so become fully complete." And suppose that person then entrusts this Perfection of Wisdom to a bodhisattva, a great being, who is irreversible from awakening. Then, Kauśika, that son or daughter of good family will generate far greater merit than the former one.

Why is this so? Because this bodhisattva will surely become fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, and will bring the suffering of beings to an end.

Furthermore, Kauśika, suppose all the beings who exist in Jambudvīpa have become irreversible from unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. And suppose some son or daughter of good family, having had this Perfection of Wisdom written down in a book, gives it to those very beings and entrusts it to them, and teaches it to them with its meaning and with its letters. Kauśika, what do you think? Would that son or daughter of good family generate much merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra) replied: "Blessed One, much! Sugata, much! Blessed One, that mass of merit cannot easily be counted. Blessed One, that mass of merit cannot easily be reckoned, nor easily shown by any example, nor easily made a basis or a cause."

The Blessed One said: "Kauśika, this son or daughter of good family generates even greater merit than that."

Suppose, then, that for those irreversible bodhisattvas, great beings, who wish to quickly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, someone writes this Perfection of Wisdom down in a book, gives it to them and entrusts it to them, and teaches it to them with its meaning and with its letters, and instructs them in this Perfection of Wisdom and guides them in it. Kauśika, setting aside the merit generated by entrusting this Perfection of Wisdom to all the beings of Jambudvīpa who have become irreversible, consider this.

Kauśika, suppose that all the beings who exist in the world system of the four great continents have become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and that some son or daughter of good family writes this Perfection of Wisdom down in a book, gives it to them and entrusts it to them, and teaches it to them with its meaning and with its letters. Kauśika, set aside even the merit generated by entrusting this Perfection of Wisdom to all the beings of the world system of the four great continents who have become irreversible.

Kauśika, suppose that all the beings who exist in the world system of the small thousandfold realm have become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and that some son or daughter of good family writes this Perfection of Wisdom down in a book, gives it to them and entrusts it to them,

and teaches it to them with its meaning and with its letters. Kauśika, set aside even the merit generated by entrusting this Perfection of Wisdom to all the beings of the small thousandfold world system who have become irreversible.

Kauśika, suppose that all the beings who exist in the world system of the middling twofold thousand have become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and that some son or daughter of good family writes this Perfection of Wisdom down in a book, gives it to them and entrusts it to them, and teaches it to them with its meaning and with its letters. Kauśika, set aside even the merit generated by entrusting this Perfection of Wisdom to all the beings of the middling twofold-thousand world system who have become irreversible.

Kauśika, suppose that all the beings who exist in the world system of the great thousand of the three thousand have become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and that some son or daughter of good family writes this Perfection of Wisdom down in a book, gives it to them and entrusts it to them, and teaches it to them with its meaning and with its letters. Kauśika, set aside even the merit generated by entrusting this Perfection of Wisdom to all the beings of the great thousand world system of the three thousand who have become irreversible.

Kauśika, suppose that in world systems as numerous as the sands of the river Gaṅgā, each a great thousand of the three thousand, all the beings there are have become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And suppose that some son or daughter of good family writes this Perfection of Wisdom down in a book, gives it to them and entrusts it to them, and teaches it to them with its meaning and with its letters. Kauśika, what do you think? Would that son or daughter of good family generate a great deal of merit on that basis?

Śakra (Indra), the lord of the gods, replied: Blessed One, a great deal! Sugata, a great deal! Blessed One, that mass of merit cannot easily be counted. Blessed One, that mass of merit cannot easily be reckoned, nor shown by example, nor made a basis, nor made a cause.

The Blessed One declared: Kauśika, even more merit than that is generated by the son or daughter of good family who writes this Perfection of Wisdom down in a book and gives it and entrusts it to those bodhisattva great beings who are irreversible and who wish to quickly attain complete awakening in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, who teaches it to them with its

meaning and with its letters, and who instructs them in this Perfection of Wisdom and guides them in it.

Then, Kauśika, suppose another bodhisattva great being appears and says: I shall attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening more quickly than these. Kauśika, if a son or daughter of good family instructs and guides in this Perfection of Wisdom that bodhisattva great being, whose higher knowledge is exceedingly swift, then that son or daughter of good family generates even more merit than the former one.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, in whatever way bodhisattva great beings draw near to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, in just that way they should be instructed and guided in the Perfection of Wisdom. By being instructed and guided in the Perfection of Wisdom in just that way, they come close to suchness. When they have come close to suchness, those who make use of their robes, alms food, bedding, seats, medicines for the sick, and requisites accomplish what is to be done, and make that offering bring great fruit and great reward. Therefore that person generates very great merit. Why is that? Blessed One, it is because such is the very nature of the bodhisattva great being who draws near to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Then the venerable Subhūti said this to Śakra, lord of the gods: Kauśika, it is excellent, excellent, that you inspire the people who follow the bodhisattva vehicle with joy, that you support them and attend to them. Kauśika, this is what you should do. Any noble hearer (śrāvaka) who wishes to look after all beings should cause bodhisattva great beings to increase their joy in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and should support them and attend to them. That is what is to be done. And why is that?

For the unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening of bodhisattva great beings is born from this. If bodhisattva great beings had not given rise to this awakening mind, those bodhisattva great beings would not train in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, nor would they train in the six perfections. And if they did not train, they would not become fully and completely awakened in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. But it is because bodhisattva great beings train in these six perfections, the training of bodhisattvas, that they give rise to the awakening mind. And for that reason they become fully and completely awakened in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

This is the fifth chapter, called "The Chapter on the Categories of Merit," from the noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Then the bodhisattva great being Maitreya said this to the venerable Subhūti: Noble Subhūti, consider further the basis of meritorious action that is accompanied by rejoicing and dedication on the part of a bodhisattva great being. Of all the bases of meritorious action that arise from the generosity of all beings, all the bases of meritorious action that arise from moral discipline, and all the bases of meritorious action that arise from meditation, this very basis of meritorious action, accompanied by a bodhisattva great being's rejoicing and dedication, is called the supreme, the sublime, the chief, the excellent, the most excellent, the finest, the highest, the unsurpassed. It is called the peerless, the unequaled, and that which equals the unequaled.

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said this to the bodhisattva great being Maitreya: Maitreya, consider a bodhisattva great being who rejoices in the following. In the worlds of the ten directions, which extend everywhere and in all ways, there are world-systems, each a great trichiliocosm, that are immeasurable beyond measure, innumerable beyond number, limitless beyond limit, inconceivable beyond conception, without boundary or end. In each direction, in each of those great trichiliocosm world-systems, in times gone by, there were tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, immeasurable beyond measure, innumerable beyond number, limitless beyond limit, inconceivable beyond conception, without boundary or end. Their path was cut off and their entry into rebirth was cut off. Elaboration and the leading on to existence were cut off, their tears were exhausted, and their thorns were destroyed. They had set down the burden completely, attained their own aim, and utterly exhausted the bonds to existence. Their minds were thoroughly liberated through right and perfect knowledge, and they had reached the far shore of the sovereign mastery of all minds. These buddhas passed completely beyond sorrow into the realm of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates. The bodhisattva rejoices in all of this, from the time when those buddhas first gave rise to the mind of awakening, up to the time when they became fully and completely awakened in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; and up to their passing beyond sorrow into the realm of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates; and up to the time when the sacred Dharma had not yet vanished, that is to say,

And likewise, the bodhisattva rejoices in the roots of virtue of all those blessed buddhas in between: the aggregate of moral discipline, the aggregate of

meditative absorption, the aggregate of wisdom, the aggregate of liberation, and the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation; whatever roots of virtue are endowed with the six perfections; the roots of virtue endowed with the perfect qualities of a buddha; the roots of virtue endowed with the perfection of the powers and of fearlessness; and likewise those endowed with the perfection of the higher knowledges, with the perfection of thorough understanding, and with the perfection of aspiration; whatever roots of virtue are endowed with the perfect wisdom of omniscience; whatever benevolent intention they held, whatever great loving-kindness, whatever great compassion; whatever immeasurable, incalculable qualities of a buddha there are; whatever unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening there is, and whatever bliss belongs to that unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; whatever perfection of sovereign mastery over all phenomena there is; the immeasurable, unsurpassable supreme exercise of miraculous power that overpowers everything; and whatever power of the Tathāgata's wisdom there is, knowing things exactly as they are, unobstructed, unattached, unimpeded, without equal, beyond the equal and the unequal, without analogy, immeasurable. He rejoices in whatever power of buddha wisdom there is among the powers, in whatever wisdom and vision of a buddha there is, in whatever perfection of the ten powers there is, in whatever full and supreme realization of the four fearlessnesses there is, and in whatever realization of the Dharma there is through ultimately accomplishing all phenomena.

He rejoices in the turning of the wheel of Dharma; in the holding up of the lamp of Dharma, the beating of the drum of Dharma, the blowing of the conch of Dharma, the proclaiming of the conch of Dharma, the wielding of the sword of Dharma, the sending down of the rain of Dharma, the giving of the sacrificial offering of Dharma; and in the way that, through the gift of Dharma, they fully satisfied and thoroughly nourished all sentient beings.

He rejoices in whatever teachings were taught, and in the roots of virtue of all those who were tamed, trained, inclined, made certain, and turned toward complete awakening through those teachings, whether the Dharma of the buddhas, the Dharma of the solitary buddhas, or the Dharma of the hearers. He rejoices in the roots of virtue endowed with the six perfections of those bodhisattvas, great beings, whom those blessed buddhas prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; in the roots of virtue of all those individuals of the solitary buddha vehicle who were prophesied to the awakening of a solitary buddha; in the bases of meritorious action arising from

generosity, those arising from moral discipline, and those arising from meditation, belonging to individuals of the hearer vehicle; in the undefiled roots of virtue of those still in training; in the undefiled roots of virtue of those beyond training; and in the roots of virtue that ordinary beings have produced in regard to those teachings.

Likewise, I rejoice in the bases of meritorious action arising from generosity, from moral discipline, and from meditation, belonging to the fourfold assembly of those buddhas, the Blessed Ones: the monks, the nuns, the laymen, and the laywomen. I rejoice in all the roots of virtue produced there, in the presence of those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, as they taught the Dharma, by gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans and non-humans, and by whatever sentient beings have gone to rebirth among animals. I rejoice in the roots of virtue that anyone has produced in regard to the complete passing beyond sorrow of those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, and likewise in regard to their having passed beyond sorrow. And I rejoice in all the roots of virtue produced in dependence upon the Buddha, the Blessed One, in dependence upon the Dharma, in dependence upon the Saṅgha, and in dependence upon those individuals who cultivate meditation in their minds.

Gathering all these roots of virtue together without exception and without remainder, adding them up and weighing them, one should rejoice with the supreme rejoicing. One rejoices with a rejoicing that is holy, chief, excellent, most excellent, sublime, supreme, unsurpassed, unexcelled, without equal, beyond compare, and equal to the unequalled. Having rejoiced in this way, one should say aloud: "I dedicate that basis of meritorious action, endowed with this rejoicing, to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. May I accomplish unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening." So one should think and speak.

Now, as for those individuals who follow the bodhisattva vehicle: with what bases, what objects, and what aspects do they dedicate, and give rise to that mind? Do they focus on those bases, those objects, and those aspects just as they have taken them as signs?

When this had been said, the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, spoke thus to the elder, the venerable Subhūti: "Venerable Subhūti, they do not focus on those bases, those objects, and those aspects just as they have taken them as signs."

When this had been said, the elder, the venerable Subhūti, spoke thus to the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya: "If one were to focus on, and take as a sign, what has no basis and no object, how would this not become an inverted perception, an inverted state of mind, and an inverted view? Why is that? In just this way, attachment, though there is no real basis, imagines and thoroughly imputes permanence upon what is impermanent, happiness upon what is suffering, self upon what is selfless, and beauty upon what is unattractive, and so inverted perception, inverted mind, and inverted view arise.

"Furthermore, just as the basis is, just as the object is, and just as the aspect is, so too is awakening, and so too is the mind. If that is so, then all phenomena and all elements are likewise so. And if, just as the basis, the object, and the aspect are, awakening and mind are likewise so, then by means of which bases, which objects, and which aspects would any mind dedicate anything to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?"

Then what basis of meritorious action accompanied by rejoicing is there that one could dedicate to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, said this to the venerable elder Subhūti: "Noble Subhūti, this should not be explained or taught in the presence of bodhisattvas, great beings, who have newly entered the Great Vehicle. Why is that? Whatever faith, joy, devotion, and reverence they may have, all of it would be destroyed. Noble Subhūti, this should be explained and taught in the presence of bodhisattvas, great beings, who are irreversible. And a bodhisattva, a great being, who is sustained by a spiritual friend will not be daunted by this, will not shrink from it, will not be unnerved, and will not be disheartened. His mind will not turn back, will not be crushed and turn back, will not tremble, will not be utterly terrified, and will not come to possess utter terror. In this way, the bodhisattva, the great being, having rejoiced, should dedicate all the bases of meritorious action accompanied by rejoicing to omniscience."

This is the seventh volume of the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Then the venerable elder Subhūti said this to the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya: "Maitreya, the mind by which one rejoices and dedicates has itself been exhausted, has ceased, has vanished and been transformed. That being so, what is that mind by which one dedicates to unsurpassed, perfect,

complete awakening? And what is that mind that dedicates the basis of meritorious action accompanied by rejoicing to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening? When two minds do not meet, and that mind cannot by its intrinsic nature dedicate anything either, then how could a mind possibly dedicate a mind?"

Then Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), said this to the venerable elder Subhūti: "Noble Subhūti, if those bodhisattvas, great beings, who are newly entered into the Great Vehicle were to hear this teaching and tremble, be utterly terrified, and come to possess utter terror, that would not be right. Noble Subhūti, then how should a bodhisattva, a great being, dedicate that basis of meritorious action accompanied by rejoicing to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening? In grasping the basis of meritorious action accompanied by rejoicing, and in dedicating the mind accompanied by rejoicing, how does that mind accompanied by rejoicing come to be well grasped and well dedicated?"

Then the venerable elder Subhūti, addressing the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, taking him as his basis, spoke to him.

"Maitreya, here a bodhisattva, a great being, may consider the worlds of the ten directions: the immeasurable, countless world systems, each a great trichiliocosm, that exist in every single direction. In each and every one of those great trichiliocosms there are buddhas, Blessed Ones of the past, who have cut off the path, cut off the entering, cut off proliferation and the leading into existence, who have exhausted their tears, destroyed the thorns, thoroughly laid down the burden, attained their own aim, utterly exhausted the bonds of existence, whose minds are perfectly liberated through right and complete knowledge, who have reached the far shore of mastery over all minds, and who, immeasurable and countless, have passed into nirvāṇa. From the time when those buddhas, those Blessed Ones, first generated the mind of awakening, up to their fully awakening into unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; and up to their passing completely into nirvāṇa in the realm of nirvāṇa without any remainder of the aggregates; and up to the time before the sacred Dharma had disappeared: whatever roots of virtue those buddhas, those Blessed Ones, had during all that time, together with the perfections; whatever formation of merit and formation of roots of virtue they accomplished; whatever aggregate of moral discipline, aggregate of meditative absorption, aggregate of wisdom, aggregate of liberation, and aggregate of the seeing of the wisdom of liberation those buddhas, those

Blessed Ones, possessed; whatever their wish to benefit others, their great loving-kindness, and their great compassion; and whatever immeasurable and countless qualities of a buddha they had.

Further, whatever Dharma those buddhas, those Blessed Ones, taught, and the roots of virtue of those who trained in that Dharma, who had devotion to it, and who abided in it; the roots of virtue, endowed with the six perfections, of those bodhisattvas, great beings, whom those buddhas, those Blessed Ones, prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; the roots of virtue of those individuals of the vehicle of the solitary buddhas whom those buddhas prophesied to their own awakening; the roots of virtue arising from generosity, from moral discipline, and from meditation among individuals of the hearer vehicle; the undefiled roots of virtue of those still in training, and the undefiled roots of virtue of those beyond training; the roots of virtue that ordinary beings have created in relation to that Dharma; the roots of virtue created by gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, and non-humans who heard that Dharma and, having heard it, created roots of virtue; the roots of virtue created by sentient beings born as animals who heard that Dharma and, having heard it, created roots of virtue; and the roots of virtue that sentient beings created in relation to those buddhas, those Blessed Ones, as they were passing into nirvāṇa and after they had passed into nirvāṇa.

Having gathered all of these roots of virtue into one, summed them up, measured them, and left nothing out, and having rejoiced in all that is worthy of rejoicing without exception, if he then dedicates that basis of meritorious action accompanied by rejoicing to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, who dedicates it not come to have a distorted perception, not come to have a distorted mind, and not come to have a distorted view?"

When he had spoken thus,

The bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, spoke to the venerable elder Subhūti and said: "Noble Subhūti, suppose a bodhisattva, a great being, does not form the perception of "mind" regarding the mind by which he dedicates, and the mind to which he dedicates. In that case, that bodhisattva, a great being, has dedicated the basis of meritorious action accompanied by rejoicing to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Because he does not truly think of that mind, "This is that mind," a bodhisattva, a great being, does not come

to have a distorted perception, does not come to have a distorted mind, and does not come to have a distorted view.

But suppose he knows of the mind by which he dedicates, and the mind to which he dedicates, "That mind is such and such," and he forms the perception of it as mind. Then that bodhisattva, a great being, comes to have a distorted perception, a distorted mind, and a distorted view.

Suppose, then, that a bodhisattva, a great being, knows rightly about the mind by which he dedicates, and thinks in this way: "When that mind is considered, it is exhausted, and what is exhausted is simply exhausted." He knows it as exhausted, and knows that it has ceased, is devoid of any basis, and has changed. And what is exhausted cannot be dedicated. Moreover, the nature of the mind by which he dedicates is just this; the nature of the things by which he dedicates is just this; and the nature of the things to which he dedicates is just this. If he dedicates in this way, it is a right dedication and not a wrong dedication. It is in this way that a bodhisattva, a great being, should dedicate.

Noble Subhūti, furthermore, there is this. A bodhisattva, a great being, should consider the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, and likewise those yet to come, whose paths of rebirth have been cut off, whose entry into new existence has been cut off, whose elaborations have been cut off, and whose pull toward becoming has been cut off, who are immeasurable and innumerable. He should consider the roots of virtue of those Blessed Buddhas, from the time they first generated the mind of awakening, until they become fully and completely awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, until they pass fully into nirvāṇa in the realm of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates, and until the sacred Dharma comes to an end, and so across all that interval. These are the roots of virtue connected with the perfections of those Buddhas, the Blessed Ones; the aggregate of moral discipline, the aggregate of meditative absorption, the aggregate of wisdom, the aggregate of liberation, and the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation of those Buddhas, the Blessed Ones; their wish to benefit others, their great loving-kindness, and their great compassion; the immeasurable and innumerable qualities of a buddha; the Dharma that those Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, will teach, the roots of virtue of those who will train in that Dharma, those who will be devoted to it, and those who will abide in it; the roots of virtue connected with the six perfections of those bodhisattvas whom those Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, will prophesy to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; and the roots of virtue of those persons of the vehicle of

the solitary buddhas whom those Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, will prophesy to the awakening of a solitary buddha, and so on.

the roots of virtue of those persons who belong to the vehicle of the hearers, namely the bases of meritorious action that arise from giving, the bases of meritorious action that arise from moral discipline, and the bases of meritorious action that arise from meditation; the undefiled roots of virtue of those still in training, and the undefiled roots of virtue of those beyond training; and the roots of virtue that ordinary beings will generate in regard to that Dharma; and all those gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, and non-humans who will hear that Dharma, and the roots of virtue they will generate having heard it; and the sentient beings born in animal realms who will also hear that Dharma, and the roots of virtue they will generate having heard it; and the roots of virtue that beings will generate in regard to those Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, who pass completely beyond sorrow, and in regard to those who have passed completely beyond sorrow.

Having gathered all of these roots of virtue into one, having totaled and measured them so that nothing is left over, and having rejoiced in what is to be rejoiced in without exception, the bodhisattva, the great being, dedicates that basis of merit, which is endowed with rejoicing, to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. How, then, does such a bodhisattva avoid perverted perception, perverted thought, and perverted view?

If that bodhisattva, the great being, does not perceive as a mind the very mind by which, and toward which, he dedicates, then in this way the bodhisattva, the great being, has dedicated the basis of merit endowed with rejoicing to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. In that the bodhisattva does not apprehend that mind, saying "this is that mind," in just this way he does not fall into perverted perception, perverted thought, or perverted view.

But if he truly knows, "this is that mind, the mind by which and toward which I dedicate," and comes to perceive it as a mind, then the bodhisattva, the great being, falls into perverted perception, perverted thought, and perverted view.

If the bodhisattva, the great being, knows and reflects in this way regarding the mind that dedicates: when I reflect on that mind, it is exhausted; he truly knows that what is exhausted is exhausted, that it has ceased, is separated, and has changed. And so he knows that what is exhausted cannot itself be dedicated. The nature of the mind by which one dedicates is just this; the

nature of those phenomena with which one dedicates is just this; and the nature of those phenomena toward which one dedicates is just this. If one dedicates in this way, one dedicates correctly and not incorrectly. In this way the bodhisattva, the great being, should dedicate.

Noble Subhūti, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, considers the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, who are present now in the immeasurable and innumerable world systems of the great trichiliocosm, who have cut off the path, cut off entry, cut off conceptual elaboration, and cut off the leading into existence, who dwell, live, and sustain themselves, from the moment they first generated the mind of awakening, up until they became fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and so on.

From then until they pass into nirvāṇa in the realm of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates, and until the sacred Dharma disappears, throughout that whole span, the bodhisattva takes into account the roots of virtue of those Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, that are endowed with the perfections; the aggregate of moral discipline, the aggregate of meditative absorption, the aggregate of wisdom, the aggregate of liberation, and the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation of those Buddhas, the Blessed Ones; their wish to benefit others, their great loving-kindness, their great compassion, and the immeasurable and innumerable qualities of a buddha.

He takes into account whatever Dharma those Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, have taught, and the roots of virtue of those who train in that Dharma, who have devoted themselves to it, and who abide in it; the roots of virtue endowed with the six perfections of those bodhisattvas, great beings, whom those Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, have prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; the roots of virtue of those individuals of the vehicle of the solitary buddhas whom those Buddhas have prophesied to the awakening of a solitary buddha; and the bases of meritorious action arising from generosity, the bases of meritorious action arising from moral discipline, and the bases of meritorious action arising from meditation, of individuals of the vehicle of the hearers.

He takes into account the undefiled roots of virtue of those still in training, and the undefiled roots of virtue of those beyond training; the roots of virtue that ordinary beings have produced with regard to that Dharma; and the roots of virtue produced by those who have heard that Dharma, whether gods, nāgas,

yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, or non-humans, who heard that Dharma and, having heard it, produced roots of virtue; and the roots of virtue produced by those sentient beings who have been born in animal births, who heard that Dharma and, having heard it, produced roots of virtue.

Further, whatever roots of virtue have been produced in relation to the passing into nirvāṇa and the having passed into nirvāṇa of those Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, he gathers all of these roots of virtue into one, sums them up, measures them, and leaves nothing out. Having rejoiced in all that is to be rejoiced in, without exception, the bodhisattva, the great being, dedicates that basis of meritorious action, endowed with rejoicing, to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Venerable Subhūti may ask: how does the bodhisattva, the great being, come to have no distorted perception, no distorted thought, and no distorted view?

If that bodhisattva, the great being, does not perceive as a mind that very mind with which he dedicates, then the bodhisattva, the great being, has dedicated the basis of meritorious action endowed with rejoicing to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Because he does not truly know that mind, saying "that mind is this," in just this way the bodhisattva, the great being, has no distorted perception, no distorted thought, and no distorted view.

But suppose that, with regard to the very mind by which he dedicates, he truly knows "that mind is this," and comes to hold it as a mind in his perception. In that case, the bodhisattva, the great being, would have a distorted perception, a distorted thought, and a distorted view.

On the other hand, if the bodhisattva, the great being, regarding the mind by which he dedicates, knows and reflects in this way: "When one examines that mind, it is exhausted, and one truly knows it as exhausted; it is free from cessation, separated from it, and transformed." Knowing it thus, he understands that whatever is exhausted cannot be dedicated. "The nature of reality of the mind by which one dedicates is just this. The nature of reality of those phenomena with which one dedicates is just this. The nature of reality of those phenomena to which one dedicates is also just this." If he dedicates in this way, it is correct dedication, not incorrect dedication. In this way the bodhisattva, the great being, should dedicate.

Noble Subhūti, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, should consider the following. Take the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, of the future, and of the present, immeasurable and innumerable, who have cut off the path, cut off entry, cut off conceptual elaboration, and cut off the leading on to existence. Consider them from the time they first generated the awakening mind, through the time they become, and will become, fully and completely awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, up to their full awakening; then their passing fully beyond sorrow into the realm of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates, and their going to, and being about to go to, final nirvāṇa; and then up to the time when the sacred Dharma has not disappeared, will not disappear, and has not come to disappear.

Of all those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, throughout that span, he should dedicate the roots of virtue of their perfections. He should dedicate the aggregate of moral discipline, the aggregate of meditative absorption, the aggregate of wisdom, the aggregate of liberation, and the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation of those buddhas, the Blessed Ones. He should dedicate their wish to benefit others, their great loving-kindness, their great compassion, and their immeasurable and innumerable buddha qualities.

He should also dedicate the roots of virtue of those who, through whatever Dharma those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, have taught, are teaching, and will teach, have trained, are training, and will train in those teachings; who have faith, are coming to have faith, and are having faith; and who have dwelt, are dwelling, and will dwell in them. He should dedicate all the roots of virtue of those bodhisattvas, great beings, whom those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, have prophesied, will prophesy, and are prophesying to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. He should dedicate all the roots of virtue of those persons of the solitary buddha vehicle whom those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, have prophesied, will prophesy, and are prophesying to their own awakening.

He should dedicate the roots of virtue of persons of the hearer vehicle: the roots of virtue arising from generosity, those arising from moral discipline, and those arising from meditation. He should dedicate the undefiled roots of virtue of those still in training, and the undefiled roots of virtue of those beyond training.

As for that Dharma, there are ordinary persons who have created, will create, and are creating roots of virtue through it. There are also gods, nāgas, yakṣas,

gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, and nonhuman beings who have heard that Dharma, will hear it, and are hearing it, and who, having heard it, have generated, will generate, and are generating roots of virtue. There are, moreover, sentient beings born in animal births who have heard, will hear, and are hearing that sacred Dharma, and who, having heard it, have created, will create, and are creating roots of virtue. And there are beings who have created, will create, and are creating roots of virtue with regard to those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, who have passed, will pass, and are passing into complete nirvāṇa.

All the roots of virtue of all of these he should gather together into one, sum up, measure, and leave nothing out. Then, with the supreme rejoicing that rejoices in all that is to be rejoiced in, with rejoicing that is sacred, foremost, excellent, supreme, most excellent, lofty, highest, unsurpassed, unequaled, without peer, and equal to the unequaled, having rejoiced in this way, he should dedicate the merit that accompanies such rejoicing, this unsurpassed basis of meritorious action, to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. He should express in words the wish: May this bring about unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Venerable Subhūti asks: How does a bodhisattva, a great being, who does this avoid distorted perception, distorted mind, and distorted view?

The Blessed One answers: Suppose the one who dedicates thinks, "Those phenomena are exhausted, ceased, departed, and changed, so I shall dedicate them in such a way that they will never be exhausted." If he reflects in this way, then the dedication to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening has been made. And suppose he reflects, "By means of a phenomenon one does not dedicate a phenomenon." Then too the dedication to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening has been made. Venerable Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who dedicates in this way does not fall into distorted perception, distorted mind, or distorted view.

Why is this so? Because he has no fixation on that dedication. And suppose he rightly understands, "Mind does not know mind, and a phenomenon does not know a phenomenon." Then too the dedication to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening has been made. This is the unsurpassed dedication of a bodhisattva, a great being.

But if that bodhisattva, that great being, takes the volitional formation of merit to be something he knows, then the dedication to unsurpassed, perfect,

complete awakening has not been made. Why is this so? Because he is fixated on that dedication.

And suppose he thinks, "That volitional formation of merit is itself secluded and peaceful, and that basis of meritorious action accompanied by rejoicing is also secluded and peaceful." If he thinks in this way, then the dedication to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening has been made.

But if he does not know even this, that all conditioning factors are secluded and peaceful, then, in that case, this is the Perfection of Wisdom of that bodhisattva, that great being.

Now consider the roots of virtue of those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, who have passed into complete nirvāṇa, and the way in which they were dedicated. If he knows that his own root of virtue is just like that, and that what is dedicated is of that same kind, has that same defining mark, belongs to that same category, and has that same intrinsic nature, then the dedication to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening has not been made. Why is this so? Because the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, do not sanction a dedication made through the mode of signs. What is past is exhausted, ceased, departed, transformed. What is future has not been attained. And in what is present, no abiding is found. What is not found is neither a sign nor an object. If he dwells on it in that way, making it a sign and thinking about it, then the dedication to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening has not been made.

Suppose instead that, being without recollection, he neither makes a sign nor thinks; or that, being without recollection or failing to comprehend, he pays it no attention. Even so, the dedication to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening has not been made. But if he thinks of that sign and yet does not make it a sign, then in this way the bodhisattva, the great being, has dedicated that root of virtue to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Thus the bodhisattva, the great being, should train in this, and this is to be recognized as that bodhisattva's skillful means. This dedication of roots of virtue through skillful means brings one close to omniscience. A bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to train in this skillful means should listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom without interruption. He should take it up, retain it, recite it, thoroughly understand it, study it intensively, teach it, explain it, chant it, memorize it, and inquire into it fully.

Why is this so? Without relying on the Perfection of Wisdom, and without having heard it, one is unable to engage in this work of dedication. Now if

someone says, "Even without relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, one can dedicate that basis of meritorious action to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening," he should be told, "Do not say so." Why is this so? Because those very things belonging to the self have ceased, and those conditioning factors too have ceased. They are peaceful, secluded, free from any object of focus. Yet that person makes a sign of what is real, imagines it conceptually, and perceives as real what is not as it truly is. Taking as an object what cannot be apprehended as an object, he performs the dedication. The buddhas, the Blessed Ones, do not sanction the dedication of his root of virtue to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening in this way. Why is this so? Because whatever signifying, conceptualizing, and objectifying one does regarding the complete nirvāṇa of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is itself that person's great fixation.

The Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, do not say that a dedication made by one who holds a perception of an object accomplishes a great purpose. Why is this so? Because such a dedication is accompanied by poison and by a thorn.

Consider an example. There is a fine meal that has been poisoned. In its color, smell, taste, and texture it may seem excellent, and yet, because it is accompanied by poison, the wise reject it entirely and do not partake of it. But a childish person, whose wisdom is confused, thinks to enjoy that very meal. When he eats it, he finds pleasure in its color, smell, taste, and texture; but when it is digested, its ripening becomes suffering for him, and on that basis he dies, or suffers pain close to death.

Noble Subhūti, in the same way, there are some who have grasped this teaching wrongly, understood it wrongly, and recited it wrongly. They do not know the meaning of what was well spoken, and do not comprehend the true meaning as it really is. They say: "Child of good family, come here. Take all the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, the future, and the present, in the immeasurable, countless world systems of all the worlds. Begin from their first generation of the mind of awakening. Take their awakening into unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, whether they have awakened, will awaken, or are awakening. Take their complete nirvāṇa in the realm of nirvāṇa without remainder of the aggregates, whether they have passed, will pass, or are passing, and the time until the sacred Dharma has vanished, will vanish, or is vanishing. Throughout that span, gather together the aggregate of moral discipline, the aggregate of meditative absorption, the aggregate of wisdom,

the aggregate of liberation, and the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation belonging to the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, future, and present, and to their hearers.

"Likewise gather the roots of virtue that have been planted, will be planted, and are being planted by those bodhisattvas, the great beings, whom those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, have prophesied, will prophesy, and are prophesying to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Gather the roots of virtue planted by those persons of the vehicle of the solitary buddhas who have been prophesied, will be prophesied, and are being prophesied to their own awakening. Gather the roots of virtue planted by those persons of the vehicle of the hearers who have been prophesied, will be prophesied, and are being prophesied to the awakening of hearers. And gather the roots of virtue planted there, in the past, future, and present, by ordinary beings.

"Collect all those roots of virtue into one, bring them together, measure them, leave nothing out, and rejoice in them without exception. Then dedicate the basis of merit, which is endowed with rejoicing, to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening." This is how they instruct and advise others.

A dedication made in that way, as a dedication made through the mode of signs, becomes poison itself, just like that poisoned meal. Thus, for one who holds a perception of an object, there is no dedication. Why is this so?

For the perception of an object comes together with poison. Therefore, a person on the path of the bodhisattva vehicle should not train in that way.

Then how should one train? How should one take up the roots of virtue of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, the future, and the present? How, when they are taken up, are they well taken up? How should one dedicate them, and how, when they are dedicated, are they well dedicated to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?

Here, noble son or noble daughter, one who follows the bodhisattva vehicle and wishes not to slander the Tathāgata should rejoice in all those roots of virtue in this way, and dedicate them in this way. One should think: "Just as those Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, know and see that root of virtue with the wisdom of a buddha and the eye of a buddha, and just as they know its type, the class to which it belongs, what it is like, its intrinsic nature, its defining characteristic, and the nature of reality by which it exists, so I rejoice in it. And just as those Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, have approved of how that root of virtue is to be

dedicated to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, so I shall rejoice and dedicate."

A bodhisattva, a great being, who rejoices in this way and dedicates in this way does not harm the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Such a one has rejoiced rightly, the root of virtue becomes well dedicated to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, are not slandered. For when one dedicates with superior intention and with deep conviction, that dedication is a dedication without poison. It is a great dedication. It is a dedication of the dharmadhātu. It is complete, and utterly complete.

Furthermore, noble son or noble daughter, one who follows the bodhisattva vehicle should dedicate in the following way. Whatever moral discipline there is, whatever meditative absorption, whatever wisdom, whatever liberation, and whatever seeing of the wisdom of liberation there is, these should be dedicated as not belonging to the desire realm, not belonging to the form realm, and not belonging to the formless realm, and as neither past, nor future, nor present.

Why is this so? Because they do not belong to the three times or the three realms, and so the dedication likewise does not belong to them. The phenomenon to which one dedicates, and the phenomenon of dedication by which one dedicates, are also not included in them. If one rests in conviction in this way and dedicates in this way, then the dedication of that bodhisattva, that great being, is not wasted. It is a dedication that is not included in them, a dedication without poison, a great dedication, a dedication of the dharmadhātu, complete and well and fully complete.

But if one becomes attached to that dedication and makes a sign of it, then it is a mistaken dedication.

Here, if a bodhisattva, a great being, thinks: "The dedication of that root of virtue is just as the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, know it and just as they have approved it. By this dedication of the dharmadhātu, it is dedicated to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and so it is well dedicated. In this way I dedicate it" — then this is a right dedication. A dedication made in this way is well dedicated to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Then the Blessed One said "Excellent!" to the venerable Subhūti: "Subhūti, you are doing the work of a teacher, and in teaching the Dharma to bodhisattvas, great beings, you have spoken well. Excellent, Subhūti, excellent! Why is that?

Subhūti, this dedication is the dedication of the dharmadhātu of a bodhisattva, a great being.

"In this very nature of reality, the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, know and see that root of virtue in every respect: what its type is, what category it belongs to, what it is like, what its intrinsic nature is, what its defining characteristic is, and by what nature of reality it exists. Rejoicing in it in just that way, and thinking, 'Just as they have approved, so do I dedicate it,' one gathers a mass of merit. Now suppose that in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the River Ganges, each a great thousand of the third thousand, whatever sentient beings there are, all of them were established and set firmly on the path of the ten virtuous actions by some son or daughter of good family, and that this person produced the merit of that. Compared with that merit, this mass of merit born from the dharmadhātu dedication of a bodhisattva, a great being, is called supreme. It is called excellent, chief, foremost, the best of the best, lofty, the highest, unsurpassed, without anything above it, without equal, and equal to the unequaled.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, set aside the merit produced by all the sentient beings in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges being established in the ten virtuous paths of action. Subhūti, suppose all the sentient beings in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges had attained the four meditative concentrations. Even greater than the merit those beings produce is this mass of merit possessed of the dedication of a bodhisattva, a great being. It is called supreme. It is called excellent, chief, foremost, the best of the best, lofty, the highest, unsurpassed, without anything above it, without equal, and equal to the unequaled.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, set aside the merit of all those sentient beings in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges having perfected the four meditative concentrations. Subhūti, suppose all the sentient beings in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges had attained the four immeasurables, and"

Furthermore, Subhūti, set aside the merit of all the sentient beings in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, each a great trichiliocosm, having attained the four immeasurables. Subhūti, suppose that all the sentient beings, however many there are, in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, each a great trichiliocosm, had attained the four formless absorptions. And furthermore, Subhūti, set aside the merit of all

the sentient beings in such world systems having attained the four formless absorptions.

Subhūti, suppose that all the sentient beings, however many there are, in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, each a great trichiliocosm, had attained the five higher knowledges. And furthermore, Subhūti, set aside the merit of all those sentient beings having attained the five higher knowledges.

Subhūti, suppose that all the sentient beings, however many there are, in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, each a great trichiliocosm, had become stream-enterers. And furthermore, Subhūti, set aside the merit of all those sentient beings having become stream-enterers.

Subhūti, suppose that all the sentient beings, however many there are, in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, each a great trichiliocosm, had become once-returners. And furthermore, Subhūti, set aside the merit of all those sentient beings having become once-returners.

Subhūti, suppose that all the sentient beings, however many there are, in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, each a great trichiliocosm, had become non-returners. And furthermore, Subhūti, set aside the merit of all those sentient beings having become non-returners.

Subhūti, suppose that all the sentient beings, however many there are, in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, each a great trichiliocosm, had become arhats. And furthermore, Subhūti, set aside the merit of all those sentient beings having become arhats.

Subhūti, suppose that all the sentient beings, however many there are, in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, each a great trichiliocosm, had become pratyekabuddhas. And furthermore, Subhūti, set aside the merit of all those sentient beings having become pratyekabuddhas.

Subhūti, suppose that all the sentient beings, whoever they are, in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, each a great trichiliocosm, had set out toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And suppose that each of those bodhisattvas, for all the sentient beings, whoever they are, in yet other world systems, as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, each a great trichiliocosm, were to provide robes and alms food, ...with bedding, medicines for the sick, requisites, and every kind of comfort and every means of dwelling in ease, serving them in this way for eons as

many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, and suppose they gave this gift with a perception that apprehends an object. Taking this as the measure, suppose that each of those bodhisattvas, for each and every one of those sentient beings, were to attend them for eons as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, with Dharma robes, alms food, bedding, medicines for the sick, requisites, and every kind of comfort and every means of dwelling in ease, honoring them, revering them, regarding them as their teachers, esteeming them, making offerings to them, venerating them, and serving them. And suppose that all those bodhisattvas, each in just this way, gave gifts, and in just this way gave to all beings. Subhūti, what do you think? Would those bodhisattvas, on that basis, generate a great deal of merit?

Subhūti replied: Blessed One, a great deal. Sugata, a great deal. Blessed One, it is immeasurable. Sugata, it is immeasurable. Blessed One, the mass of that merit is not even easy to count. Blessed One, that mass of merit is not easy to count, nor to illustrate by example, nor to teach through analogy, nor to treat as a basis or as a cause. Blessed One, if that mass of merit had a form, it would not fit even in world systems as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, each a great trichiliocosm.

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to the venerable elder Subhūti: Subhūti, so it is, so it is. Furthermore, Subhūti, a person who is of the Bodhisattva Vehicle, who is embraced by the perfection of wisdom and by skillful means, and who dedicates the roots of virtue toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening through this dedication, which is the dedication of the dharmadhātu, generates a great deal of merit on that account.

Subhūti, compared to this mass of merit born from the dedication of the dharmadhātu, that earlier accumulation of merit arising from the generosity of bodhisattva great beings who hold a perception that apprehends an object does not come to a hundredth part of it. It does not come to a thousandth part, nor a hundred-thousandth part, nor a ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-thousand-ten-millionth part, nor a thousand-ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-thousand-thousand-ten-millionth part, nor even the most minute fraction of such an immense number. It cannot be reckoned in number, nor counted, nor illustrated by example, nor treated as a basis, as a cause, or even as a proximate cause. Why is that? Because the generosity of those earlier bodhisattvas, who hold a perception that apprehends an object, though it may be given in great abundance, comes to be counted as great only in the sense of a reckonable number.

Then twenty thousand gods of the class of the Four Great Kings joined their palms, bowed down, and said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, this dedication of all roots of virtue toward omniscience, embraced by the perfection of wisdom and skillful means of the bodhisattva great being, is indeed a great dedication.

Even so much merit arising from the generosity of those bodhisattvas who hold a perception that apprehends an object, even that much is overwhelmed and surpassed.

Then a hundred thousand sons of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three scattered and strewed all over the Blessed One a rain of divine flowers, divine incense, divine fragrances, divine garlands, divine unguents, and divine powders, a rain of divine jewels and a rain of divine garments. With divine parasols, divine banners, divine bells, divine pennants, and many kinds of divine offerings, they honored the Blessed One, revered him, held him supreme, made offerings to him, adorned him, and attended him. Sounding their divine cymbals, they spoke these words: Blessed One, this dedication of the dharmadhātu by the bodhisattva great being is indeed a great dedication. Even that great mass of merit arising from the generosity of those bodhisattvas who hold a perception that apprehends an object is overwhelmed and surpassed. Because it is embraced by the perfection of wisdom and skillful means, this is a great dedication.

In the same way, gods of the other classes also came to the Blessed One. With the finest honoring, the finest veneration, the finest gain, the finest offering, the finest adornment, and the finest attendance, they honored, revered, held supreme, made offerings to, adorned, and attended him, and then they cried out in the same words and echoed them in song. In the same manner, the gods of the Heaven Without Combat, the Joyful Heaven, the Heaven of Delighting in Creation, and the Heaven of Mastery over Others' Creations, the gods of the Brahmā class, the Priests of Brahmā, the Retinue of Brahmā, and the Great Brahmā, the gods of Lesser Light, Immeasurable Light, and Radiant Light, the gods of Lesser Virtue, Immeasurable Virtue, and Increasing Virtue, the gods of Cloudless, Merit-Born, and Great Fruit, the beings without perception, and the gods of Not Great, Not Burning, Fair-Seeming, Well-Seeing, and Akaniṣṭha, all likewise joined their palms and bowed down to the Blessed One, and said this: Blessed One, the dedication of roots of virtue embraced by the perfection of wisdom and skillful means of the bodhisattva great being is

wonderful. Even that mass of merit, so vast and so perfectly accomplished, is overwhelmed and surpassed, though those bodhisattvas who hold a perception that apprehends an object have gathered theirs over so long a time.

Then the Blessed One addressed all those sons of the gods, beginning with the sons of the gods of the Pure Abodes: Sons of the gods, leave aside the merit of giving generosity for the sake of all the beings, as many as the sands of the Ganges, in a world system of a trichiliocosm, who have entered perfectly toward unsurpassed, perfect awakening, so that they might attain unsurpassed, perfect awakening. Sons of the gods, by this way of reckoning, suppose that all the beings who dwell in other world systems, as many as the sands of the Ganges, again and again, of a trichiliocosm, were each to make an aspiration for unsurpassed, perfect awakening and to arouse the awakening mind.

Suppose that, in other world systems of a trichiliocosm, as many as the sands of the Ganges, there were beings, and that to all of them one gave robes, alms food, bedding, medicines for the sick, requisites, everything that brings comfort and everything that allows one to dwell in ease. Suppose that each bodhisattva, for as many eons as the sands of the Ganges, remained there giving such gifts. And suppose that all of those who give with a notion of an object were to give in this same way, down to the very last of them. By this way of reckoning, consider all those beings and all those bodhisattvas one by one. Suppose that each bodhisattva, in turn, through the whole sequence of those bodhisattvas, remained for eons as many as the sands of the Ganges, serving all those beings in order with robes, alms food, bedding, medicines for the sick, requisites, everything that brings comfort and everything that allows one to dwell in ease; and suppose that this giving were also done with a notion of an object.

Now suppose that a great bodhisattva, a great being, who is fully held by the Perfection of Wisdom and by skillful means, gathers into one, sums up, and measures completely, without exception, the aggregate of moral discipline, the aggregate of meditative absorption, the aggregate of wisdom, the aggregate of liberation, and the aggregate of the seeing of the wisdom of liberation of all the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, the future, and the present, and of those bodhisattvas, solitary buddhas, and persons of the Hearers' Vehicle; and also all the roots of virtue that other beings have planted, are planting, and will plant in them. And suppose that this bodhisattva

rejoices in that entire totality with the supreme rejoicing: a rejoicing that is sublime, chief, excellent, most excellent, exalted, supreme, unsurpassed, without anything higher, higher even than the highest, without equal, without peer, matchless, and inconceivable. And suppose that from that rejoicing he fully dedicates the unsurpassed basis of meritorious action, endowed with rejoicing, saying, "May this accomplish unsurpassed, perfect awakening," dedicating it to unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

Compared with this basis of meritorious action, endowed with rejoicing and dedication, the earlier accumulation of merit of those bodhisattvas who have a notion of an object does not come to a hundredth part, nor a thousandth part, nor a hundred-thousandth part, nor a ten-millionth part, nor a hundred ten-millionth part, nor a thousand ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-thousand ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-thousand billionth part. It cannot be counted, reckoned, illustrated by an example, shown by analogy, or supported by any basis or cause. Why is that? Because all those bodhisattvas give their gifts with a notion of an object.

This is the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines, the eighth volume.

Then the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: "The Blessed One has said this: all the roots of virtue of all the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, the future, and the present, of the bodhisattvas, solitary buddhas, and the whole Saṅgha of Hearers, and of all beings, whether past, future, or present, are to be gathered into one, summed up, and measured completely, without exception."

"You have spoken of rejoicing with a supreme rejoicing that is without remainder, a rejoicing that is holy, chief, excellent, best, most exalted, sublime, unsurpassed, without superior, higher than the highest, without equal, equal to the unequalled, and utterly without peer, a rejoicing that surpasses rejoicing and is beyond thought. Blessed One, to what extent does one become supreme among those who rejoice?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows.

"Subhūti, suppose persons who follow the bodhisattva vehicle do not grasp at phenomena of the past, future, and present. They do not take them as objects of pride, do not form a notion of them, do not apprehend them, do not conceptualize them or imagine them, and do not perceive them as truly existent. Suppose they further consider those phenomena in this way: all

phenomena are established through conceptual thought; they are unborn, definitely unborn, without coming and without going. In this, no phenomenon has been born, no phenomenon will come to be born, no phenomenon is born. In this, no phenomenon has ceased, no phenomenon will come to cease, no phenomenon ceases. Having examined those phenomena in this way, they rejoice in accordance with the nature of those phenomena just as it is. Having rejoiced in this way, they dedicate it, in that very same manner, to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. Subhūti, to this extent a bodhisattva, a great being, becomes supreme among those who rejoice.

"Subhūti, compared with this dedication of roots of virtue, the merit arising from the giving of those earlier bodhisattvas, who hold a notion of an object and a view that apprehends an object, does not come to a hundredth part of it. It does not come to a thousandth part, nor a hundred-thousandth part, nor a ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-ten-millionth part, nor a thousand-ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-thousand-ten-millionth part, nor even a part measured by a hundred thousand of the greatest numbers. It cannot be counted, cannot be tallied, cannot be conveyed by any comparison or illustration, and cannot be admitted as a basis or a cause.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, a person who follows the bodhisattva vehicle and wishes to rejoice in the generosity of all the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, the future, and the present, and wishes to rejoice in their moral discipline, their patience, their diligence, their meditative concentration, and their wisdom, should rejoice in this way. As liberation is, so is generosity. As liberation is, so is moral discipline. As liberation is, so is patience. As liberation is, so is diligence. As liberation is, so is meditative concentration. As liberation is, so is wisdom. As liberation is, so is liberation itself. As liberation is, so is the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation. As liberation is, so is rejoicing. As liberation is, so is the basis of meritorious action accompanied by rejoicing. As liberation is, so is dedication. As liberation is, so are the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, and the solitary buddhas. As liberation is, so are those Hearers of theirs who have passed completely beyond sorrow. As liberation is, so are those phenomena that are past and have ceased. As liberation is, so are those phenomena that are future and have not yet arisen."

As liberation is, so are those phenomena that are present, that have arisen and are abiding. As liberation is, so are the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, and their Hearers. As liberation is, so are the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the future, and their Hearers. As liberation is, so are the Buddhas, the

Blessed Ones of the present, who dwell, live, and sustain themselves in world-systems immeasurable and innumerable, and their Hearers. As liberation is, so are the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, the future, and the present. Whatever the nature of reality of these phenomena is, which are thus unbound, unliberated, and unattached, in that I rejoice with unsurpassed rejoicing. Having rejoiced, I dedicate the unsurpassed basis of meritorious action accompanied by rejoicing, by way of not dedicating it to perfect and complete awakening as a thing, but rather as the nature of reality of those phenomena is, in just that way, without shifting and without perishing. This is what is meant by dedication.

Subhūti, this much is the supreme rejoicing of a bodhisattva, a great being.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose that all those sentient beings who exist in other and still other world-systems, as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges, in a great trichiliocosm, had properly entered upon unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Having entered upon it, suppose they roused the awakening mind in all the sentient beings of other and still other world-systems, as numerous as the sands of the Ganges, in a great trichiliocosm. And suppose that each one of all those bodhisattvas, for as many eons as there are sands in the Ganges, should offer gifts to each of those bodhisattvas, serving them with robes, alms food, bedding, medicine for the sick, provisions, and everything that gives comfort and ease, doing so with a perception of objective support (a notion of someone giving, receiving, and something given). And suppose that in this same manner each of them served every one of the others. Set aside that giving, Subhūti, offered with a perception of objective support.

Suppose that all the sentient beings, however many there are in world-systems as numerous as the sands of the Ganges, in a great trichiliocosm, had properly entered upon unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Having entered upon it, suppose that for as many eons as there are sands in the Ganges they had undertaken and maintained the moral discipline of good conduct of body, good conduct of speech, and good conduct of mind, with a perception of objective support. And suppose that in this same manner each of those bodhisattvas, for as many eons as there are sands in the Ganges, undertook and maintained that moral discipline of good conduct of body, speech, and mind, with a perception of objective support. And suppose that all those bodhisattvas maintained their moral discipline in this manner, with a perception of objective support.

Now let there be a bodhisattva, a great being, who is fully embraced by the perfection of wisdom and by skillful means. For the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, the future, and the present, that bodhisattva rejoices in their moral discipline, their meditative absorption, their wisdom, their liberation, and the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation, and in...

the moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation of those solitary buddhas (pratyekabuddhas), and of those hearers (śrāvakas), the moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation. Having gathered together into one, summed up, and measured all those roots of virtue of all beings of the past, future, and present, leaving nothing out, that bodhisattva rejoices in all of it with the supreme rejoicing. With a rejoicing that is excellent, foremost, choice, supreme, exalted, unsurpassed, without any higher, higher than the highest, without equal, unequaled, equal to the unequaled, and inconceivable, the bodhisattva rejoices. And having rejoiced, that bodhisattva dedicates the meritorious basis of action, endowed with rejoicing, to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Subhūti, compared with this meritorious basis of action endowed with rejoicing, the former merit that those bodhisattvas with objective support produced from their moral discipline does not approach even a hundredth part of it. It does not approach a thousandth part, nor a hundred-thousandth part, nor a ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-ten-millionth part, nor a thousand-ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-thousand-ten-millionth part, nor even a hundred-thousandth part of a trillion. It does not approach it in number. It cannot be counted, nor illustrated by any example, nor shown by comparison, nor can it bear comparison as a basis or as a cause. Why is that? Because all those bodhisattvas maintain their moral discipline with a perception of objective support.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose that all the beings in as many billion-fold world systems as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges were fully set out toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And having set out, suppose that for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the Ganges, they maintained, with a perception of objective support, the moral discipline of good conduct of body, speech, and mind. Leave that aside. Suppose that all the beings who exist in as many billion-fold world systems as there are grains

of sand in the Ganges were fully set out toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and having set out, remained so for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the Ganges. And suppose that all the beings in other such world systems, as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, one after another, were to strike and beat each of those bodhisattvas, and shower them with abuse, yet with pride and with a perception of objective support, those bodhisattvas took up and maintained patience. In that same way, suppose that all those bodhisattvas with a perception of objective support took up and maintained patience. By this way of reckoning, suppose that each one of those bodhisattvas, for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the Ganges, were struck, beaten, and abused by all the beings who live in still other world systems, as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the Ganges, and yet with pride and with a perception of objective support took up and maintained patience. And suppose that all of them, though all were struck, beaten, and abused, likewise took up and maintained patience with pride and with a perception of objective support.

Subhūti, now consider a bodhisattva, a great being, who is embraced by the perfection of wisdom and by skillful means. Such a bodhisattva gathers into one, brings together, and measures, leaving nothing out, all the following: the aggregate of moral discipline, the aggregate of meditative absorption, the aggregate of wisdom, the aggregate of liberation, and the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation belonging to the buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, the future, and the present; the moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation belonging to those solitary buddhas; the same belonging to those hearers; and all the roots of virtue of all sentient beings, past, future, and present. Having left nothing out, the bodhisattva rejoices in all of it with the supreme rejoicing. With a rejoicing that is holy, chief, excellent, supreme, most excellent, unsurpassed, without superior, higher than the highest, unequalled, matching the unmatched, utterly without equal, and inconceivable, the bodhisattva rejoices. And having rejoiced, the bodhisattva fully dedicates to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening the basis of meritorious action that accompanies that rejoicing.

Subhūti, compared with this basis of meritorious action accompanied by rejoicing, the merit produced by those earlier bodhisattvas who held to objective support, merit that comes with patience, does not approach even a hundredth part. It does not approach a thousandth part, nor a

hundred-thousandth, nor a ten-millionth, nor a hundred-ten-millionth, nor a thousand-ten-millionth, nor a hundred-thousand-ten-millionth, nor even a hundred-thousandth part of a billion-fold ten-millionth. It cannot be reckoned by number, by count, by simile, by illustration, by comparison, by cause, or by any ground of comparison. Why is that? Because all those bodhisattvas take up and maintain patience with a perception of objective support.

Furthermore, Subhūti, leave aside the case of those bodhisattvas who, struck, beaten, and abused by all the beings of other world systems, as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, each system a great trichiliocosm, took up and maintained patience for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the Ganges, with pride and with a perception of objective support.

Subhūti, suppose that in a great trichiliocosm world system, as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, there are beings, however many there may be, and that all of them have entered rightly upon unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Having so entered, suppose that for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the Ganges they remain walking and sitting, standing vigilantly, and that for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the Ganges they do not grow weary or dull, and are not overcome by torpor or sleep, but take up and maintain diligence with a perception of objective support.

And suppose there is a bodhisattva, a great being, embraced by the perfection of wisdom and skillful means, who gathers together the aggregate of moral discipline, the aggregate of meditative absorption, the aggregate of wisdom, the aggregate of liberation, and the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation belonging to the buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, the future, and the present.

And also the aggregate of moral discipline, the aggregate of meditative absorption, the aggregate of wisdom, the aggregate of liberation, and the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation belonging to those solitary buddhas; and likewise the aggregate of moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the vision of the wisdom of liberation belonging to those hearers. And all the roots of virtue that sentient beings have produced in the past, the future, and the present, all of these he gathers into one, brings together, and measures, so that nothing is left out. Then, for all that is without remainder, he rejoices with the supreme rejoicing. He rejoices with a rejoicing that is holy, chief, excellent, most excellent, sublime, supreme, unsurpassed, without anything higher, higher than the highest,

without equal, matchless, comparable only to the incomparable, utterly without peer, and inconceivable. And having so rejoiced, he fully dedicates the meritorious basis of action that is endowed with that rejoicing to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Subhūti, compared with this meritorious basis of action endowed with rejoicing, the merit produced by the diligence of those earlier bodhisattvas who hold to an objective support does not come to a hundredth part of it. It does not come to a thousandth part, nor a hundred-thousandth part, nor a ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-ten-millionth part, nor a thousand-ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-thousand-ten-millionth part, nor even a part of a hundred thousand times ten billion. It cannot be reckoned by number, nor counted, nor compared by any example, nor shown by simile, nor accepted as a basis or a cause of comparison. Why is that? Because all those bodhisattvas abide having taken up diligence with a perception of objective support.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose that all the sentient beings, as many as there are grains of sand in the Ganges, in a great trichiliocosm world-system were to set out completely toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Having so set out, for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the Ganges, they remain standing, walking, and sitting. For as many eons as there are grains of sand in the Ganges they do not grow weary, and are not overcome by torpor or sleep, but abide having taken up diligence with a perception of objective support. Let that be as it may.

Subhūti, suppose all those sentient beings, as many as there are grains of sand in the Ganges in a great trichiliocosm world-system, were to set out completely toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and having so set out, were for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the Ganges to rest in the four meditative concentrations with a perception of objective support.

And suppose, further, there is a bodhisattva, a great being, embraced by this perfection of wisdom and by skillful means, who gathers together the aggregate of moral discipline, the aggregate of meditative absorption, the aggregate of wisdom, the aggregate of liberation, and the aggregate of the vision of the wisdom of liberation belonging to all the buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, the future, and the present; and likewise the aggregate of moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the vision of

the wisdom of liberation belonging to those solitary buddhas; and the same for those hearers. And all the roots of virtue that sentient beings have produced in the past, the future, and the present, all of these he gathers into one, brings together, and measures, so that nothing is left out; and for all that is without remainder, he rejoices with the supreme rejoicing.

He rejoices with a rejoicing that is holy, chief, excellent, supreme, most exalted, unsurpassed, without superior, higher even than the highest, without equal, equal to the unequalled, matched by none, and inconceivable. Having rejoiced in this way, he fully dedicates the merit that accompanies that rejoicing, the basis of meritorious action, to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Subhūti, compared with this basis of meritorious action that accompanies rejoicing, the earlier merit that a bodhisattva generates from the four meditative concentrations, which still involve an object of focus, does not come near to a hundredth part of it. It does not come near to a thousandth part, nor a hundred-thousandth, nor a ten-millionth, nor a hundred-ten-millionth, nor a thousand-ten-millionth, nor a hundred-thousand-ten-millionth, nor even a hundred-thousand-times-a-billionth part. It cannot be reckoned by number, nor counted, nor conveyed by any simile or demonstrated by any example, nor made the basis or cause of any comparison. Why is this so? Because all those bodhisattvas, holding perceptions that fix upon an object, rest in the meditative concentrations.

This is the sixth chapter, called "Rejoicing and Dedication," from the noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom brings to full accomplishment the wisdom of omniscience. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is omniscience itself.

The Blessed One declared: So it is, Śāriputra, so it is, just as you say.

Śāriputra said: Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom makes things clear. Blessed One, I pay homage to the Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is worthy of homage. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is utterly unstained. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is not stained by any world. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom brings light. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom frees all who dwell in the three realms from the blurring of sight. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom dispels all

the darkness of affliction and wrong view. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is what one relies upon. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom makes beings supreme. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom brings the factors that accord with awakening to a good and happy state. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom brings light to sentient beings who wander blind. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom wholly removes all fear and harm and brings light. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom, by holding the five eyes, shows the path to all sentient beings. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is the eye. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom frees beings from delusion, darkness, and the blurring of sight. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom frees beings from the blurring of sight.

Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom does not make any phenomena. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom leads onto the path those sentient beings who have strayed from the path. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is itself omniscience. Blessed One, in order to abandon the afflictions, the habitual tendencies of the cognitive obscurations, and all the links that bind, the Perfection of Wisdom does not cause any phenomena to arise. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom does not bring any phenomena to cessation. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is unborn and unceasing. Blessed One, because of the emptiness of own-characteristic, the Perfection of Wisdom is the mother of the bodhisattvas, the great beings. Blessed One, in order to bestow all the precious qualities of the buddhas, the Perfection of Wisdom brings about the ten powers. Blessed One, because it brings about the four fearlessnesses, the Perfection of Wisdom cannot be subdued. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is the protector of sentient beings who have no protector. Blessed One, because nothing abides permanently, the Perfection of Wisdom is the antidote to saṃsāra. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom reveals the essential nature of all phenomena. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is the complete fulfillment of the turning of the wheel of Dharma by the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, which is turned three times in twelve aspects. Blessed One, how should a bodhisattva, a great being, abide in the Perfection of Wisdom? Blessed One, how should one attend to the Perfection of Wisdom in the mind? Blessed One, how should one pay homage to the Perfection of Wisdom?

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Śāriputra as follows. Śāriputra, just as the Teacher has taught, so one should abide in the Perfection of Wisdom. Śāriputra, just as the Teacher has taught, so one should

attend to the Perfection of Wisdom in the mind. Śāriputra, just as the Teacher has taught, so one should pay homage to the Perfection of Wisdom.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), thought: Alas, why has the noble Śāriputra asked this? On what ground has the noble Śāriputra asked this? Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the venerable Śāriputra: Noble Śāriputra, why do you ask this? On what ground, noble Śāriputra, do you ask this?

When he had said this, the venerable Śāriputra said to Śakra, lord of the gods: Kauśika, consider a bodhisattva, a great being, who is held by the skillful means of the Perfection of Wisdom, and who dedicates to omniscience every meritorious act, every basis of meritorious action, that accompanies rejoicing. Whatever merit is generated from the generosity of all those earlier bodhisattvas who are still caught up in objectifying, whatever arises from their moral discipline, whatever arises from their patience, and whatever arises from their diligence,

It overpowers and surpasses all of that merit, whatever it may be, which arises from meditative concentration and is brought about through deliberate construction. That is why I put this question on this basis.

Kauśika, moreover, it is the Perfection of Wisdom itself that goes before the other five perfections, so that they may enter the path of omniscience. Kauśika, it is like this. Suppose there were a hundred, or a thousand, or a hundred thousand blind people, and no one to lead them. They would have no chance of entering the road, and no chance of reaching a village, a town, or a city. In just the same way, Kauśika, generosity, moral discipline, patience, diligence, and meditative concentration, when separated from the Perfection of Wisdom, do not earn the name of perfections. They are like the blind, for they have no guide. Since they have no chance even of entering the path of omniscience, how could they ever enter the great city of omniscience, or even see it, let alone attain it?

But, Kauśika, when generosity, moral discipline, patience, diligence, and meditative concentration are embraced by the Perfection of Wisdom, then they gain the name and designation of perfections. Then these five perfections come to possess eyes, so that they may enter the path of omniscience and attain omniscience.

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, how should a bodhisattva, a great being, accomplish the Perfection of Wisdom?

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāriputra: Śāriputra, one should view form as not being accomplished. In the same way, Śāriputra, one should view feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as not being accomplished. Śāriputra, that which does not construct the five aggregates is called, Śāriputra, accomplishing in the Perfection of Wisdom. Accomplishing in the five aggregates by not constructing in this way is accomplishing in the Perfection of Wisdom; this is what is called accomplishing.

When he had said this, the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, when the Perfection of Wisdom is accomplished in this way, what phenomenon does it destroy?

The Blessed One said: Śāriputra, when the Perfection of Wisdom is accomplished in this way, it does not destroy any phenomenon whatsoever. Śāriputra, when no phenomenon is destroyed, then it is counted as what is called the Perfection of Wisdom.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, does this Perfection of Wisdom not destroy even omniscience?

The Blessed One said: Kauśika, when you ask, "Does this Perfection of Wisdom not destroy even omniscience?", know that it does not destroy it in the way that it is objectified. It does not destroy it in the way that it is named. It does not destroy it in the way that it is constructed.

Śakra said: Blessed One, then in what way does it destroy?

The Blessed One said: Kauśika, it destroys in the way that it does not destroy.

Śakra said:

Śakra said: Blessed One, since by this Perfection of Wisdom no phenomenon is produced and none is stopped, and since all phenomena are without arising and without cessation, this Perfection of Wisdom neither abides nor is it something that abides. It is wonderful!

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, if a bodhisattva, a great being, conceives of things in this way, would he not be making this Perfection of Wisdom distant, accumulating it, and amassing it? Would he not, then, be failing to practice this Perfection of Wisdom?

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Subhūti, there is a way in which one makes this Perfection of

Wisdom distant, accumulates it, and amasses it, and a way in which one fails to practice it. Why is that? Subhūti, when this Perfection of Wisdom is fully illumined, it is not form that is fully illumined. It is not feeling, not perception, not the formations, and it is not consciousness that is fully illumined. The fruit of stream-entry is not fully illumined, the fruit of once-returning is not fully illumined, the fruit of non-returning is not fully illumined. Arhatship is not fully illumined. Pratyekabuddhahood is not fully illumined. Buddhahood is not fully illumined.

The elder Subhūti said: Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is, in this sense, a great perfection.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you have in mind? In what way is this Perfection of Wisdom a great perfection?

The elder Subhūti said: Blessed One, one does not make form great, nor make it small; one does not gather form together, nor scatter it. In the same way with feeling, with perception, with the formations; Blessed One, one does not make consciousness great, nor small; one does not gather consciousness together, nor scatter it. Whatever the powers of the Tathāgatas are, those too one does not make endowed with power, nor make empty, nor gather together, nor scatter. Whatever omniscience is, that too one does not make great, nor small, nor gather together, nor scatter. Why is that? Blessed One, because omniscience itself is neither gathered nor scattered.

Blessed One, if a bodhisattva, a great being, were to think in this way, he would not be practicing the Perfection of Wisdom. How much less, then, would he be practicing it if he thought: "I possess the wisdom of omniscience; thus I shall teach the Dharma to beings; thus I shall bring these beings completely beyond sorrow." Why is that? The thought "I shall bring these beings completely beyond sorrow" is not in accord with the cause of the Perfection of Wisdom, for this very focusing upon beings becomes for him a great object of fixation. Why is that? Because the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as having the nature of beings being without essential nature and without arising.

Because beings are without essential nature, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as without essential nature. Because beings are secluded, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as secluded. Because beings are inconceivable, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as inconceivable. Because beings have the nature of being indestructible, the

Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as having the nature of being indestructible. Because beings cannot be fully awakened to, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as not being fully awakened to. Because beings cannot be fully awakened to as the true meaning, just as it is, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as not being fully awakened to as the true meaning, just as it is. Because beings accomplish the powers perfectly, it should be understood that the powers of the Tathāgata are accomplished perfectly. Blessed One, by this way of explanation, the Perfection of Wisdom is the great perfection.

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, if a bodhisattva, a great being, has faith in this profound Perfection of Wisdom and feels no hesitation, no doubt, and does not fall into bewilderment, then, Blessed One, from where should it be understood that he passed away and was reborn here? Blessed One, how long should it be understood that this bodhisattva, this great being, who will follow, realize, and gain insight into the meaning, the nature, the way of the meaning, and the way of the nature of this Perfection of Wisdom, has practiced and kept to discipline in a single-minded way?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Śāriputra as follows: "Śāriputra, it should be understood that this bodhisattva, this great being, has served and honored the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, and questioned them, and then passed away from other world systems and was reborn here. Why is that? Śāriputra, any bodhisattva, any great being, who has served and honored the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, and questioned them, and who passed away from other world systems and was reborn here, listens to the explaining, teaching, demonstrating, and prophesying of this profound Perfection of Wisdom. Having heard this Perfection of Wisdom, he develops the perception of the Teacher with regard to this Perfection of Wisdom. He gives rise to the thought: 'My Teacher has appeared before me; I have seen my Teacher.' He lends his ear and listens respectfully to the explaining, teaching, demonstrating, and prophesying of this Perfection of Wisdom, and he does not interrupt the discourse. Śāriputra, it should be understood that this bodhisattva, this great being, is of such a nature that he has practiced and kept to discipline for a long time. Śāriputra, it should be understood that this bodhisattva, this great being, is of such a kind that he has served and honored many buddhas."

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, is it also possible to listen to this Perfection of Wisdom, to realize it, to reflect upon it, to give rise to it, or to take hold of it?"

Is it possible to teach or to listen to this Perfection of Wisdom by saying, "This is that Perfection of Wisdom," or "That Perfection of Wisdom is here," or "That Perfection of Wisdom is in such and such a place," or "It is indicated by this form, this sign, this mark"?

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, it is not so. Subhūti, this Perfection of Wisdom cannot be taught, listened to, realized, reflected upon, given rise to, or taken hold of as an aggregate, an element, or a sense source. Why is that? Subhūti, because all phenomena are empty of intrinsic nature, because all phenomena are utterly secluded, the Perfection of Wisdom cannot be taught, listened to, realized, reflected upon, given rise to, or taken hold of.

"It should be understood that the Perfection of Wisdom does not exist apart from the aggregates, elements, and sense sources. Why is that? Subhūti, because the aggregates, elements, and sense sources themselves are empty, secluded, and peaceful. Therefore this Perfection of Wisdom and these aggregates, elements, and sense sources are not two; they cannot be made into two. Because of emptiness, seclusion, and peace, there is nothing to be observed. The non-observing of all phenomena is what is called the Perfection of Wisdom. When perception, recognition, designation, and conventional expression no longer arise, then it is called the Perfection of Wisdom."

The venerable Subhūti said: "Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, applies himself in yoga to this profound Perfection of Wisdom, for how long should it be understood that he has practiced and kept to discipline?"

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, since the faculties of bodhisattvas, great beings, differ in degree, I will explain this by distinguishing and prophesying. Subhūti, there are also grounds on which bodhisattvas may see many hundreds of buddhas, many thousands of buddhas, many hundreds of thousands of buddhas, and lead the holy life in their presence, and yet still have no faith or devotion toward this Perfection of Wisdom.

"Why is that? Because in the past, in the presence of those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, when this profound Perfection of Wisdom was being explained, demonstrated, and taught, they showed no respect. Being disrespectful, they did not listen well. Not listening well, they did not serve or honor it. Not serving or honoring it, they did not inquire into it. Not inquiring, they had no real faith.

Having no real faith, they drifted away from that assembly. On that basis they performed, accumulated, fully gathered, and amassed karma conducive to being deprived of the Dharma. As a result, even now, when this profound Perfection of Wisdom is being explained, demonstrated, and taught, they are disrespectful and drift away. They have no faith and no devotion, and with body and mind they do not engage in gathering the accumulations.

"Because they do not engage in the accumulations, they do not know, see, comprehend, or realize this Perfection of Wisdom. Thus they come to lack faith in the Perfection of Wisdom. Lacking faith, they do not listen. Not listening, they do not know. Not knowing, they do not see. Not seeing, they do not comprehend. Not comprehending, they perform karma conducive to being deprived of the Dharma; they fully accumulate it, gather it everywhere, and amass it."

"Through the karma they have performed, accumulated, fully accumulated, and amassed, a karma conducive to being deprived of the Dharma, they come to perform a karma conducive to the corruption of wisdom. Through the karma conducive to the corruption of wisdom that they have performed, accumulated, fully accumulated, and amassed, then when this Perfection of Wisdom is being explained, taught, and demonstrated, they will reject it, they will slander it, and they will speak ill of it; and having slandered it, they will drift away.

"Subhūti, moreover, by rejecting, slandering, and speaking ill of this Perfection of Wisdom, they reject, slander, and speak ill of the omniscience of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, the future, and the present. Having ruined and scorched their own mental continuum, these are persons of small intellect, small wisdom, small merit, and small roots of virtue. Others, those who possess merely a little faith, a little joy, a little clarity, a little aspiration, beginners who are by nature without the fortune for it, these people too they turn back, separate, and cause to reverse even that little faith, joy, and aspiration. They say, 'One should not train in this,' and they declare in words, 'This is not the word of the Buddha.'

"Thus, having ruined and torn away their own mental continuum, and having ruined and torn away the mental continuum of others, they come to slander the Perfection of Wisdom. If one slanders the Perfection of Wisdom, one slanders omniscience. If one slanders omniscience, one slanders the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, the future, and the present. In this way they

drift away from the presence of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones; they are abandoned by the Dharma; and they become wholly cast out from the Saṅgha. Thus, in every way and in every respect, they become entirely outside the Three Jewels.

"Because they cut off the benefit and happiness of sentient beings, they gather a karma conducive to ripening in the great hells. Because of having performed, established, and set in motion such karma, and by that very nature which is conducive to deprivation of the Dharma and to the corruption of wisdom, they will fall into the great hells for many hundreds of years, many thousands of years, many hundreds of thousands of years, many millions of years, many tens of millions of years, many hundreds of millions of years, many thousands of millions of years, and many hundreds of thousands of millions of years.

"They go from one great hell to another great hell. While they pass for such a long time from great hell to great hell, the eon of destruction by fire arrives. When the eon of destruction by fire has arrived, they are cast away into whichever great hells exist in other world systems, and they fall into those great hells. Having been cast there, having fallen into those great hells, there too they pass from great hell to great hell. And while they pass there too from great hell to great hell, in exactly the same way the eon of destruction by fire arrives there as well."

"When the eon of destruction by fire arrives for them, then, immediately upon dying and passing away, they are cast away into whichever great hells of sentient beings exist in other world systems, and they come to be born in those great hells. There too, in exactly the same way, they pass from great hell to great hell. And while they pass there too, for a long time, from great hell to great hell, the eon of destruction by fire arrives there as well. When the eon of destruction by fire has arrived, they die and pass away from there as well. Because their karma is not exhausted and a remainder is still left, by that very karma they are cast back once more into this world system, and when they have been cast away they are again born in the great hells. Once more, in the great hells, they undergo those great sufferings of the hells, and they undergo them for as long as the destruction by fire has yet to come. In this way they experience a karma that accords with undergoing great suffering. Why is that? Because they spoke such harmful words."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the deeds of the five heinous crimes, done and accumulated, are not even a reflection, an approximation, or a likeness of this misconduct of mind and misconduct of speech."

The Blessed One declared: "So it is, Śāriputra, so it is. Śāriputra, the deeds of the five heinous crimes, done and accumulated, are not even a reflection, an approximation, or a likeness of this deed of misconduct of mind and misconduct of speech, done and amassed, fully accumulated and gathered.

"Those who, toward the teaching, demonstration, and explanation of this profound Perfection of Wisdom, think to turn away from it, who slander it and speak of it in unpleasant terms, who say, 'One should not train in this,' who declare, 'This was not spoken by the Tathāgata,' and who cause other beings too to be separated from it, such persons destroy their own mental continuum and also ruin the continuum of others. Having poisoned their own continuum, they poison the continuum of others as well. Having ruined themselves, they bring others to ruin too. They themselves neither know nor realize the profound Perfection of Wisdom, and they lead others to hold that one should not train in it.

"Śāriputra, I would not even permit myself to look upon a person of such a nature, still less to keep company with them, still less to give them gain and honor, still less to dwell with them. Why is that? Śāriputra, persons of such a nature should be recognized as rejecters of the Dharma. Śāriputra, persons of such a nature should be recognized as having become like rotten leaves. Śāriputra, such persons should be recognized as being of dark nature and as nurturing what is dark. Śāriputra, whatever anyone thinks to hear or to believe from such persons, all of that is wrongful and leads to ruin. Śāriputra, those who reject the Perfection of Wisdom should be recognized as persons who reject the Dharma."

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, you have shown the measure of the body of the person who is born there and dwells in the great hells."

The Blessed One said: "Śāriputra, leave aside the measure of the body of the person, the being, who is born in that great hell. Why? Hearing the measure of the body of a person of such a nature would cause one to vomit hot blood from the mouth and to die, or to come near to dying, or to fall into unbearable suffering. Illness would strike and burn one; the thorn of sorrow would pierce one; one would fall into a great abyss, or wither, or be crushed. That cannot be

allowed. So let no one hear of the measure of a body that has such faults, a measure so terrifying." Thus the Blessed One did not open the way for the venerable Śāriputra by declaring, "The measure of that body will be this much."

A second time and a third time the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: "The measure of that person's body would be made manifest to later beings, so that they would know: by the deeds of speech and mind that have been done, gathered, accumulated, and amassed, one takes on such a vast body as a being in the great hells. Blessed One, please explain this to me."

The Blessed One said: "Śāriputra, whoever commits wrongdoing through speech and mind, and brings about, brings together, gathers, accumulates, and amasses non-virtuous action, will experience suffering for this long a time. Precisely this will be made manifest to later beings. Śāriputra, because that very suffering is immeasurable and is spoken of as manifold, sons and daughters of good family who have the fortune of the white side will grow weary of it. From then on they will turn away from the actions that lead to being deprived of the Dharma, and will do nothing but bring about merit. They will think: 'So that I too will not meet with suffering like that, I will not abandon the sacred Dharma even for the sake of my life.'"

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, sons and daughters of good family should restrain with great care their actions of body, speech, and mind. Why? Blessed One, because one who speaks wrongly with speech, being of such a nature, gives rise to this great mass of demerit. Blessed One, by what action does this great mass of demerit arise?"

The Blessed One said: "Subhūti, by speaking wrongly with speech, being of such a nature, this great mass of demerit, this vast, arises. Subhūti, there are foolish people who think to refute this profound Perfection of Wisdom, who think to denigrate it, who think to cast it back. They go forth in this very Dharma and Vinaya that is well taught. If this Perfection of Wisdom is cast back, then the awakening of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is also cast back. If the awakening of the buddhas is cast back, then the omniscience of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, the future, and the present is cast back. If omniscience is cast back, then the sacred Dharma is cast back. If the sacred Dharma is cast back, then the Saṅgha of the Tathāgata's hearers is cast back."

If the Saṅgha of the Tathāgata's hearers is cast back, then in every way, entirely and completely, they have placed themselves outside the Three Jewels, and so they take up and accumulate immeasurable, countless great unwholesome karma."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what is the cause, what is the condition, by which a son or daughter of good family comes to think of rejecting this Perfection of Wisdom?"

The Blessed One said: "Subhūti, that son or daughter of good family has been influenced by Māra, or, through verbal actions that accord with the corruption of wisdom, they have no faith in these profound teachings and do not come to have clear faith in them. Subhūti, because they possess these two evil factors, that son or daughter of good family comes to cast back this Perfection of Wisdom.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, when this profound Perfection of Wisdom is being explained, taught, and expounded, whoever comes to think of rejecting it will possess these four features. That son or daughter of good family will have fallen into the hands of an evil friend; or will not strive earnestly; or will become attached to the aggregates; or will praise themselves and disparage others, seeking out faults."

This is the seventh chapter, called "Hell," from the noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines. Ninth bundle.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is difficult to have faith in, because of lack of earnest effort, because of being bereft of roots of virtue, and because of having fallen into the hands of an evil friend."

The Blessed One said: "So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom is difficult to have faith in for those who do not strive earnestly, whose roots of virtue are slight, whose intelligence is weak, who do not seek the meaning, who have heard little, whose wisdom is feeble, who are supported by evil friends, who do not listen well, who are by nature not inclined to ask questions, and who do not strive in virtuous things."

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, how profound is this Perfection of Wisdom, that it should be so difficult to have faith in!"

The Blessed One said: "Subhūti, form is neither bound nor liberated. Why is that? Subhūti, because form has no intrinsic nature, form is neither bound nor liberated. In the same way, Subhūti, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are neither bound nor liberated. Why is that? Subhūti, because consciousness has no intrinsic nature, consciousness is neither bound nor liberated.

"Subhūti, the former extreme of form is neither bound nor liberated. Why is that? Because, Subhūti, form has no intrinsic nature of a former extreme. Subhūti, the later extreme of form is neither bound nor liberated. Why is that? Because form has no intrinsic nature of a later extreme. Subhūti, the present arising of form is neither bound nor liberated. Why is that? Because form has no intrinsic nature of a present arising.

"In the same way, Subhūti, the former extreme of feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness is neither bound nor liberated. Why is that? Because, Subhūti, consciousness has no intrinsic nature of a former extreme."

Subhūti, the later extreme of consciousness is neither bound nor liberated. Why is that? Because consciousness has no intrinsic nature of a later extreme. Subhūti, the present arising of consciousness is neither bound nor liberated. Why is that? Because, Subhūti, consciousness has no intrinsic nature of a present arising.

Subhūti then said: "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is difficult to have faith in, and supremely difficult to have faith in, for those who lack diligence, who have not accumulated roots of virtue, who have fallen into the hands of bad friends, who have come under the power of Māra, who are lazy, weak in effort, lacking in mindfulness, and confused in wisdom."

The Blessed One declared: "So it is, Subhūti, so it is. The Perfection of Wisdom is difficult to have faith in for those who lack diligence, who have not accumulated roots of virtue, who have fallen into the hands of bad friends, who have come under the power of Māra, who are lazy, weak in effort, lacking in mindfulness, and confused in wisdom. Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom is supremely difficult to have faith in.

"Why is that? Subhūti, whatever is the purity of form is the purity of the result, and whatever is the purity of the result is the purity of form. Thus, Subhūti, the purity of form and the purity of the result are not two, and cannot be made into two; they are not different, and not divided. Thus, Subhūti, because the result is pure, form is pure; and because form is pure, the result is pure.

"In the same way, Subhūti, whatever is the purity of feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness is the purity of the result, and whatever is the purity of the result is the purity of consciousness. Thus, Subhūti, the purity of consciousness and the purity of the result are not two, and cannot be made into two; they are not different, and not divided. Thus, Subhūti, because the result is pure, consciousness is pure; and because consciousness is pure, the result is pure.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, whatever is the purity of form is the purity of omniscience, and whatever is the purity of omniscience is the purity of form. Thus, Subhūti, the purity of form and the purity of omniscience are not two, and cannot be made into two; they are not different, and not divided. Thus, Subhūti, because omniscience is pure, form is pure; and because form is pure, omniscience is pure.

"In the same way, Subhūti, whatever is the purity of feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness is the purity of omniscience, and whatever is the purity of omniscience is the purity of consciousness. Thus, Subhūti, the purity of consciousness and the purity of omniscience are not two, and cannot be made into two; they are not different, and not divided. Thus, Subhūti, because omniscience is pure, consciousness is pure; and because consciousness is pure, omniscience is pure."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is profound."

The Blessed One declared: "Śāriputra, it is because of its purity."

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom brings clarity."

The Blessed One declared: "Śāriputra, it is because of its purity."

Śāriputra said:

"Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom illuminates."

The Blessed One declared: "Śāriputra, it is because of its purity."

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom has no junction."

The Blessed One declared: "Śāriputra, it is because of its purity."

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom has no affliction whatsoever."

The Blessed One declared: "Śāriputra, it is because of its purity."

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom has no attainment and no realization."

The Blessed One declared: "Śāriputra, it is because of its purity."

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom has no accomplishment."

The Blessed One declared: "Śāriputra, it is because of its purity."

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom has no birth at all in the desire realm, the form realm, or the formless realm."

The Blessed One declared: "Śāriputra, it is because of its purity."

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is without grasping, without grasping in the full sense."

The Blessed One declared: "Śāriputra, it is because of its purity."

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, then what is it that the Perfection of Wisdom does not grasp, and does not fully grasp?"

The Blessed One declared: "Śāriputra, the Perfection of Wisdom does not know form, and does not fully know it. Why is that? Śāriputra, it is because of its purity. In the same way, Śāriputra, the Perfection of Wisdom does not know feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness, and does not fully know them. Why is that? It is because of its purity."

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom neither harms omniscience nor benefits it."

The Blessed One declared: "It is because of its purity."

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom neither fully holds onto any phenomenon nor fully lets go of any."

The Blessed One declared: "It is because of its purity."

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, because I am pure, form is pure."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, it is because of utter purity."

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, because I am pure, feeling, perception, and formations are pure. Blessed One, because I am pure, consciousness is pure."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, it is because of utter purity."

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, because I am pure, the result is pure."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, it is because of utter purity."

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, because I am pure, omniscience is pure."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, it is because of utter purity."

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, because I am pure, there is no attainment, and there is no realization either."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, it is because of utter purity."

Subhūti said:

"Blessed One, because I am without end, form is without end."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, it is because of utter purity."

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, because I am without end, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are without end."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, it is because of utter purity."

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, whatever realization that great bodhisattva has in this way, that is this bodhisattva's Perfection of Wisdom."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, it is because of utter purity."

The venerable Subhūti said: "Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom does not abide on this shore, nor does it abide on the far shore, nor does it abide in the long stretch between the two."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, it is because of utter purity."

The venerable Subhūti said: "Blessed One, if a great bodhisattva perceives it in this way, he will abandon this Perfection of Wisdom, and he will make this Perfection of Wisdom distant."

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent, Subhūti, excellent! It is so, Subhūti, it is so. Why is that? Subhūti, one may become attached through a name, and one may also become attached through a sign."

When this had been said, the venerable Subhūti spoke to the Blessed One as follows: "Blessed One, in this way, by speaking of the very things to which one becomes attached, the Blessed One has taught this Perfection of Wisdom well and shown it well; it is wonderful, utterly complete."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the venerable Subhūti: "Venerable Subhūti, what are those attachments?"

Subhūti replied: "Venerable Śāriputra, the thought 'form is empty' is attachment. Likewise, venerable Śāriputra, the thought 'feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are empty' is attachment. To know correctly of past phenomena that they are past phenomena is attachment. To know correctly of future phenomena that they are future phenomena is attachment. To know correctly of present phenomena that they are present phenomena is attachment. To know correctly that a person who has entered the bodhisattva vehicle, by giving rise to the first thought of awakening, produces this much of a mass of merit, is attachment."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), said to the venerable Subhūti: "Noble Subhūti, in what manner does attachment come about?"

Subhūti replied: "Kauśika, suppose someone knows, 'This is the first thought of awakening,' and dedicates that awakening mind toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, saying, 'I dedicate it.' Then that son or daughter of good family who has properly entered the Great Vehicle is unable to dedicate the intrinsic nature of mind. Therefore, Kauśika, those who teach others rightly, establish them rightly, praise them rightly, and gladden them rightly should, through realizing in accord with the true nature of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, rightly instruct, rightly establish, rightly praise, and rightly gladden others,

In this way that son or daughter of good family does no harm even to themselves, and by rightly establishing others in the way the buddhas have permitted, they cause others to be rightly established; and all these extremes of attachment are completely abandoned.

Then the Blessed One said "Excellent!" to the venerable Subhūti: "Subhūti, it is excellent, truly excellent, that you thus bring bodhisattvas, the great beings, to understand these extremes of attachment. Therefore, Subhūti, I shall also speak of other, extremely subtle attachments. Listen well, attend carefully, and keep it in mind, and I will explain it to you."

Subhūti said, "Excellent, Blessed One," and the venerable Subhūti listened as the Blessed One instructed. Then the Blessed One spoke as follows:

"Subhūti, suppose that sons or daughters of good family with faith take the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha as a sign and attend to

him in that way. Subhūti, for as long as there is a sign, there is attachment. Why is that? Subhūti, it is from a sign that attachment arises. Now suppose one thinks: 'I rejoice in whatever undefiled qualities belong to the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, the future, and the present.' And having so rejoiced, one dedicates the roots of virtue that accompany that rejoicing toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, saying, 'I dedicate them.' Subhūti, the nature of phenomena, whatever it is, is neither past, nor future, nor present. What is neither past, nor future, nor present is utterly liberated from the three times. What is utterly liberated from the three times cannot be dedicated, cannot be made into a sign, and cannot be taken as an object. It is also not something seen, heard, realized, or cognized."

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, the intrinsic nature of phenomena is profound."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, it is because it is secluded."

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is profound in its intrinsic nature."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, because its intrinsic nature is utterly pure, and because, Subhūti, its intrinsic nature is secluded, the Perfection of Wisdom is profound in its intrinsic nature."

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, because the Perfection of Wisdom is secluded in its intrinsic nature, I pay homage to the Perfection of Wisdom."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, all phenomena are likewise secluded in their intrinsic nature. Subhūti, that very seclusion of the intrinsic nature of all phenomena is the Perfection of Wisdom. Why is that? Subhūti, it is because all phenomena were fully and perfectly awakened to without being made by the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha."

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, in that case the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha has not fully and perfectly awakened to any phenomena at all."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, that is so, because in their intrinsic nature those phenomena do not exist at all. What is intrinsic nature is without intrinsic nature; and what is without intrinsic nature is intrinsic nature. That is to say, because all phenomena have no defining characteristic, they have a single characteristic. Therefore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha has not fully and perfectly awakened to any phenomena. Why is that? Subhūti, the nature of phenomena is not twofold."

Subhūti, the nature of all phenomena comes down to one alone."

Subhūti, whatever is the intrinsic nature of all phenomena is without intrinsic nature; and whatever is without intrinsic nature is intrinsic nature. In this way, Subhūti, all those extremes of attachment are completely abandoned.

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, is the Perfection of Wisdom profound?"

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom is profound because space is profound."

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, is the Perfection of Wisdom difficult to realize?"

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, it is so, in that no one fully and perfectly awakens to it."

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, is the Perfection of Wisdom inconceivable?"

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, it is so, in that the Perfection of Wisdom is not to be known by the mind and not to be realized by the mind."

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, is the Perfection of Wisdom something that has not been made?"

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, because no maker is observed, the Perfection of Wisdom is unmade."

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, that being so, how should a bodhisattva, a great being, practice in the Perfection of Wisdom?"

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in the Perfection of Wisdom does not engage with form, he practices in the Perfection of Wisdom. In the same way, if he does not engage with feeling, nor with perception, nor with formations, and if he does not engage with consciousness, he practices in the Perfection of Wisdom.

"If he does not engage with form by thinking, 'Form is impermanent,' he practices in the Perfection of Wisdom. In the same way, if he does not engage with feeling, perception, and formations, and if he does not engage with consciousness by thinking, 'Consciousness is impermanent,' he practices in the Perfection of Wisdom.

"If he does not engage with form by thinking, 'Form is empty,' he practices in the Perfection of Wisdom. In the same way, if he does not engage with feeling, nor with perception, nor with formations, and if he does not engage with consciousness by thinking, 'Consciousness is empty,' he practices in the

Perfection of Wisdom.

"If he does not engage with form by thinking, 'Form is incomplete,' or 'Form is complete,' he practices in the Perfection of Wisdom. The incompleteness or the completeness of form is not form; and if he does not engage in that way either, he practices in the Perfection of Wisdom. In the same way, if he does not engage with feeling, nor with perception, nor with formations, and if he does not engage with consciousness by thinking, 'Consciousness is incomplete,' or 'Consciousness is complete,' he practices in the Perfection of Wisdom. The incompleteness or the completeness of consciousness is not consciousness; and if he does not engage in that way either, he practices in the Perfection of Wisdom."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, it is wonderful that, as long as it is so, the bodhisattvas, the great beings, are said to be both with attachment and without attachment."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, does not engage with form by thinking, 'It is with attachment,' or 'It is without attachment,' he practices in the Perfection of Wisdom. In the same way, if he does not engage with feeling, perception, and formations, and if he does not engage with consciousness by thinking, 'It is with attachment,' or 'It is without attachment,' he practices in the Perfection of Wisdom."

Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, does not engage in the thought, "The eye is accompanied by attachment," or "It is free of attachment," then that bodhisattva practices the Perfection of Wisdom. In the same way, if one does not engage in the thought, "The feeling arising from the contact that is the coming together of mind is accompanied by attachment," or "It is free of attachment," then one practices the Perfection of Wisdom. If one does not engage in the thought, "The earth element is accompanied by attachment," or "It is free of attachment," then one practices the Perfection of Wisdom. And likewise, up to the element of consciousness, if one does not engage in the thought, "It is accompanied by attachment," or "It is free of attachment," then one practices the Perfection of Wisdom.

If one does not engage in the thought, "The perfection of generosity is accompanied by attachment," or "It is free of attachment," then one practices the Perfection of Wisdom. In the same way, if one does not engage in such thoughts about the perfection of moral discipline, the perfection of patience,

the perfection of diligence, the perfection of meditative concentration, and the perfection of wisdom, then one practices the Perfection of Wisdom.

In the same way, if one does not engage in the thought, "The thirty-seven factors of awakening, the powers, the fearlessnesses, the individual exact knowledges, and the eighteen unshared qualities of a buddha are accompanied by attachment," or "They are free of attachment," then one practices the Perfection of Wisdom.

If one does not engage in the thought, "The fruit of stream-entry is accompanied by attachment," or "It is free of attachment," then one practices the Perfection of Wisdom. In the same way, if one does not engage in such thoughts about the fruit of once-returning, the fruit of non-returning, and the state of an arhat, then one practices the Perfection of Wisdom. If one does not engage in the thought, "The state of a pratyekabuddha is accompanied by attachment," or "It is free of attachment," then one practices the Perfection of Wisdom. If one does not engage in the thought, "Buddhahood is accompanied by attachment," or "It is free of attachment," then one practices the Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti, if one does not engage in the thought, "Omniscience itself is accompanied by attachment," or "It is free of attachment," then one practices the Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in this way does not generate attachment to form. In the same way, one does not generate attachment to feeling, nor to perception, nor to formations, nor to consciousness. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in this way does not generate attachment to the eye, and so on up to the feeling arising from the contact that is the coming together of mind. One does not generate attachment to the earth element, and so on up to the element of consciousness. One does not generate attachment to the perfection of generosity. One does not generate attachment to the perfection of moral discipline, nor to the perfection of patience, nor to the perfection of diligence, nor to the perfection of meditative concentration, nor to the perfection of wisdom. One does not generate attachment to the factors of awakening, nor to the powers, nor to the fearlessnesses, nor to the individual exact knowledges, nor to the eighteen unshared qualities of a buddha.

One does not generate attachment to the fruit of stream-entry, nor to the fruit of once-returning, nor to the fruit of non-returning, nor to the state of an arhat.

One does not generate attachment to the state of a pratyekabuddha. One does not generate attachment to buddhahood. One does not generate attachment even to omniscience.

Why is that?

Subhūti, omniscience is unattached, unbound, unliberated, and has not fully passed beyond. Subhūti, it is thus, in order to turn away completely from all attachment, that a bodhisattva, a great being, should practice the Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, this teaching called the Perfection of Wisdom is profound. It is wondrous that it does not diminish when it is taught and does not diminish when it is not taught, and that it does not increase when it is taught and does not increase when it is not taught.

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows: Excellent, Subhūti, excellent! It is so, Subhūti, it is so. Subhūti, it is just as when the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, remains for as long as he lives and speaks in praise of space: space does not thereby increase, and if he does not praise it, space does not thereby decrease. Subhūti, it is also like a conjured man: if he is praised, he does not become attached, nor is he afflicted; if he is not praised, he does not become angry, nor is he afflicted. In the same way, Subhūti, the nature of phenomena, whatever it may be, is only so much whether it is taught or not taught.

The elder Subhūti said: Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices this profound Perfection of Wisdom and meditates on the Perfection of Wisdom, who is not discouraged and does not become faint-hearted, who applies himself to it and does not turn back, performs a difficult deed. Blessed One, meditating on the Perfection of Wisdom is meditating on space. Blessed One, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who have put on this armor are worthy of homage. Why is that? Blessed One, to wish to put on armor for the sake of beings is to wish to put on armor together with space. To wish to put on armor for the sake of beings who are equal to space and equal to the dharmadhātu is, Blessed One, for a bodhisattva, a great being, to have put on the great armor; Blessed One, such a bodhisattva, a great being, is a hero. To wish to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening is, Blessed One, to wish to set space entirely free. It is, Blessed One, to wish to carry space away. Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to put on armor for the sake of beings who are equal to space and equal to the dharmadhātu

has obtained the great armor of the perfection of diligence.

Then another monk, in the direction where the Blessed One was, bowed with palms joined, and said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, I pay homage to the Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom does not produce any phenomenon and does not bring any phenomenon to cessation.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the venerable Subhūti: Noble Subhūti, when one practices this Perfection of Wisdom in this way, in what does one practice? Subhūti replied: Kauśika, one who practices this Perfection of Wisdom practices in space.

Kauśika, one who studies this Perfection of Wisdom and sets his mind on practicing it is practicing in a way that is unsurpassed.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, when a son or daughter of good family comes to hold this Perfection of Wisdom, what protecting, guarding, and sheltering should be done for them? Please instruct me.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to Śakra, lord of the gods: Kauśika, do you rightly perceive any phenomenon that could be protected, guarded, or sheltered?

Śakra said: Noble Subhūti, I do not.

Subhūti said: Kauśika, if a bodhisattva, a great being, abides in this Perfection of Wisdom just as it has been explained, then that very abiding will protect, guard, and shelter him. But if he should become separated from the Perfection of Wisdom, then humans and nonhumans who watch for an opening and seek an opening will find one.

Furthermore, Kauśika, anyone who thinks of protecting, guarding, and sheltering a bodhisattva, a great being, who is practicing the Perfection of Wisdom is thinking of protecting, guarding, and sheltering space. Kauśika, what do you think? Would you be able to protect, guard, and shelter an echo?

Śakra said: Noble Subhūti, I would not.

Subhūti said: Kauśika, in just the same way, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices and abides in this Perfection of Wisdom fully understands all phenomena to be like an echo. Therefore he has no pride in this. He does not rightly perceive it, does not know it, and does not truly know it. He abides in the understanding that those phenomena do not exist, do not truly appear, are

truly nonexistent, and cannot be apprehended. If he abides in this way, he is practicing the Perfection of Wisdom.

Then, through the power of the Buddha, in the great trichilocosm world-system, the Four Great Kings, all the Śākras, lords of the gods, all the great Brahmās, and the great Brahmā who is lord of the Sahā world, as many as there were, all came to where the Blessed One was. Having come, they bowed with their heads at the feet of the Blessed One, circled him three times, and sat to one side.

When they were seated to one side, those Great Kings, all the Śākras, lords of the gods, all the great Brahmās, and the great Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, came to know, through the power of the Buddha and the blessing of the Buddha, that a thousand buddhas had taught this very Perfection of Wisdom and this very chapter on the Perfection of Wisdom, with these very names, these very words, and these very letters, through this very monk called Subhūti. They also knew that in this very place the Śākras, lords of the gods, themselves had questioned and made requests, and that this very Perfection of Wisdom had been explained here. And they knew that the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, too, after he becomes fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, will teach this very Perfection of Wisdom in this very place.

This is the eighth chapter, called Purification, from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this thing called the perfection of wisdom is a mere name. And even that name is not apprehended as 'this'; it is only the basis of speech that is called a name. The perfection of wisdom, too, does not exist and is not apprehended. As the name is, so is the perfection of wisdom; and as the perfection of wisdom is, so is the name. Since these two phenomena do not exist and are not apprehended, Blessed One, why is it that the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, after fully and perfectly awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, will teach this very perfection of wisdom in this very place, using just these names, just these words, and just these letters?"

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: "Subhūti, it is in this way. The bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, will awaken fully to the understanding that form is neither permanent nor impermanent, that form is neither bound nor liberated, and that therefore it is

beyond extremes and perfectly pure. In the same way, he will awaken fully to the understanding that feeling, perception, and the formations are likewise so, and that consciousness is neither permanent nor impermanent, neither bound nor liberated, and that therefore it is beyond extremes and perfectly pure. Subhūti, it is for this reason that the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, after fully and perfectly awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, will teach this very perfection of wisdom in this very place, using just these names, just these words, and just these letters."

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how wonderful! This perfection of wisdom is utterly pure."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, because form is pure, the perfection of wisdom is utterly pure. In the same way, Subhūti, because feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are pure, the perfection of wisdom is utterly pure. Subhūti, because form is without arising, without cessation, without affliction, and without purification, it is pure, and so the perfection of wisdom is utterly pure. In the same way, Subhūti, because feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are without arising, without cessation, without affliction, and without purification, they are pure, and so the perfection of wisdom is utterly pure. Subhūti, because space is pure, the perfection of wisdom is utterly pure. Subhūti, because form is unstained and without grasping, the perfection of wisdom is utterly pure. In the same way, Subhūti, because feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are unstained and without grasping, the perfection of wisdom is utterly pure. Subhūti, because space and the echo are non-existent, inexpressible, and not apprehended, the perfection of wisdom is utterly pure. Subhūti, because all phenomena, whether stained or unstained, are unstained, the perfection of wisdom is utterly pure."

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One:

Blessed One, even those sons or daughters of good family into whose ears this Perfection of Wisdom resounds have gained a gain, a truly good gain. How much more, then, those who hold it, bear it in mind, read it, fully comprehend it, recite it, teach it, explain it, give instruction in it, and learn it by heart. No disease of the eye will arise in them, nor disease of the ear, nose, or tongue, nor disease of the body. They will not become deluded. Free from dread, they will not meet a time of death. Many hundreds of thousands of sons of the gods will follow close behind them. On the eighth, the fourteenth, and the fifteenth days of the lunar month, wherever that son or daughter of good family who

teaches the Dharma expounds the Perfection of Wisdom, in that very place they will generate very great merit.

When Subhūti had spoken thus, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Close behind that son or daughter of good family, hundreds of thousands of gods will follow. Hundreds of thousands of gods will come to that place. All those who wish to hear the Dharma from the teacher who expounds this Perfection of Wisdom will protect, shelter, and conceal that teacher. Why is that? Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom is the unsurpassed jewel of the world with its gods, humans, and asuras. Therefore, Subhūti, that son or daughter of good family will generate much merit on that basis.

Subhūti, however, many obstacles will arise for anyone who writes down this profound Perfection of Wisdom, or holds it, bears it in mind, reads it, fully comprehends it, recites it, teaches it, explains it, gives instruction in it, or learns it by heart. Why is that? Subhūti, a great jewel has many enemies, and the more precious it is, the heavier the enemies become. Subhūti, this Perfection of Wisdom, this great jewel, is the unsurpassed jewel in the world. It has entered the world for the sake of the world's benefit and happiness, so that all phenomena may be unarisen and unceasing, and so that there may be no afflictions whatsoever. It abides in a manner that does not perish.

Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom does not abide in any phenomenon, is not joined with any phenomenon, and does not fully grasp any phenomenon. Why is that? Subhūti, because all those phenomena are nonexistent and cannot be apprehended. Subhūti, because nothing has arisen, the Perfection of Wisdom is unstained. Subhūti, what is called unstained is this very Perfection of Wisdom. Subhūti, because form is unstained, the Perfection of Wisdom is unstained. In the same way, because feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are unstained, Subhūti, this Perfection of Wisdom is unstained.

Subhūti, even so, a bodhisattva, a great being, who does not truly understand this, still practices the Perfection of Wisdom. Furthermore, Subhūti, this Perfection of Wisdom does not cause entry into any phenomenon, nor cause definite entry; it does not demonstrate any phenomenon, nor definitely demonstrate it; it does not cause any phenomenon to be obtained, nor definitely obtained.

Then many thousands of sons of the gods appeared in the sky, shouting and laughing, tossing up their garments, and they said, "Oh, it appears that the

wheel of the Dharma has now been turned twice in Jambudvīpa!"

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable elder Subhūti, "Subhūti, this is not a twice-turning of the wheel of the Dharma. For there is no turning forth and no turning back of any phenomenon whatsoever. Subhūti, such is the Perfection of Wisdom of the bodhisattva, the great being."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, this is the great perfection of that bodhisattva, that great being, who is free from attachment to all phenomena; who, although he wishes to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, does not awaken to any phenomenon at all; and who, although he turns the wheel of the Dharma, does not truly teach any phenomenon at all. Why is that? Because there is no phenomenon to be observed, and no phenomenon to be taught, and there is no one who turns anything for anyone."

"Why is that? Blessed One, because all phenomena are utterly unestablished; no phenomenon will be turned back, and none will be turned forth. Why is that? Blessed One, because all phenomena are unestablished from the very beginning. All phenomena are empty of intrinsic nature."

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti, "So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Subhūti, there is no entering into emptiness, and no turning back from it. Subhūti, there is no entering into the signless, and no turning back from it. Subhūti, there is no entering into the wishless, and no turning back from it. Subhūti, this teaching is the teaching of all phenomena. No one has taught it, no one has heard it, no one has received it, no one realizes it directly, no one is realizing it directly, and no one will realize it directly. Through this teaching of the Dharma no one has passed completely beyond sorrow, no one will pass completely beyond sorrow, and no one is passing completely beyond sorrow. And through this teaching of the Dharma, no one has been made a worthy recipient of offerings."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, because space does not exist, this is the perfection that does not exist. Blessed One, because all phenomena are equal in being unobservable, this is the perfection of the unequal and of equality itself. Blessed One, because of utter emptiness, this is the perfection of seclusion. Blessed One, because all phenomena are not observed, this is the perfection of what is not to be forgotten. Blessed One, because there is no

name and no body, this is the perfection of having no abode. Blessed One, because there is no going and no coming, this is the perfection of having no essential nature. Blessed One, because all phenomena are free of conceptual thought, this is the perfection of the inexpressible. Blessed One, because the five aggregates are not observed, this is the perfection of having no name. Blessed One, because all phenomena do not go anywhere, this is the perfection of not going. Blessed One, because all phenomena have nothing to be grasped, this is the perfection of what cannot be seized."

Blessed One, because it is endowed with qualities that do not diminish, this is the perfection of non-diminishing. Blessed One, because no phenomenon is truly established, this is the perfection of the non-arising of all phenomena. Blessed One, because no agent is apprehended, this is the perfection without an agent. Blessed One, because all phenomena are without self, this is the perfection without a knower. Blessed One, because death, transmigration, and birth do not truly arise, this is the perfection of non-transmigration. Blessed One, because neither the past extreme, nor the future extreme, nor the present time is apprehended, this is the perfection that has nothing to be tamed.

Blessed One, because it makes known that nothing is born, this is the perfection that is like a dream, an echo, a mirage, a shimmering haze, and an illusion. Blessed One, because attachment, aversion, and delusion are without intrinsic nature, this is the perfection without total affliction. Blessed One, because no support is apprehended, this is the perfection without purification. Blessed One, because space is unstained, this is the perfection without stain. Blessed One, because it goes beyond all conceit, this is the perfection without conceptual elaboration. Blessed One, because there is no movement, this is the perfection without conceit.

Blessed One, because the dharmadhātu abides as it is, this is the perfection that does not move. Blessed One, because all phenomena are suchness, unmistaken, this is the perfection free from attachment. Blessed One, because all phenomena are nonconceptual, this is the perfection without arising. Blessed One, because the signs of all phenomena are not apprehended, this is the perfection of peace. Blessed One, because it is the perfection of good qualities, this is the perfection without fault. Blessed One, because there is no thorough imputation, this is the perfection without affliction.

Blessed One, because of the limit of reality, this is the perfection without sentient beings. Blessed One, because no phenomenon arises, this is the perfection without measure. Blessed One, because there is no clinging to any phenomenon, this is the perfection that does not realize the two extremes. Blessed One, because all phenomena are without division, this is the perfection without difference. Blessed One, because śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have no desire for anything, this is the perfection that grasps nothing as supreme. Blessed One, because conceptual thought is pacified, this is the perfection of nonconceptuality. Blessed One, because the nature of reality is immeasurable, this is the perfection that cannot be measured. Blessed One, because there is no attachment to any phenomenon, this is the perfection without attachment.

Blessed One, because all phenomena are uncompounded, this is the perfection of impermanence. Blessed One, because all phenomena are equal to space, this is the perfection of suffering. Blessed One, because no phenomenon is apprehended, this is the perfection of emptiness.

Blessed One, because all phenomena are not clung to, this is the perfection of selflessness. Blessed One, because all phenomena are not truly accomplished, this is the perfection of the absence of characteristics. Blessed One, because it has no limit and no extremity, this is the perfection of all emptinesses.

Blessed One, because those factors of awakening are not apprehended, this is the perfection of the factors of awakening, beginning with the establishments of mindfulness. Blessed One, because the three doors of liberation are not apprehended, this is the perfection of emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness. Blessed One, because these are not apprehended, this is the perfection of the eight liberations. Blessed One, because the first meditative concentration and the rest are not apprehended, this is the perfection of the nine successive absorptions. Blessed One, because suffering and the rest are not apprehended, this is the perfection of the Four Truths. Blessed One, because generosity and the rest are not apprehended, this is the perfection of the ten grounds.

Blessed One, because it is not forgotten, this is the perfection of the powers. Blessed One, because it is utterly undaunted, this is the perfection of fearlessness. Blessed One, because all wisdoms are free from attachment and free from obstruction, this is the perfection of the fully discriminating knowledges. Blessed One, because it passes entirely beyond enumeration, this

is the perfection of all the distinctive qualities of a buddha. Blessed One, because all phenomena are unmistakable suchness, this is the perfection of the suchness of the Tathāgata. Blessed One, because all phenomena are without intrinsic nature, this is the perfection of the self-arisen. Blessed One, because the intrinsic nature of all phenomena is fully known in all its aspects, this Perfection of Wisdom is the perfection of the wisdom of omniscience.

This is the ninth chapter, the chapter of praise, from the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines. Tenth volume.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, thought: "Those sons or daughters of good family in whose ears this Perfection of Wisdom comes to be heard have surely performed special service to the Victors of the past, have planted roots of virtue under many buddhas, and are held by spiritual friends. How much more so are those who take up this profound Perfection of Wisdom, hold it, read it, fully understand it, recite it, teach it, explain it, give instruction in it, and learn it by heart; and who, having taken it up, held it, read it, fully understood it, taught it, explained it, given instruction in it, and learned it by heart, study it just as it is, practice it just as it is, and apply themselves to it in yoga just as it is. These will not have merely meager roots of virtue. Those sons and daughters of good family will have honored and served many buddhas."

Those who even now will listen to this Perfection of Wisdom, and having listened will hold it, bear it in mind, read it, fully understand it, recite it, teach it, explain it, give transmission of it, memorize it, train in it just as it is, practice it just as it is, and apply themselves to it in yoga just as it is: such sons or daughters of good family have already, in the presence of the former Tathāgatas, Arhats, perfectly awakened Buddhas, heard this Perfection of Wisdom, and have questioned and inquired about it thoroughly from those Buddhas, the Blessed Ones. And those who, when this profound Perfection of Wisdom is being spoken, taught and explained, are not stunned, do not shrink back, are not alarmed, do not tremble, whose minds do not turn away, who do not become disheartened and turn back, who are not frightened, who are not utterly terrified, and who are not seized by dread: it should be known that those sons and daughters of good family have planted roots of virtue under many buddhas.

Then the venerable Śāriputra, knowing by his own mind the thought that had arisen in the mind of Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One:

Blessed One, if a son or daughter of good family, when this very profound Perfection of Wisdom is being taught, shown and explained, has faith in it, thinks on it and is inclined toward it, with a clear and believing mind arouses the thought of awakening, and holds, bears in mind, reads, fully understands, recites, teaches, explains, gives transmission of, memorizes, trains in just as it is, practices just as it is, and applies themselves in yoga just as it is to this Perfection of Wisdom, then such a person should be regarded as a bodhisattva, a great being, who is irreversible, exactly as such.

Why is that? Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom is profound. Blessed One, those whose roots of virtue are slight, who have not heard it directly in the presence of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, and have not questioned them, who by nature are of that kind, and who have not practiced in the past and so lack the foundation, are unable to have confidence in this Perfection of Wisdom that is so profound.

Blessed One, moreover, those who have no confidence in it, and who, through not understanding it, think of rejecting it: those sons and daughters of good family rejected this very profound Perfection of Wisdom in earlier times too, when it was being taught. Why is that? Blessed One, because their roots of virtue are slight and they did not practice in the past, they cannot in any way have confidence in this profound Perfection of Wisdom.

Those who come to reject this profound Perfection of Wisdom when it is being taught should be understood in the same way: they too rejected this very profound Perfection of Wisdom when it was taught in earlier times. For they have no faith in the teaching of this profound Perfection of Wisdom, no forbearance, no longing, no aspiration, no diligence, no clarity of mind, and no inclination toward it. They did not question or inquire of the former buddhas, the Blessed Ones, or of the buddhas' hearers.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the venerable Śāriputra: Noble Śāriputra, the Perfection of Wisdom is profound.

Bodhisattvas, great beings, who have not practiced before, may not take delight when this profound Perfection of Wisdom is taught; what is surprising in that?

Then Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, I pay homage to the Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, to pay homage to the Perfection of Wisdom is to pay homage to omniscient wisdom."

The Blessed One declared, "So it is, Kauśika, so it is. To pay homage to the Perfection of Wisdom is to pay homage to omniscient wisdom. Why is that? Kauśika, the omniscience of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is born from this. And Kauśika, the Perfection of Wisdom has also been fully revealed through the wisdom that is born of omniscience. In this way one should practice in this Perfection of Wisdom; in this way one should abide in this Perfection of Wisdom; in this way one should engage in yogic practice in this Perfection of Wisdom."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, abide in the Perfection of Wisdom when practicing the Perfection of Wisdom? How, when practicing the Perfection of Wisdom, does one engage in yogic practice in the Perfection of Wisdom?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to Śakra, lord of the gods, "Excellent, excellent, Kauśika! It is excellent, Kauśika, that you think to inquire and to question the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha, about this matter. Kauśika, this confidence of yours has also been born through the power of the buddha.

"Kauśika, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices this Perfection of Wisdom, he does not abide in form, and he does not abide thinking, 'It is form.' Kauśika, in that a bodhisattva, a great being, does not abide in form and does not abide thinking, 'It is form,' in that way, Kauśika, a bodhisattva, a great being, engages in yogic practice in form. In the same way, he does not abide in feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness, and does not abide thinking, 'It is consciousness.' Kauśika, in that a bodhisattva, a great being, does not abide in consciousness and does not abide thinking, 'It is consciousness,' in that way, Kauśika, a bodhisattva, a great being, engages in yogic practice in consciousness.

"Kauśika, he does not apply himself to the notion 'It is form.' Kauśika, in that he does not apply himself to the notion 'It is form,' in that way he does not abide in the thought 'It is form.' In the same way, Kauśika, he does not apply himself to the notion 'It is feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness.' Kauśika, in that he does not apply himself to the notion 'It is consciousness,' in that way he does not abide in the thought 'It is consciousness.' Thus he abides in the Perfection of Wisdom in this way, and thus he engages in yogic practice in it."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is profound. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is hard to fathom. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is hard to grasp. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is immeasurable."

The Blessed One declared, "So it is, Śāriputra, so it is. Śāriputra, one does not abide thinking, 'Form is profound.'

Śāriputra, when one does not abide in the thought, "Form is profound," in that very way one is practicing yoga with respect to form. So too with feeling, perception, and the formations. Śāriputra, one does not abide in the thought, "Consciousness is profound"; Śāriputra, when one does not abide in the thought, "Consciousness is profound," in that very way one is practicing yoga with respect to consciousness.

Śāriputra, one does not practice in the thought, "Form is profound." Śāriputra, when one does not practice in the thought, "Form is profound," in that way one is not abiding in the thought, "Form is profound." So too with feeling, perception, and the formations. Śāriputra, one does not practice in the thought, "Consciousness is profound"; Śāriputra, when one does not practice in the thought, "Consciousness is profound," in that way one is not abiding in the thought, "Consciousness is profound."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is profound. Should it be taught in the presence of bodhisattvas, great beings, who have received the prediction of irreversibility? Why is that? Blessed One, such beings feel no dismay; they will have no doubt, no confusion, and no dispute."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the venerable Śāriputra: "Noble Śāriputra, what fault would there be if this Perfection of Wisdom were taught in the presence of a bodhisattva, a great being, who has not received a prediction?"

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Śāriputra said to Śakra, lord of the gods: "Kauśika, consider a bodhisattva, a great being, who has not received a prediction, yet who gains the opportunity to see, to pay homage to, to honor and serve, and to hear this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and who, on hearing it, does not tremble, is not terrified, and is not seized by terror. Kauśika, you should know that such a bodhisattva, a great being, has come from far away. You should know that he entered the Great Vehicle long ago and that his roots of virtue have fully ripened. Before long he will receive the prediction to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening; you should know

that he is close to receiving the prediction.

"That bodhisattva, a great being, will not pass beyond one, two, or three Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas before he receives the prediction to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. Moreover, he will please those Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, and having pleased them, he will never cause them to be disheartened. His seeing the Tathāgatas will also bear fruit through the prediction. From that very seeing of the Tathāgatas he will receive the prediction to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

"For as long as he has not received the prediction to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, for that long, by seeing the Tathāgatas, paying homage to them, honoring them, serving and attending them, and up until he becomes manifestly and perfectly awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, his seeing them will bear fruit."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, as for the bodhisattva, the great being, who gains the opportunity to see, to pay homage to, to honor and serve, and to hear this profound Perfection of Wisdom, that bodhisattva, great being..."

Blessed One, they have come from far away. I would say that they entered the Great Vehicle properly long ago, and that their roots of virtue have fully ripened. How much more is this so for those who, having heard this Perfection of Wisdom, take it up, hold it, read it, thoroughly understand it, recite it, teach it, explain it in detail, give instruction in it, and know it by heart.

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāriputra: "So it is, Śāriputra, so it is. Any bodhisattva, any great being, who has gained the opportunity to see this profound Perfection of Wisdom, to pay homage to it, to honor and serve it, and to hear it, should be known as one who has come from far away, who entered the Great Vehicle properly long ago, and whose roots of virtue have fully ripened. How much more is this so for one who, having heard it, takes it up, holds it, reads it, thoroughly understands it, recites it, teaches it, explains it in detail, gives instruction in it, and knows it by heart."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, I am inspired to offer an illustration. Sugata, I am inspired. Blessed One, suppose a son or daughter of good family who follows the bodhisattva vehicle dreams, even in a dream, of sitting at the heart of awakening. Blessed One, that bodhisattva, that great being, is close to the unsurpassed, perfect and

complete awakening, for the sake of fully awakening to it. In just the same way, Blessed One, if any son or daughter of good family gains the opportunity to see this profound Perfection of Wisdom, to pay homage to it, to honor and serve it, and to hear it, then, Blessed One, that person who follows the bodhisattva vehicle has come from far away; and if they entered the Great Vehicle properly long ago and their roots of virtue have fully ripened, how much more is this so for one who, having heard it, takes it up, holds it, reads it, thoroughly understands it, recites it, teaches it, explains it in detail, gives instruction in it, and knows it by heart.

"That person who follows the bodhisattva vehicle is close to receiving the prophecy. It should be known that the buddha, the Blessed One, will give that bodhisattva, that great being, the prophecy of fully and perfectly awakening to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. A bodhisattva, a great being, who obtains even the mere hearing of this profound Perfection of Wisdom should be known as one who entered the Great Vehicle properly long ago and whose roots of virtue have fully ripened. How much more is this so for a son or daughter of good family who takes up this profound Perfection of Wisdom, holds it, reads it, thoroughly understands it, recites it, teaches it, explains it in detail, gives instruction in it, and knows it by heart.

"Why is that? Blessed One, most beings have not been free from accumulated karma that accords with being impoverished of the Dharma. For the most part, the minds of such beings do not accord with this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and their minds turn away from it. Beings who have not accumulated roots of virtue for the most part do not enter into this true limit, and do not come to have faith in it.

Those sons and daughters of good family who enter into this ultimate limit and come to have faith in it, O Blessed One, are those who have accumulated roots of virtue. They should be known as ones who have accumulated roots of virtue in abundance.

Blessed One, it is like this. Suppose a man has come out of a wilderness a hundred leagues wide, or two hundred, or three hundred, or four hundred, or five hundred, or a thousand leagues wide. As he comes out, he sees the signs that show a village, a town, or a city to be near: the signs seen earlier, such as herdsmen of cattle or of other livestock, a boundary, a lovely park, a lovely grove, or other signs besides these. When he sees those earlier signs, he thinks, "Because these earlier signs appear, I have drawn near to a village, a

town, or a city." Then he has found relief and breathes freely, and from then on he gives no thought to bandits.

In the same way, Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, abides close to this profound Perfection of Wisdom, that bodhisattva, a great being, should be known as one who has drawn near to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. It should be known that before long this bodhisattva, this great being, will receive the prophecy of unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Such a one will also feel neither fear nor terror at the level of the śrāvakas or the level of the pratyekabuddhas. Why is that? Because, just as that man saw the earlier signs, so this bodhisattva has attained the seeing of this profound Perfection of Wisdom, the paying of homage to it, the honoring of it, and the hearing of it.

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Śāriputra as follows. "Śāriputra, so it is, so it is. Just as you speak, and will speak, through the power of the Buddha, so too you should have confidence about this matter."

When he had said this, the venerable Śāriputra addressed the Blessed One as follows. "Blessed One, it is like this. Suppose a certain man wishes to see the great ocean. As he goes toward the great ocean, the more he goes to see it, the more he may notice a tree, or the sign of a tree, or a mountain, or the sign of a mountain. If he does, he should think, 'From here the great ocean is still far away.' If later he no longer sees a tree, or the sign of a tree, or a mountain, or the sign of a mountain, he should think, 'From here the great ocean is near.' Why is that? The great ocean slopes down gradually, and so within the great ocean there is no tree or sign of a tree, no mountain or sign of a mountain. Even though he has not yet seen that great ocean directly with his eyes, he thinks, 'I have drawn near to the great ocean; from here the great ocean is not far.'

In the same way, Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, hears this profound Perfection of Wisdom, he should know this. Even though those Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and completely awakened buddhas, have not yet given me a prophecy face to face, I should nonetheless know that I am drawing near to receiving the prophecy of unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Why is that?"

They are so for this reason: it is in order to obtain the sight of this profound Perfection of Wisdom, to pay homage to it, to honor and revere it, and to hear

it.

Blessed One, it is like this. When the spring season draws near, the old leaves fall from the branches of the various trees, and new leaves of many kinds appear. When the leaves appear, the people of Jambudvīpa see those earlier signs in the forests and become glad, thinking, "Before long, flowers and fruits will come." Why is this so? Because such signs were previously present in the trunks of the trees.

In the same way, Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, draws near in order to obtain the sight of this profound Perfection of Wisdom, to pay homage to it, to honor and revere it, and to hear it, it should be understood that this bodhisattva, this great being, has brought his roots of virtue to full maturity with regard to this profound Perfection of Wisdom. This profound Perfection of Wisdom has been brought near to him by that very root of virtue from before.

Then the gods who had seen the buddhas in the past think, "In the case of those earlier bodhisattvas, great beings, the signs of being prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening also appeared beforehand. So this bodhisattva, this great being, will before long receive the prophecy to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening." Thinking so, they become delighted, rejoice, and feel a gladdened mind.

Blessed One, it is like this. When a pregnant woman is heavy with child and moves her body, she becomes very weary. She has little desire to walk about, she wants little food, she becomes drowsy and sleeps little, she speaks little, her strength is small, and her suffering is great. She often stays alone, brooding, and has little enthusiasm for company. She thinks, "Because I have attended to things improperly, and have indulged in, relied upon, cultivated and often done such things, my body is experiencing such sensations." At that time, Blessed One, just as one sees these earlier signs, so one should understand that this woman will give birth to a child before long.

In the same way, Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, whose roots of virtue have matured, draws near in order to obtain the sight of this profound Perfection of Wisdom, to pay homage to it, to honor and revere it, and to hear it, and when, on hearing it, he rejoices in it and gives rise to a mind that seeks the Perfection of Wisdom, at that time, Blessed One, it should be understood that this bodhisattva, this great being, will before long receive the prophecy to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Śāriputra: "Excellent, excellent, Śāriputra! This too, Śāriputra, you have been inspired to say through the power of the Buddha."

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, it is wonderful that the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha, has so well embraced, so well trained, and so well entrusted these bodhisattvas, these great beings."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, it is so. These bodhisattvas, these great beings, have set out for the benefit of many beings, for the happiness of many beings, out of compassion for the world, and for the sake, benefit and happiness of the great multitude of people."

out of compassion for gods and humans, wishing to fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and, having become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, wishing to teach the unsurpassed Dharma.

Subhūti asked: Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices this perfection of wisdom, how does the cultivation of the perfection of wisdom become fully complete?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, practicing the perfection of wisdom, does not perceive any increase of form, then he is practicing the perfection of wisdom. In the same way, if he does not perceive any increase of feeling, of perception, of formations, or of consciousness, then he is practicing the perfection of wisdom. If he does not perceive any decrease of form, then he is practicing the perfection of wisdom. In the same way, if he does not perceive any decrease of feeling, of perception, of formations, or of consciousness, then he is practicing the perfection of wisdom. If he does not perceive any phenomenon, then he is practicing the perfection of wisdom. If he does not perceive any non-phenomenon, then he is practicing the perfection of wisdom. In this way, his cultivation of the perfection of wisdom becomes fully complete.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, this teaching is inconceivable.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, form is inconceivable. In the same way, feeling, perception, and formations are inconceivable, and, Subhūti, consciousness is inconceivable. Subhūti, if he does not even know that form is inconceivable, then he is practicing the perfection of wisdom. In the same way, if he does not

even know that feeling, perception, and formations are inconceivable, and, Subhūti, that consciousness is inconceivable, then he is practicing the perfection of wisdom.

Then the venerable Śāriputra said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, who will have faith in this perfection of wisdom, which is so profound?

The Blessed One said: Śāriputra, whichever bodhisattva, great being, has become one who has practiced the perfection of wisdom, he will have faith in this perfection of wisdom.

The venerable Śāriputra asked: Blessed One, in what way is a bodhisattva, a great being, one who has practiced? Blessed One, in what way does he obtain the name "one who has practiced"?

The Blessed One said: Śāriputra, here a bodhisattva, a great being, has no conceptual thought about the powers, no conceptual thought about the fearlessnesses, no conceptual thought about the qualities of a buddha, and no conceptual thought even about omniscience. Why is that? Śāriputra, the powers are inconceivable, the fearlessnesses are also inconceivable, the qualities of a buddha are also inconceivable, omniscience is also inconceivable, and all phenomena are also inconceivable. Śāriputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has practiced in this way, and who does not dwell in anything at all, is practicing the perfection of wisdom. In that way he is called "one who has practiced," and he obtains the name "one who has practiced."

Then the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One:

Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is profound. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is a heap of jewels. Blessed One, because space is pure, the Perfection of Wisdom is a mass of purity. Blessed One, it is wonderful that when sons and daughters of good family take up this Perfection of Wisdom, hold it, read it, master it, recite it, teach it, explain it, give instruction in it, memorize it, and copy it down in writing, many obstacles arise for them.

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Subhūti, when sons or daughters of good family take up this Perfection of Wisdom, hold it, read it, master it, recite it, teach it, explain it, give instruction in it, memorize it, and copy it down in writing, many obstacles do arise. Why is that? Subhūti, it is because Māra the Evil One strives to create obstacles for those sons and daughters of good family who take up

this Perfection of Wisdom, hold it, read it, master it, recite it, teach it, explain it, give instruction in it, memorize it, and write it down. Therefore they should write it quickly. Even if it will be requested to be written in one month, two months, or three months, they should still write it. And if it will be requested to be written after a year or more, even then, Subhūti, those sons or daughters of good family should write this Perfection of Wisdom. Why is that? Subhūti, it is just so: for anything that is a great and precious jewel, many obstacles arise.

When he had said this, the venerable Subhūti spoke to the Blessed One: Blessed One, when this Perfection of Wisdom is taken up, held, read, mastered, recited, taught, explained, given in instruction, memorized, and copied in writing, Māra the Evil One will give rise to many kinds of eagerness to act as an obstructor, and will make an effort to do so.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, although it is so that Māra the Evil One will strive to carry out the work of obstruction against those who take up, hold, read, master, recite, teach, explain, give instruction in, memorize, and copy down this Perfection of Wisdom, even so he cannot create obstacles for bodhisattva mahāsattvas who have not lost their commitment.

Then the venerable Śāriputra spoke to the Blessed One: Blessed One, at a time when Māra the Evil One becomes eager to create obstacles for sons and daughters of good family who take up, hold, read, master, recite, teach, explain, give instruction in, memorize, and copy down this Perfection of Wisdom, then, Blessed One, how will sons and daughters of good family in these times come to take up, hold, read, master, recite, teach, explain, give instruction in, memorize, and copy down this Perfection of Wisdom?

Blessed One, through whose power do those sons and daughters of good family come to hold this Perfection of Wisdom, to bear it in mind, to recite it, to master it fully, to read it aloud, to teach it, to explain it, to give its transmission, to recite it from memory, and to inquire into its written text?

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Śāriputra as follows.

Śāriputra, it is through the power of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, the Tathāgatas, arhats, fully awakened buddhas, that those sons and daughters of good family come to hold this Perfection of Wisdom, to bear it in mind, to recite it, to master it fully, to read it aloud, to teach it, to explain it, to give its transmission, to recite it from memory, and to inquire into its written text; and they will also study it just as it is, practice it just as it is, and apply themselves

to it in yoga just as it is.

Why is this so? Śāriputra, this is the nature of phenomena: in the immeasurable, innumerable world systems, whatever buddhas, Blessed Ones, are dwelling, living, and sustained, those buddhas keep in mind and take under their care those who hold this Perfection of Wisdom, who bear it in mind, recite it, master it fully, read it aloud, teach it, explain it, give its transmission, recite it from memory, and inquire into its written text.

Sons and daughters of good family who hold this Perfection of Wisdom, who expound it, recite it, master it fully, read it aloud, teach it, explain it, give its transmission, recite it from memory, and inquire into its written text, and who study it just as it is, practice it just as it is, and apply themselves to it in yoga just as it is: those too are kept in mind and taken under their care by those buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Śāriputra, no one is able to create obstacles for those sons and daughters of good family who are kept in mind by the buddhas and taken under the buddhas' care.

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, all those bodhisattvas, the great beings, who listen to this Perfection of Wisdom, hold it, bear it in mind, recite it, master it fully, read it aloud, teach it, explain it, give its transmission, recite it from memory, and inquire into its written text, and who study it just as it is, practice it just as it is, and apply themselves to it in yoga just as it is, will so practice through the power of the buddhas, through the blessing of the buddhas, and through being taken under the buddhas' care.

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Śāriputra as follows: Śāriputra, so it is, so it is.

Śāriputra, all those bodhisattvas, those great beings, through the power of the buddhas, through the blessing of the buddhas, and through being embraced by the buddhas, will listen to this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and will hold it, bear it in mind, read it, master it fully, recite it, teach it, explain it, give transmission of it, memorize it, and have it written down in books. They will also train in accordance with suchness, practice in accordance with suchness, and apply themselves in yoga in accordance with suchness.

Śāriputra, those bodhisattvas, those great beings, who listen to this Perfection of Wisdom, hold it, bear it in mind, read it, master it fully, recite it, teach it, explain it, give transmission of it, memorize it, and have it written down in books, and who train in accordance with suchness, practice in accordance with

suchness, and apply themselves in yoga in accordance with suchness, are known by the Tathāgata. Śāriputra, they are blessed by the Tathāgata. Śāriputra, they are seen by the Tathāgata. Śāriputra, they are looked upon by the Tathāgata with the buddha eye.

Having heard it, they hold it, bear it in mind, read it, master it fully, recite it, teach it, explain it, give transmission of it, memorize it, and write it down in books. Training in accordance with suchness, practicing in accordance with suchness, and applying themselves in yoga in accordance with suchness, they come near to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and they will abide in unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening and in suchness.

Śāriputra, there will be those who write down this Perfection of Wisdom and hold it, read it, master it fully, recite it, teach it, explain it, give transmission of it, memorize it, and have it copied into books, but who do not train in accordance with suchness, do not practice in accordance with suchness, and do not apply themselves in yoga in accordance with suchness. Because they do not train, practice, and apply themselves in yoga in accordance with suchness, they will not come to abide in suchness and in unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Even so, Śāriputra, those too are known by the Tathāgata; those too are blessed by the Tathāgata; those too are seen by the Tathāgata. Śāriputra, those too are looked upon by the Tathāgata with the buddha eye. Śāriputra, their effort and their exertion will also bring great benefit, great advantage, great results, and a great karmic maturation.

Why is this so? Because the Perfection of Wisdom is endowed with the ultimate meaning of all phenomena, and it abides close to all sentient beings so that they may realize things exactly as they are.

Furthermore, Śāriputra, these sūtras endowed with the six perfections will appear in the south when the Tathāgata has passed away and the time has come for the true Dharma to decline, when the Dharma and Vinaya have reached their essence and their last remnant. From the south they will go on to appear in Vartani. From Vartani they will appear again in the north.

Śāriputra, at that time, those sons and daughters of good family who take up, hold, read, comprehend, recite, teach, explain, expound, and memorize this Perfection of Wisdom, and who even set it down in a book and keep it, are regarded by the Tathāgata. They are known by the Tathāgata. Śāriputra, they are blessed by the Tathāgata. Śāriputra, they are seen by the Tathāgata. Śāriputra, they are beheld by the Tathāgata with the buddha eye.

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, will a Perfection of Wisdom as profound as this also flourish, in the later time, in the later age, in the northern country and the northern region?"

The Blessed One said: "Śāriputra, in that northern country and northern region, those who hear this profound Perfection of Wisdom and then practice it will cause it to flourish. Śāriputra, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who hear, ask about, hold, keep, read, comprehend, recite, teach, explain, expound, and memorize this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and who train in it just as it is, accomplish it just as it is, and practice it just as it is, should be understood to have set out well upon the vehicle long ago."

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, in the northern country and northern region, how many will there be of those bodhisattvas, great beings, who hear, ask about, hold, keep, read, comprehend, recite, teach, explain, expound, and memorize this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and who train in it just as it is, accomplish it just as it is, and practice it just as it is? Will they be few, or will they be many? How many will there be?"

The Blessed One said: "Śāriputra, in the northern country and northern region there will be many bodhisattvas, great beings, very many indeed. Śāriputra, though they are many, among those many there will be very few bodhisattvas, great beings, who hear, ask about, hold, keep, read, comprehend, recite, teach, explain, expound, and memorize this Perfection of Wisdom, who train in it just as it is, accomplish it just as it is, and practice it just as it is, and who, when this Perfection of Wisdom is being taught, do not become stunned, do not become utterly discouraged, do not become timid, do not shrink back, do not turn their minds away, do not tremble, do not become utterly terrified, and are not gripped by utter terror. Those bodhisattvas, great beings, should be understood to have set out well upon the vehicle long ago."

They have followed the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas of the past, and have questioned them, inquired of them, and asked them repeatedly; those sons and daughters of good family who belong to the vehicle of the bodhisattvas have made offerings to the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas of the past. They will bring their moral discipline to complete fulfillment. Beginning from this very unsurpassed, perfect awakening, they will work for the benefit of many beings.

Why is this so? Because I myself have spoken with those sons and daughters of good family about matters connected with omniscience. Even when their

lives change, they will practice rightly in this very way that is connected with omniscience and with the perfection of wisdom. Beginning from unsurpassed, perfect awakening, they will speak of it, and they will take delight in speaking of it. They will abide well in these, and they will rest in meditative equipoise in this perfection of wisdom, and Māra will not be able to divert them. How much less could other beings divert them by means of desire or by means of spells! Why is this so? Because their strength is firm in unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

When those sons and daughters of good family hear this, they will gain great joy, faith, and deep faith in this perfection of wisdom. Through them, the roots of virtue of many beings will be brought forth toward unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

Why is this so? Because in my very presence those sons and daughters of good family spoke these words: "While I practice the conduct of a bodhisattva, I will establish many hundreds of living beings, many thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of living beings, many millions of living beings, many thousands of millions, many hundreds of thousands of millions, and many hundreds of thousands of billions of living beings in unsurpassed, perfect awakening. I will instruct them, encourage them, praise them, bring joy to them, and clearly distinguish the path for them. I will make them abide in complete awakening. I will make them irreversible."

Why is this so? Looking into the minds of those sons and daughters of good family who belong to the bodhisattva vehicle, who spoke these words, I rejoiced in them. Thus those sons and daughters of good family are possessed of great aspiration, in the place where the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas, present before them, will teach the Dharma, and

In the buddha fields where this Perfection of Wisdom is heard extensively from the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, they will think of going to one buddha field after another. And in those buddha fields they will establish, instruct, set in place, praise, fill with joy, distinguish, and cause to awaken, and make irreversible in unsurpassed, perfect awakening many hundreds of living beings, many thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of living beings, many hundreds of millions of living beings, many thousands of millions of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of millions of living beings, and many hundreds of thousands of billions of living beings.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, there is nothing in the dharmas of the past, the future, and the present that the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened Buddha has not seen, not heard, not directly known, or not fully known. There is no dharma that he does not fully know, and no conduct of sentient beings that he does not fully know. And, Blessed One, that you know the conduct of those future bodhisattvas, the great beings who seek awakening, who have perfect lofty intention and who have undertaken diligent effort, those who, at that time, hold, bear, recite, understand, thoroughly master, teach, explain, give instruction in, memorize, and write down this profound Perfection of Wisdom, is wonderful.

At that time, for the sake of these six perfections and for the sake of all sentient beings, they will generate diligence, and there are sons and daughters of good family who seek, search out, and go on seeking. Among these, some bodhisattvas who seek, search out, and go on seeking will find this profound Perfection of Wisdom when they seek it. Some, even though they seek it, will not find this profound Perfection of Wisdom. And some, even though they do not seek it, will find it. Blessed One, what is the cause of this?

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāriputra: So it is, Śāriputra, so it is. There is nothing among the dharmas of the past, the future, and the present that the Tathāgata has not seen, not heard, not known, or not fully known. Śāriputra, at that very time, some bodhisattvas will seek this Perfection of Wisdom, will seek it again and again, and will search it out thoroughly, yet will not find it. But some bodhisattvas, even though they do not seek it, do not seek it again and again, and do not search it out, will find it. Why is this? In the very distant past, those bodhisattvas sought and thoroughly searched out this Perfection of Wisdom without letting their diligence lapse. Therefore, through the very aspiration of the roots of virtue they formed in the past, they will find this Perfection of Wisdom even though they do not seek it, do not seek it again and again, and do not search it out.

Other sūtras as well, those that proclaim this very Perfection of Wisdom, will also come to them of their own accord, and will incline and turn toward them. Why is that? Śāriputra, it is like this: a bodhisattva, a great being, who seeks and thoroughly seeks this Perfection of Wisdom with unflagging diligence will, even after passing from this life into later lives, find this Perfection of Wisdom again. And the other sūtras that are accompanied by the Perfection of Wisdom will likewise come to that bodhisattva's side of their own accord, and will

incline and turn toward him.

When this was said, the venerable Śāriputra addressed the Blessed One: Blessed One, will only these sūtras, which are endowed with the six perfections, come to those sons and daughters of good family, and incline and turn toward them? Will others not do so?

The Blessed One said: Śāriputra, whatever other profound and deep sūtras there are, these also will come to those sons and daughters of good family of their own accord, and will incline and turn toward them. Why is that? Śāriputra, it is like this: those bodhisattvas, great beings, who establish beings in unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, who rightly teach them, rightly set them in it, rightly praise it to them, rightly bring them delight in it, rightly open it up for them, who bring them to abide in perfect awakening and make them irreversible, and who themselves train in it as well, Śāriputra, even after passing from this life, profound and deep sūtras that are endowed with non-apprehension, endowed with emptiness, and endowed with the six perfections will come to them of their own accord, will incline toward them of their own accord, and will turn toward them of their own accord.

This is the tenth chapter, called "Praise of the Qualities of Upholding," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines, the eleventh volume.

Then the venerable Subhūti addressed the Blessed One: Blessed One, if the Blessed One speaks of these qualities of those sons and daughters of good family, then what manner of obstacles will arise for them?

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, many deeds of Māra that create obstacles will arise.

Subhūti asked: Blessed One, what sorts of many deeds of Māra, obstructing and hindering them, will arise?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, for those bodhisattvas, great beings, who teach the Perfection of Wisdom, eloquence will arise only after a very long time. Subhūti, this should be recognized as the first deed of Māra. Subhūti, even when that eloquence does arise, it will become a cause of distraction, and this too should be recognized as a deed of Māra. Subhūti, if they become frivolous, boisterous and laughing, and are inquisitive about the letters, this too should be recognized as a deed of Māra. Subhūti, if they come to understand with a mind that is scattered and distracted, this too should be

recognized as a deed of Māra.

Subhūti, if those who are writing it down question one another with their minds distracted by mutual consciousness, this too should be understood as the work of Māra. Subhūti, if they cannot hold the teaching in mind, this too should be understood as the work of Māra. Subhūti, if they laugh and joke with one another while writing it down, this too should be understood as the work of Māra. Subhūti, if they quarrel with one another while writing it down, this too should be understood as the work of Māra. Subhūti, if their eyes wander while they write, this too should be understood as the work of Māra. Subhūti, if those who are writing it down fall out with one another and cannot agree as a gathering, this too should be understood as the work of Māra.

Subhūti, if someone says, "I cannot fathom the depth of this, I cannot taste its flavor," and gets up from the seat and leaves, this too should be understood as the work of Māra. Subhūti, if someone gets up from the seat and goes away, without faith, thinking, "In this Perfection of Wisdom I have not been given any prophecy," this too should be understood as the work of Māra.

Subhūti, suppose someone thinks: "The name of the village, town, or city where I was born is not mentioned here. My own name and lineage are not mentioned here. The names and lineages of my father and mother are not mentioned here. The family into which I was born is not mentioned here." And so, deciding not to listen to the Perfection of Wisdom, he resolves to leave. As many as give rise to such thoughts, in whatever way they go off, in just that way, wherever they must again practice yoga, for that many eons they will be held fast in saṃsāra.

Why is that? Subhūti, bodhisattva mahāsattvas who do not listen to this Perfection of Wisdom will not become emancipated from worldly and transcendent phenomena. Subhūti, this too should be understood as their work of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, there will be persons who belong to the bodhisattva vehicle who abandon and cast aside this Perfection of Wisdom, which accomplishes omniscient wisdom, and who think to seek out instead those sūtras that do not accomplish omniscient wisdom. Subhūti, this too should be understood as their work of Māra.

Subhūti, just as they do not wish to train in worldly and transcendent phenomena, and do not wish to become emancipated from worldly and transcendent phenomena, so too they do not train in this Perfection of

Wisdom. Because they have not trained in this Perfection of Wisdom, they will not become emancipated from worldly and transcendent phenomena. Thus those of small intellect abandon and cast aside the Perfection of Wisdom, the root of fully knowing worldly and transcendent phenomena exactly as they are, and think to seek the branches.

Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose a dog, giving up begging for scraps from its own master, were to think of seeking morsels from a servant. In the same way, Subhūti, in the future, in the final time, there will be certain persons of the bodhisattva vehicle who cast aside this root of omniscient wisdom, the Perfection of Wisdom, and think to seek the essence, buddhahood, from the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, which are like branches, leaves, and foliage. Subhūti, this too should be understood as the work of Māra for those bodhisattvas.

Why is that? Because those of small intellect do not know how this Perfection of Wisdom accomplishes omniscient wisdom.

Having abandoned and cast aside the Perfection of Wisdom, they will think of seeking, as something superior, whatever other sūtras show the stage of the śrāvakas and show the stage of the pratyekabuddhas. Bodhisattvas of this kind should be understood to have entered upon branches, leaves, and foliage.

Why is that? Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, should not train in the way that persons of the śrāvaka vehicle and persons of the pratyekabuddha vehicle train.

Subhūti, how do persons of the śrāvaka vehicle and of the pratyekabuddha vehicle train? Subhūti, they think: "I alone shall be tamed. I alone shall be pacified. I alone shall pass completely beyond sorrow." For the sake of their own taming, their own pacification, and their own complete nirvāṇa alone, they undertake the practice of bringing about all roots of virtue. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, should not train in that way.

Rather, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, should train as follows: "For the benefit of the entire world, I shall myself abide in suchness, and I shall also establish all sentient beings in suchness. I shall lead the immeasurable realm of sentient beings to complete nirvāṇa." A bodhisattva, a great being, should undertake the practice of bringing about all roots of virtue in this way, and should not become conceited because of it.

Subhūti, suppose, for example, that there were a man who had never seen an elephant and went looking for the color and shape of an elephant. In the dark he came upon an elephant and judged it to be like whatever he felt of it. Having judged it so, he thought of searching for the elephant's trail, and thought of taking the color and shape of the elephant from the elephant's trail. Subhūti, what do you think? Would that man be of a skilled nature?

Subhūti said: "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, in just the same way, there are persons of the bodhisattva vehicle who do not know this Perfection of Wisdom and do not ask about it, but abandon it. Though they wish to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, they think of seeking out those sūtras that show the stage of the śrāvakas and show the stage of the pratyekabuddhas. Such persons should be understood in this way. Subhūti, this too should be understood as their work of Māra.

Subhūti, suppose, for example, that there were a man in need of jewels who saw the great ocean. Without investigating, thinking about, or entering into the jewels there, he thought to search for the cause of jewels in a cow's hoofprint, and thought to make the cow's hoofprint equal to the great ocean. Subhūti, what do you think? Should that man be considered to be of a skilled nature?

Subhūti said: "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, in just the same way, there are persons of the bodhisattva vehicle who, even when they have found this Perfection of Wisdom, do not understand it, and, not knowing it, cast it aside. Wishing to remain with little effort, they think of seeking those sūtras that show the stage of the śrāvakas and show the stage of the pratyekabuddhas. Such persons should be understood in this way, wherever the bodhisattva vehicle has not been taught.

"I alone will be tamed, I alone will be pacified, I alone will pass completely into nirvāṇa." Thinking in this way, and settling the mind inward, they resolve: "I shall attain the fruit of the stream-enterer; I shall attain the fruit of the once-returner, the fruit of the non-returner, and the fruit of arhatship; I shall attain solitary awakening. In this very life, without clinging, I shall free my mind from the defilements and pass completely into nirvāṇa." Such an aspiration is said to belong to the level of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas, great beings, should not give rise to the mind in this way.

Why is that? Subhūti, bodhisattvas, great beings, have properly entered the Great Vehicle and put on the great armor. They never set their minds on a feeble enthusiasm. Why is that? Because these superior beings lead the world completely and work for the benefit of the world. Therefore they should always train well, without interruption, in the six perfections.

Furthermore, Subhūti, there are persons of the bodhisattva vehicle whose roots of virtue have not fully ripened, who are of small intelligence and weak in their higher intention. They do not know or comprehend the sūtras that are endowed with the six perfections. Abandoning and casting aside this Perfection of Wisdom, they think to seek out those sūtras that expound the level of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Subhūti, in the case of such persons of the bodhisattva vehicle who act in this way, this too should be recognized as the work of Māra.

Subhūti, it is as if a carpenter or a carpenter's apprentice wished to build and complete a house of the size of the Vaijayanta palace. He would go looking for the measure and the layout of the palace of the sun and moon. Having sought it, he would see the palace of the sun and moon and think to take its measurements as his own. Subhūti, what do you think? If he wished to build and complete a house of the size of the Vaijayanta palace, would he have to take the measure of the palace of the sun and moon?

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, he would not."

The Blessed One said: "In just the same way, Subhūti, in a future time there will be some persons of the bodhisattva vehicle who hear this Perfection of Wisdom and find this Perfection of Wisdom, yet abandon this Perfection of Wisdom and cast it aside. They think to seek omniscience from sūtras endowed with the level of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, from those sūtras that proclaim: 'I alone will be tamed; I alone will be pacified; I alone will pass completely into nirvāṇa.' They seek out sūtras in such a way, by which they alone attain taming, pacification, and nirvāṇa, and they think to train in that manner. Subhūti, what do you think? Should those bodhisattvas be recognized as skilled by nature?"

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, they should not."

The Blessed One said: "Subhūti, this too should be recognized as the work of Māra on their part.

Subhūti, it is as if a certain man wished to see a wheel-turning king. He saw a wheel-turning king, and having seen him, he fixed in his mind the sign of his color, his form, his splendor, and his miraculous power, thinking, 'He is like this.' Then, if he were to see a ruler of a fortress, he would take the color, form, splendor, miraculous power, and signs of that ruler of a fortress,

Since they cannot tell the particulars apart, they say, "That wheel-turning king looks just like this: such is his color, form, splendor, miraculous power, and appearance." Subhūti, what do you think? Should a person who thinks to equate the wheel-turning king with the king of a city be regarded as wise by nature?

Subhūti said, "Certainly not, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said, "In just the same way, Subhūti, in a future time there will be persons following the bodhisattva vehicle who hear this Perfection of Wisdom and obtain it, and yet abandon the Perfection of Wisdom, cast it aside, hold it at a distance, and think to seek omniscience in sūtras that belong to the level of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Subhūti, this too should be understood as the work of māra for them.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, I do not say that bodhisattvas, great beings, should seek omniscience in these sūtras connected with the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Rather, Subhūti, unless bodhisattvas, great beings, train in the skillful means of bodhisattvas, great beings, that the Tathāgata has taught in the Perfection of Wisdom, they will not come forth definitively toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Why is that? Because in other sūtras it is difficult for a bodhisattva to be truly accomplished.

"Therefore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, seeing the benefits of the Perfection of Wisdom correctly, in many ways truly teaches this Perfection of Wisdom to bodhisattvas, great beings, truly establishes them in it, truly praises it, truly delights them in it, truly engages them in it, and truly sets them firmly in it. In this way bodhisattvas, great beings, become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

"Subhūti, what do you think? Suppose some, having obtained and accomplished the irreversible vehicle, the Great Vehicle, abandon it and think to seek the lesser vehicle. Would those bodhisattvas too be wise by nature?"

Subhūti said, "Certainly not, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose a hungry man found a food with a hundred flavors, nourishing, delicious, one that would end hunger and thirst for the rest of his life. He casts it aside and thinks to seek rice of sixty days' keeping, and having found that rice, he casts aside the food of a hundred flavors and thinks to eat the sixty-day rice. Subhūti, what do you think? Would that man be wise by nature?"

Subhūti said, "Certainly not, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said, "In just the same way, Subhūti, in a future time there will be some bodhisattvas who hear this Perfection of Wisdom and obtain it, and yet abandon the Perfection of Wisdom, cast it aside, hold it at a distance, and think to seek sūtras connected with the vehicle of the śrāvakas and the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas,

If they should think to seek omniscience and skillful means in those sūtras that set forth the grounds of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, Subhūti, what do you think? Should those bodhisattvas also be regarded as skilled by nature?

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, they should not."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, this too should be recognized as their work of Māra. Subhūti, it is as if a certain man had found a priceless jewel and thought to put it on a par with a jewel of small value and little worth. Subhūti, what do you think? Should that man be regarded as skilled by nature?"

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, he should not."

The Blessed One said, "In the same way, Subhūti, in the future there will be certain individuals of the Bodhisattva Vehicle who, having heard and found this profound, luminous, precious Perfection of Wisdom, will think to put it on a par with the vehicle of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. They will think to seek omniscience and skillful means from the grounds of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Subhūti, what do you think? Should those bodhisattvas also be regarded as skilled by nature?"

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, they should not."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, this too should be recognized as the work of Māra for those bodhisattvas.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, as they explain, teach, and demonstrate this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and as they hold it, retain it, read it, give transmission of it, recite it from memory, and, while they are still young, inquire into it in

writing, many obstacles will arise that distract the mind. Subhūti, this too should be recognized as the work of Māra for those bodhisattvas."

When this had been said, the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, can the Perfection of Wisdom be written down in letters?"

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, it cannot. Subhūti, there may be those who, having written the Perfection of Wisdom in letters, think that they have written the Perfection of Wisdom, or say that it does not exist, or cling to the Perfection of Wisdom as being in the letters, or think that without letters there is none. Subhūti, this too should be recognized as their work of Māra.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, as they inquire into the Perfection of Wisdom in writing, thoughts about places will arise. Thoughts will arise about villages, towns, market towns, regions, provinces, and royal palaces and courts. Thoughts will arise about parks and pleasure groves. Thoughts will arise about teachers. Thoughts will arise about those who instruct in everything. Thoughts will arise about bandits. Thoughts will arise about predators. Thoughts will arise about Viśikhā. Thoughts will arise about Śivika. Thoughts will arise about prostitutes. Thoughts will arise about happiness, thoughts about suffering, and thoughts about fear. Thoughts will arise about women, thoughts about men, and thoughts about those who are neither. Thoughts will arise about those who are friendly and those who are unfriendly. Thoughts will arise about parents."

Thoughts about brothers and sisters will arise. Thoughts about relatives and friends will arise, and thoughts about companions, kinsfolk, and blood relations. Thoughts about wife, sons, and daughters will arise. Thoughts about house, food, and drink will arise, and thoughts about clothing, about bedding and seats, about the requisites of livelihood, and about immediate tasks. Thoughts of attachment will arise, thoughts of aversion, and thoughts of delusion. Thoughts about the seasons will arise, about auspicious times and inauspicious times. Thoughts about songs, about cymbals, and about dance will arise, and thoughts about poetry, lyrics, and stories. Thoughts about treatises will arise, about worldly conventions, about laughter and jesting, and about flirtation. Thoughts of sorrow will arise, thoughts of the afflictions, and thoughts of the self.

Subhūti, these thoughts and others like them are brought about by the evil Māra, and they will become obstacles and distractions for the bodhisattva, the great being, when he explains this Perfection of Wisdom, teaches it, instructs

others in it, upholds it, retains it, reads it, gives the oral transmission of it, recites it, and even when he questions about it in writing. The bodhisattva, the great being, should recognize these deeds of Māra, and having recognized them, should abandon them.

Furthermore, Subhūti, thoughts about kings will arise, thoughts about princes, about elephants, about horses, about chariots, and about the sight of the amusements of the handed, the sporting entertainers. Subhūti, these too should be recognized as the deeds of Māra for those bodhisattvas, those great beings.

Furthermore, Subhūti, thoughts about fire will arise, thoughts about objects of desire, and thoughts about the abundance of wealth and grain. Subhūti, these too should be recognized by the bodhisattva, the great being, as the deeds of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, while the bodhisattva, the great being, explains this Perfection of Wisdom, teaches it, instructs others in it, gives the oral transmission of it, recites it, and even questions about it in writing, gains, honors, robes, alms food, bedding and seats, medicines for the sick, and other requisites may come to him, but they become an obstacle to him. Then, as he tastes the flavor of gains, honors, and praises in verse, torment may arise in his mind. Subhūti, these too should be recognized by bodhisattvas, great beings, as the deeds of Māra. They should recognize all these deeds of Māra, and having recognized them, they should abandon them.

Furthermore, Subhūti, when bodhisattvas, great beings, explain this Perfection of Wisdom, teach it, instruct others in it, give the oral transmission of it, recite it, and even question about it in writing, the evil Māra may come in the guise of a monk and offer them whatever profound sūtras there are that belong to the level of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. He says: "Train in this. Write this down. Receive the transmission of this. Memorize this. From this, omniscience will be attained." Subhūti, the bodhisattva, the great being, skilled in means, should not take delight in them. Why is that? Subhūti, although it is true that those sūtras do teach emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness,

Moreover, in those sūtras the skillful means of the bodhisattva, the great being, is not taught. Those bodhisattvas who do not clearly know the distinctions within the wisdom of skillful means will think to abandon this profound Perfection of Wisdom. Having abandoned this profound Perfection of

Wisdom, they will think to seek skillful means in sūtras connected with the stages of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Subhūti, this should be recognized by the bodhisattva, the great being, as the work of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose the listeners of the Dharma are keen and wish to take up the Perfection of Wisdom, but the Dharma speaker is lazy and does not wish to teach the Dharma. Subhūti, this lack of harmony should be recognized by the bodhisattva, the great being, as the work of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose the Dharma speaker is not lazy and wishes to give the Perfection of Wisdom, but the listener to the Dharma is lazy and has many tasks to attend to. Subhūti, this lack of harmony should be recognized by the bodhisattva, the great being, as the work of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose the listeners of the Dharma are keen and wish to take up, to hold, to read, to master, and to recite the Perfection of Wisdom, and even wish to write it down, and they are endowed with comprehension, intelligence, and mindfulness. But the Dharma speaker is about to go to another region, or is unable to grasp the text from its very beginning, or elaborates it in a confused way and so does not understand it, or does not clearly know it. Subhūti, for the one who would explain, teach, point out, and give prophecies concerning this Perfection of Wisdom, who would recite it, study it, and even write it down, there will be a lack of harmony. Subhūti, this should be recognized by the bodhisattva, the great being, as the work of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose the Dharma speaker is not lazy and clearly knows the meaning, and wishes to give this Perfection of Wisdom and to have it read. But the listener to the Dharma is about to go to another region, or cannot grasp the text from its very beginning, or elaborates it in a confused way and so does not understand it, or does not clearly know it. Subhūti, this lack of harmony should be recognized by the bodhisattva, the great being, as the work of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose the Dharma speaker is intent on wealth, intent on gain and honor, intent on robes, while the listener to the Dharma has few desires and is content, delights in solitude, and does not wish to give away wealth. Subhūti, for the one who would train in and write out this Perfection of Wisdom, there will be a lack of harmony. Subhūti, this should be recognized by the bodhisattva, the great being, as the work of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose the listener to the Dharma has faith and wishes to hear this Perfection of Wisdom, to fully grasp its meaning, and to give up all

wealth, but the Dharma speaker has no faith, or does not wish to accept wealth, or has few desires, or does not wish to speak. Subhūti, this too, because of the lack of harmony, should be recognized as the work of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose the listener to the Dharma has faith, wishes to listen, and wishes to fully grasp the meaning, but the Dharma speaker has become an obstacle to the Dharma, so that those sūtras are lacking or he does not engage with them. Subhūti, because of this too, the listener to the Dharma, not finding a Dharma speaker, will fall into discord.

Subhūti, if someone has heard this Perfection of Wisdom and is holding it, retaining it, reading it, or writing it down, and he is not provided with a gathering, then this too should be recognized by a bodhisattva, a great being, as the work of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose the Dharma speaker wishes to explain, but the Dharma listeners do not wish to listen. Then, Subhūti, the one who has heard this Perfection of Wisdom and holds it, retains it, reads it, or writes it down is not provided with a gathering. This too should be recognized by a bodhisattva, a great being, as the work of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose the Dharma listeners become very sleepy and their bodies heavy, and, being possessed of that sleepiness and that bodily torpor, they do not wish to listen, while the Dharma speaker does wish to explain. Then, Subhūti, there is no gathering. This should be recognized by a bodhisattva, a great being, as the work of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose the Dharma speaker becomes very sleepy and his body heavy, and, being possessed of that sleepiness and that bodily torpor, he does not wish to explain, while the Dharma listeners do wish to listen. Then, Subhūti, the writing, reading, and full understanding of this text are not provided with a gathering. This too should be recognized by a bodhisattva, a great being, as the work of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose that while the Perfection of Wisdom is being written down, explained, and studied, someone comes there and speaks of the faults of the beings in the hells, speaks of the faults of the animal realm, speaks of the faults of the realm of hungry ghosts, and speaks of the faults of the body of an asura. He says: "The beings in the hells suffer in this way. The animal realm is a place of suffering in this way. The realm of hungry ghosts is a place of suffering in this way. The realm of the asuras is a place of suffering in this way. Conditioned things are suffering in this way. So bring suffering to

its end right here." Then, Subhūti, this should be recognized by a bodhisattva, a great being, as the work of Māra, since it is not provided with a gathering.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose that while the Perfection of Wisdom is being written down, explained, and studied, someone comes there and speaks in praise of the gods. He says: "The gods are happy in this way. The higher realms are happy in this way. In the desire realm one enjoys desires in this way. In the form realm one rests in meditative concentrations in this way. In the formless absorptions one rests in equipoise in this way." And he says: "If everything is examined with wisdom, all birth is suffering. Even the Blessed One said: 'Monks, I do not praise any rebirth, not even one as brief as a fingersnap, as something that can be achieved.' All conditioned things are impermanent. All that has gone into existence is suffering. All that belongs to the three realms is empty. All phenomena are without self. Having recognized all these as unstable, impermanent, suffering, and subject to change, the wise should attain right here the fruit of stream-entry. They should attain the fruit of the once-returner and the fruit of the non-returner, and right here they should fully attain arhatship. Otherwise we may again meet with the ruin of wealth and the decline into those many sufferings." If in this way he makes some bodhisattvas weary and disheartened, then, Subhūti, this too should be recognized by a bodhisattva, a great being, as the work of Māra, since it is not provided with a gathering.

Subhūti, furthermore, there may be a Dharma teacher, a monk, who delights in being alone, while those who listen to the Dharma are devoted to a retinue. And that Dharma teacher may say, "To those who attend on me, I will give this Perfection of Wisdom; to those who do not attend on me, I will not give it." Then those sons and daughters of good family, longing for the Dharma, wishing for it and respecting it, may attend on the Dharma teacher, yet he does not give them the opportunity. The Dharma teacher desires only a small amount of material goods, and even that he is unwilling to give up. Moreover, he will go to wherever there is famine, or lack of success and happiness, or danger to life. When those who listen to the Dharma hear from others that famine has struck that region, that there is no success or happiness there, and that it is also dangerous to life, they should understand it so. Then the Dharma teacher may say to those sons of good family, "Sons of good family, in such and such a region there is the terror of famine. Son of good family, if you go there, you will regret it afterward because of the terror of famine." In this way the Dharma teacher turns them away by subtle means. They too become

disheartened and understand thus: "These are signs of rejection; they are not signs of willingness to give. He does not wish to give this." Knowing this, they do not attend on him. In this way, for one who asks about this Perfection of Wisdom, studies it, teaches it, expounds it, gives its transmission, and recites it, there is a lack of harmony. Subhūti, this too should be recognized as the work of Māra by the bodhisattva, the great being.

Subhūti, furthermore, that Dharma teacher may enter a place where there is the danger of living creatures, or the danger of beasts of prey, or the danger of non-humans; he goes there or stays there. He may go to a wilderness of beasts of prey, a wilderness of poisonous snakes, a wilderness of robbers, a wilderness of water, or a wilderness of famine. And he says to those who listen to the Dharma, "Sons of good family, understand this: I am going to a land where there is danger from living creatures, danger from beasts of prey, danger from flesh-eaters, a wilderness of poisonous snakes, a wilderness of robbers, a wilderness of water, a wilderness of famine. Sons of good family, understand this. Are you able to endure these sufferings?" Saying this, he turns them away by subtle means. Then they too become disheartened. Disheartened, they do not attend on him and turn back. Subhūti, these obstacles will arise for the giving of the transmission of the Perfection of Wisdom, for its recitation, and even for its writing down. Subhūti, this too, because of the lack of harmony, should be recognized as the work of Māra by the bodhisattva, the great being.

Subhūti, furthermore, a Dharma teacher, a monk, may become fixated on the houses of his friends and the houses of those who give alms. Being fixated on the houses of friends and almsgivers, he constantly thinks of going near to look at those houses. Because of his constant looking, he has much to do, and so he abandons those who listen to the Dharma, saying, "For now there is something I must look in on."

If he says, "I have something I must attend to, I have to go," then, Subhūti, he becomes one who lacks the gathering needed for writing out and understanding this Perfection of Wisdom. Subhūti, this too should be recognized by a bodhisattva, a great being, as the work of Māra: a lack of the necessary gathering.

Subhūti, in this way the evil Māra strives by every such means so that no one at all will take up this Perfection of Wisdom, or hold it, or read it, or fully comprehend it, or recite it thoroughly, or teach it, or explain it, or give

transmission of it, or learn it by heart, or write it down, or have it written. Therefore, Subhūti, whatever obstacles there are, whatever causes a lack of the necessary gathering, a bodhisattva, a great being, should recognize all of them as the work of Māra, and having recognized them, should abandon them.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, for what reason does the evil Māra strive so hard, and apply every means, so that no one at all will take up this Perfection of Wisdom, or hold it, or read it, or fully comprehend it, or recite it thoroughly, or teach it, or explain it, or give transmission of it, or learn it by heart, or write it down, or have it written?

When he had said this, the Blessed One said this to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, the omniscience of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is born from the Perfection of Wisdom. The teaching of the Tathāgatas arises from omniscience. And from the teaching of the Tathāgatas comes the abandoning of afflictions by immeasurable, countless, inconceivable beings. For one who has abandoned the afflictions, the evil Māra finds no opening. Finding none, his mind is tormented by suffering, he is unhappy, and the dart of sorrow pierces him to the heart.

For this reason he takes great displeasure in anyone writing out, fully comprehending, or studying the Perfection of Wisdom, and he exerts himself with great effort and vigor, applying every means, so that no one at all will write out, fully comprehend, or study this Perfection of Wisdom.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the evil Māra will come in the guise of a renunciant and cause division. Subhūti, he will separate in this way those sons of good family who are newly set out in the Great Vehicle as bodhisattvas, who are of small intelligence, weak intelligence, inferior intelligence, who are dull, and who have not been given a prediction of unsurpassed, perfect awakening. He says: "Venerable one, what you hear is not the Perfection of Wisdom. Rather, only what is included within my sūtras, only what belongs among my sūtras, is the Perfection of Wisdom." Subhūti, in this way the evil Māra makes them doubt, and causes them to abandon it.

Subhūti, in just this way the evil Māra, coming in the guise of a renunciant and creating division, makes doubt arise in bodhisattvas who are newly set out in the Great Vehicle, who are of small, weak, and inferior intelligence, who are dull, and who have not been given a prediction of unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

Being thrown into doubt, they will not take up this Perfection of Wisdom, will not hold it, will not read it, will not fully understand it, will not recite it, will not teach it or explain it to others, will not give instruction in it, will not memorize it, will not copy it, and will not have it copied. Subhūti, this too should be recognized by a bodhisattva, a great being, as the work of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the evil Māra may take the form of a monk and come in the guise of a buddha. Concerning a bodhisattva who practices the profound teachings, he will say: "This one is realizing the true limit, and so he will become a śrāvaka and will not become a bodhisattva." And he will give an example, saying: "A bodhisattva is just like this." In this way he brings about the work of Māra. Subhūti, this too should be recognized by a bodhisattva, a great being, as the work of Māra.

Subhūti, in this way, as people copy, fully understand, and study this Perfection of Wisdom, the evil Māra will bring about many further works of Māra, one after another. A bodhisattva, a great being, should recognize these, and having recognized them, should abandon them completely and should not rely on them. Rather, he should undertake diligence and should be endowed with mindfulness and vigilance.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said to him: "So it is, Blessed One. So it is, Sugata. Blessed One, those who possess great and precious jewels have many enemies. Why is that? Blessed One, it is because such jewels are hard to find and very precious. They are treasures, and therefore those who hold them come to have many enemies. In just the same way, Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom too will for the most part meet with many obstacles.

"Blessed One, under the power of these obstacles some will become lazy. And those bodhisattvas who think of not taking up this Perfection of Wisdom, of not holding it, not reading it, not fully understanding it, not reciting it, not teaching it, not explaining it, not giving instruction in it, not memorizing it, not copying it, and who think of not even having it copied in small part, should be known as those whom Māra has empowered. Blessed One, they are newly set out in the Vehicle. They are of small intellect, of inferior intellect, of weak intellect. Blessed One, their intellects are inverted, and their minds do not enter the vast and extensive teachings. This too should be recognized."

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: "So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Those bodhisattvas who think of not taking up this

Perfection of Wisdom, of not holding it, not reading it, not fully understanding it, not reciting it, not teaching it, not explaining it, not giving instruction in it, not memorizing it, not copying it, and who think of not even having it copied in small part, should be recognized, Subhūti, as those whom Māra has empowered. Subhūti, those bodhisattvas are newly set out in the Vehicle. They are of small intellect. They are of inferior intellect. They are of weak intellect."

Subhūti, these bodhisattvas are those whose minds are inverted, and in that way they will not turn their minds to the vast and great phenomena of the Dharma.

Subhūti, in this way too the works of Māra will arise, and many faults of Māra and many obstructions will appear. Yet even so, Subhūti, when any of them think of upholding this Perfection of Wisdom, of bearing it in mind, reading it, mastering it, reciting it, teaching it, expounding it, giving its transmission, memorizing it, writing it down, or, even if they are of lesser capacity, think of having it written down, then, Subhūti, it should be understood that this is through the power of the buddhas, through the blessing of the buddhas, and through being held by the buddhas, that they uphold it, bear it in mind, read it, master it, recite it, teach it, expound it, give its transmission, memorize it, write it down, or cause it to be written down. Why is that? Because the evil Māra makes great effort to create obstacles here, and the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, in holding it, also make great effort.

This is the eleventh chapter, called "The Works of Māra," from the noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines, the twelfth volume.

Then the Blessed One again spoke to the venerable Subhūti. Subhūti, suppose, for example, that a certain woman has many sons, five, or ten, or twenty, or thirty, or forty, or fifty, or a hundred, or a thousand, or a hundred thousand. If their mother should fall ill, they would all strive and exert themselves, thinking: "May our mother by no means come to any danger to her life. May our mother live a long life. May our mother's body by no means become unwell. May our mother remain for a long time. May our mother by no means become weakened. May no painful feeling arise in our mother. May nothing here be unknown to her, and may nothing disagreeable arise in her body." Why is that? Because they think: "She bore us. She did the hard work of giving us life. She showed us the world." So, so that no painful feeling or painful

contact at all should arise in her, those sons carefully take hold of the mother by every means of bringing her comfort, carefully guard her, and carefully tend her. They think: "May no wind, bile, phlegm, or combination of the humors, no bee, no gadfly, no snake, no human or non-human being, no falling thing, no calamity, no sudden misfortune, nothing undesired, arise in her body." In this way those sons, reflecting on their mother, tend her and protect her, and make her their own, by every means of bringing her comfort, saying: "She is our mother who bore us, who rejoiced in doing so. She is the one who gave us life and showed us the world."

Subhūti, in the same way the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, also have this Perfection of Wisdom in mind. All those who write it down, uphold it, bear it in mind, read it, master it, recite it, teach it, expound it, give its transmission, and memorize it, all of them, too, come about through the power, the blessing, and the intention of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas.

In other world systems, whatever Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas there may be who are presently living and sustained for the benefit of many beings, for the happiness of many beings, out of compassion for the world, for the sake, benefit, and happiness of the great multitude of beings, and out of compassion for gods, humans, and all sentient beings, all of them, too, hold this very Perfection of Wisdom in mind. Through their power they see to it that this Perfection of Wisdom will endure for a long time, that the name of this Perfection of Wisdom will not perish, and that no evil Māra, nor any gods of Māra's host, will become an obstacle to those who expound it, write it down, or study it.

Subhūti, in this way the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas also care for this Perfection of Wisdom, make it their own, and guard it. Why is that? Because this is the mother of the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas; it gives them birth, it shows omniscience, it shows it throughout the world.

Subhūti, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas are born from this. Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom gives rise to the wisdom of omniscience in the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas, and shows it. In this way it shows it throughout this world. Subhūti, the omniscience of the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas is born from this.

Subhūti, in past times, all the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas who fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening did so by relying on this very Perfection of Wisdom. In future times, all the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas who will arise and attain complete buddhahood in unsurpassed, perfect awakening will do so by relying on this very Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti, at the present time, in the immeasurable and innumerable world systems of the ten directions, there are Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas who live and are sustained for the benefit of many beings, for the happiness of many beings, out of compassion for the world, for the sake, benefit, and happiness of the great multitude of beings, and out of compassion for gods, humans, and all sentient beings. All of them, too, have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening by relying on this very Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti, I too, the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly awakened buddha, have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening by relying on this very Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti, in this way the Perfection of Wisdom gives rise to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, and thus it is what shows the world.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, you have said that the Perfection of Wisdom shows the world to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas. Blessed One, how does the Perfection of Wisdom show the world to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas? Blessed One, what is it that the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, has spoken of as the world?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows: "Subhūti, the Tathāgata has spoken of the five aggregates as the world. Which five? They are form, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness. Subhūti, these five aggregates are what the Tathāgata has called the world."

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, how does the Perfection of Wisdom teach the five aggregates to the Tathāgata? Blessed One, what does the Perfection of Wisdom teach?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows: "Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom teaches the Tathāgatas that the

five aggregates are the world because they are indestructible and utterly indestructible."

"Why is it taught that they are indestructible and utterly indestructible? Subhūti, because the five aggregates have no intrinsic nature, their intrinsic nature is emptiness. Subhūti, emptiness is neither destroyed nor utterly destroyed. Thus, Subhūti, this Perfection of Wisdom shows this world to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas.

"Subhūti, the signless, the wishless, the unconditioned, the unarisen, the nonexistent, and the dharmadhātu are indestructible and utterly indestructible. Thus, Subhūti, this Perfection of Wisdom shows this world to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata fully knows, correctly and just as it is, that sentient beings are immeasurable and sentient beings are innumerable.

"Subhūti, how is it that, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata fully knows, correctly and just as it is, that sentient beings are immeasurable and sentient beings are innumerable? Subhūti, because sentient beings have no intrinsic nature, the Tathāgata fully knows, correctly and just as it is, that sentient beings are immeasurable and innumerable. Thus, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata fully knows, correctly and just as it is, the immeasurable and innumerable sentient beings.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, because sentient beings are without any real entity, the Tathāgata also fully knows the workings of the minds of those immeasurable and innumerable sentient beings. Thus, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata fully knows, correctly and just as it is, the immeasurable and innumerable workings of the minds of immeasurable and innumerable sentient beings."

Subhūti, in this way the Perfection of Wisdom reveals this world to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas.

Furthermore, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is, "These are the minds of immeasurable, innumerable sentient beings, and these minds are contracted." How, Subhūti, does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know exactly as it is that the contracted minds of immeasurable, innumerable sentient beings are contracted? He knows exactly as it is that the contracted mind, together with

its contraction, is exhausted, and that even its exhaustion is inexhaustible. In this way, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is that the contracted minds of immeasurable beings are contracted.

Furthermore, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is, "These are the minds of immeasurable beings, and these minds are distracted." How, Subhūti, does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know exactly as it is that the distracted minds of immeasurable beings are distracted? Subhūti, in the nature of reality those minds that are distracted have no defining characteristic. Those minds are inexhaustible and utterly inexhaustible; they are not distracted. The Tathāgata knows those minds exactly as they are. In this way, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is that the distracted minds of immeasurable beings are distracted.

Furthermore, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is, "These are the minds of immeasurable, innumerable sentient beings, and in these immeasurable and inexhaustible minds, the mind is immeasurable and inexhaustible." How, Subhūti, does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know exactly as it is that, in the immeasurable and inexhaustible minds of immeasurable, innumerable sentient beings, the mind is immeasurable and inexhaustible? Subhūti, because the mind is immeasurable and inexhaustible like space, one who knows exactly as it is that the mind is immeasurable and inexhaustible has a mind that is blessed by the Tathāgata. It is without cessation, without arising, without abiding, without support, immeasurable, and inexhaustible. In this way, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is that, in the immeasurable and inexhaustible minds of immeasurable, innumerable sentient beings, the mind is immeasurable and inexhaustible.

Furthermore, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is, "These are the minds of immeasurable beings, and these minds are afflicted." How, Subhūti, does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know exactly as it is that the afflicted minds of immeasurable beings are afflicted?

Subhūti, those minds are not afflicted by affliction, and there is no designation for them. In just this way, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows as it truly is, "The afflicted minds of immeasurable beings are

afflicted minds."

Furthermore, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows as it truly is, "The unafflicted minds of immeasurable beings are unafflicted minds."

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know as it truly is that the unafflicted minds of immeasurable beings are unafflicted minds? Subhūti, those minds are luminous by their intrinsic nature. In just this way, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows as it truly is, "The unafflicted minds of immeasurable beings are unafflicted minds."

Furthermore, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows as it truly is, "The abiding minds of immeasurable beings are abiding minds."

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know as it truly is that the abiding minds of immeasurable beings are abiding minds? Subhūti, those minds abide in what has no ground. In just this way, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows as it truly is, "The abiding minds of immeasurable beings are abiding minds."

Furthermore, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows as it truly is, "The grasping minds of immeasurable beings are grasping minds."

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know as it truly is that the grasping minds of immeasurable beings are grasping minds? Subhūti, those minds are not grasped, and they are not something that is to be grasped. In just this way, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows as it truly is, "The grasping minds of immeasurable beings are grasping minds."

Furthermore, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows as it truly is, "The minds with defilement of immeasurable beings are minds with defilement."

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know as it truly is that the minds with defilement of immeasurable beings are minds with defilement? Subhūti, those minds have no essential nature and are like what does not exist.

Subhūti, in this way, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows, exactly as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are

with outflows are minds with outflows.

Furthermore, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows, exactly as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are without outflows are minds without outflows.

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know, exactly as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are without outflows are minds without outflows? Subhūti, those minds are inclined toward the absence of real entities, and this is spontaneously accomplished. Subhūti, in this way, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows, exactly as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are without outflows are minds without outflows.

Furthermore, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows, exactly as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are with attachment are minds with attachment.

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know, exactly as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are with attachment are minds with attachment? Subhūti, the attachment that a mind has is not the true suchness of the mind. And the true suchness of the mind is not a mind with attachment. Subhūti, in this way, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows, exactly as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are with attachment are minds with attachment.

Furthermore, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows, exactly as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are free of attachment are minds free of attachment.

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know, exactly as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are free of attachment are minds free of attachment? Subhūti, the freedom of the mind is not itself a mind with attachment. And the true suchness of the mind that is free of attachment is not a mind with attachment. Subhūti, in this way, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows, exactly as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are free of attachment are minds free of attachment.

Furthermore, Subhūti, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, the Tathāgata knows, exactly as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are with aversion are minds with aversion.

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know, exactly as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are with aversion are minds with aversion?

Subhūti, the mind that has aversion is not the very suchness of mind. And the very suchness of mind is not a mind that has aversion. Subhūti, it is thus that the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows exactly as it is, in accordance with reality, that the minds of immeasurable beings who have aversion are minds that have aversion.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows exactly as it is, in accordance with reality, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are free of aversion are minds that are free of aversion.

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know exactly as it is, in accordance with reality, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are free of aversion are minds that are free of aversion? Subhūti, the freedom of the mind is not a state of having aversion. And the very suchness of the mind that is free of aversion is not a mind that has aversion. Subhūti, it is thus that the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows exactly as it is, in accordance with reality, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are free of aversion are minds that are free of aversion.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows exactly as it is, in accordance with reality, that the minds of immeasurable beings who have delusion are minds that have delusion.

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know exactly as it is, in accordance with reality, that the minds of immeasurable beings who have delusion are minds that have delusion? Subhūti, the mind that has delusion is not the very suchness of mind. And the very suchness of mind is not a mind that has delusion. Subhūti, it is thus that the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows exactly as it is, in accordance with reality, that the minds of immeasurable beings who have delusion are minds that have delusion.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows exactly as it is, in accordance with reality, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are free of delusion are minds that are free of delusion.

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know exactly as it is, in accordance with reality, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are free of delusion are minds that are free of delusion? Subhūti, the freedom of the mind is not a state of having delusion. And the very suchness of the mind that is free of delusion is not a mind that has delusion. Subhūti, it is thus that the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows exactly as it is, in accordance with reality, that the minds of immeasurable beings who are free of delusion are minds that are free of delusion.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows exactly as it is, in accordance with reality, that the minds of immeasurable beings whose minds are not expansive are minds that are not expansive.

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, know in accordance with reality, as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable sentient beings that are not vast are not vast? Subhūti, those minds are without the arising of motivation; they are included within the absence of motivation. Subhūti, in just this way the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, knows in accordance with reality, as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable sentient beings that are not vast are not vast.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, knows in accordance with reality, as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable sentient beings that are vast are vast. Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, know in accordance with reality, as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable sentient beings that are vast are vast? Subhūti, those minds do not diminish and do not increase, and because minds are never separated from their nature, those minds are not separated at all. Subhūti, in just this way the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, knows in accordance with reality, as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable sentient beings that are vast are vast.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, knows in accordance with reality, as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable sentient beings that have not become exalted are not exalted. Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, know in accordance with reality, as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable sentient beings that have not become exalted are not exalted? Subhūti, those minds are nothing

other than being without coming and without going. Subhūti, in just this way the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, knows in accordance with reality, as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable sentient beings that have not become exalted are not exalted.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, knows in accordance with reality, as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable sentient beings that have become exalted are exalted. Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, know in accordance with reality, as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable sentient beings that have become exalted are exalted? Subhūti, those minds are equal through equality; they are equal by their very nature. Subhūti, in just this way the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, knows in accordance with reality, as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable sentient beings that have become exalted are exalted.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, knows in accordance with reality, as it truly is, that the minds of immeasurable sentient beings that are measureless are measureless.

Subhūti, how is it that the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows correctly, exactly as it is, that the immeasurable minds of immeasurable beings are immeasurable minds? Subhūti, those minds are immeasurable minds because they have no support. In just this way, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows correctly, exactly as it is, that the immeasurable minds of immeasurable beings are immeasurable minds.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows correctly, exactly as it is, that the minds of immeasurable beings that can be shown are minds that can be shown. Subhūti, how is it that the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows correctly, exactly as it is, that the minds of immeasurable beings that can be shown are minds that can be shown? Subhūti, those minds are shown to be equal to the essential nature of mind. In just this way, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows correctly, exactly as it is, that the minds of immeasurable beings that can be shown are minds that can be shown.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows correctly, exactly as it is, that the minds of immeasurable beings that cannot be shown are minds that cannot be shown. Subhūti, how is it that the

Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows correctly, exactly as it is, that the minds of immeasurable beings that cannot be shown are minds that cannot be shown? Subhūti, because it has no defining characteristic and is empty of any real object, that mind does not appear; it does not become manifest to the three eyes, nor to any of them. In just this way, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows correctly, exactly as it is, that the minds of immeasurable beings that cannot be shown are minds that cannot be shown.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows correctly, exactly as it is, that the minds of immeasurable beings that have obstruction are minds that have obstruction. Subhūti, how is it that the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows correctly, exactly as it is, that the minds of immeasurable beings that have obstruction are minds that have obstruction? Subhūti, those minds are imputed onto what does not exist; they are empty, and come within the range of what is apprehended. In just this way, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows correctly, exactly as it is, that the minds of immeasurable beings that have obstruction are minds that have obstruction.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows correctly, exactly as it is, that the minds of immeasurable beings that are without obstruction are minds that are without obstruction. Subhūti, how is it that the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows correctly, exactly as it is, that the minds of immeasurable beings that are without obstruction are minds that are without obstruction? Subhūti, in just this way the Tathāgata knows it correctly, exactly as it is.

Subhūti, those minds have become non-dual; they have not arisen, and yet they have fully arisen. Subhūti, in this way the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows perfectly and exactly as it is that the unobstructed minds of immeasurable sentient beings are unobstructed minds.

Subhūti, furthermore, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows perfectly and exactly as it is that the surpassable minds of immeasurable sentient beings are surpassable minds. Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know perfectly and exactly as it is that the surpassable minds of immeasurable sentient beings are surpassable minds? Subhūti, whatever the surpassable mind is, exactly as it is, regarding that there is no conceit.

Subhūti, furthermore, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows perfectly and exactly as it is that the surpassable minds of immeasurable sentient beings are surpassable minds.

Subhūti, furthermore, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows perfectly and exactly as it is that the unsurpassable minds of immeasurable sentient beings are unsurpassable minds. Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know perfectly and exactly as it is that the unsurpassable minds of immeasurable sentient beings are unsurpassable minds? Subhūti, those minds are free of conceptual elaboration, because not even a subtle particle of mind is apprehended. Subhūti, in this way the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows perfectly and exactly as it is that the unsurpassable minds of immeasurable sentient beings are unsurpassable minds.

Subhūti, furthermore, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows perfectly and exactly as it is that the unconcentrated minds of immeasurable sentient beings are unconcentrated minds. Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know perfectly and exactly as it is that the unconcentrated minds of immeasurable sentient beings are unconcentrated minds? Subhūti, those minds engage in the unequal through the equal and the equal through the unequal, and in that way the mind is unconcentrated. Subhūti, in this way the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows perfectly and exactly as it is that the unconcentrated minds of immeasurable sentient beings are unconcentrated minds.

Subhūti, furthermore, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows perfectly and exactly as it is that the concentrated minds of immeasurable sentient beings are concentrated minds. Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know perfectly and exactly as it is that the concentrated minds of immeasurable sentient beings are concentrated minds? Subhūti, those minds engage the equal through the equal, and those minds that are concentrated in this way are like space. Subhūti, in this way the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows perfectly and exactly as it is that the concentrated minds of immeasurable sentient beings are concentrated minds.

Subhūti, furthermore, relying on this perfection of wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is, in the right way, the unliberated minds of immeasurable

beings: "These are unliberated minds."

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, know exactly as it is, in the right way, the unliberated minds of immeasurable beings: "These are unliberated minds"? Subhūti, those minds are by their intrinsic nature already liberated; their nature is to have no inherent identity. Thus, Subhūti, relying on this perfection of wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is, in the right way, the unliberated minds of immeasurable beings: "These are unliberated minds."

Subhūti, furthermore, relying on this perfection of wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is, in the right way, the liberated minds of immeasurable beings: "These are liberated minds."

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, know exactly as it is, in the right way, the liberated minds of immeasurable beings: "These are liberated minds"? Subhūti, it is because mind does not exist. The Tathāgata does not apprehend mind as past, and does not apprehend it as future or as arisen in the present. Thus, Subhūti, relying on this perfection of wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is, in the right way, the liberated minds of immeasurable beings: "These are liberated minds."

Subhūti, furthermore, relying on this perfection of wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is, in the right way, the unseeable minds of immeasurable beings: "These are unseeable minds."

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, know exactly as it is, in the right way, the unseeable minds of immeasurable beings: "These are unseeable minds"? Subhūti, because it does not exist, mind is thus nonexistent; because it has not arisen, it is not something to be cognized; and because it is not truly established, it cannot be grasped even by the eye of wisdom or the divine eye. Since it does not appear at all, how much less could it be seen by the eye of flesh! Thus, Subhūti, relying on this perfection of wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is, in the right way, the unseeable minds of immeasurable beings: "These are unseeable minds."

Subhūti, in this way the perfection of wisdom reveals this world to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas.

Subhūti, furthermore, relying on this perfection of wisdom, the Tathāgata knows exactly as it is, in the right way, the open and the closed in other sentient beings and other persons, immeasurable and innumerable: "These

are open, and these are closed."

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, know exactly as it is, in the right way, the open and the closed in other sentient beings and other persons, immeasurable and innumerable: "These are open, and these are closed"? Subhūti, he knows exactly as it is, in the right way, that all those beings arise by abiding in form.

Subhūti, in the same way, the Tathāgata knows, exactly as it is, that all those beings arise by resting upon feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness.

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata come to know that those who are of open mind and those who are of closed mind rest upon form? And likewise, how does he come to know that those who are of open mind and those who are of closed mind rest upon feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness?

The view "One who has gone thus will exist after death" depends upon form. The view "One who has gone thus will not exist after death" depends upon form. The view "One who has gone thus will both exist and not exist after death" depends upon form. The view "One who has gone thus will neither exist nor not exist after death" depends upon form.

In the same way, for feeling, perception, and formations, and likewise for consciousness: the view "One who has gone thus will exist after death" depends upon consciousness. The view "One who has gone thus will not exist after death" depends upon consciousness. The view "One who has gone thus will both exist and not exist after death" depends upon consciousness. The view "One who has gone thus will neither exist nor not exist after death" depends upon consciousness.

The claim "The self and the world are permanent; this alone is true, anything else is delusion" depends upon form. The claim "The self and the world are impermanent; this alone is true, anything else is delusion" depends upon form. The claim "The self and the world are both permanent and impermanent; this alone is true, anything else is delusion" depends upon form. The claim "The self and the world are neither permanent nor impermanent; this alone is true, anything else is delusion" depends upon form.

In the same way, for feeling, perception, and formations: the claim "The self and the world are permanent; this alone is true, anything else is delusion" depends upon consciousness. The claim "The self and the world are

impermanent; this alone is true, anything else is delusion" depends upon consciousness. The claim "The self and the world are both permanent and impermanent; this alone is true, anything else is delusion" depends upon consciousness. The claim "The self and the world are neither permanent nor impermanent; this alone is true, anything else is delusion" depends upon consciousness.

Here ends the twelfth fascicle of the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines. Now begins the thirteenth fascicle.

The claim "The self and the world have an end; this alone is true, anything else is delusion" depends upon form. The claim "The self and the world are endless; this alone is true, anything else is delusion" depends upon form. The claim "The self and the world both have an end and are endless; this alone is true, anything else is delusion" depends upon form. The claim "The self and the world neither have an end nor are endless; this alone is true, anything else is delusion" depends upon form.

In the same way, for feeling, perception, and formations: the claim "The self and the world have an end; this alone is true, anything else is delusion" depends upon consciousness.

"The self and the world have no end": this very view holds that this alone is true and anything else is delusion, and it rests on consciousness. "The self and the world both have an end and have no end": this very view holds that this alone is true and anything else is delusion, and it rests on consciousness. "The self and the world neither have an end nor are without an end": this very view holds that this alone is true and anything else is delusion, and it rests on consciousness.

"The life force is the same as the body": this very view holds that this alone is true and anything else is delusion, and it rests on form. "The life force is one thing and the body another": this very view holds that this alone is true and anything else is delusion, and it rests on form. In the same way, for feeling, perception, and formations, and likewise for consciousness: "The life force is the same as the body": this very view holds that this alone is true and anything else is delusion, and it rests on consciousness. "The life force is one thing and the body another": this very view holds that this alone is true and anything else is delusion, and it rests on consciousness.

Subhūti, in this way the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, has fully known that the open and the

closed minds of immeasurable, innumerable other sentient beings and other persons rest on form. In the same way he has fully known that those open and closed minds rest on feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows precisely, just as they really are, the open and the closed minds of immeasurable, innumerable other sentient beings and other persons.

Subhūti, how does the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, know precisely, just as they really are, the open and the closed minds of immeasurable, innumerable other sentient beings and other persons? Subhūti, here the Tathāgata knows form. And how, Subhūti, does the Tathāgata know form? Subhūti, the Tathāgata knows form exactly according to its suchness. In this way, Subhūti, the Tathāgata knows form. The same applies to feeling, perception, and formations. Here, Subhūti, the Tathāgata knows consciousness. And how does the Tathāgata know consciousness? Subhūti, the Tathāgata knows consciousness exactly according to its suchness. In this way, Subhūti, the Tathāgata knows consciousness.

Subhūti, in this way the Tathāgata, relying on this Perfection of Wisdom, knows precisely, just as they really are, the open and the closed minds of immeasurable, innumerable other sentient beings and other persons.

Subhūti, thus the Tathāgata designates, within suchness, the suchness of the Tathāgata, the suchness of the aggregates, and the suchness of the open and the closed minds. Subhūti, the suchness of the aggregates is also the suchness of the world. Why is that? Subhūti, the Tathāgata has given the name "world" to the five aggregates. Therefore, Subhūti, the suchness of the aggregates is the suchness of the world. The suchness of the world is the suchness of all phenomena. The suchness of all phenomena is the suchness of the fruit of stream-entry.

The suchness of the fruit of stream-entry is the suchness of the fruit of the once-returner. The suchness of the fruit of the once-returner is the suchness of the fruit of the non-returner. The suchness of the fruit of the non-returner is the suchness of the fruit of the arhat. The suchness of the fruit of the arhat is the suchness of the pratyekabuddha. The suchness of the pratyekabuddha is the suchness of the Tathāgata. Subhūti, in this way, the suchness of the Tathāgata, the suchness of the aggregates, the suchness of all phenomena, and the suchness of all the noble ones, the hearers and the solitary buddhas, are this one suchness, free from the many entities and non-entities. This is

because it is not one, because it is not different, because it is inexhaustible, because it is unchanging, because it is non-dual, and because it cannot be made dual.

Subhūti, it is in this way that the Tathāgata, relying on this perfection of wisdom, fully and perfectly awakened to this suchness. Subhūti, in this way this perfection of wisdom reveals this world to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas. Subhūti, the Tathāgata reveals the world to this world as it truly is, and in this way the whole of this world has been revealed. Subhūti, in this way the perfection of wisdom is the mother of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, their begetter and the one who brings them forth. Subhūti, having fully and perfectly awakened to suchness, the Tathāgata knows the suchness of the world. He knows the unmistakable suchness. He knows the suchness that is not otherwise. Subhūti, because the Tathāgata has fully and perfectly awakened to suchness, he is called the Tathāgata.

The elder Subhūti said: Blessed One, suchness is profound. Blessed One, it is from this suchness that the awakening of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is distinguished and fully revealed. Blessed One, who else would have faith in this? Only irreversible bodhisattvas, great beings, or arhats whose examination is complete, or persons endowed with perfect view. Blessed One, the Tathāgata fully and perfectly awakened to such supremely profound matters as these, and then taught them.

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti thus: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. The Tathāgata fully and perfectly awakened to these supremely profound matters, and then explained them. Subhūti, the suchness to which the Tathāgata fully and perfectly awakened is inexhaustible. Having fully and perfectly awakened, he taught the inexhaustible as the inexhaustible.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), and the other sons of the gods who move in the desire realm, together with two hundred thousand sons of the gods of the Brahmā class, went to where the Blessed One was. Having come, they bowed their heads to the feet of the Blessed One and sat to one side. Seated to one side, those sons of the gods who move in the desire realm and in the form realm spoke to the Blessed One thus: Blessed One, when you teach profound phenomena, how, Blessed One, do you establish their defining characteristic?

The Blessed One declared: Sons of the gods, the defining characteristic is established as emptiness.

Sons of the gods, it is the signless. It is the wishless. In this way the defining characteristic is established. Sons of the gods, it is the unborn. It is the unceasing. It is without thorough affliction. It is without purification. It is without entities. It is nirvāṇa; it is the dharmadhātu; it is suchness. In this way the defining characteristic is established.

Why is this so? Sons of the gods, these characteristics are non-abiding; these characteristics are like space. Sons of the gods, these characteristics were not established by the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha. These characteristics are not counted as form. They are not counted as feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness. These characteristics do not depend on form. They do not depend on feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness. These characteristics were not established by gods, humans, or non-humans. These characteristics cannot be shaken by the world with its gods, humans, and asuras. Why is this so? Because the world with its gods, humans, and asuras is itself nothing but these very characteristics. These characteristics were not set down by anyone's hand.

Sons of the gods, if someone were to say, "Who established this space?", sons of the gods, would that person be speaking truthfully?

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, those sons of the gods who dwell in the desire realm and the form realm said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, space was established by no one. Why is that? Blessed One, space is unconditioned, and so space was established by no one."

Then the Blessed One said to those sons of the gods who dwell in the desire realm and the form realm: "Sons of the gods, so it is, so it is. Whether tathāgatas appear or tathāgatas do not appear, these characteristics abide just so. Why is that? Just as these abide, so the Tathāgata has fully awakened to them in perfect buddhahood and has taught them. Therefore, sons of the gods, the Tathāgata is called the Tathāgata."

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the Tathāgata has fully awakened in perfect buddhahood to these profound characteristics. That is to say, the Perfection of Wisdom is the unattached wisdom of the tathāgatas. Because it is unattached wisdom, the Perfection of Wisdom is the domain of the Tathāgata."

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: "Subhūti, so it is, so it is. Subhūti, in just this way, this Perfection of Wisdom truly reveals this world to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha. Subhūti, just as the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas rely upon and abide in this Dharma of the Perfection of Wisdom, so, because they do not abide in those phenomena, they abide constantly. And just as they are, so the Tathāgata has fully awakened in perfect buddhahood. Therefore they rely upon and abide in the Dharma alone. They honor the Dharma. They hold it as their teacher. They esteem it. They make offerings to it. They paint it in images. They serve and revere it. Subhūti, this Perfection of Wisdom is the very nature of all phenomena.

For this reason the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, show reverence to the Perfection of Wisdom, hold it as their teacher, honor it, make offerings to it, paint its image, and attend upon it. Why is that? Subhūti, it is from this Perfection of Wisdom that the omniscience of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, is brought forth and made distinct. The Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, are those who know what has been done for them and who feel gratitude for what has been done.

Subhūti, if anyone says, "The Tathāgata knows what has been done for him and feels gratitude for what has been done," that person speaks truly. If one says, "He knows what has been done for him and feels gratitude for what has been done," one speaks in accord with what is true.

Subhūti, in what way is the Tathāgata one who knows what has been done for him and feels gratitude for it? Subhūti, whatever vehicles the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, has gone by, and whatever practices he has relied on, by which he fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, those very vehicles and those very practices are what he knows and feels gratitude for, and for that very reason the Tathāgata upholds and protects them. Subhūti, this is to be understood as the Tathāgata's knowing what has been done for him and feeling gratitude for it.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the Tathāgata has fully awakened to the fact that all phenomena are unmade, that is, unmade. He has fully awakened to the fact that they are unchanging, that is, unchanging. He has fully awakened to the fact that they are not constructed by any conditioning activity, that is, not constructed by any conditioning activity. Subhūti, this too is to be understood

as the Tathāgata's knowing what has been done for him and feeling gratitude for it.

Subhūti, relying on the Perfection of Wisdom, the wisdom of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, enters into all phenomena. Subhūti, by this way of explaining as well, the Perfection of Wisdom is that which truly reveals this world to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said to him: Blessed One, when all phenomena are without a knower and without a seer, then, Blessed One, in what way does the Perfection of Wisdom truly reveal this world to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas?

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, it is excellent, truly excellent, that you should put such a question to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, and that you should reflect on it in this way. Subhūti, when you say that all phenomena are without a knower and without a seer, then, Subhūti, it is just so, it is just so. All phenomena are without a knower and without a seer.

Subhūti, in what way are all phenomena without a knower and without a seer? Subhūti, all phenomena are empty. Subhūti, all phenomena are without abiding. In this way, Subhūti, all phenomena are without a knower and without a seer. In this way, Subhūti, it is by relying on the Perfection of Wisdom that the Tathāgata has fully awakened to all these phenomena.

Subhūti, in this way too, the Perfection of Wisdom truly shows this world to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas. It shows it truly because they do not see form, and do not see feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness. Thus, Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom truly shows this world to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas.

Subhūti asked, "Blessed One, how is it that form is not seen? How is it that feeling, perception, and formations are not seen? Blessed One, how is it that consciousness is not seen?"

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, if no consciousness arises that takes form as its object, then in that way form is not seen. In the same way, if no consciousness arises that takes feeling, perception, and formations as its object, then they are not seen. Subhūti, if one does not give rise to a mind that takes consciousness as its object, then in that way consciousness is not seen.

Subhūti, the non-seeing of form, the non-seeing of feeling, perception, and formations, and the non-seeing of consciousness: in this way the Tathāgata sees the world. Thus, Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom truly shows this world to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas.

"Subhūti, and how does the Perfection of Wisdom truly show the world? In this way: the world is empty. In this way the world is expressed. In this way the Tathāgata makes the world known. In this way he causes the world to be seen. In this way the world is inconceivable, in this way the world is peaceful, in this way the world is secluded, in this way the world is utterly pure. So the world is spoken of, so it is made known, and so he causes the world to be seen."

This is the twelfth chapter, called "Truly Showing the World," from the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines of the Noble One.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom is profound. Blessed One, how marvelous! This Perfection of Wisdom abides as a great deed. Blessed One, how marvelous! This Perfection of Wisdom abides as an inconceivable deed, an unequalled deed, an immeasurable deed, an innumerable deed, and a deed equal to the unequalled."

The Blessed One said, "So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Subhūti, this Perfection of Wisdom abides as a great deed. Subhūti, this Perfection of Wisdom abides as an inconceivable deed, an unequalled deed, an immeasurable deed, an innumerable deed, and a deed equal to the unequalled.

"Subhūti, how does this Perfection of Wisdom abide as an inconceivable deed? Subhūti, the state of being a Tathāgata, the state of being a buddha, the state of being self-arisen, the state of being omniscient, are inconceivable. Subhūti, in this way this Perfection of Wisdom abides as an inconceivable deed, and it cannot be conceived by the mind. Why is that? Because mind, mental activity, and mental factors do not enter into it.

"Subhūti, how does this Perfection of Wisdom abide as an unequalled deed?"

Subhūti, the Tathāgata's state of being a tathāgata, his buddhahood, his self-arisen nature, and his omniscience cannot be thought of or matched. In this way, Subhūti, this perfection of wisdom abides through an activity that has no equal.

Subhūti, how does this perfection of wisdom abide through an activity that is immeasurable? Subhūti, the state of being a tathāgata, buddhahood, the

self-arisen nature, and omniscience are immeasurable. In this way, Subhūti, this perfection of wisdom abides through an activity that is immeasurable.

Subhūti, how does this perfection of wisdom abide through an activity that is innumerable? Subhūti, the state of being a tathāgata, buddhahood, the self-arisen nature, and omniscience are innumerable. In this way, Subhūti, this perfection of wisdom abides through an activity that is innumerable.

Subhūti, how does this perfection of wisdom abide through an activity that is both unequal and equal? Subhūti, if there is not even an equal to the state of being a tathāgata, to buddhahood, to the self-arisen nature, and to omniscience, how much less is there anything greater! In this way, Subhūti, this perfection of wisdom abides through an activity that is unequal and equal.

The elder Subhūti then said: Blessed One, is the state of being a tathāgata inconceivable, without equal, immeasurable, innumerable, unequal and equal? Likewise, are buddhahood, the self-arisen nature, and omniscience inconceivable, without equal, immeasurable, unequal and equal? Or, Blessed One, is form also inconceivable, without equal, immeasurable, innumerable, unequal and equal? Likewise, are feeling, perception, and the formations, or consciousness also inconceivable, without equal, immeasurable, innumerable, unequal and equal? Or are all phenomena also inconceivable, without equal, immeasurable, innumerable, unequal and equal?

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Subhūti, form too is inconceivable, without equal, immeasurable, innumerable, unequal and equal. Likewise, Subhūti, feeling, perception, the formations, and consciousness are inconceivable, without equal, immeasurable, innumerable, unequal and equal. Likewise, Subhūti, all phenomena are inconceivable, without equal, immeasurable, innumerable, unequal and equal.

Why is this so? Subhūti, in the nature of form there is no mind, no thought, and no mental factors, and so there is no thinking of "it is so." Likewise, Subhūti, in the nature of feeling, perception, the formations, and consciousness there is no mind, no thought, and no mental factors, and so there is no thinking of "it is so." Subhūti, in the nature of all phenomena there is no mind, no thought, and no mental factors, and so there is no thinking of "it is so."

In this way, Subhūti, form is inconceivable and without equal. Likewise, Subhūti, feeling, perception, the formations, and consciousness are inconceivable and without equal. Likewise, Subhūti, all phenomena are

inconceivable and without equal. Subhūti, form is also immeasurable.

Subhūti, in the same way feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are also immeasurable. Subhūti, all phenomena are also immeasurable. Why is this? Subhūti, one does not know the measure of form. In the same way, Subhūti, one does not know the measure of feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness; and one does not know the measure of any phenomenon at all.

Subhūti, why does one not know the measure of form? In the same way, why does one not know the measure of feeling, perception, and formations? Subhūti, why does one not know the measure of consciousness? Subhūti, why does one not know the measure of any phenomenon at all? Subhūti, it is because form has no measure. In the same way, Subhūti, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness have no measure; Subhūti, all phenomena have no measure.

Subhūti, why does form have no measure? Why do feeling, perception, and formations have no measure? Why does consciousness have no measure? Why do all phenomena have no measure? Subhūti, it is because all phenomena are without measure.

Subhūti, form is also innumerable. In the same way, Subhūti, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are also innumerable. Subhūti, all phenomena are also innumerable, because they are beyond all counting.

Subhūti, form is also unequal and equal. In the same way, Subhūti, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are also unequal and equal. Likewise, Subhūti, all phenomena are unequal and equal, because, Subhūti, all phenomena are equal to space.

Subhūti, what do you think? In space, is there any equality, number, measure, comparison, mind, thought, or mental factor whatsoever? Subhūti replied: Blessed One, there is not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, it is just so. By this line of explanation, all these phenomena are inconceivable, incomparable, immeasurable, innumerable, unequal and equal. Subhūti, these are the qualities of the Tathāgata. Subhūti, by this line of explanation too, all phenomena are inconceivable, incomparable, immeasurable, innumerable, unequal and equal. Subhūti, these qualities of the Tathāgata are inconceivable because they are free of mind. They are incomparable because they have utterly passed beyond comparison.

Subhūti, what is called the inconceivable and the incomparable is a designation for the Dharma that has become consciousness. The same holds for what is called the immeasurable, the innumerable, the unequal and equal. Subhūti, what is called immeasurable, innumerable, and unequal and equal is so because it is free of equality, number, and measure. The qualities of the Tathāgata are immeasurable, innumerable, and unequal and equal.

These phenomena, being equal to space, being innumerable and immeasurable, are unequal and equal, innumerable and immeasurable. Ah, these phenomena, being equal to space, do not enter into either inequality or equality. Therefore, Subhūti, these phenomena are said to be incomparable.

Because space is inconceivable, these phenomena are inconceivable. Because space is incomparable, these phenomena are incomparable. Because space is immeasurable, these phenomena are immeasurable. Because space is innumerable, these phenomena are innumerable. Because space is unequal and equal, these phenomena are unequal and equal.

Even as the Blessed One spoke of these things that are inconceivable, incomparable, immeasurable, innumerable, unequal and equal, five hundred monks had their minds fully liberated from the defilements without grasping. Two thousand nuns likewise had their minds fully liberated from the defilements without grasping. Six thousand laymen attained the Dharma eye, free of dust and stain, utterly pure, with regard to all phenomena. Three thousand laywomen likewise attained the Dharma eye, free of dust and stain, utterly pure, with regard to all phenomena. Twenty thousand bodhisattvas attained the acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena. And the Blessed One prophesied that, in this very Fortunate Eon, they would reach unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. As for those laymen and laywomen who attained the Dharma eye, free of dust and stain, utterly pure, the Blessed One also gave them a prophecy: they too would have their minds fully liberated from the defilements without grasping.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, the perfection of wisdom is profound. Blessed One, how wonderful that this perfection of wisdom is established for the sake of a great purpose."

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti, "So it is, Subhūti, so it is. The perfection of wisdom is profound. Subhūti, this perfection of wisdom is established for the sake of a great purpose. Why is that? Subhūti, it is fully endowed with omniscience. It is fully endowed with the

stage of the solitary buddhas. It is fully endowed with the stage of the hearers.

"Subhūti, it is like this. Consider a king of the warrior caste, consecrated on the crown of his head, who has gained power and diligence over the people of his country. Whatever the tasks of the king, whatever the tasks of the cities, and whatever the tasks of the provinces, all of these are bound up with his ministers. For that reason the king exerts little effort and is relieved of the burden. In the same way, Subhūti, whatever the qualities of the buddhas, or the qualities of the solitary buddhas, or the qualities of the hearers may be, all of them are fully endowed with the perfection of wisdom, and so it is the perfection of wisdom itself that does the work for them. Subhūti, for this reason this perfection of wisdom is established for the sake of a great purpose.

"The perfection of wisdom is established so that one will not grasp at form or cling to it, and likewise so that one will not grasp at feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness, or cling to them. It is established so that one will not grasp at the fruit of stream-entry or cling to it, and likewise so that one will not grasp at the fruit of once-returning, the fruit of non-returning, and arhatship, or cling to them. It is established so that one will not grasp at self-arisen awakening or cling to it, and so that one will not grasp at omniscience or cling to it."

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, in what way is the perfection of wisdom established so that one will not grasp at omniscience or cling to it?"

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, what do you think? Do you perceive any arhatship at all that one could grasp at or cling to?"

Subhūti replied, "Blessed One, no. I do not see, Blessed One, any such factor as arhatship by which one would be grasping or clinging."

The Blessed One declared, "So it is, Subhūti, so it is. I too do not see the Tathāgata; and because I do not see that Tathāgata, I do not grasp at him or cling to him. Therefore, Subhūti, even in omniscience there is no grasping and no clinging."

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, when bodhisattvas, great beings, who have newly entered the vehicle and whose roots of virtue are slight hear this teaching, that even omniscience is not grasped and not clung to, they will tremble and become utterly terrified. Blessed One, however, those bodhisattvas, great beings, whose causes are complete, who in the past served the Victors and for a long time have planted roots of virtue, will have faith when they hear this

profound perfection of wisdom."

The Blessed One declared, "So it is, Subhūti, so it is."

Then the sons of the gods who dwell in the desire realm and those who dwell in the form realm said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, the perfection of wisdom is profound, difficult to behold, difficult to realize. Blessed One, those bodhisattvas who have faith on hearing this profound perfection of wisdom have served the Victors in the past and have planted roots of virtue for a long time. Blessed One, suppose all the sentient beings in the great thousand worlds of the three-thousandfold universe were to practice for an eon, or for more than an eon, on the stage of those who follow through faith. And suppose someone were to endure this profound perfection of wisdom, even for a single day, and to desire, seek, reflect upon, weigh, examine, and ponder it. Blessed One, that one would be superior to all of them."

When they had spoken, the Blessed One said to the sons of the gods who dwell in the desire realm and the form realm, "Sons of the gods, if any sons or daughters of good family listen to this profound perfection of wisdom, then, sons of the gods, they should expect to reach nirvāṇa very swiftly, which is not so for those who practice for an eon or more than an eon on the stage of those who follow through faith."

Then the sons of the gods who dwell in the desire realm and the form realm said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, this perfection of wisdom is indeed the great perfection." Having said this, they bowed their heads to the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and departed from the presence of the Blessed One. When they had gone a short distance, they vanished from sight. The sons of the gods who dwell in the desire realm returned to the desire realm, and the sons of the gods who dwell in the form realm returned to the world of Brahmā.

This is the thirteenth chapter, "The Inconceivable," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Then the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, suppose a bodhisattva, a great being, on the very moment of hearing this profound Perfection of Wisdom being taught, is drawn to it with faith. He is not stunned by it, not discouraged, does not hesitate, is not bewildered, and feels neither doubt nor perplexity, but takes delight in the Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, after dying and passing away from where does he come to be reborn there?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who on the very moment of hearing this profound Perfection of Wisdom being taught is drawn to it with faith, who is not stunned, not discouraged, does not hesitate, is not bewildered, and feels neither doubt nor perplexity, takes delight just in looking at it. He will hold and cultivate this profound Perfection of Wisdom. He does not abandon attention that is endowed with the Perfection of Wisdom, and he does not turn his mind away from it. He generates the wish to grasp it, retain it, read it, fully comprehend it, and recite it. He follows after it and walks behind it, and he does not abandon the Dharma teacher.

Subhūti, it is like a young calf, which does not leave its mother cow. In the same way, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has heard this profound Perfection of Wisdom, does not abandon the Dharma teacher for as long as this Perfection of Wisdom has not been taken up in his body, that is, committed to memory, or set down in a book. Such a bodhisattva, a great being, Subhūti, has died and passed away from among humans and been reborn as a human.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, is there a bodhisattva, a great being, endowed with these qualities who, having died and passed away from another buddha-field, has been reborn here?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, there are also bodhisattvas, great beings, who have honored and served other buddhas, the Blessed Ones, and have questioned them thoroughly and inquired of them in detail, and who, having died and passed away from those other buddha-fields, have been reborn here. These too should be understood as endowed with these very qualities.

Furthermore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has died and passed away from among the gods of Tuṣṭita and been reborn here should also be understood as endowed with these very qualities. One who has honored the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, and has questioned him thoroughly and inquired of him in detail concerning this Perfection of Wisdom should likewise be understood as endowed with these qualities.

Again, Subhūti, a bodhisattva who has heard this profound Perfection of Wisdom but who, even in the past, never questioned thoroughly, never inquired, and never asked for details, is reborn among humans, yet he becomes stupefied, bewildered, and discouraged when this profound Perfection of Wisdom is taught. Subhūti, such a bodhisattva should be understood as being by nature one who did not question even in the past. Why

is that? Because he became stupefied, bewildered, and discouraged when this profound Perfection of Wisdom was taught.

Furthermore, Subhūti, there is a bodhisattva who, even in the past, heard this profound Perfection of Wisdom for only one, two, three, four, or five days.

If, having shown respect and attended, a bodhisattva has questioned and inquired thoroughly, that faith lasts only for a while; it will be lost again, and it will be carried off by the very questioning. Why is that? Subhūti, it is like this. A bodhisattva who has not previously inquired about this profound Perfection of Wisdom, has not questioned it properly, has not examined it through questioning, and has not followed it, will sometimes follow it with eagerness in order to listen to this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and sometimes will have no eagerness. Because of that, he becomes distracted and discouraged, his mind turns restless, and he becomes like a tuft of cotton blown about. You should understand that this bodhisattva entered the Vehicle not long ago, and has come to it newly.

That bodhisattva will abandon that faith, that clarity of mind, and that eagerness. That is, he will not take up this profound Perfection of Wisdom, will not engage in it, and will not rely on it. So he should look forward to one or the other of the two levels, the level of the śrāvakas or the level of the pratyekabuddhas.

Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose a ship that has set out on the great ocean breaks apart. If those aboard do not hold on to a plank or a piece of wood, or do not cling to a corpse, then, Subhūti, you should understand that they will meet their death in the water without reaching the far shore. Subhūti, but if those aboard a ship that has broken apart on the great ocean do hold on to a plank or a piece of wood or a corpse, then you should understand that they will not die in the water, but will reach the far shore in safety, and will stand on dry land unharmed and uninjured.

In the same way, Subhūti, even if a bodhisattva has faith, joy, clarity of mind, and eagerness, if he does not rely on the Perfection of Wisdom, you should understand that he will be ruined midway along the path, and without attaining omniscience will remain at the level of a śrāvaka or a pratyekabuddha.

Furthermore, Subhūti, take those great bodhisattvas who have faith, patience, longing, eagerness, diligence, earnestness, devotion, a lofty intention, generosity, respect, delight, contentment, clarity of mind, great joy, and

unfailing perseverance for the sake of fully awakening to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. If they rely on the Perfection of Wisdom, then that faith of theirs, that patience, that longing, that eagerness, that diligence, that earnestness, that devotion, that lofty intention, that generosity, that respect, that delight, that contentment, that clarity of mind, that great joy, and that unfailing perseverance, having obtained the Perfection of Wisdom, will come to rest in omniscience.

Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose a woman or a man were to fill a new, unbaked pot with water. Subhūti, you should understand that such a pot will not last long; it will quickly break and fall apart. Why is that? Because the pot has not been fired, it will in the end turn back into earth.

Subhūti, in the same way, there may be some bodhisattva, a great being, who has faith in fully awakening to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, who has patience, who has aspiration, who has zeal, who has diligence, who has conscientiousness, who has conviction, who has superior intention, who has the capacity to give up, who has reverence, who has joy, who has great delight, who has serenity, who has gladness of mind, and who does not abandon perseverance. And yet, if that bodhisattva is not held by the perfection of wisdom and by skillful means, Subhūti, it should be understood that this bodhisattva will be destroyed midway along the path.

Subhūti, what is the destruction of a bodhisattva midway along the path? It is the level of the śrāvakas or the level of the pratyekabuddhas.

Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose a woman or a man has a well-baked pot and draws water with it from a spring, a pool, a pond, a lake, a well, or some other source of water. If that person carries the water away, Subhūti, it should be understood that the pot will reach home safely. Why is that? Because, Subhūti, the pot was well baked.

In the same way, Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, has faith in fully awakening to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and has patience, aspiration, zeal, diligence, conscientiousness, conviction, superior intention, the capacity to give up, reverence, joy, great delight, serenity, gladness of mind, and also does not abandon perseverance, and that bodhisattva is held by the perfection of wisdom and by skillful means, then, Subhūti, it should be understood that this bodhisattva, this great being, will not be destroyed midway along the path. Unharmful and unobstructed, that bodhisattva will come to abide in omniscience.

This is the end of the fourteenth volume of the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose a man of confused discernment has a seagoing ship whose planks are not caulked and not repaired, and which was lashed together long ago. He drags it into the water, loads it with goods until it is full, and goes aboard weighed down by the burden. Subhūti, such a ship is bound to break apart in this way. It will not cross to the far shore of the water; the goods will be lost, and the ship itself will go to ruin. In just this way, that unskilled captain of confused discernment will suffer the loss of great wealth and will fall away from the great source of jewels.

In the same way, Subhūti, there may be some bodhisattva who has faith in fully awakening to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, who has patience, aspiration, zeal, diligence, conscientiousness, conviction, superior intention, the capacity to give up, reverence, joy, contentment, serenity, great delight, and who does not abandon perseverance. Yet if that bodhisattva is not held by the perfection of wisdom and is without skillful means, Subhūti, then before reaching the source of the jewel of omniscience, that bodhisattva will be ruined midway and will fall into despair. He will fall away from his own great aim, and he will fall away from the heap of jewels that is the great aim of others. That is, he will fall away from the great source of jewels that is the great aim of omniscience. This should be understood.

Subhūti, and what is the ruin of a bodhisattva midway?

That is to say, the level of the hearers or the level of the solitary buddhas.

Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose a skilled captain builds a ship for sailing the ocean. He binds it well, fits its lattice of planks well, and repairs whatever needs repair. He then draws the ship into the water, loads the cargo until it is full, arranges everything properly, and, joined with a favorable wind, sails gradually toward whatever destination he wishes. Subhūti, that ship will not be destroyed by the water. It will reach the destination toward which it was meant to go, and that captain will obtain great gains, namely, he will come to possess the jewels of the world. This is how it should be understood.

In the same way, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, may have faith in fully and perfectly awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, and have patience, longing, aspiration, diligence, carefulness, devotion, superior intention, generosity, respect, joy, delight, serene confidence, and great gladness, and may also not abandon his perseverance. If he is embraced by

the Perfection of Wisdom and is not separated from skillful means, then, Subhūti, that bodhisattva, that great being, will not be wasted in the middle and will not become discouraged. It should be understood that this bodhisattva, this great being, will abide in unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

Why is that? Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose there are bodhisattvas, great beings, who have faith in fully and perfectly awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, and have patience, longing, aspiration, diligence, carefulness, devotion, superior intention, generosity, respect, joy, delight, serene confidence, and great gladness, and also do not abandon their perseverance. If these qualities of theirs are embraced by the Perfection of Wisdom and are not separated from skillful means, then they will actualize the qualities by which one becomes omniscient, and they will set out correctly toward fully and perfectly awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening. They will not instead accomplish the level of the hearers or the level of the solitary buddhas.

Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose a man has been born and has reached the age of one hundred and twenty. He is old, aged, and bent over. If some illness arising from wind, or from bile, or from phlegm, or from a combination of these, strikes his body, what do you think, Subhūti? Could that man get up from his bed without support?

Subhūti replied, "Blessed One, he could not."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, even if that man were able to get up from his bed, being overcome by that old age and that illness, he would have no strength to walk even one league or even two leagues. Even if he could get up from his bed, he would have no strength to walk.

In the same way, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, may have faith in fully and perfectly awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, and have patience, longing, aspiration, diligence, carefulness, devotion, superior intention, generosity, respect, joy, delight, serene confidence, and great gladness, and may also not abandon his perseverance, and yet...

If such a bodhisattva is not embraced by the Perfection of Wisdom and is separated from skillful means, then even though he has properly set out to attain full and perfect awakening, Subhūti, he will be ruined and destroyed along the way. Know that he will come to rest in the stage of the śrāvakas or the stage of the pratyekabuddhas. Why is that? Because he is not embraced by the Perfection of Wisdom and is separated from skillful means.

Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose a man has been born and has reached the age of a hundred and twenty. He is old, worn out with age, and bent. His body is struck by some illness, whether arising from wind, from bile, from phlegm, or from a combination of these. Two strong men, one on his right and one on his left, support him well, hold him up, grasp him firmly, and say to him: "Good man, until you reach the place where you wish to go, we two will support you, so you need not fear falling or collapsing along the way. Go wherever you wish to go." Then he would be able to rise from his bed.

In the same way, Subhūti, suppose a bodhisattva, a great being, has faith, patience, longing, aspiration, diligence, carefulness, devotion, and a lofty intention for the attainment of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Suppose he also has generosity, reverence, joy, contentment, serene confidence, delight, and unflagging perseverance. If he is embraced by the Perfection of Wisdom and is not separated from skillful means, then, Subhūti, that bodhisattva, that great being, will not be ruined or destroyed along the way. Know that from that very position he will be able to reach the state of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

This is the fourteenth chapter, the chapter on similes, from the noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how should a bodhisattva, a great being who is a beginner, abide in the Perfection of Wisdom, and how should he train?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti: "Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being who is a beginner and wishes to train in the Perfection of Wisdom, should draw near to good spiritual friends, rely on them, and honor them. Those who counsel and instruct him in this Perfection of Wisdom, and those who explain the meaning of this Perfection of Wisdom, should be recognized, Subhūti, as that bodhisattva's good spiritual friends.

They will say to him: 'Come, child of good family, apply yourself to the perfection of generosity. In the same way, apply yourself to the perfection of moral discipline, the perfection of patience, the perfection of diligence, the perfection of meditative concentration, and the perfection of wisdom. Child of good family, whatever gifts you give, dedicate all of them fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.'"

Child of good family, do not take pride in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening as form. In the same way, do not take pride in it as feeling, as perception, or as formations. Child of good family, do not take pride in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening as consciousness. Why is that? Child of good family, because omniscience is without pride.

In the same way, whatever moral discipline you keep, and, joining all the others in the same manner, whatever patience you practice, whatever diligence you undertake, whatever meditative concentration you enter into in equipoise, and whatever wisdom you cultivate, dedicate all of it fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Child of good family, do not take pride in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening as form. In the same way, do not take pride in it as feeling, as perception, or as formations. Child of good family, do not take pride in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening as consciousness. Why is that? Child of good family, because omniscience is without pride. Child of good family, do not aspire to the ground of the śrāvakas or the ground of the pratyekabuddhas.

Thus they should give instruction on the meaning of the Perfection of Wisdom. In this way, Subhūti, the good spiritual friends should gradually introduce the novice bodhisattva, the great being, to the Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, there are bodhisattvas, great beings, who have properly entered upon the path to fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Relying on generosity of such a nature, on moral discipline of such a nature, on patience of such a nature, on diligence of such a nature, on meditative concentration of such a nature, and on wisdom of such a nature, they have gained mastery over passing completely beyond sorrow, and yet they do not wish to pass completely beyond sorrow. Rather, seeing the realm of sentient beings so greatly afflicted by suffering, they wish to fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and they are not frightened of saṃsāra. This, Blessed One, is a difficult thing they do."

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to the venerable Subhūti: "So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Subhūti, there are bodhisattvas, great beings, who have set out for the benefit of the world, for the happiness of the world, and out of compassion for the world, thinking: 'Having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, I shall become a protector of the world. I shall become a refuge of the world. I shall become a resting place of the world. I shall become an ally of the world. I shall become an island for the

world. I shall become a light for the world. I shall become a guide of the world. I shall become a support of the world.' To undertake diligence toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening of such a nature is a difficult thing to do."

"Subhūti, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, become a protector of the world?"

Subhūti, whatever sufferings there are in the world of those who move in saṃsāra, from these he protects them; he strives to abandon those sufferings and arouses diligence. In this way, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, becomes the protector of the world.

Subhūti, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, become the refuge of the world? Subhūti, there are beings who are subject to birth, subject to aging, subject to sickness, subject to death, subject to sorrow, lamentation, suffering, mental distress, and turmoil. Such beings he frees completely from birth, aging, sickness, death, sorrow, lamentation, suffering, mental distress, and turmoil. In this way, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, becomes the refuge of the world.

Subhūti, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, become the resting place of the world? Subhūti, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, teaches the Dharma to beings so that they may come to be without engagement. In this way, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, becomes the resting place of the world.

Subhūti asked: Blessed One, how is it that there is no engagement?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what is without connection to form is without engagement with form. What is without engagement with form is without connection to form. What is without connection to form is without the arising and without the cessation of form. What is without the arising and without the cessation of form is without engagement with form. That which is the absence of engagement with form is the absence of connection to form, and this absence of connection to form is the absence of engagement with form.

It is the same with feeling, perception, and the formations. Subhūti, what is without connection to consciousness is without engagement with consciousness. What is without engagement with consciousness is without connection to consciousness. What is without connection to consciousness is without the arising and without the cessation of consciousness. What is without the arising and without the cessation of consciousness is without engagement with consciousness. What is without engagement with consciousness is without connection to consciousness, and this absence of connection to consciousness is the absence of engagement with consciousness.

Subhūti, when consciousness sees in this way that all phenomena are without engagement and without connection, one comes to be without engagement. In this way, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, becomes the resting place of the world.

Subhūti, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, become the ally of the world?

Subhūti, the far shore of form is not form. Subhūti, as the far shore is, so too is form. In the same way, the far shore of feeling, of perception, and of the conditioning factors is not feeling, perception, or the conditioning factors. And Subhūti, the far shore of consciousness is not consciousness. As the far shore is, so too is consciousness. Subhūti, as the far shore of form, feeling, perception, the conditioning factors, and consciousness is, so too are all phenomena.

Subhūti then spoke. Blessed One, if as the far shore of form, feeling, perception, the conditioning factors, and consciousness is, so too are all phenomena, then, Blessed One, is it not the case that bodhisattvas, the great beings, are already fully awakened to all phenomena? Why do I say so? Blessed One, because there is no conceptual thought whatsoever in this.

The Blessed One declared: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. In that which is the far shore there is no conceptual thought whatsoever. Subhūti, because there is no conceptual thought, bodhisattvas, the great beings, are indeed fully awakened to all phenomena. Subhūti, this too is a supremely difficult deed of bodhisattvas, the great beings: that when they have thus come to a firm conviction about all phenomena, they neither become arrogant nor become discouraged, and think, "We shall fully awaken to these phenomena. Having

thus fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, we shall teach these phenomena and explain them thoroughly."

Subhūti, in this way a bodhisattva, a great being, having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, becomes a protector for the world.

Subhūti, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, become an island for the world? Subhūti, for example, in the midst of rivers or oceans, a place that is surrounded on every side by water is called an island. In the same way, Subhūti, form is utterly cut off from its former limit and its later limit. In the same way, feeling, perception, and the conditioning factors, and likewise, Subhūti, consciousness, are utterly cut off from their former limit and their later limit. Subhūti, by this complete cutting off, all phenomena are completely cut off from their former limit and their later limit.

Subhūti, this complete cutting off of all phenomena is peace. It is stillness. It is complete nirvāṇa. It is things as they truly are. It is the unmistaken. Subhūti, in this way a bodhisattva, a great being, having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, becomes an island for the world.

Subhūti, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, become a light for the world? Subhūti, here a bodhisattva, a great being, having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, brings light through wisdom to beings who for a long time have been wholly enclosed in the shell and membrane of the egg of ignorance and overwhelmed by darkness, and dispels all the pitch darkness of unknowing.

Subhūti, in this way bodhisattvas, great beings, having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, become the light of the world. Subhūti, how is it that bodhisattvas, great beings, having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, become the guides of the world? Subhūti, here bodhisattvas, great beings, having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, teach that form, by its intrinsic nature, is without arising and without cessation. In the same way, they teach that feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness, by their intrinsic nature, are without arising and without cessation. They teach that the qualities of ordinary beings, by their intrinsic nature, are without arising and without cessation. They teach that the qualities of the śrāvakas, by their intrinsic nature, are without arising and without cessation. They teach that the qualities

of the pratyekabuddhas, by their intrinsic nature, are without arising and without cessation. They teach that the qualities of the bodhisattvas, by their intrinsic nature, are without arising and without cessation. They teach that the qualities of the buddhas, by their intrinsic nature, are without arising and without cessation. They teach that all phenomena, by their intrinsic nature, are without arising and without cessation. Subhūti, in this way bodhisattvas, great beings, having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, become the guides of the world.

Subhūti, how is it that bodhisattvas, great beings, having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, become the support of the world? Subhūti, here bodhisattvas, great beings, having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, teach the world that form rests on space. In the same way they teach that feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness rest on space. Subhūti, likewise all phenomena rest on space; they have no coming and no going, and are equal to space. Just as space has no coming and no going, is unmade, unchanging, unfabricated, nonabiding, without any true abiding, without any particular abiding, unarisen, and unceased, so too, Subhūti, all phenomena have no coming and no going, are unmade, unchanging, unfabricated, nonabiding, without any true abiding, without any particular abiding, unarisen, and unceased. Because they are equal to space, they are free of conceptualization.

Why is this so? Subhūti, the emptiness of form has neither coming nor going. In the same way, the emptiness of feeling, perception, formations, and, Subhūti, of consciousness has neither coming nor going. Subhūti, likewise the emptiness of all phenomena has neither coming nor going.

Why is this so? Subhūti, all phenomena rest on emptiness, and they do not go beyond that basis. Subhūti, all phenomena rest on signlessness, and they do not go beyond that basis. Subhūti, all phenomena rest on wishlessness, and they do not go beyond that basis. Subhūti, all phenomena rest on non-fabrication, and they do not go beyond that basis. Subhūti, all phenomena rest on non-occurrence, and they do not go beyond that basis. Subhūti, all phenomena rest on non-arising, and they do not go beyond that basis.

Subhūti, all phenomena have the absence of entities as their support, and they do not pass beyond that support. Subhūti, all phenomena have the dream as their support, and they do not pass beyond that support. Subhūti, all phenomena have the self as their support, and they do not pass beyond that

support. Subhūti, all phenomena have the boundless as their support, and they do not pass beyond that support. Subhūti, all phenomena have peace as their support, and they do not pass beyond that support. Subhūti, all phenomena have nirvāṇa as their support, and they do not pass beyond that support. Subhūti, all phenomena have the unextractable as their support, and they do not pass beyond that support. Subhūti, all phenomena have the absence of coming as their support, and they do not pass beyond that support. Subhūti, all phenomena have the absence of going as their support, and they do not pass beyond that support. Subhūti, all phenomena have the immovable as their support, and they do not pass beyond that support. Subhūti, all phenomena have form as their support, and they do not pass beyond that support. Likewise, Subhūti, all phenomena have feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as their support, and they do not pass beyond that support. Subhūti, all phenomena have the arhat, the pratyekabuddha state, and unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening as their support, and they do not pass beyond that support.

Therefore, having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, the bodhisattva, the great being, teaches the Dharma, saying that all phenomena have space as their support. Subhūti, in this way, having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, the bodhisattva, the great being, becomes a support for the world.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, who will understand this profound Perfection of Wisdom?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, you should know that this profound Perfection of Wisdom will be understood by those bodhisattvas, great beings, who have practiced in the presence of the buddhas of the past, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, and whose roots of virtue have fully matured.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, what is the essential nature of those bodhisattvas, great beings, who will understand this profound Perfection of Wisdom?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who will understand this profound Perfection of Wisdom are those whose nature is solitude, arisen from the Vinaya.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, do those bodhisattvas, great beings, become dependent on precisely such supports? And having fully awakened, do they teach these very supports to sentient beings, and in that way become a support for sentient beings?

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Subhūti, those bodhisattvas, great beings, become those who have such supports. Having fully awakened to these supports, they teach these supports to sentient beings, and in that way they become a support for sentient beings.

Subhūti, in this way a bodhisattva, a great being, after fully and perfectly awakening to unsurpassed, complete awakening, becomes a support for immeasurable, countless sentient beings.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has put on this armor with the thought, "I shall bring immeasurable, countless sentient beings to complete nirvāṇa," is doing something difficult.

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. A bodhisattva, a great being, who has put on this armor with the thought, "I shall bring immeasurable, countless sentient beings to complete nirvāṇa," is doing something difficult.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the armor of a bodhisattva, a great being, who has put on the great armor is not connected with form, nor is it connected for the sake of form. In the same way, it is not connected with feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness, nor is it connected for the sake of consciousness. It is not connected with the stage of the śrāvakas, nor connected for the sake of the stage of the śrāvakas. It is not connected with the stage of the pratyekabuddhas, nor connected for the sake of the stage of the pratyekabuddhas. It is not connected with the stage of the buddhas, nor connected for the sake of the stage of the buddhas. Why is that? Subhūti, this armor of a bodhisattva, a great being, who has put on the great armor, is not connected with any phenomena at all.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has put on the great armor and practices in this way in the profound Perfection of Wisdom, should not hope for three things. What are the three? They are the stage of the śrāvakas, the stage of the pratyekabuddhas, and the stage of the buddhas.

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, what purpose do you see, that you say: "A bodhisattva, a great being, who has put on the great armor and practices in this way in the profound Perfection of Wisdom, should not hope for three things: the stage of the śrāvakas, the stage of the pratyekabuddhas, and the stage of the buddhas"?

Subhūti, for a bodhisattva, a great being, who has put on the great armor and practices in this way in the profound Perfection of Wisdom, to hope for the stage of the śrāvakas or the stage of the pratyekabuddhas is impossible, and there is no occasion for it. Yet whoever has put on this great armor for the sake of all sentient beings should hope for buddhahood itself.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is profound. It is not cultivated by anyone. It has not been cultivated by anyone, no one cultivates it, and no one will cultivate it. There is nothing at all to be cultivated, and there is nowhere in which to cultivate it. Why is that? Blessed One, because in the Perfection of Wisdom no phenomenon whatsoever is truly established.

Blessed One, this cultivation of the Perfection of Wisdom is a cultivation of space. Blessed One, this cultivation of the Perfection of Wisdom is a non-cultivation of all phenomena.

Blessed One, this cultivation of the Perfection of Wisdom is the cultivation of non-attachment. Blessed One, this cultivation of the Perfection of Wisdom is the cultivation of the limitless. Blessed One, this cultivation of the Perfection of Wisdom is the cultivation of the non-existence of things. Blessed One, this cultivation of the Perfection of Wisdom is the cultivation of the absence of any grasping.

When Subhūti had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows. Subhūti, it is just so, it is just so. Therefore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in the way of abiding of the profound Perfection of Wisdom should be recognized as irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Subhūti, such a bodhisattva, a great being, does not become fixated on this profound Perfection of Wisdom. Nor does he become fixated on what others say or what others discuss. Nor does he follow others out of faith placed in them. Subhūti, when this profound Perfection of Wisdom is being taught, this bodhisattva, this great being, is not stunned, is not discouraged, does not tremble, is not terrified, and does not become possessed by terror. He does not hesitate, does not fall into doubt, and is not bewildered. He understands and has confidence, and he delights to see and to hear the Perfection of Wisdom. Therefore, Subhūti, it should be understood that in the past, too, he has thoroughly questioned the Perfection of Wisdom. Why is that? Subhūti, it is because when this profound Perfection of Wisdom is being taught, he does not tremble, is not terrified, and is not possessed by terror.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, if a bodhisattva, a great being, does not tremble, is not terrified, and is not possessed by terror when this profound Perfection of Wisdom is being taught, then Blessed One, in what way has he examined the Perfection of Wisdom in detail?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, it is by a mental continuum inclined toward omniscience that a bodhisattva, a great being, has examined the Perfection of Wisdom in detail.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, how has he examined in detail the continuum inclined toward omniscience?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, it is by a continuum inclined toward space, Subhūti, one that flows down toward space, Subhūti, one that is directed toward space, that the continuum inclined toward omniscience has been examined in detail. Subhūti, moreover, whatever is examined in detail through a continuum inclined toward omniscience is thus examined in detail. Why is that? Subhūti, omniscience is immeasurable. Subhūti, omniscience is without measure. Subhūti, whatever is immeasurable and without measure is not form, not feeling, not perception, not formations, not consciousness. It is not an attainment, not a realization, not a comprehension. It is not a path, not the fruit of the path, not wisdom, not consciousness. It is not arising, not ceasing, not increase, not decrease, not cessation. It is not cultivation, not cultivation in particular. It is made by no one, comes from nowhere, goes nowhere, abides in no object, and abides in no direction.

Otherwise, it would fall into the category of what is called the immeasurable and the unfathomable. Because space is unmeasurable, omniscience is unmeasurable. What is unmeasurable cannot be fully and perfectly awakened to by anyone. It is not awakened to by means of form, nor by feeling, nor by perception, nor by formations, nor by consciousness. It is not awakened to by the perfection of generosity, nor by the perfection of moral discipline, nor by the perfection of patience, nor by the perfection of diligence, nor by the perfection of meditative concentration. Nor can anyone fully and perfectly awaken by means of the Perfection of Wisdom.

Why is that? Subhūti, form itself is omniscience. In the same way, feeling itself, perception itself, and formations themselves are omniscience, and, Subhūti, consciousness itself is omniscience. Subhūti, the perfection of generosity itself is omniscience. In the same way, the perfection of moral discipline itself, the perfection of patience itself, the perfection of diligence itself, and the

perfection of meditative concentration itself are omniscience, and, Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom itself is omniscience.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, together with the sons of the gods who dwell in the desire realm, and Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, together with the sons of the gods who dwell in the form realm, approached the Blessed One. Having arrived, they bowed with their heads at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and sat to one side. When they were seated, Śakra, lord of the gods, together with the sons of the gods who dwell in the desire realm, and Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, together with the sons of the gods who dwell in the form realm, spoke to the Blessed One as follows.

Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is profound. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is difficult to fathom. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is difficult to behold. Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is difficult to realize. It was in view of this very point that the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, having fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassable, perfect awakening, and while abiding at the heart of awakening, inclined his mind toward little exertion and did not incline it toward teaching the Dharma.

When they had spoken thus, the Blessed One said to Śakra, lord of the gods, and the sons of the gods who dwell in the desire realm, and to Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, and the sons of the gods who dwell in the form realm: Sons of the gods, it is so. It is just so. Sons of the gods, alas, this Perfection of Wisdom is profound. Sons of the gods, this Perfection of Wisdom is difficult to fathom. Sons of the gods, this Perfection of Wisdom is difficult to behold. Sons of the gods, this Perfection of Wisdom is difficult to realize. It was in view of this very point that the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, immediately after fully and perfectly awakening to unsurpassable, perfect awakening, while abiding at the heart of awakening, thought, "Alas, I have fully awakened to this profound Dharma," and inclined his mind toward little exertion, and did not incline it toward teaching the Dharma. This is the profundity of the Dharma: that in it, no one has ever become fully awakened, no one becomes fully awakened, and no one will become fully awakened.

Because space is profound, this Dharma is profound. Because the self is profound, this Dharma is profound. Because no phenomenon comes, this Dharma is profound. Because no phenomenon goes, this Dharma that I have

fully awakened to is profound.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, Śakra, lord of the gods, together with the sons of the gods who move in the desire realm, and Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, together with the sons of the gods who move in the form realm, said to the Blessed One: "How wondrous, Blessed One! How marvelous, Sugata! Blessed One, this Dharma has been taught as running counter to the entire world. Blessed One, this Dharma has been taught so that no phenomenon is grasped, whereas the people of the world dwell in grasping."

This is the fifteenth chapter, called "The Gods," of the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines, fifteenth volume.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Alas, Blessed One, in this Dharma that has been taught, no phenomenon is apprehended. Blessed One, this Dharma is obstructed by nothing. Blessed One, because it is like space, and nothing in any place is apprehended, this Dharma has the characteristic of being unobstructed. Blessed One, because there is no duality, this Dharma has the characteristic of having no equal. Blessed One, because there is no one to dispute it, this Dharma has the characteristic of having no counterpart. Blessed One, because nothing is truly accomplished, this Dharma has no abiding. Blessed One, because no arising of any kind has arisen, this Dharma has no coming into being. Blessed One, because no path of any kind is apprehended, this Dharma has no path."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, and Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, and those sons of the gods who move in the desire realm and the form realm, said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this noble elder Subhūti, a śrāvaka of the Blessed One, has been born in accord with the Blessed One. Why is that? Blessed One, it is because whatever Dharma this elder Subhūti teaches, he teaches that very Dharma on the basis of emptiness."

Then the venerable Subhūti said to those sons of the gods, Śakra, lord of the gods, Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, and those who move in the desire realm and the form realm: "Sons of the gods, you say that this elder Subhūti has been born in accord with the Tathāgata. It is because he has not been born that the elder Subhūti has been born in accord with the Tathāgata. The elder Subhūti follows the suchness of the Tathāgata. Just as the suchness of the Tathāgata neither comes nor goes, so the suchness of the elder Subhūti neither comes nor goes. In this way the elder Subhūti follows the suchness of

the Tathāgata. From the very beginning the elder Subhūti has followed the suchness of the Tathāgata. Why is that? The suchness of the Tathāgata is the suchness of all phenomena. The suchness of all phenomena is the suchness of the Tathāgata.

The suchness of the Tathāgata, and the suchness of all phenomena, is the suchness of the elder Subhūti. The elder Subhūti has followed that very suchness, and so he has been born in the wake of the Tathāgata. Yet that suchness of the Tathāgata is not itself a suchness apart; it is that to which he conforms. In this way the elder Subhūti is born in the wake of the Tathāgata. By the very abiding in which the suchness of the Tathāgata abides, by that abiding the elder Subhūti is born in the wake of the Tathāgata.

Just as the suchness of the Tathāgata is without change, without alteration, without conceptual thought, and without discursive conceptualization, so too the suchness of the elder Subhūti is without change, without alteration, without conceptual thought, and without discursive conceptualization. In this way the elder Subhūti too, by that suchness which is unchanging, unaltering, and free of thought and conceptualization, is born in the wake of the Tathāgata.

Just as the suchness of the Tathāgata is unchanging, unaltering, free of thought and conceptualization, and unobstructed in regard to anything, so too the suchness of all phenomena is unchanging, unaltering, free of thought and conceptualization, and unobstructed in regard to anything. Why is this so? Because this suchness of the Tathāgata and this suchness of all phenomena are one; there is no duality, and it cannot be made dual. The nondual suchness is not the suchness located in anything, nor arising from anything, nor belonging to anything. Since it belongs to nothing at all, that suchness is nondual, and the nondual suchness cannot be made dual.

In this way the elder Subhūti is born in the wake of the Tathāgata through the uncreated suchness. That uncreated suchness never becomes other than suchness. Because it never becomes other than suchness, that suchness is nondual, and the nondual suchness cannot be made dual. In this way the elder Subhūti is born in the wake of the Tathāgata.

Just as the suchness of the Tathāgata, in every respect, does not conceptualize or discursively conceptualize any phenomenon, so too the suchness of the elder Subhūti, in every respect, does not conceptualize or discursively conceptualize any phenomenon. Likewise the Tathāgata and Subhūti are

manifested by suchness; these two are neither distinct in kind nor different, since nothing that would make them different is perceived. In this way the elder Subhūti is born in the wake of the Tathāgata.

Just as the suchness of the Tathāgata is not other than the suchness of all phenomena, so too the suchness of Subhūti is not other than the suchness of all phenomena. And what is not other than the suchness of all phenomena can never become not the suchness of anything, for that very suchness is the suchness of all phenomena.

Venerable Subhūti has accepted that he follows along with that suchness, a suchness that is not other, and yet here there is no one who follows along with anything anywhere. In this way, Subhūti is born after the Tathāgata. Just as the suchness of the Tathāgata is not past, not future, and not present, so too the suchness of all phenomena is not past, not future, and not present. Thus, because Subhūti follows along with that suchness, he is said to be born after the Tathāgata.

Moreover, the suchness of the Tathāgata follows along with suchness. The suchness of the Tathāgata follows along with the suchness of the past, and the suchness of the past follows along with the suchness of the Tathāgata. The suchness of the Tathāgata follows along with the suchness of the future, and the suchness of the future follows along with the suchness of the Tathāgata. The suchness of the Tathāgata follows along with the suchness of the present, and the suchness of the present follows along with the suchness of the Tathāgata. The suchness of the Tathāgata follows along with the suchness of the past, the future, and the present, and the suchness of the past, the future, and the present follows along with the suchness of the Tathāgata. Thus, the suchness of Subhūti, the suchness of the past, the future, and the present, and the suchness of the Tathāgata are not two; they cannot be made into two. In the same way, the suchness of all phenomena and the suchness of Subhūti are not two; they cannot be made into two.

Blessed One, the suchness of one who has become a bodhisattva is none other than the suchness of the Blessed One who has fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. It is by this very suchness that a bodhisattva, a great being, having become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, obtains the name Tathāgata. This is that suchness. At the very time when this suchness of the Tathāgata was taught, just as when a Tathāgata fully awakens to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, this

great earth trembled in the six ways and the eighteen great signs: it shook, shook strongly, and shook all over; it quivered, quivered strongly, and quivered all over; it heaved, heaved strongly, and heaved all over; it was stirred, stirred strongly, and stirred all over; it resounded with a rumbling, resounded strongly, and resounded all over; it roared, roared strongly, and roared all over.

Then venerable Subhūti spoke further to those sons of the gods: Sons of the gods, in this way Subhūti is born after the Tathāgata. Moreover, Subhūti is not born after form; he is not born after feeling, nor perception, nor the formations, nor consciousness. He is not born after the fruit of stream-entry; nor the fruit of once-returning, nor the fruit of non-returning, nor the fruit of an arhat. He is not born after the state of a pratyekabuddha, and he is not born after the state of a buddha. Why is that so?

For in this way, those by whom there is a following in birth, and the phenomena that are followed in birth, do not truly exist and are not apprehended. In this way, the elder Subhūti was born in the wake of the Tathāgata.

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, this very suchness is a profound practice.

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāriputra: So it is, Śāriputra, so it is. Śāriputra, this very suchness is a profound practice. Even as this teaching of suchness was being expounded, three hundred monks, without grasping, had their minds fully liberated from the defilements. Five hundred nuns obtained the pure, stainless Dharma eye with regard to phenomena. Five thousand sons of the gods, who had previously trained, attained the acceptance that phenomena are unborn. And sixty bodhisattvas, without grasping, had their minds fully liberated from the defilements.

Then the venerable Śāriputra, knowing that those bodhisattvas had their minds fully liberated from the defilements without grasping, said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, what is the cause and what is the condition by which these bodhisattvas have their minds fully liberated from the defilements without grasping?

The Blessed One said: Śāriputra, these bodhisattvas have attended and honored five hundred buddhas. Throughout, they gave gifts, kept moral discipline, cultivated patience, undertook diligence, and developed meditative concentration. Yet all of this was not embraced by the Perfection of Wisdom,

and they were separated from skillful means. Śāriputra, although the path of these bodhisattvas was one of practice in emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness, even so, because they were not endowed with skillful means, they made the true limit manifest and definitively emerged into the level of the śrāvakas, not into the level of the buddhas.

Śāriputra, it is like this. Suppose there were a bird whose body measured a hundred leagues, or two hundred, or three hundred, or four hundred, or five hundred leagues. It lives among the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, and it thinks, I shall go to this Jambudvīpa. But, Śāriputra, that bird has no wings grown, or its wings have been plucked out, or its wings have been cut off. Thinking, I shall stay in Jambudvīpa, it hurls itself from the realm of the gods of the Thirty-Three, and the bird falls from there. While it remains in the space of the sky, it thinks, Alas, I shall go back and dwell among the gods of the Thirty-Three. What do you think, Śāriputra? Would that bird be able to go back and stay among the gods of the Thirty-Three?

The venerable Śāriputra said: Blessed One, it would not.

The Blessed One said: Śāriputra, suppose it thinks, Alas, I shall stay in Jambudvīpa unharmed and uninjured. What do you think, Śāriputra? Would that bird come to stay in Jambudvīpa unharmed and uninjured?

Śāriputra said: Blessed One, it would not. Having fallen to Jambudvīpa, it would be harmed and injured, and it would suffer pain amounting to death or close to death. Why is that? Blessed One, it is like this: because its body is huge, it has no wings, and it has fallen from a great height.

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to the venerable Śāriputra: "So it is, Śāriputra, so it is. Śāriputra, suppose a bodhisattva, a great being, has given rise to the mind of unsurpassed, perfect awakening, and for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā has remained giving gifts, guarding moral discipline, cultivating patience, undertaking diligence, and resting in meditative concentration. Suppose he has entered into all this on a vast scale, and has greatly strengthened his resolve to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect awakening. Even so, if he is not held by the Perfection of Wisdom and is separated from skillful means, he will fall to the ground of the śrāvakas or the ground of the pratyekabuddhas.

"Furthermore, Śāriputra, suppose a bodhisattva thinks about and clings, through the mode of signs, to the moral discipline, the concentration, the wisdom, the liberation, and the vision of the wisdom of liberation of the

buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, the future, and the present. Such a person does not know or see the moral discipline of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas. It is not concentration, it is not wisdom, it is not liberation; and he does not know or see the vision of the wisdom of liberation of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas.

"Because he does not know and does not see, he listens to the sound 'emptiness,' and he makes a sign of that sound. Having made that sound into a sign, he wishes to dedicate it toward unsurpassed, perfect awakening. For this reason, it should be understood that he will come to abide on the ground of the śrāvakas or the ground of the pratyekabuddhas. Why is that? Śāriputra, whoever is not held by the Perfection of Wisdom and is separated from skillful means will come to be in this way."

Śāriputra said: "Blessed One, as I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has explained, if a bodhisattva possesses a very great accumulation of merit, yet is not held by the Perfection of Wisdom, is separated from skillful means, and does not have a spiritual friend, then it becomes doubtful whether he will attain unsurpassed, perfect awakening. Therefore, Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect awakening should cultivate the Perfection of Wisdom and should also strive in skillful means."

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to the venerable Śāriputra: "So it is, Śāriputra, so it is. Śāriputra, if a bodhisattva, a great being, is not held by the Perfection of Wisdom and is separated from skillful means, then even though he possesses a great accumulation of merit, if he is also separated from spiritual friends, it becomes doubtful whether he will attain unsurpassed, perfect awakening. Therefore, Śāriputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect awakening should cultivate the Perfection of Wisdom and should also be endowed with skillful means."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, together with the sons of the gods who move in the desire realm, and Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world (Sahāṃpati), together with the sons of the gods who move in the form realm, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom is profound."

Blessed One, unsurpassed, perfect awakening is hard to come by. Blessed One, to fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect awakening is

exceedingly hard to come by.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the sons of the gods of the desire realm, with Śakra, lord of the gods, at their head, and to the sons of the gods of the form realm, with Brahmā, lord of the world of endurance, at their head. He said: "Sons of the gods, so it is, so it is. Sons of the gods, this Perfection of Wisdom is profound. Unsurpassed, perfect awakening is also hard to come by. For those whose wisdom is confused, whose diligence is weak, whose faith and interest are weak, who are unskilled in means, and who rely on bad friends, fully and perfectly awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening is exceedingly hard to come by."

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the Blessed One has said that unsurpassed, perfect awakening is hard to come by, and that fully awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening is exceedingly hard to come by. But if there is nothing at all that one could fully awaken to, then, Blessed One, how is it that unsurpassed, perfect awakening is hard to come by, and that fully and perfectly awakening to it is exceedingly hard to come by? Why do I ask? Blessed One, because all phenomena are empty, there is no phenomenon at all that could be fully awakened to. Blessed One, all phenomena are empty in just this way. Blessed One, there is also no phenomenon taught for the sake of being abandoned. In the same way, whatever full and perfect awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening there is, whatever is to be awakened to, whatever is realized, and whatever is to be realized, all of those phenomena are empty. Blessed One, by this way of explaining too, it occurs to me that fully and perfectly awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening is easy to come by, and that it is not hard to come by."

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti: "Subhūti, because there is no arising, unsurpassed, perfect awakening is hard to come by. Subhūti, because it is not truly real, unsurpassed, perfect awakening is hard to come by. Subhūti, because it is free of conceptual thought, unsurpassed, perfect awakening is hard to come by. Subhūti, because it is not brought about by any construction, unsurpassed, perfect awakening is hard to come by. Fully and perfectly awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening is supremely hard to come by."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the venerable Subhūti: "Venerable Subhūti, by this way of explaining too, which is called emptiness, unsurpassed,

perfect awakening is hard to come by, and fully and perfectly awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening is supremely hard to come by. Why is that? Venerable Subhūti, space does not think, 'I shall fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect awakening.' Venerable Subhūti, in just the same way, these phenomena too are not something to be fully awakened to."

Why is this so? Venerable Subhūti, it is because all phenomena are equal to space. Venerable Subhūti, if unsurpassed, perfect awakening were truly something that could come about, then the bodhisattvas, as many as the sands of the Ganges, would have become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect awakening. Yet, Venerable Subhūti, bodhisattvas as many as the sands of the Ganges do turn back from unsurpassed, perfect awakening. Therefore, Venerable Subhūti, you should understand that unsurpassed, perfect awakening is difficult to come about, and that fully awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening is supremely difficult to come about.

When this was said, the Venerable Subhūti spoke to the Venerable Śāriputra as follows. Venerable Śāriputra, does form turn back from unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it does not. Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, is there, apart from form, some phenomenon that turns back from unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, there is not. Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, do feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness turn back from unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, they do not. Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, is there, apart from feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness, some phenomenon that turns back from unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, there is not.

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, does the suchness of form turn back from unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it does not. Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, does the suchness of feeling, the suchness of perception, the suchness of formations, and the suchness of consciousness turn back from unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it does not. Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, is there, apart from the suchness of form, some phenomenon that turns back from unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, there is not. Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, is there, apart from the suchness of feeling, the suchness of perception, the suchness of formations, and the suchness of consciousness, some phenomenon that turns back from unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, there is

not.

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, does form fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it does not. Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, do feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, they do not.

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, does the phenomenon that is fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening exist apart from form? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it does not. Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, does the phenomenon that is fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening exist apart from feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it does not.

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, is whatever is the suchness of form fully awakened to as unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it is not. Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, is whatever is the suchness of feeling, the suchness of perception, the suchness of formations, and the suchness of consciousness fully awakened to as unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it is not.

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, does whatever phenomenon is fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening exist apart from the suchness of form? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it does not. Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, does whatever phenomenon is fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening exist apart from the suchness of feeling, the suchness of perception, and the suchness of formations, or apart from the suchness of consciousness? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it does not.

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, is whatever is form to be known as unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it is not. Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, is whatever is feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness to be known as unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it is not.

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, is whatever phenomenon is other than form to be known as unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it is not. Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, is whatever phenomenon is other than feeling, perception, and formations, and other than consciousness, to be known as unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it is not.

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, is whatever is the suchness of form to be known as unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it is not. Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, is whatever is the suchness of feeling, the suchness of perception, the suchness of formations, and the suchness of consciousness to be known as unsurpassed, perfect awakening? Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, it is not.

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, is whatever phenomenon is other than the suchness of form to be known as unsurpassed, perfect awakening?

Śāriputra said, "Venerable Subhūti, it is not so."

Subhūti said, "Venerable Śāriputra, is there any phenomenon, other than the suchness of feeling, other than the suchness of perception, other than the suchness of the formations, other than the suchness of consciousness, that is to be known as unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?"

Śāriputra said, "Venerable Subhūti, there is not."

Subhūti said, "Venerable Śāriputra, what do you think: does suchness turn back from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?"

Śāriputra said, "Venerable Subhūti, it does not."

Subhūti said, "Venerable Śāriputra, what do you think: does that phenomenon which turns back from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening exist in suchness?"

Śāriputra said, "Venerable Subhūti, it does not."

Subhūti said, "Venerable Śāriputra, then what is that phenomenon which turns back from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, abiding in the manner of not abiding in that very nature of reality? And what is that phenomenon which has become suchness? Venerable Śāriputra, can suchness itself ever turn back?"

Śāriputra said, "Venerable Subhūti, it cannot."

Subhūti said, "Venerable Śāriputra, since all phenomena, in this way, in truth and in their abiding, cannot be apprehended, what is that phenomenon which could turn back from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?"

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Śāriputra said to the venerable Subhūti, "By the manner of the Dharma as the venerable elder Subhūti has explained it, there is no phenomenon at all that turns back from unsurpassed,

perfect, complete awakening. Venerable Subhūti, the three kinds of persons belonging to the vehicle of the bodhisattvas were taught by the Tathāgata. But according to what the venerable Subhūti has shown, there would be no establishing of three; there would be only one vehicle, namely the Buddha vehicle, the bodhisattva vehicle."

Then the venerable Pūrṇa, son of Maitrāyaṇī, said to the venerable Śāriputra, "Venerable Śāriputra, does the venerable elder Subhūti not acknowledge even a single follower of the Śrāvaka Vehicle, or of the Pratyekabuddha Vehicle, or a bodhisattva of the Great Vehicle? Let us first put this question to the elder, the venerable Subhūti."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the venerable elder Subhūti, "Venerable Subhūti, do you not acknowledge even a single follower of the Śrāvaka Vehicle, or of the Pratyekabuddha Vehicle, or a bodhisattva of the Great Vehicle?"

Subhūti said, "Venerable Śāriputra, in the suchness of suchness, do you perceive even a single follower of the Śrāvaka Vehicle, or of the Pratyekabuddha Vehicle, or a bodhisattva of the Great Vehicle?"

Śāriputra said, "Venerable Subhūti, I do not. Since suchness itself cannot be apprehended in any of the three ways, how much less a bodhisattva."

Subhūti said, "Venerable Śāriputra, then is suchness apprehended in even a single way?"

Śāriputra said, "Venerable Subhūti, it is not so."

Subhūti said, "Venerable Śāriputra, do you then see, correctly and in accordance with reality, even a single dharma of a bodhisattva in suchness?"

Śāriputra said, "Venerable Subhūti, it is not so."

Subhūti said, "Venerable Śāriputra, since in this way even that dharma of a bodhisattva is not apprehended in true reality and in the abiding nature, why do you think, 'This one belongs to the vehicle of the śrāvakas, this one belongs to the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas, and this one belongs to the Great Vehicle'?"

"Śāriputra, when bodhisattvas, great beings, hear that all the distinctions made within suchness are without difference, without distinction, and incapable of being made separate, and if that bodhisattva, that great being, is not discouraged, is not utterly disheartened, and does not turn back, then it

should be known that this bodhisattva, this great being, is certain to go forth to awakening."

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti, "Subhūti, so it is. So it is. Subhūti, it is by the power of the Tathāgata and the blessing of the buddhas that you have the confidence to speak in this way. Excellent, Subhūti! Excellent! Indeed, when bodhisattvas, great beings, hear that all the distinctions made within suchness are without difference, without distinction, and incapable of being made separate, and are not discouraged, are not utterly disheartened, and do not turn back, then, Subhūti, it should be known that such a bodhisattva, such a great being, is certain to go forth to awakening."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, by what awakening will this bodhisattva, this great being, be certain to go forth?"

The Blessed One said, "Śāriputra, it is by unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening that this bodhisattva, this great being, will be certain to go forth."

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to go forth with certainty to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, how should he abide, and how should he train?"

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to go forth with certainty to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening should abide in evenness toward all sentient beings. He should generate a mind of evenness toward all sentient beings. That is, he should regard others with a mind free of partiality. He should regard others with a mind of loving-kindness. He should regard others with a mind of benefit. He should regard others with a mind of virtue. He should regard others with a mind that has broken down pride. He should regard others with a mind free of hostility. He should regard others with a mind free of harmfulness. He should regard others with a mind free of enmity. He should establish the perception that every sentient being is a mother, and the perception that every sentient being is a father, a son, or a daughter, and in this way regard others.

"Subhūti, in this way a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to attain manifest, complete awakening in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening should abide toward all sentient beings in this manner, and should train in this manner. He should resolve, 'I shall become the protector of all sentient beings.' And he himself should abide in turning away from all evil."

Practice generosity, guard moral discipline, cultivate patience, undertake diligence, settle in meditative concentration, and become fully developed in wisdom. Observe dependent origination, both in its accordant and in its non-accordant order. Urge others as well to do likewise, speak in praise of this, and rejoice in it in accord with them. In the same way, from the truths up to the bodhisattva's entry into the state beyond fault, and while abiding in the full maturing of sentient beings, one should urge others as well to this, speak its praise, and rejoice in it in accord with them. One who wishes in this way and trains in this way will come, through the manner of being without obscurations, to abide in the sacred Dharma, and will come as far as the nature that is without obscurations.

This is the sixteenth chapter, called "Suchness," of the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Then the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what are the aspects of an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being? What are the signs, and what are the marks? Blessed One, how am I to recognize an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being?"

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, the ground of ordinary beings, the ground of the śrāvakas, the ground of the pratyekabuddhas, and the ground of the buddhas are all called the ground of suchness. For the suchness of all of these there is no duality and nothing that can be made into two; it is without thought and without conceptualization. One who enters into that suchness and that nature of reality, who abides in suchness, does not think about suchness and does not conceptualize it. One who thus enters and has thus entered, having heard suchness just as it is, and having gone even beyond that, does not feel regret, saying 'It is not like this.' He feels no doubt, no hesitation, and no bewilderment. Rather, he is convinced and he comprehends, saying 'This is suchness; it is just so.' He does not come to speak at random, but speaks words that are connected with meaning, never words disconnected from meaning. And he does not look to what others have done or left undone.

"Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who possesses these aspects, these signs, and these marks should be understood to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, does not look to the faces of other ascetics and brahmins, thinking 'These people know what is to be known and have seen what is to be seen.' He does not pay

homage to other gods. He does not think of offering flowers, incense, perfume, garlands, unguents, powders, robes, parasols, banners, bells, flags, or lamps to other gods, and he does not rely on other gods. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who also possesses these aspects, these signs, and these marks should be understood to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

"Moreover, Subhūti, those irreversible bodhisattvas, great beings, are not born in the lower realms, and they do not take on the condition of a woman.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, takes up and abides in the ten paths of virtuous action. He himself abstains from taking life, and he also establishes others in abstaining from taking life."

He himself abstains from taking what is not given, and he also establishes others in abstaining from taking what is not given. He himself abstains from sexual misconduct, and he also establishes others in abstaining from sexual misconduct. He himself abstains from the occasion of heedlessness that comes from grain liquor and prepared liquor, and he also establishes others in abstaining from it. He himself abstains from false speech, and he also establishes others in abstaining from false speech. He himself abstains from divisive speech, and he also establishes others in abstaining from divisive speech. He himself abstains from harsh speech, and he also establishes others in abstaining from harsh speech. He himself abstains from idle chatter, and he also establishes others in abstaining from idle chatter. He himself abstains from covetousness, and he also establishes others in abstaining from covetousness. He himself abstains from malice, and he also establishes others in abstaining from malice. He himself abstains from wrong view, and he also establishes others in abstaining from wrong view.

Subhūti, in this way an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, himself takes up and abides in the ten paths of virtuous action, and he also teaches others the ten paths of virtuous action, establishes them in them, encourages them, delights them, and makes them steadfast. Even in a dream, none of the ten paths of non-virtuous action, whether one or many, ever arises in him in any way whatsoever, and he does not engage in them even in thought.

Furthermore, Subhūti, even in the dreams of that irreversible bodhisattva, that great being, the ten paths of virtuous action become manifest. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has these aspects, these signs, and these marks should be understood to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect,

complete awakening.

Furthermore, Subhūti, whatever Dharma an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, comes to understand and gives to others, he understands and gives it with this thought: "I shall give this Dharma for the sake, the benefit, and the happiness of all sentient beings. May all sentient beings, through this teaching of the Dharma, come to have their aspiration for the Dharma fulfilled." And he shares this gift of the Dharma in common with all sentient beings. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has these aspects, these signs, and these marks should be understood to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Furthermore, Subhūti, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, is not discouraged when profound Dharma is being taught; he has no hesitation and no doubt, and he does not become bewildered. His speech becomes beneficial, his speech becomes fitting, and his speech becomes gentle. He becomes free of dullness and sleeps little. He is free of latent tendencies. Whether he is coming or going, he goes and comes with a mind that is not confused. He goes with mindfulness well established, and he comes with mindfulness well established. He does not set his feet down on the ground slowly or lift them slowly. He sets them down and lifts them comfortably, he does not raise his feet or place them on the ground carelessly or clumsily, and he steps forward on the ground with full awareness, seeing where he steps.

Subhūti, the robes that an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, wears on his body also do not wear out. His conduct becomes careful, he is little troubled by harm, and he has few faults. The eighty thousand kinds of worms that live in the bodies of other beings do not arise at all, in any way, anywhere in his body. Why is that? Subhūti, the roots of virtue of an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, are exalted above the whole world. As those roots of virtue grow, in just that way the bodhisattva, the great being, also comes to hold a body that is utterly pure, a speech that is utterly pure, and a mind that is utterly pure.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, how should one recognize the utter purity of the mind of a bodhisattva, a great being?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, as the roots of virtue of the bodhisattva, the great being, grow, in just that way he comes to have a mind with little to do. He holds a mind that is not agitated, a mind without deceit, a mind without crookedness, and a mind without pretense. Subhūti, because his mind is

utterly pure, he passes beyond the grounds of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Subhūti, this is how one should recognize the utter purity of the mind of a bodhisattva, a great being. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who possesses these aspects, these signs, and these marks should be understood to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Furthermore, Subhūti, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, does not hanker after gain, honor, and praise. He is not eager for robes, alms food, bedding and seats, medicines for illness, and requisites. He is not given to jealousy or to much miserliness. When profound teachings are expounded he does not shrink back but becomes steady of mind and deep of understanding. He listens to the Dharma from others with full respect, and whatever Dharma he hears from others, he connects all of it with the Perfection of Wisdom. Whatever worldly crafts and occupations there are, he relies on the Perfection of Wisdom and connects every one of them with the nature of reality. He sees no phenomenon whatsoever that is not connected with the dharmadhātu; he sees everything correctly as joined with it. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who possesses these aspects, these signs, and these marks should be understood to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose Māra the Evil One were to conjure up the eight great hells. In each of those great hells he would conjure up many hundreds of bodhisattvas, many thousands of bodhisattvas, and many hundreds of thousands of bodhisattvas. And he would say to the irreversible bodhisattva, the great being: "These bodhisattvas, great beings, whom the Tathāgata prophesied to be irreversible, have been born in these eight great hells.

Since you too have been prophesied to be irreversible, you too will be born among these eight great hells. So you should confess that mind of awakening and give it up. If you are born in those eight hells, what will buddhahood do for you? If you do this, you will go to the world of the gods.

Even when he says this, if the bodhisattva, the great being, remains unshaken and unmoved in mind, and understands, "For an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, to be born in the lower realms is impossible; there is no occasion for it," then, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, endowed with these aspects, signs, and marks should also be taken to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Furthermore, Subhūti, Māra the Evil One, in the guise of an ascetic, may come to an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, and say: "Confess what you

heard before. Give up what you formerly took up. If you confess this and give it up, then I will come to you again and again. What you have heard in this way is not the word of the Buddha. It was fabricated by poets for their own display. But what I am teaching is what the Buddha has taught; this is the word of the Buddha." If, hearing this, the bodhisattva is shaken and moved, then, Subhūti, you should know that this bodhisattva has not been prophesied by the Tathāgatas, is not certain to attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and does not abide in the state of irreversibility.

But, Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, hears these words from Māra the Evil One and is neither shaken nor moved, relying on the nature of reality, relying on non-arising, non-cessation, and the absence of conditioned activity, and does not go along with others out of faith in them, then he is like this. Subhūti, just as a monk who is an arhat, whose defilements are exhausted, does not follow another out of faith, because he has realized the nature of reality directly and cannot be carried off by Māra the Evil One, so too, Subhūti, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, cannot be turned aside by persons of the Śrāvaka Vehicle or the Pratyekabuddha Vehicle. He is of a nature never to fall back to the level of the śrāvakas or the level of the pratyekabuddhas. He is certain of omniscience and inclines toward complete awakening.

Furthermore, Subhūti, when that bodhisattva, a great being, comes to abide in the state of irreversibility, then he will not be placed in the keeping of others. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, endowed with these aspects, signs, and marks should be taken to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines, sixteenth volume.

Furthermore, Subhūti, someone may come to an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, and say: "This conduct of a bodhisattva is the conduct of saṃsāra. Bring your suffering to an end right here. Do not undergo the suffering and unhappiness of conduct in repeated saṃsāra."

"Alas, mother! For now, in this very life, these aggregates of yours will not come to be accomplished; how then could you even think of taking up other aggregates?" If, being spoken to in this way, that bodhisattva is not disturbed and does not waver, then Māra the Evil One will come in person and say to him: "There were bodhisattvas, great beings, who for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges served buddhas, the Blessed Ones, with robes, almsfood, bedding and seats, medicines for the sick, and requisites.

They lived the holy life in the presence of as many buddhas, the Blessed Ones, as there are grains of sand in the Ganges. They honored and attended those buddhas, and for the sake of this very vehicle of the bodhisattvas they inquired, questioned, and asked again and again: 'How should bodhisattvas, great beings, abide?' And they abided just as those Tathāgatas taught them, practiced just so, and trained in yoga just so. Yet even they did not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. If even those who stayed within such instruction and guidance, and who trained in this way, did not attain omniscience, then how could you possibly attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?"

If even after such words he is not disturbed and does not waver, then Māra the Evil One will magically conjure monks in that very place, and they will say: "Those monks who are arhats, whose defilements are exhausted, had set out for awakening, and yet now they have attained only arhatship and abide in arhatship. So how could you possibly attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?" If such things are said and shown to the bodhisattva, the great being, and his mind is still not disturbed and does not waver, then that bodhisattva, great being, should be understood to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

If, having heard such words meant to turn him away from others, that bodhisattva, great being, does not fall away from the nature of reality, his mind does not turn back, his mind does not change, and he knows all these deeds of Māra for what they are, then, Subhūti, it is impossible, there is no occasion, for a bodhisattva, great being, who practices the perfections in this way, to fail to attain omniscience.

A bodhisattva, great being, who practices and trains in this way, who is not separated from the conduct that the Tathāgata has taught, and who is not separated from those attentions that accord with the perfections, cannot possibly give Māra the Evil One an opening. That is impossible, there is no occasion for it.

If that bodhisattva, great being, understands the deeds of Māra, and having heard from others words meant to turn him away does not fall away, his mind does not turn back, and his mind does not change, because he knows those deeds of Māra in this way, then, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, great being, who has these aspects, these signs, and these marks should likewise be understood to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Subhūti, furthermore, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, does not form the perception of form, and does not generate the perception of form. In the same way, he has no perception of feeling, no perception of perception, and no perception of formations; he does not form the perception of consciousness, and does not generate the perception of consciousness. Why is that? Because an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, being empty of intrinsic characteristics, enters without fault into the bodhisattva's path through phenomena. Yet he does not apprehend those phenomena, and does not form or generate any notion of them. Therefore he is said to have attained the forbearance of the wisdom of non-arising. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has these aspects, these signs, and these marks should be taken to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Subhūti, furthermore, Māra the Evil One, having transformed himself into the guise of a monk, may come into the presence of a bodhisattva, a great being, and try to turn back the bodhisattva's resolve. He says: "Omniscience is like space. This thing called omniscience does not exist. This thing called omniscience is not something that is. Who could know it? Who could become fully and completely awakened to it? Nothing at all comes forth from it. That which fully awakens, that which is to be fully awakened to, that which knows, and that which is to be known, all these phenomena are like space. You are tormenting yourself for no purpose. The claim that one should become fully and completely awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening is shown to be Māra's work. This was not taught by the Buddha." And the son or daughter of good family should understand, think, and recognize in this way: "Whatever draws one away from awakening, this is the work of Māra." Having thought in this way, he should make his mind steadfast regarding it, keeping his mind unshaken and not letting it be carried away. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has these aspects, these signs, and these marks should be taken to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Subhūti, furthermore, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, turns away from the grounds of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas and enters into omniscience. If he wishes, he enters into the first meditative concentration. In the same way he enters the second, the third, and the fourth meditative concentration. He abides in those four concentrations and becomes thoroughly familiar with meditative concentration. Although he enters into these concentrations, he is not reborn through the power of concentration. Instead, by his own wish, he abides in the states of the desire realm. Subhūti, this too

should be understood as a defining mark of the irreversibility of an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being.

Subhūti, furthermore, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, does not make a great matter of his name. He does not make a great matter of fame, reputation, or verses of praise, and he has no attachment to a name. His mind is undisturbed, and his mind becomes one of benefit toward all sentient beings. When he goes and when he comes, he does not go with a confused mind and does not come with a confused mind; he comes mindfully and goes mindfully.

Even if such a bodhisattva dwells in the household life, he does not become attached to the objects of desire, nor does an excessive inclination toward them arise in him. He engages with desires while perceiving them as a source of weariness, and while perceiving them as fearsome. Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose a man goes into a wilderness haunted by bandits and takes a meal there. He eats in a state of fear, and he eats thinking only of moving on, reflecting, "How long before I get out of this bandit-ridden wilderness?" Perceiving things in this way, he eats in haste. In just the same way, Subhūti, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, even when dwelling in the household life, engages with whatever objects of desire he enjoys without seeking them, without craving them, and without clinging to them. He becomes one who does not seek after the five strands of sensual pleasure, whose nature is delight and whose nature is bliss.

While dwelling in the household life, they do not make their living by means fair or unfair. They live by the Dharma alone and do not live by what is contrary to the Dharma. Even at the cost of their lives, they would not readily harm another. Why is this? It is because those who are noble persons, great persons, supreme persons, most excellent persons, beautiful persons, the best of the herd among persons, vast persons, chief persons, foremost persons, cherished persons, lotus persons, white lotus persons, wise persons, elephant persons, lion persons, those who turn the reins of those to be trained, bring all beings to hold to the supreme of bliss. Subhūti, such bodhisattvas, great beings, dwell in the household life because they have gained the power produced by the Perfection of Wisdom. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, endowed with these aspects, these signs, and these marks should also be held to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the great yakṣa Vajrapāṇi constantly follows close behind an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being. Such a bodhisattva is hard to overcome, and neither humans nor non-humans are able to get past him. He becomes hard for all beings to approach. His mind is not distracted. He does not have deficient faculties; his faculties are fully complete, and he is never without fully complete faculties. He is endowed with the faculties of the best of the herd among persons, and he is never other than a noble person. He never applies, in any way whatever, to women the classes of mantras, ointments, spells, medicines, and other means of bringing them under his control. His livelihood becomes entirely pure, and he does not live by wrong livelihood. He does not become one who is by temperament quarrelsome or given to contentious speech. He does not disparage those whose views are upright, and he does not slander others. He is endowed with these good qualities and with others as well. He does not make predictions to men or women, saying, "You will have a son," or "You will have a daughter." Such faults of a prognosticator do not arise in him; no such nature is found in him.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who is endowed with these aspects, these signs, and these marks should be held to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Furthermore, Subhūti, I shall now set forth the aspects, the signs, and the marks by which one should know a bodhisattva, a great being, to be irreversible from unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. What are they?

Such bodhisattvas do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice, and the continued practice, of the aggregates, the sense sources, the elements, and dependent origination. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice, and the continued practice, of talk that delights in company and idle gatherings. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice of talk about kings, nor of talk about thieves, nor of talk about armies, nor of talk about quarrels. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice of talk about villages, towns, market towns, regions, countries, and royal palaces and their retinues. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice of talk about themselves. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice of talk about ministers and chief ministers. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice of talk about men, women, and eunuchs. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice of talk about conveyances, pleasure groves, monasteries, palaces, ponds, lakes, pools, tanks, forests, parks, and mountains. They do not dwell in strenuous

application to the practice of talk about yakṣas, rākṣasas, hungry ghosts, flesh-eating piśācas, crawling ghouls, and kumbhāṇḍas. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice of talk about food and drink, clothing, ornaments, incense, garlands, and ointments. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice of talk about the marketplace, crossroads, rest houses, gatherings of merchants, and the bearing of children. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice of talk about song, dance, the reciting of praises, clapping and dancing, and musicians. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice of talk about oceans, rivers, and continents. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice of talk that runs contrary to the Dharma. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice of talk that delights ordinary people.

Rather, they dwell in strenuous application to the practice, and the continued practice, of talk about the Perfection of Wisdom, and they are never separated from the attentive engagement of the mind that is joined with omniscience. They do not dwell in strenuous application to the practice, and the continued practice, of talk about quarrels, disputes, contention, and debate. They desire only the Dharma, and do not desire what is contrary to the Dharma.

They do not delight in quarrels that cause division; they speak words that bring harmony and do not speak words that create discord. They wish for friendship and do not wish for enmity. They speak the Dharma and do not speak what is contrary to the Dharma. They long with yearning only to see the Tathāgata. In other world systems there are Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas who dwell, live and abide there; they give rise to the thought of being born in the presence of those buddhas, and if they wish it, they are born there. Thus they are never separated from seeing the Tathāgata and from serving and honoring the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, Subhūti, when irreversible bodhisattvas, great beings, pass away from among the gods who move in the desire realm, from among the gods who move in the form realm, or from among the gods who move in the formless realm, they are born in this very central region of Jambudvīpa. They are born among human beings who are skilled in the arts, skilled in poetry, skilled in mantras, skilled in the sciences, skilled in treatises, skilled in signs, and skilled in the meaning of the Dharma. Few are born among the people of the border regions; for the most part they are born in the central region. Even those who are born among the people of the border regions are born in great cities, and they too possess these qualities. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great

being, who possesses these aspects, these signs and these marks should be understood to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Furthermore, Subhūti, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, does not think, "Am I irreversible, or am I not irreversible?" For regarding his own stage he feels no doubt and no hesitation, and he does not become wholly discouraged. Subhūti, it is just as a stream-enterer feels no vacillation and no doubt about his own fruit of stream-entry. In the same way, Subhūti, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, feels no vacillation, doubt or hesitation about his own bodhisattva stage, and he does not become wholly discouraged regarding his own stage. He also quickly recognizes the actions of Māra as they arise and occur, and he does not come under the sway of those actions of Māra that arise and occur.

Subhūti, it is just as when a person has committed a deed of immediate retribution: until the time of death he is never separated from the mind of that deed. He can neither dispel nor suppress that mind, and it follows him until the time of death. In the same way, Subhūti, the irreversible mind of an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, abides firmly, and he does not stir from his own irreversible stage. Neither the world with its gods, humans and asuras can move or shake him. He also recognizes the actions of Māra as they arise and occur, and he does not come under their sway. Because he feels no vacillation or doubt about his own stage, even when he passes away, the mind of a śrāvaka and the mind of a pratyekabuddha do not arise in him. Even when he passes away, he thinks, "I will certainly not fail to attain full awakening."

Thinking, "I shall fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect awakening," he remains on his own ground, and he will not be left at the mercy of others; he will not be shaken from his own ground. Why is that? Because he abides endowed with an unplundered mind and unplundered wisdom.

Suppose Māra the Evil One approaches in the guise of a buddha, and having approached, says: "Realize arhatship right here. You have not been prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect awakening. The modes, the signs, and the marks by which a bodhisattva, a great being, fully awakens to unsurpassed, perfect awakening are not found in you; those signs are absent, those marks are absent. Since they do not exist in you, why do you practice this?" If the mind of that bodhisattva, that great being, were to change, then, Subhūti, it should be understood that this bodhisattva, this great being, has not been

prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect awakening by the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas of the past.

But suppose he thinks, "Alas, this is Māra the Evil One, who has magically appeared in the guise of a buddha; or he is under Māra's empowerment, or is an emanation of Māra. This is not the Tathāgata. What the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, has declared is exactly so, and not otherwise." Or suppose he reflects carefully and thinks, "Alas, Māra the Evil One has taken on the appearance of a buddha, wishing to separate me from unsurpassed, perfect awakening." Subhūti, if Māra the Evil One then turns back, it should be understood that this bodhisattva, this great being, has been prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect awakening by the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas of the past, and that he abides on the ground of an irreversible bodhisattva.

Subhūti, if these modes, these signs, and these marks are present in a bodhisattva, a great being, then, in accord with his possessing these qualities, one should understand: "Surely this bodhisattva, this great being, has been prophesied by the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas of the past, and abides on the ground of an irreversible bodhisattva." Why is that? Because those modes, those signs, and those marks of an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, are present in him. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, endowed with those modes, signs, and marks should likewise be taken as irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

Furthermore, Subhūti, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, in order to uphold the sacred Dharma, gives up even his own self and gives up even his life. Therefore, Subhūti, the irreversible bodhisattva, the great being, strives with intense diligence in order to uphold the sacred Dharma.

Out of delight in and reverence for the buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, the future, and the present, and out of delight in and reverence for the Dharma, thinking, "The buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are the body of the Dharma," he takes up the sacred Dharma. He thinks: "This is not only the taking up of the sacred Dharma by the buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past. The taking up of the sacred Dharma by the buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the present is this very same thing, and so too is that of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, who have yet to come. I too am counted among those future buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Therefore I too will be prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. This is my own taking up of the sacred Dharma as well."

Seeing this significance, he gives up even his own body for the sake of taking up the sacred Dharma. He even gives up his life, and in this he does not become discouraged and is not lazy.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has these aspects, these signs, and these marks should be understood to be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Furthermore, Subhūti, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, has no regret and no doubt when the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha, teaches the Dharma.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, is it only with regard to the Tathāgata's teaching of the Dharma that he has no regret and no doubt, and not with regard to that of a śrāvaka?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, he feels no regret and has no doubt even when a śrāvaka teaches the Dharma. Why is that? Because that bodhisattva, that great being, has attained acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena. For that reason he listens in a way that does not contradict the nature of all phenomena, and having heard, he feels no regret and has no doubt. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has these qualities is irreversible. Subhūti, these too should be recognized as the aspects, signs, and marks of a bodhisattva, a great being, who is irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

This is the seventeenth chapter, "The Aspects, Signs, and Marks of Irreversibility," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, it is marvelous that a bodhisattva, a great being, possesses such a vast collection of qualities, that a bodhisattva, a great being, possesses immeasurable qualities, and that a bodhisattva, a great being, possesses incalculable qualities.

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, so it is, so it is. Why is that? Subhūti, an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, attains boundless, limitless wisdom, which cannot be taken away by any śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, even if the Blessed One were to set forth the aspects, signs, and marks of an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges, he would still go on

practicing.

Therefore, Blessed One, please teach the profound, profound points that are connected with the Perfection of Wisdom to the bodhisattva, the great being.

When he had spoken in this way, the Blessed One said this to the venerable Subhūti: "Subhūti, it is excellent, truly excellent, that you wish to know about the profound, profound points. Subhūti, 'profound' is a synonym for emptiness. Subhūti, 'profound' is a synonym for the signless, the wishless, the unconditioned, the unarisen, the unborn, the non-existent, freedom from attachment, cessation, and nirvāṇa, and for what has become free."

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, is this a synonym only for those phenomena, or is it also a synonym for all phenomena?"

The Blessed One said: "Subhūti, this is a synonym for all phenomena as well. Why is that? Subhūti, form is profound. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are profound."

"Subhūti, how is form profound? And how, Subhūti, are feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness profound? Subhūti, form is profound in just the way that suchness is. In the same way, feeling, perception, and formations are profound, and, Subhūti, consciousness is profound in just the way that suchness is. Subhūti, in this regard, form is profound in just the way that the suchness of form is. In the same way, feeling, perception, and formations are profound in just the way that the suchness of feeling, the suchness of perception, and the suchness of formations are; and, Subhūti, consciousness is profound in just the way that the suchness of consciousness is.

"Subhūti, that in which there is no form is the profundity of form. In the same way, Subhūti, that in which there is no feeling, no perception, no formations, and no consciousness is the profundity of feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness."

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, it is wonderful that, through subtle skillful means, one is turned away even from form and nirvāṇa is shown; and in the same way, that through subtle skillful means one is turned away even from feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness, and nirvāṇa is shown."

The Blessed One said: "Subhūti, whoever reflects on, weighs, and thoroughly considers these profound, profound points connected with the Perfection of Wisdom, thinking, 'I shall abide just as it is taught in the Perfection of Wisdom; I shall train just as it is explained in the Perfection of Wisdom; I shall

accomplish just as it is closely taught in the Perfection of Wisdom'; and who practices in that way, reflects closely in that way, examines thoroughly in that way, applies himself in that way, makes effort in that way, and strives in that way, and who practices yoga in this for even a single day, how much activity does that bodhisattva, that great being, accomplish in that one day?

"Subhūti, suppose, for example, there were a man of passionate temperament, given to conceptual thought. And suppose that this man of passionate temperament, given to conceptual thought, had made an assignation with a beautiful woman, lovely to behold and delightful to see, and that this woman was one who was held by another."

If he has no power to leave the household and come and go as he wishes, Subhūti, what do you think? What kinds of conceptual thoughts would arise in that man?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, the thoughts that arise in that man would be only those connected with the woman. He would think, "I will go to her, and with her I will indulge in such pleasures; in this way I will take delight, in this way I will play, in this way I will wander about in enjoyment."

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Until the day has passed, how many conceptual thoughts would arise in that man?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, until the day has passed, a great many conceptual thoughts would arise in that man.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, however many conceptual thoughts arise in that man until the day has passed, for that many eons a bodhisattva, a great being, turns his back on saṃsāra, casts it aside, and brings it to an end. As for one who abides in this Perfection of Wisdom, who studies it, realizes it, reflects on it closely, and practices it in yoga, just as it is set forth, taught, closely explained, shown, and thoroughly demonstrated, such a one also removes those faults through which a bodhisattva, a great being, would turn back from unsurpassable, perfect awakening.

Subhūti, in this way the bodhisattva, the great being, who exerts himself in the practice of the Perfection of Wisdom and who abides in this manner, accomplishes this much in a single day through the attention that accompanies the Perfection of Wisdom.

Suppose a bodhisattva, devoid of the Perfection of Wisdom, were to remain for eons as many as the sands of the river Gaṅgā, giving gifts. And suppose a

bodhisattva, a great being, were to practice the Perfection of Wisdom in yoga for even a single day. This latter is more excellent than the former.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose a bodhisattva were to remain for eons as many as the sands of the river Gaṅgā, giving gifts to stream-enterers and establishing them in the Dharma. Likewise he gives gifts to once-returners, to non-returners, and to arhats, and establishes them. He gives gifts to pratyekabuddhas and establishes them. He gives gifts to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, and establishes them. Yet he is devoid of the Perfection of Wisdom. And suppose a bodhisattva, a great being, were to practice in yoga, for even a single day, just as it is closely explained, taught, and thoroughly demonstrated in the Perfection of Wisdom. This bodhisattva, this great being, generates far greater merit.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose a bodhisattva were to remain for eons as many as the sands of the river Gaṅgā, giving gifts to beings from stream-enterers up to the perfectly awakened buddhas and establishing them, and were also to bring moral discipline to complete perfection, yet were devoid of the Perfection of Wisdom. And suppose a bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in the Perfection of Wisdom, were to attend to it, and rising from that attention were to teach the Dharma.

Subhūti, this bodhisattva, this great being, generates far more merit than the former bodhisattva.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose a bodhisattva remains for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā, and from the stream-enterers up to the perfectly complete buddhas, offers gifts to them and establishes them in virtue. Suppose he also brings moral discipline to full perfection and is endowed with patience, yet is separated from the Perfection of Wisdom. And suppose another, a bodhisattva, a great being who abides in the Perfection of Wisdom, rises from that very attention and gives the gift of the Dharma. Then, Subhūti, this bodhisattva, this great being, generates far more merit than the former bodhisattva.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose a bodhisattva remains for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā, and from the stream-enterers up to the perfectly complete buddhas, offers gifts and establishes them in virtue. Suppose he brings moral discipline to full perfection, is endowed with patience, and undertakes diligence, and devotes himself to the meditative concentrations and to the factors that are on the side of awakening, yet is

separated from the Perfection of Wisdom. And suppose a bodhisattva, a great being, having given the gift of the Dharma in this way, dedicates it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Then, Subhūti, this bodhisattva, this great being, generates far more merit than the former bodhisattva.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose a bodhisattva, a great being, gives the gift of the Dharma in this way and dedicates it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening through the dedication taught in the Perfection of Wisdom. Then he generates far more merit than the one before.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose a bodhisattva, a great being, gives the gift of the Dharma in this way and dedicates it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening through the dedication taught in the Perfection of Wisdom, but, having dedicated it, does not practice by correctly establishing it within. And suppose another bodhisattva, a great being, gives the gift of the Dharma in this way, dedicates it to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening through the dedication taught in the Perfection of Wisdom, and, having dedicated it, does practice by correctly establishing it within. When he practices by correctly establishing it within, that correct establishing within is embraced by the Perfection of Wisdom and is not separated from the Perfection of Wisdom. This bodhisattva, this great being, generates far more merit.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, when the Blessed One has said that this manifest composing is conceptual construction, in what way, then, is it said that much merit is generated?

The Blessed One replied: Subhūti, the merit that a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom manifestly composes, even that, as things now appear, appears just like something shown; it appears as something accumulated; it appears as something nourished; it appears as something without essence.

Furthermore, Subhūti, to whatever extent a bodhisattva, a great being, discerns all phenomena individually in this way, to that same extent, Subhūti, the bodhisattva, the great being, is not separated from the Perfection of Wisdom. And furthermore, Subhūti, to whatever extent a bodhisattva, a great being, is not separated from the Perfection of Wisdom, to that same extent he generates merit that is immeasurable and incalculable.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, what difference is there, what distinction, between the immeasurable and the incalculable?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, "immeasurable" means that to which no measure applies. Subhūti, "incalculable" means that which cannot be exhausted by counting.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, is there a way of speaking by which even form comes to be immeasurable? And likewise, Blessed One, is there a way of speaking by which feeling, perception, and formations, and also consciousness, come to be immeasurable?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, you have asked in these words: "Blessed One, is there a way of speaking by which even form comes to be immeasurable? And likewise feeling, perception, and formations; and, Blessed One, is there a way of speaking by which even consciousness comes to be immeasurable?" Subhūti, there is a way of speaking by which form itself comes to be immeasurable. Likewise, there is a way of speaking by which feeling itself, perception itself, formations themselves, and consciousness itself come to be immeasurable.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, of what is this "immeasurable" a synonym?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, this "immeasurable" is a synonym for emptiness. This "immeasurable" is a synonym for the signless. Subhūti, this "immeasurable" is a synonym for the wishless.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, is this "immeasurable" a synonym for emptiness alone? Blessed One, is this "immeasurable" a synonym for the signless and the wishless alone, and not for other phenomena?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Has it not been taught that all phenomena are empty?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, the Tathāgata has taught that all phenomena are emptiness.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, whatever is emptiness is inexhaustible, and whatever is emptiness is also immeasurable. Therefore, Subhūti, these phenomena are not found to be distinct or different in meaning. Subhūti, they are merely verbal designations, as the Tathāgata has shown and declared.

Whether it is called the immeasurable, the incalculable, the inexhaustible, emptiness, the signless, the wishless, the non-constructed, the non-arising,

the unborn, the non-entity, freedom from attachment, cessation, or nirvāṇa, Subhūti, all of this has been spoken of by the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, as the establishing of the teaching.

Subhūti said:

How wondrous that the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, has taught even this, the very nature of all phenomena, and that this nature of all phenomena is itself inexpressible! Blessed One, as I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has said, all phenomena are indeed inexpressible.

The Blessed One declared: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Subhūti, all phenomena are inexpressible. Why is that? Subhūti, because the emptiness of all phenomena cannot be expressed.

Subhūti asked: Blessed One, is there then any increase or decrease in the meaning of the inexpressible?

The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, there is not.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, if there is no increase and no decrease in the meaning of the inexpressible, then there would be neither increase nor decrease in the perfection of generosity either. In the same way, Blessed One, there would be neither increase nor decrease in the perfection of moral discipline, the perfection of patience, the perfection of diligence, the perfection of meditative concentration, and the perfection of wisdom. Blessed One, if there is neither increase nor decrease in these six perfections, then how, Blessed One, could a bodhisattva, a great being, by the power of six perfections that do not increase, come to be fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening? Or how could he draw near to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening? Blessed One, without bringing the perfections to completion, a bodhisattva, a great being, cannot draw near to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

The Blessed One declared: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Subhūti, although there is indeed no increase or decrease in the meaning of the perfections, nevertheless, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom and meditates on the Perfection of Wisdom, and who is skilled in means, does not think, "This perfection of generosity is increasing; this perfection of generosity is decreasing." Rather, he thinks, "This so-called perfection of generosity is merely a name." Having thought so, he practices

giving, and he dedicates those attentions, those aspirations of mind, and those roots of virtue to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, dedicating them just as unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening truly is.

Furthermore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom and meditates on the Perfection of Wisdom, and who is skilled in means, thinks, "This perfection of moral discipline is increasing."

He does not think, "This perfection of moral discipline is increasing," nor "This perfection of moral discipline is declining." Rather, he thinks, "What is called the perfection of moral discipline is merely a name." Having thought this, he takes up moral discipline properly and abides in it, and he dedicates those acts of attention, those generations of the mind of awakening, and those roots of virtue toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. He dedicates them just as unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening truly is.

Subhūti, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom and meditates on the Perfection of Wisdom, being skilled in means, does not think, "This perfection of patience is increasing," nor "This perfection of patience is declining." Rather, he thinks, "What is called the perfection of patience is merely a name." Having thought this, he cultivates patience, and he dedicates those acts of attention, those generations of the mind of awakening, and those roots of virtue toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. He dedicates them just as unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening truly is.

Subhūti, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom and meditates on the Perfection of Wisdom, being skilled in means, does not think, "This perfection of diligence is increasing," nor "This perfection of diligence is declining." Rather, he thinks, "What is called the perfection of diligence is merely a name." Having thought this, he undertakes diligence, and he dedicates those acts of attention, those generations of the mind of awakening, and those roots of virtue toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. He dedicates them just as unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening truly is.

Subhūti, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom and meditates on the Perfection of Wisdom, being skilled in means, does not think, "This perfection of meditative concentration is increasing," nor "This perfection of meditative concentration is declining." Rather, he thinks, "What is called the perfection of meditative concentration is

merely a name." Having thought this, he settles in meditative equipoise in the concentrations, and he dedicates those acts of attention, those generations of the mind of awakening, and those roots of virtue toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. He dedicates them just as unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening truly is.

Subhūti, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom and meditates on the Perfection of Wisdom, being skilled in means, does not think, "This perfection of wisdom is increasing," nor "This perfection of wisdom is declining." Rather, he thinks, "This perfection of wisdom is merely a name." Having thought this, he practices the Perfection of Wisdom and meditates on the Perfection of Wisdom, and he dedicates those acts of attention, those generations of the mind of awakening, and those roots of virtue toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. He dedicates them just as unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening truly is.

Then the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what then is this that is called unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?"

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, what is called unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening is suchness. Subhūti, suchness neither increases nor diminishes. If a bodhisattva, a great being, remains for long without interruption, endowed with those modes of attention, then he is close to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Subhūti, in the same way, in what is inexpressible there is neither increase nor decrease. By those modes of attention nothing diminishes. Subhūti, in the same way, in the perfections there is neither increase nor decrease. Subhūti, in the same way, in all phenomena there is neither increase nor decrease. Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, abides with such modes of attention, then he is close to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening."

This is the eighteenth chapter, called the chapter on emptiness, from the noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines. The seventeenth volume.

Then the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, does a bodhisattva, a great being, fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening through the first arising of the mind? Or does a bodhisattva, a great being, fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening through a later arising of the mind? Blessed One, the earlier arising of the mind does not meet with the later arising of the mind, and the later arising of the mind does

not meet with the earlier arising of the mind. Then, Blessed One, how do the roots of virtue of a bodhisattva, a great being, come to completion?"

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to the venerable Subhūti: "Subhūti, what do you think? When the flame of an oil lamp is burning, is the wick burned by the first flame that touches it, or is the wick burned by a later flame that touches it?"

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, not so. The wick is not burned by the first flame that touches it, yet without depending on the first flame having arisen, the wick would not be burned. Blessed One, nor is the wick burned by the later flame that touches it, yet without depending on the later flame touching it, the wick would not be burned."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, what do you think? Is that wick burned?"

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, it is burned. Sugata, it is burned."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, in the same way, a bodhisattva, a great being, does not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening through the first arising of the mind, yet without depending on the first arising of the mind he would not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Nor does he awaken through the later arising of the mind, yet without depending on the later arising of the mind he would not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Nor is it that he awakens through those arisings of the mind alone, and neither does he fully awaken through anything other than those arisings of the mind."

A bodhisattva, a great being, also fully awakens to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

When this was said, the venerable Subhūti spoke to the Blessed One as follows. Blessed One, this dependent origination is profound. Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, does not fully awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening through the first generation of the awakening mind; yet without relying on that first generation of the awakening mind, he also does not fully awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. A bodhisattva, a great being, does not fully awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening through the final generation of the awakening mind; yet without relying on the final generation of the awakening mind, he also does not fully awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. He does not fully awaken through those generations of the awakening mind, nor through

any generation of mind other than those; and yet a bodhisattva, a great being, does fully awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows. Subhūti, what do you think? Does a mind that has ceased arise again afterward?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it does not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Is a mind that arises of a nature to cease?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it is of a nature to cease.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Does a mind that is of a nature to cease go on to cease?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it does not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Is a mind that has not arisen of a nature to cease?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it is not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Does a mind that is not of a nature to cease go on to cease?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it does not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Does a mind that neither arises nor ceases, being of a nature that does not cease, go on to cease?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it does not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Does a phenomenon whose essential nature is, by its intrinsic nature, already ceased go on to cease?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it does not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Does the nature of reality of phenomena, whatever it is, go on to cease?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it does not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Does suchness abide just as it is?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, suchness abides just as it is.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? If suchness abides just as it is, then would it not at that time be something that is not permanently fixed?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it would not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Is suchness not profound?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it is profound.

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, what do you think? Does mind exist in suchness?"

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, it does not."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, what do you think? Is the mind itself suchness?"

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, it is not."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, what do you think? Does mind exist apart from suchness?"

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, it does not."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, do you correctly perceive suchness?"

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, I do not."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, what do you think? Does one who practices in this way practice in the profound?"

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, one who practices in this way does not practice in anything at all. Why is that? Because in this there are no engagements to enter into, and no engaging at all."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom, in what does he practice?"

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, he practices in the ultimate."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, what do you think? Does a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in the ultimate, practice in signs?"

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, he does not."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, what do you think? Has he not destroyed that sign?"

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, that is not so."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, what do you think? Does a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom, thereby destroy signs?"

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, when that bodhisattva, that great being, practices the conduct of a bodhisattva, he does not apply himself with the thought, 'May I attain, right here, the abandoning of signs.' For if he were to attain it, then, because the qualities of a buddha would not have been completed, he would become a śrāvaka. Blessed One, he knows what the defining characteristic is and what the sign is, and he also understands that sign, and yet he becomes thoroughly familiar even with the absence of that sign. This is the skillful means of a bodhisattva, a great being."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said this to the venerable Subhūti: "Venerable Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, cultivates in a dream the three doors of liberation, emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness, will his Perfection of Wisdom increase?"

Subhūti replied, "Venerable Śāriputra, if it increases through cultivation by day, then it increases in dreams as well. Why is that? Venerable Śāriputra, the Blessed One has said that dream and daytime are without conceptual distinction. Venerable Śāriputra, if a bodhisattva, a great being, who has found the Perfection of Wisdom practices the Perfection of Wisdom throughout a whole day, then for that bodhisattva, that great being, who is accustomed to the Perfection of Wisdom, the Perfection of Wisdom will also grow in dreams."

Śāriputra said, "Venerable Subhūti, if any man or woman performs in a dream some virtuous or non-virtuous action, does that action accumulate, or become fully accumulated?"

Subhūti replied,

As the Blessed One taught that all phenomena are like a dream, in that way that action is not accumulated, nor is it fully accumulated. Venerable Śāriputra, but suppose that man, having awakened, conceptualizes and generates the perception of having killed; then that action is accumulated and fully accumulated. Venerable Śāriputra, moreover, suppose that someone has taken life in a dream, and then, having awakened, he too thinks in this way: "Ah! I killed it! I killed it well! I killed it thoroughly! It was I who killed it!" If he thinks like that and generates the perception of rejoicing in it, then, venerable Śāriputra, that action is accumulated and fully accumulated.

Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, if that man, having awakened, thinks in this way, conceptualizes, and generates the perception of killing, thinking, "Ah! I killed it! I killed it well! I killed it thoroughly! It was I who killed it!", and if in that case the action is accumulated and fully accumulated, then, since the Buddha, the Blessed One, also brings about the conceptualization that perceives exhaustion, would his action too be accumulated and fully accumulated?

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, that is not so. Why? Because the Tathāgata is free from all thought and conceptualization; he is, as it were, just like space. Venerable Śāriputra, in the same way, without an object of focus no action arises, and without an object of focus no mind arises. Venerable Śāriputra, therefore action arises only together with an object of focus, and not without an object of focus. Mind arises only together with an object of focus, and not without an object of focus. Venerable Śāriputra, the mind engages with phenomena that are seen, heard, understood, and cognized. With some of these the mind takes hold of what is thoroughly afflicted, and with others it takes hold of what is purified. Venerable Śāriputra, therefore volition arises only together with an object of focus, and not without one. Mind arises only together with an object of focus, and not without one.

Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, when the Blessed One has taught that all objects of focus are empty and secluded, then, venerable Subhūti, why does volition arise only together with an object of focus, and not arise without one?

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, volition arises together with an object of focus because one has fixed on a sign and has taken as one's object what is in fact nonexistent; it does not arise without an object of focus. Venerable Śāriputra, volition is secluded, and the sign is also secluded. In the same way, the formations conditioned by ignorance are also secluded. Consciousness conditioned by the formations is also secluded, and so on, up to aging and death conditioned by birth, which are also secluded. Venerable Śāriputra, in the same way all those objects of focus are secluded. Volition too is secluded from signs, yet depending on worldly convention, a mind together with an object of focus arises.

Śāriputra said: Venerable Subhūti, suppose a bodhisattva, a great being, in a dream practices generosity, and also fully dedicates that generosity to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Is that generosity then said to have been fully dedicated?

Subhūti said: Venerable Śāriputra, this bodhisattva, this great being Maitreya, is present here.

"He has been prophesied by the Tathāgata to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, without any interruption. This matter he realizes directly in his own person. Ask him, and he will answer this question."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya: "Venerable Maitreya, the elder Subhūti says that the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, will give the answer to this question. Venerable Invincible One, please give the answer to this question."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, said to the venerable Subhūti: "Venerable Subhūti, you say that the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, will give the answer to this question. Venerable Subhūti, is the name 'Maitreya' what gives the answer to this question? Or is it form that gives the answer? Or is it feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness that give the answer? Or is it color that gives the answer? Or is it shape that gives the answer? Or is it the emptiness of form, whatever that is, that gives the answer? Or is it the emptiness of feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness, whatever that is, that gives the answer?"

"Venerable Subhūti, that which is the emptiness of form cannot give the answer. In the same way, venerable Subhūti, that which is the emptiness of feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness cannot give the answer. Venerable Subhūti, I do not see, as a genuine fact, any phenomenon that gives an answer. I do not see, as a genuine fact, any phenomenon to which an answer is to be given. I do not see, as a genuine fact, any phenomenon by which an answer is to be given. And I do not see, as a genuine fact, any phenomenon that is prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening."

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya: "Venerable Maitreya, just as these phenomena have been taught in words, have you realized them directly in that way?"

Maitreya said: "Venerable Śāriputra, I have not realized these phenomena directly in the way they are taught in words. Venerable Śāriputra, even those phenomena that are expressed in words or conceived by the mind, I do not know in that way, I do not apprehend them, and I do not see them as a genuine fact. Venerable Śāriputra, just as that which cannot be touched by the body, cannot be expressed in words, and cannot be conceived by the mind is

so, in the same way all phenomena too are without intrinsic nature, because they have no inherent existence."

Then the venerable Śāriputra thought: "Ah, this bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, is profound in wisdom. He teaches as one who has practiced the Perfection of Wisdom for a very long time."

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Śāriputra: "Śāriputra, why do you think, 'Ah, this bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, is profound in wisdom'? Śāriputra, by possessing which phenomenon are you distinguished as an arhat? Do you see that phenomenon as a genuine fact?"

Śāriputra replied: "Blessed One, I do not."

The Blessed One said:

Śāriputra, in the same way, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the Perfection of Wisdom, he does not think: "This Dharma has been prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect awakening. This Dharma will be prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect awakening. This Dharma is being prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect awakening. Through this Dharma I will become fully awakened in unsurpassed, perfect awakening." A bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in this way is practicing the Perfection of Wisdom. While practicing, he is not alarmed, he is not frightened, and he does not come to be possessed by terror. Nor does he reflect: "Because I have obtained the power that has been developed, I will not fail to become fully awakened." If he practices like this, he is practicing the Perfection of Wisdom.

Furthermore, Śāriputra, when a bodhisattva, a great being, enters a wilderness haunted by predatory beasts, he should not be alarmed, should not be frightened, and should not be possessed by terror. Why is that? Because he has given up everything for the sake of all sentient beings. He should generate the thought in this way: "If I am eaten by predatory beasts, then I will have given them that gift, and my perfection of generosity will also be fully completed. I will draw close to unsurpassed, perfect awakening. And may it be so that in the buddha field where I become fully awakened in unsurpassed, perfect awakening, those sentient beings who have gone to the animal realm will never, in any way, anywhere, appear at all, nor even be known of, but instead will possess the enjoyments of the gods and the full use of them." This is how he thinks.

Furthermore, Śāriputra, when a bodhisattva, a great being, enters a wilderness haunted by bandits, he should not be alarmed, should not be frightened, and should not be possessed by terror. Why is that? Because a bodhisattva, a great being, delights in the root of virtue that consists in giving up all possessions. A bodhisattva, a great being, must completely abandon even his own body, and likewise all his belongings and necessities. He should generate the thought in this way: "If they plunder all my belongings and necessities, may I have given those gifts to those beings. If someone takes my life, I will not generate malice, anger, or hatred toward him, and I will not harm even those people with body, speech, or mind. In this way, my perfection of generosity, my perfection of moral discipline, and my perfection of patience will be fully completed, and I will draw close to unsurpassed, perfect awakening. And in the buddha field where I become fully awakened in unsurpassed, perfect awakening, may all wildernesses haunted by bandits never, in any way, anywhere, appear at all, nor even be known of." In this way he acts, and in this way he accomplishes it. He thinks: "In the buddha field where I become fully awakened in unsurpassed, perfect awakening, may those faults and others like them never, in any way, anywhere, appear at all, nor even be known of. For the sake of completely purifying the buddha field, I will strive."

Śāriputra, furthermore, when a bodhisattva, a great being, goes into a wilderness that has become a waterless waste, he should not tremble, should not be terrified, should not be possessed by terror. Why is that? A bodhisattva, a great being, is by nature one who does not tremble and is not terrified. He should arouse the thought in this way: "I train in order to cut off the craving for existence in all sentient beings. If I were to die of thirst, I would be born in the world of hungry ghosts." Even so, the bodhisattva, the great being, should not tremble, should not be terrified, should not be possessed by terror. Rather he should think, "Alas, these beings have little merit, for such waterless wastes are seen in this world," and thus arouse a mind of great compassion toward all sentient beings. "In the buddha field of the buddha I shall become, when I fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, waterless wastes shall be wholly, entirely, in every way and by every means nonexistent and unknown. I shall bring it about that all sentient beings find water endowed with the eight qualities. Just so I shall hold fast to merit. Just as my perfection of diligence will then be fully perfected, so for the sake of all sentient beings I shall undertake diligence with firm resolve."

Śāriputra, furthermore, when a bodhisattva, a great being, goes into a wilderness of famine, he should not tremble, should not be terrified, should not be possessed by terror. He should put on the armor in this way: "In the buddha field of the buddha I shall become, when I fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, wildernesses of famine such as these shall be wholly, entirely, in every way and by every means nonexistent and unknown, and all those beings shall be endowed with well-being and happiness and shall meet with every happiness. For this I undertake diligence with firm resolve. In this way I shall purify the buddha field. I shall bring it about that whatever those beings wish, whatever they think of in their minds, is accomplished, just as for the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three everything arises merely by being thought of in the mind. Likewise for those beings everything shall be accomplished merely by being thought of in the mind, and everything thought of shall arise. Just as my perfection of meditative concentration will then be fully perfected, so for the sake of all sentient beings I shall strive to purify my own mind." Thinking thus, he undertakes diligence with firm resolve, so that the Dharma aspirations of those beings may be fully perfected, and so that all the necessities of life of all sentient beings may never, at any time, in any way, be lacking.

Śāriputra, furthermore, when a bodhisattva, a great being, goes into a wilderness of sickness, he should not tremble, should not be terrified, should not be possessed by terror. He should examine, reflect, and weigh it in this way: "In this, there is no phenomenon that makes one sick, and no phenomenon that is called sickness." Thus he should examine it as empty, and not tremble, not be terrified, not be possessed by terror. Śāriputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, is one who

He should not give rise to the thought, "After a very long time I shall become fully and perfectly awakened in unsurpassable, perfect awakening." He should not generate such a thought, and he should not tremble, should not be terrified, should not be seized by terror. Why is that? Because this single moment of mind is the very end of the beginningless, which is to say that it is endless.

Śāriputra, the bodhisattva, the great being, should not give rise to the perception of difficulty, thinking, "This end of the beginningless is vast and long. This end of the beginningless is joined to a single moment of mind, which is to say it is endless." Thus, Śāriputra, the bodhisattva, the great being, should not tremble, should not be terrified, should not be seized by terror at

the thought, "Only after a very long time shall I become fully and perfectly awakened in unsurpassable, perfect awakening."

Śāriputra, if a bodhisattva, a great being, does not tremble, is not terrified, and is not seized by terror when he sees, hears, understands, and cognizes these and other unbearable terrors, then, Śāriputra, you should know that this son of good family or daughter of good family has the destiny to become fully and perfectly awakened in unsurpassable, perfect awakening.

Śāriputra, the bodhisattva, the great being, having donned the great armor, should act and should undertake steadfast diligence in such a way that, in the buddha field where he becomes fully awakened in unsurpassable, perfect awakening, the illnesses of all sentient beings will in every respect, completely and entirely, not arise and will be unknown. He should act in such a way that he speaks what the Tathāgata has spoken and does just as it has been spoken. And so that the Perfection of Wisdom may be brought to full completion in him at that time, he should become thoroughly familiar with the Perfection of Wisdom for the sake of all sentient beings.

Then, in that assembly, a woman called the goddess Gaṅgā was gathered and seated. She rose from her seat, arranged her upper robe over one shoulder, set her right knee on the ground, and, turning toward the Blessed One, joined her palms, paid homage, and said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, I shall not tremble at this matter, I shall not be terrified, I shall not be seized by terror. Without trembling and without terror, I shall teach the Dharma to all sentient beings."

Then, at that time, the Blessed One smiled, a smile like the color of gold. That light pervaded boundless, limitless world systems and reached as far as the world of Brahmā. Returning, it circled the Blessed One three times and disappeared into the crown of the Blessed One's head.

As soon as the Blessed One had smiled, the woman took golden flowers and scattered them over the Blessed One, strewing them, showering them forth. Then those golden flowers remained unattached in the open space of the sky.

Then the venerable Ānanda rose from his seat, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, set his right knee on the ground, and, turning toward the Blessed One, joined his palms, paid homage, and said to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, does not smile without a cause and without a condition. What, then, is the cause

and what is the condition for the Blessed One's smiling?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, this sister, the goddess of the Gaṅgā River, will in a future time become a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly awakened buddha called Golden Flower, perfect in knowledge and conduct, a Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed leader of those to be tamed, teacher of gods and humans, a buddha, a Blessed One, who will appear in the world. In the eon called Star-like, he will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

"Ānanda, this sister, the goddess of the Gaṅgā, will change from a female body and obtain a male body. After she passes away from here, she will be born in the buddha field of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Akṣobhya, in the world realm called Abhirati, Manifest Joy. Born there, she will practice the holy life in the presence of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Akṣobhya. Passing away from there, she will never be parted from the sight of the Tathāgatas, and will go from buddha field to buddha field. Then again, from the buddha field where she is never separated from the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, she will go from buddha field to buddha field, going to this one and that one.

"Ānanda, it is just as a wheel-turning king goes from palace to palace. For as long as he lives, he goes without the soles of his feet touching the ground, and even at the time of death he dies without the soles of his feet having touched the ground. In just the same way, Ānanda, this sister, the goddess of the Gaṅgā, will go from buddha field to buddha field, and until she fully awakens to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, she will never be parted from the buddhas, the Blessed Ones."

Then the venerable Ānanda thought: "The bodhisattvas, the great beings, who sit in the presence of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Akṣobhya, should be known as those who have gathered into the Tathāgata himself."

Then the Blessed One, knowing with his mind the thought in the mind of the venerable Ānanda, spoke to him: "So it is, Ānanda, so it is. Those bodhisattvas, the great beings, have crossed over the mire, and they practice the holy life in the buddha field of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Akṣobhya. Ānanda, those bodhisattvas, the great beings, should be known as those who are close to the full accomplishment of awakening.

"Furthermore, Ānanda, the community of śrāvakas of that Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Golden Flower, will not be a finite number. Why is that? Ānanda, in that field the śrāvakas will be so many that they will be immeasurable, and what is called the countless and the incalculable will be the number into which they fall.

"Furthermore, Ānanda, at that time, in that period, in that buddha field there will be no wilderness of wild beasts, no wilderness of bandits, no wilderness of water, no wilderness of famine, no wilderness of disease.

Ānanda, those wildernesses of misfortune, and other misfortunes besides, will in that buddha-field be entirely absent, in every respect and in every way, and will not even be known. Ānanda, when the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Suvarṇapuṣpa became fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, such fearsome and unbearable wildernesses were then wholly absent, in every respect and in every way, and were not even known.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda said to him: "Blessed One, in the presence of which Tathāgata did this sister, the goddess Gaṅgādevī, first generate the root of virtue of giving rise to the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect awakening?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, this sister, the goddess Gaṅgādevī, first generated the root of virtue of giving rise to the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect awakening in the presence of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Dīpaṃkara. At that time, with a mind that sought unsurpassed, perfect awakening, she scattered golden flowers before the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara and dedicated them, thinking: 'When I scatter these five stalks of lotus to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Dīpaṃkara, may I also attain acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena.' Then the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Dīpaṃkara prophesied to me, to unsurpassed, perfect awakening: 'Young brahmin, in a future time you will become the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha named Śākyamuni, perfect in knowledge and conduct, the Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed trainer of those to be tamed, teacher of gods and humans, a buddha, a Blessed One.' When this sister heard that prophecy given to me, the thought arose in her: 'Oh, mother! Just as this young brahmin has been prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, what would be wrong if I too

were prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect awakening?' In this way, Ānanda, this sister first generated the root of virtue of giving rise to the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect awakening in the presence of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Dīpaṃkara."

When he had said this, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how wonderful! This sister, the goddess Gaṅgādevī, has indeed trained thoroughly and brought her training to completion, and she has been prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect awakening."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "So it is, Ānanda, so it is, just as you have said. Indeed, this sister, the goddess Gaṅgādevī, has trained thoroughly and brought her training to completion, and she has been prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect awakening."

This is the nineteenth chapter, called "The Goddess Gaṅgādevī," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One:

Blessed One, how should a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom become thoroughly familiar with emptiness? How should he enter into the meditative absorption of emptiness?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, here a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom should closely examine, thinking, "Form is empty." In the same way he should closely examine, "Feeling, perception, the formations, and consciousness are empty." And as he examines in this way, he does not correctly see, in that very nature of things, any intrinsic nature that exists by virtue of that nature. With an undistracted stream of mind he examines in this way; yet because he does not correctly see even that nature of things, he does not make the true limit directly manifest.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Subhūti said to him: Blessed One, you have said that a bodhisattva, a great being, should not make emptiness directly manifest. Blessed One, if a bodhisattva, a great being, abides in that meditative absorption, how is it that he does not make emptiness directly manifest?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, in this regard a bodhisattva, a great being, contemplates emptiness endowed with the supreme of all aspects. Yet he does not think, "I shall make it directly manifest," nor does he think, "I am making it directly manifest." He thinks only, "I shall become thoroughly familiar with it."

He thinks, "This is the time for becoming thoroughly familiar, not the time for making it directly manifest." And thinking, "I shall be held by the Perfection of Wisdom, and I shall not make it directly manifest," he fixes his mind on an object while not yet resting in full equipoise. In that interval, the bodhisattva, a great being, does not fall away from the factors that belong to awakening, and he does not bring about the exhaustion of defilements; and yet he does become thoroughly familiar with this.

When a bodhisattva, a great being, abides in the meditative absorption of emptiness, the door of liberation, then he should also abide in the meditative absorption of the signless, but he should not make the signless directly manifest. Why is this? Because a bodhisattva, a great being, who has firm roots of virtue and possesses the qualities that bring them to full maturity, should closely consider, "This is the time for becoming thoroughly familiar with this, not the time for making it directly manifest." He is held by the Perfection of Wisdom, and he does not make the true limit directly manifest.

Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose there were a man who is exceedingly courageous, endowed with great diligence, steady and firmly grounded. He is of fine appearance, handsome, and pleasing to behold. He has many good qualities and the finest qualities, such as moral discipline, supreme power, learning, and generosity. He is trustworthy, able to speak and able to answer, accomplished in eloquence, endowed with skill in carrying out tasks. He knows the right time, the right region, and the right place. He has reached the summit of skill in archery, and he can turn aside many weapons and even the hardest weapons. He is highly skilled in all the arts, thoroughly accomplished, and has reached the utmost perfection in every field of craft.

He is mindful, intelligent, and discerning; he has faith, he knows the proper way of doing things, and he is fearless in every field of learning. He has friends, wealth, and an army. He lacks no limb and has all his faculties complete; he is perfectly provided with every resource and with a fine retinue. He is dear and pleasing even to many people, and whatever undertaking he begins, he is able to bring it through to completion. He is also one who conducts himself according to sound reasoning. In all of this he has great gain, and because he possesses such great gain, he is kind to many people: he honors those who should be honored, treats as teachers those who should be treated as teachers, esteems those who should be esteemed, and makes offerings to those who deserve offerings.

Subhūti, what do you think? Would that man, on this account, feel great delight, satisfaction, exhilaration, and happiness?

Subhūti replied: Blessed One, he would indeed. Sugata, he would indeed.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, suppose further that this man, endowed with such great good fortune, takes his parents, his children, and his wife, and, together with a certain party of travelers, enters a vast and terrifying wilderness, dreadful and harsh for the simple-minded, called "Hair-Raising." Having arrived there, he reassures his parents, children, and wife, saying: "I will quickly and safely bring you out of this terrible, frightful wilderness, and you will soon be free of it. Do not be afraid; do not be afraid!" And so he grants them fearlessness.

Subhūti, now suppose that in that wilderness many enemies and hostile men appear against this man. What do you think, Subhūti? Would that man, a hero who never turns back, who has insight, diligence, and strength, who is wise, gentle, clever, and steadfast, and who is accompanied by a great company, abandon his parents, children, and wife, and think to go forth alone out of that terrifying, dreadful wilderness?

Subhūti replied: Blessed One, he would not. Why is that? Blessed One, because the man would not abandon his parents, children, and wife. He is also equipped with an army both within and without, and in that wilderness there are others who oppose those enemies and hostile men, who are far more numerous, braver, more heavily armed, and mightier, and who protect him. Therefore those hostile enemies who seek faults and watch for an opening do not find an opportunity. Blessed One, for that reason that powerful man, without being harmed or injured, is able to bring his parents, children, and wife, and himself as well, out of that terrible, dreadful wilderness, and he will soon and safely reach a village, a town, or a market settlement.

When Subhūti had spoken thus, the Blessed One addressed the venerable Subhūti with these words.

Subhūti, in the same way, a bodhisattva, a great being, abides in loving-kindness, which is the wish to benefit all sentient beings and a tender affection for them. He abides in compassion, abides in joy, and abides in equanimity. He is embraced by skillful means and by the Perfection of Wisdom, and he dedicates his roots of virtue through the dedication that the perfectly awakened buddhas have approved. In this way he enters the gateways to liberation, the absorptions of emptiness, signlessness, and

wishlessness. Even so, he does not make any true limit directly manifest on the ground of the śrāvakas or on the ground of the pratyekabuddhas.

Why is that? Because what embraces him is supremely powerful and supremely stable, namely the Perfection of Wisdom and skillful means. Therefore he does not abandon any sentient being, and for that reason he is able to awaken fully and manifestly, in virtue and in happiness, to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, brings to mind the thought of loving-kindness toward all sentient beings, and having brought it to mind, unites himself with them through the supreme of loving-kindness, then that bodhisattva, that great being, has passed far beyond the side of the afflictions and the side of Māra. He has passed far beyond the ground of the śrāvakas and the ground of the pratyekabuddhas, and he abides in that absorption.

Subhūti, even when he sees the exhaustion of defilements, he makes himself thoroughly familiar with emptiness, the supreme of the perfections.

Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, abides in the absorption of emptiness, the gateway to liberation, then during that time he does not abide in the absorption of signlessness, and he has not made the absorption of signlessness directly manifest.

Subhūti, it is like this. A bird moves through the sky. It does not fall to the ground, and it rests on nothing, remaining without support. Though it stays in the very midst of the sky, it neither relies on it nor dwells in it.

In the same way, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, abides by abiding in emptiness, and also makes himself thoroughly familiar with emptiness. He abides by abiding in signlessness, and also makes himself thoroughly familiar with signlessness. He abides by abiding in wishlessness, and also makes himself thoroughly familiar with wishlessness. Yet before the qualities of a buddha are fully perfected, he does not fall into emptiness, signlessness, or wishlessness.

Subhūti, it is like this. A powerful master archer, well trained in the weapon of the arrow and fully accomplished in it, shoots an arrow upward. Having shot it, he sends other arrows to turn it back, and so keeps that arrow from falling to the ground. Against the first arrow he shoots later arrows in an unbroken series, and does not let it fall. For as long as he has not thought, "Alas, let that arrow fall to the ground," the arrow does not fall.

In the same way, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom and is embraced by skillful means, does not make that true limit directly manifest, for as long as the roots of virtue directed toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening have not ripened, and have not become fully ripened.

But when those roots of virtue directed toward unsurpassed, perfect awakening have fully ripened and become thoroughly ripe, then he realizes the ultimate true limit directly. Therefore, Subhūti, the bodhisattva, the great being, should practice the Perfection of Wisdom and should meditate on the Perfection of Wisdom. In this way he should examine and closely contemplate the nature of these profound phenomena, but he should not realize it directly.

Here ends the eighteenth volume of the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

When this had been said, the venerable Subhūti spoke to the Blessed One as follows. Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices emptiness, abides in emptiness, rests in the meditative absorption of emptiness, and yet does not realize the true limit directly, performs a difficult deed. Blessed One, that bodhisattva, that great being, performs a very difficult deed. Blessed One, this is wonderful. Sugata, this is truly wonderful.

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. A bodhisattva, a great being, who practices emptiness, abides in emptiness, rests in the meditative absorption of emptiness, and yet does not realize the true limit directly, performs a difficult deed. That bodhisattva, that great being, performs a very difficult deed.

Why is that? Subhūti, it is because that bodhisattva, that great being, does not abandon any sentient being. For him there arise special aspirations of this kind: "I shall liberate all these sentient beings." When a bodhisattva, a great being, sets his mind thus, "I will not abandon any sentient beings; I will bring all of them to liberation," and at the same time brings about the door of liberation that is the meditative absorption of emptiness, brings about the door of liberation that is the meditative absorption of signlessness, and brings about the door of liberation that is the meditative absorption of wishlessness, at that time the bodhisattva, the great being, should be known as one endowed with skillful means. Until the qualities of a buddha are fully complete, he will not, in the interim, realize the true limit directly.

Why is that? Because he is protected by skillful means. His not abandoning any sentient beings is itself his generation of the awakening mind. One who has generated the mind in this way and is endowed with such skillful means will not, in the interim, realize the true limit directly.

Furthermore, Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, has come to dwell in the profound, that is, in the doors of liberation, namely the meditative absorption of emptiness, the meditative absorption of signlessness, and the meditative absorption of wishlessness, and when he examines these, or wishes to examine them, he should set his mind in this way:

"These beings have long engaged with objects through the perception of a sentient being. Having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, I will teach the Dharma to these beings in order to abandon the view of those who hold to objects." Thinking thus, the bodhisattva rests in equipoise in the concentration of the door of liberation of emptiness, yet does not make the true limit manifest. He rests in equipoise in the concentration of the door of liberation of signlessness, yet does not make the true limit manifest. He rests in equipoise in the concentration of the door of liberation of wishlessness, yet does not make the true limit manifest.

Thus, when a bodhisattva, a great being, possesses this generation of the mind and this skillful means, then even in the interim he does not make the true limit manifest, and he does not fall away from the concentration of loving-kindness. Nor does he fall away from compassion, nor from joy, nor does he completely fall away from the concentration of equanimity. Why is that? Because he is held by skillful means, the bodhisattva, the great being, greatly increases through white, virtuous qualities. His faculties of faith and the rest also become very keen, and he attains the powers, the limbs of awakening, and the paths.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the bodhisattva, the great being, thinks thus: "These beings have long engaged with objects through the perception of phenomena. Having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, I will teach the Dharma in order to abandon the view of those who hold to objects." Thinking thus, for the sake of all beings he rests in equipoise in the concentration of the door of liberation of emptiness. Possessing that generation of the mind and that earlier skillful means, he rests in equipoise in the concentration of the door of liberation of emptiness, yet does not make the true limit manifest. He does not fall away from the concentrations of

loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity. Why is that? Because the bodhisattva, the great being, held by skillful means, greatly increases through white, virtuous qualities. His faculties of faith and the rest also become very keen, and he attains the powers, the limbs of awakening, and the paths.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the bodhisattva, the great being, thinks thus: "These beings have long engaged with signs through the perception of signs. Having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, I will teach the Dharma to them in order to abandon the perception of signs." Thinking thus, for the sake of all beings he rests in equipoise in the concentration of the door of liberation of signlessness. Possessing that generation of the mind and that earlier skillful means, he rests in equipoise in the concentration of the door of liberation of signlessness, yet does not make the true limit manifest, and he does not completely fall away from the concentrations of loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity, nor from any concentration. Why is that? Because he is held by skillful means, the bodhisattva, the great being, greatly increases through white, virtuous qualities. His faculties of faith and the rest also become very keen, and he attains the powers, the limbs of awakening, and the paths.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the bodhisattva, the great being, thinks thus: "These beings have long been mistaken, through the perception of permanence, the perception of happiness, the perception of self, and the perception of the pleasant,

"May I, having awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, teach the Dharma so as to remove the inversions of beings who have been deluded by the perception of permanence, the perception of happiness, the perception of self, and the perception of the beautiful. I will teach that all this is impermanent, and that this is not permanent; that all this is suffering, and that this is not happiness; that all this is without self, and that this is not possessed of a self; that all this is unlovely, and that this is not lovely." One should proceed in just this way.

Endowed with that aspiration to awakening, and skilled in means, and held firmly by the earlier skillful means and by the Perfection of Wisdom, the bodhisattva does not, before the qualities of a buddha are fully perfected, realize the true limit in the interim. In the same way, while abiding in meditative equipoise in the samādhi of the aspirationless door of liberation, the bodhisattva does not realize the true limit. Nor does the bodhisattva fall

away from loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity.

Why is this so? A bodhisattva, a great being, who is held firmly by skillful means grows greatly in the white qualities, and the faculties of faith and the rest become exceedingly keen. Such a bodhisattva also gains the powers, the factors of awakening, and the paths.

Subhūti, when any bodhisattva, any great being, generates this aspiration, thinking: "For a long time these beings have engaged with a focus of attention, and even now they engage with a focus of attention. They have engaged in the perception of signs, and even now they engage in the perception of signs. They have engaged in inversion, and even now they engage in inversion. They have engaged in the perception of wholes, and even now they engage in the perception of wholes. They have engaged in mistaken perception, and even now they engage in mistaken perception. They have engaged in wrong views, and even now they engage in wrong views. How might none of these faults arise in them at all, in any way, in every respect? I will see to it that, through not knowing, they do not fall into these." In this way the bodhisattva thinks of all beings.

That bodhisattva, a great being, being endowed with such knowing mindfulness and such an aspiration to awakening, and also being endowed with skillful means and held firmly by the Perfection of Wisdom, examines in this way the nature of these profound phenomena, seeing it as emptiness, or as signlessness, or as aspirationlessness, or as non-conditioning, or as non-arising, or as non-production, or as the absence of any real entity.

Subhūti, for a bodhisattva, a great being, who is endowed with such knowing qualities, to fall into the state of non-conditioning, or to remain together with the three realms, is not possible; there is no opportunity for it.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect awakening should put this question to other bodhisattvas, great beings: "Do you not bring emptiness into direct experience? Do you not bring the signless into direct experience? Do you not bring the wishless into direct experience? Do you not bring non-conditioning into direct experience? Do you not bring non-arising into direct experience? Do you not bring non-production into direct experience? Do you not bring the absence of entities into direct experience? And while you also cultivate the Perfection of Wisdom, what is it that you should become thoroughly familiar with in these teachings? And when you bring about such states of mind, in

what kind of intrinsic nature should you bring them about?"

Subhūti, suppose that a bodhisattva, a great being, is questioned in this way by another bodhisattva, a great being. If he replies, "A bodhisattva, a great being, should attend to emptiness. A bodhisattva, a great being, should attend to the signless, the wishless, non-conditioning, non-arising, non-production, and the absence of entities," and so gives his prediction in this way, but does not set forth that mind which never abandons any sentient being, and does not show skillful means, then, Subhūti, you should know that this bodhisattva, a great being, was not predicted by the Tathāgatas of the past, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, as irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

Why is that? Because he does not teach, does not distinguish, does not explain, and does not understand those unshared qualities that belong to the irreversible bodhisattva, the great being. Even when questioned he gives no prediction and no reply, and he does not stand upon the ground that belongs to the irreversible bodhisattva, the great being.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, is there a way by which a bodhisattva, a great being, becomes irreversible?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, there is a way by which a bodhisattva, a great being, becomes irreversible. If a bodhisattva, a great being, whether he has heard this Perfection of Wisdom or not, understands it in this way and answers in this way, he should be recognized as an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, then although many practice for awakening, few answer in this way.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, so it is. Those bodhisattvas, great beings, who are predicted to the stage of irreversible wisdom are few; but those who have been so predicted do answer in this way. You should know that these bodhisattvas, great beings, have made their roots of virtue blaze. These bodhisattvas, great beings, cannot be swept away by the world with its gods, humans, and asuras.

Furthermore, Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, even in a dream, rightly sees all phenomena as like a dream and does not bring them into direct experience, then, Subhūti, you should recognize this too as a defining mark of the irreversibility of the irreversible bodhisattva, the great being.

Subhūti, furthermore, if a bodhisattva, a great being, even in a dream has no longing for the level of the śrāvakas or the level of the pratyekabuddhas or for the three realms, and does not generate a mind that seeks their benefits, then, Subhūti, this too should be understood as a mark of irreversibility in an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being.

Subhūti, furthermore, if a bodhisattva, a great being, even in a dream sees himself seated in the middle of an assembly of many hundreds, many thousands, many hundreds of thousands, many hundreds of millions, many thousands of millions, many hundreds of thousands of millions, and many hundreds of thousands of billions of beings, in the center of the circle of that assembly, surrounded by the community of monks and with the community of bodhisattvas gathered before him, and sees himself, having become a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly complete buddha, teaching the Dharma, then, Subhūti, this too should be understood as a mark of irreversibility in an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being.

Subhūti, furthermore, if a bodhisattva, a great being, even in a dream rises into the sky and teaches the Dharma to beings; or if he knows that his light fills a fathom's breadth; or if he goes to other directions and, in another world-realm, performs the deeds of a buddha, and there too emanates monks and teaches the Dharma; if, Subhūti, in this way even in a dream he is recognized as an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, then, Subhūti, this too should be understood as a mark of irreversibility in an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being.

Subhūti, furthermore, if a bodhisattva, a great being, even in a dream does not tremble, is not frightened, and is not seized by terror, even when harm comes upon a village, or upon a town, or upon a market town, or upon a region, or upon a district, or a wildfire breaks out; or when he sees beasts of prey, or wild animals, or other kinds of lesser creatures; or when he is about to be beheaded, or any other great, unbearable danger, painful and distressing, arises; and even when he sees the suffering, distress, and great unbearable fear of other beings, no unbearable fear arises in him; he does not tremble, is not frightened, and is not seized by terror; and then, awakening from sleep, as soon as he rises he thinks: "All these three realms are like a dream. Having fully and completely awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, I shall teach the Dharma exactly as the Teacher truly teaches it" — then, Subhūti, this too should be understood as a mark of irreversibility in an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being.

Subhūti, furthermore, if an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, even in a dream sees beings in the hells and thinks: "How might I act so that, in the buddha-field of the one who has fully and completely awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, all the bad destinies will altogether, entirely, in every respect, and everywhere cease to occur?" then, Subhūti, this too should be understood as a mark of the purification of the bad destinies in this irreversible bodhisattva, a great being.

Subhūti, how is one to know that, in the buddha field of that irreversible bodhisattva, that great being, who has awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, the evil destinies will never arise at all, in any way, in any aspect whatsoever?

Subhūti, suppose a bodhisattva, a great being, sees in a dream beings who belong to the hells, or to the animals, or to the realm of hungry ghosts, and thereupon recalls this. Having recalled it, he thinks: "How may it come about that in the buddha field of me, who have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, the evil destinies will never arise at all, in any way, in any aspect whatsoever?" Subhūti, this should be known as the mark of the purification of the evil destinies of a bodhisattva, a great being, and this too should be known as a mark of the irreversibility of an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose a bodhisattva, a great being, dreams of a city on fire, or of a village that has been burned. Having woken from that dream, he thinks: "By whatever aspects, signs, and marks I saw in the dream, a bodhisattva, a great being, is to be taken as irreversible. If those aspects, signs, and marks are present in me, then by this truth and by these words of truth, may this burning city and this burned village be extinguished, may they be cooled, may they cease to be." If he speaks thus, Subhūti, and the burning village or city is extinguished, cooled, and ceases to be, then that bodhisattva, that great being, should be known to have been prophesied by the Tathāgatas of the past, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, as irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect awakening. If it is not extinguished, not cooled, and does not cease to be, then that bodhisattva, that great being, should be known not to have been prophesied for unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

Again, Subhūti, suppose the fire spreads from house to house, from street to street, passing on to some other street or some other house, and burns on without being extinguished, cooled, or ceasing to be. Then, Subhūti, it should

be known that this bodhisattva, this great being, has accumulated karma that accords with rejecting the Dharma and with confusing wisdom. Therefore the ripening of that karma, which accords with rising up in this very life, is a ripening with a remainder, arising from that very rejection of the Dharma.

Subhūti, such is the cause and such is the condition of the mark of irreversibility of an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being. And by this, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, is to be taken as irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

Furthermore, Subhūti, I shall explain to you the aspects, signs, and marks by which an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, is to be taken as irreversible. Listen well, and keep it in mind. I shall teach it to you.

Then the venerable Subhūti said, "Excellent!" to the Blessed One, and listened as the Blessed One had instructed. The Blessed One spoke as follows.

Subhūti, suppose a man or a woman, a boy or a girl, has been seized and possessed by a non-human being. Then a bodhisattva, a great being, should come and reflect with a blessing in this way: "If I have been prophesied by the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas of the past, to unsurpassed, perfect awakening; and if my intention toward fully awakening to unsurpassed, perfect awakening is utterly pure; and if I wish to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, with my attention to unsurpassed, perfect awakening utterly pure, and free of any mind of a śrāvaka or of a pratyekabuddha; then I shall become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening. It is not that I will fail to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect awakening. I will certainly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect awakening. Moreover, in those immeasurable, innumerable world systems there dwell, live and are sustained the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas; and for them nothing is unknown, unseen, uncomprehended, unrealized before their eyes, or not fully awakened to. If those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, know my intention, and so I will awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, then by this truth and by these words of truth, let the non-human possession that has seized and overpowered this man, woman, boy or girl depart!"

Subhūti, if the bodhisattva, the great being, speaks in this way and the non-human being does not depart, then you should understand that this bodhisattva, this great being, has not been prophesied by the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas of the past to unsurpassed, perfect

awakening. And, Subhūti, if the bodhisattva, the great being, speaks in this way and the non-human being departs, then you should understand that this bodhisattva, this great being, has been prophesied by the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas of the past to unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

This is the twentieth chapter, called "Practice in Skillful Means," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Subhūti, furthermore, in that case a bodhisattva, a great being, may speak these words: "By whatever truth and words of truth I have been prophesied by the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas of the past to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, by that truth and those words of truth, let this non-human being depart!" Then, Subhūti, Māra the Evil One strives to make that non-human being go away. Why is that?

Then, Subhūti, Māra the Evil One, who is exceedingly powerful and exceedingly splendid, strives to make the non-human spirit depart, thinking, "How might this non-human depart?" And so the non-human departs through the blessing of Māra. Even so, that bodhisattva, that great being, thinks, "The departing of this non-human is due to my power," and does not understand that the non-human departs through the power of Māra. He does only that much striving, and because of that striving he comes to look down on other bodhisattvas, great beings. He disparages them, belittles them, makes light of them, scorns them, and reviles them. He thinks, "I have been prophesied by the former Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, to unsurpassable, perfect awakening." On that ground alone, again and again he gives rise to pride. He fully produces pride, increases pride, greatly increases pride, relies on pride, depends upon pride, makes pride grow, makes pride flourish, and brings pride forth.

Through that pride, through great pride, through pride upon pride, through conceit and through false pride, he puts omniscience far away. He puts far away the unsurpassed wisdom of a buddha, the self-arisen wisdom, the wisdom of omniscience. He puts far away unsurpassable, perfect awakening.

In that way, when he sees bodhisattvas, great beings, who are spiritual friends, who have virtuous qualities, who have vast inclination, who are endowed with superior intention, who are skilled in means, and who possess the qualities of irreversibility, he gives rise to conceit and looks down on them. He does not associate with such spiritual friends, does not rely on them, does

not honor or revere them, and does not question them. He only makes more firm the bond by which Māra binds him. He should be understood as belonging to one of two grounds, namely, the ground of the śrāvakas or the ground of the pratyekabuddhas.

Subhūti, in this way, through the blessing of that truth, Māra the Evil One obstructs unsurpassable, perfect awakening for a bodhisattva, a great being, who has newly entered the vehicle, who has little faith and little learning, who is separated from spiritual friends, who is not held by the Perfection of Wisdom, and who lacks skill in means. Subhūti, this too should be understood as a deed of Māra for a bodhisattva, a great being.

Furthermore, Subhūti, pointing out a bodhisattva's name also becomes a deed of Māra. Subhūti, how does pointing out a bodhisattva's name become a deed of Māra? Here, Subhūti, Māra the Evil One draws near to a bodhisattva, a great being, by pointing out his name and by blessing the name. Coming in some guise or other, whatever suits, he says this: "You were prophesied by the former Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, to unsurpassable, perfect awakening. Why is that so? Your name is such and such. Your mother's name is such and such. Your father's name is such and such. Your brother's name is such and such. Your sister's name is such and such.

Mara will say, "Your friends, your ministers, your relatives and your kin by blood and marriage have such and such names," and he will recite the names going back seven generations on both the paternal and maternal sides. He will say, "You were born in such and such a region, in such and such a village, town, or hamlet." If the person is by nature dull, Mara will say, "You were dull in the past as well." If the person is by nature sharp in faculties, Mara will say, "You had sharp faculties in the past as well."

Suppose the person is a forest dweller, or an alms-gatherer, or one who wears rag robes, or one who does not take food after the meal, or one who sits in a single session, or one who keeps to the seat as laid out, or one who has only the three robes, or a charnel-ground dweller, or one who lives at the foot of a tree, or one who sits in the open air, or one who has no shelter, or one who wears felt, or one with few desires, contentment, and deep seclusion, or one who goes barefoot, or one who speaks gently and sparingly. To such a person Māra the Evil One, drawing on these qualities of this present life, will say, "In the past too you possessed these very qualities. You were definitely

prophesied by the Tathāgatas of the past, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, to irreversibility from unsurpassable, perfect awakening, to the stage of an irreversible bodhisattva. Why is that? Because you have these ascetic qualities, you surely possessed them in the past as well." In this way he exhorts the person.

Then, relying on the names recounted from the past and on the ascetic qualities and the few possessions he now has, the person will give rise to conceit. He will think, "I was prophesied by the Tathāgatas of the past, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, to unsurpassable, perfect awakening, for I have these qualities." And Māra the Evil One will say to him, "You were prophesied by the Tathāgatas of the past, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, to irreversibility from unsurpassable, perfect awakening. Why is that? Because you have such ascetic qualities."

Furthermore, Subhūti, Māra the Evil One will sometimes think to appear in the guise of a monk, sometimes in the guise of a nun, sometimes in the guise of a layman, sometimes in the guise of a laywoman, sometimes in the guise of a brahmin, sometimes in the guise of a householder, sometimes in the guise of a mother, sometimes of a father, sometimes of a brother, sometimes of a sister, and sometimes in the guise of a friend, a minister, a relative, or a kinsman by blood or marriage. Having come, he will say, "You were prophesied by the Tathāgatas of the past, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, to the irreversible stage of unsurpassable, perfect awakening. Why is that? Because you have the ascetic qualities of an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being." Furthermore, Subhūti, if those qualities, those aspects, signs, and marks of irreversible bodhisattvas, great beings, which I have taught are absent in him, Subhūti, in such a case another bodhisattva, a great being, should recognize, "Alas, this bodhisattva, this great being, is under the sway of Māra." Why is that? Because the aspects, signs, and marks of the bodhisattvas, the great beings who never turn back, are absent in him.

Furthermore, Subhūti, through the sway of such a power, that bodhisattva, that great being, becomes inflated with conceit. Having generated conceit, he is overpowered by it and puffed up with pride, overcome by the sway of Māra. As a result he comes to belittle other bodhisattvas, great beings; he treats them with contempt, ridicules them, derides them, and disparages them. Subhūti, this too should be recognized by the bodhisattva, the great being, as the work of Māra, brought about through the sway of Māra.

Furthermore, Subhūti, the bodhisattva, the great being, should recognize as the work of Māra any teaching of a name and any prophecy of a name. Subhūti, how should a bodhisattva, a great being, recognize a teaching of a name or a prophecy of a name as the work of Māra? Subhūti, in this case Māra the Evil One comes in the guise of a monk and gives a prophecy to a bodhisattva, a great being, in these words. Whatever name the bodhisattva has been thinking, "Oh, may I become known by this name when I fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect awakening," following after that name, reflecting on it and examining it in his mind, exactly that name does the monk prophesy: "You will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect awakening and be called by this very name."

Then that bodhisattva, whose wisdom is flawed by nature and who is unskilled in means, thinks, "Just as I followed after the name, reflecting on it and examining it, thinking, 'Oh, may I become known by this name when I fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect awakening,' so has this monk declared it." Having thought this, he reasons, "The name that I reflected upon, and the name spoken by Māra the Evil One himself, or by a monk emanated by those of Māra's following, or by a monk under Māra's sway, are the same in both cases. As the thought arose in my mind, so this monk has declared my name; the two names coincide." And he comes to think, "I have been prophesied to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, by name, by the buddhas of the past, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened ones."

Subhūti, the aspects, signs, and marks that I have taught for bodhisattvas, great beings who never turn back, are absent in him, and he is bereft of them. Yet through that teaching and prophecy of his name, he generates conceit about it.

Having conceived this arrogance, he thinks, "I have received the prediction to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, but these others have not received the prediction to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening," and so he holds other bodhisattvas, great beings, in contempt. Through that contemptuous mind, through pride, great pride, pride beyond pride, wrong pride, and the pride of presumption, he holds other bodhisattvas, great beings, in contempt, and so he makes omniscience distant and makes the wisdom of the buddhas distant. Not being embraced by the Perfection of Wisdom, lacking skillful means, lacking spiritual friends, and being held by evil companions, he should expect only one of two grounds: the ground of the śrāvakas or the ground of the pratyekabuddhas.

Now suppose that, after training and taming himself for a long time, indeed a very long time, he comes to rely on this Perfection of Wisdom and wishes to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Suppose too that he were to follow spiritual friends and always go to the presence of spiritual friends. Even so, in this very life, with his body fully formed, he would be one who disparages those who have generated the awakening mind, who disgraces them, harms them, abandons them, and denounces them one by one. Even then, it would be hard for him to reach the ground of a buddha.

Why is that? Subhūti, the ground of downfall that arises from the arrogance of a bodhisattva, a great being, is this heavy.

Subhūti, take for example a monk of the Śrāvaka Vehicle, on the ground of the śrāvakas. The four root downfalls are heavy for him. If he commits any one of these downfalls, or any other, he is not a monk, not an ascetic, not a son of the Śākya. Yet generating arrogance and a contemptuous mind is heavier than those four downfalls. That is to say, when the mind of great nonvirtue, the mind of contempt, arises on the occasion of the naming of a bodhisattva, a great being, you should know that generating this mind is heavier than those downfalls.

Subhūti, leave aside the four root downfalls. Even compared with those five acts of immediate retribution, when a bodhisattva, a great being, names another and the mind arises that is accompanied by arrogance, you should know that generating this mind is heavier, and heavier than the downfall of those five acts of immediate retribution.

Subhūti, even a declaration of a name like that can give rise to the subtle, very subtle works of Māra. The bodhisattva, the great being, should recognize them. Having recognized them, he should abandon them completely, and he should help others to understand and cause them to give them up.

Furthermore, Subhūti, Māra the Evil One comes into the presence of a bodhisattva, a great being, and urges and reminds him with the qualities of solitude. Subhūti, how does Māra the Evil One come into the presence of a bodhisattva, a great being, and urge and remind him with the qualities of solitude? Subhūti, in this case Māra the Evil One approaches the bodhisattva, the great being, and having approached him says, "The Tathāgata speaks in praise of solitude. You should dwell in the wilderness, in forest thickets, in mountain caves, in charnel grounds, in heaps of straw, and the like."

Subhūti, I do not say that the various dwelling places, such as forests, remote borderlands, uninhabited regions, woodland thickets, mountain caves, charnel grounds, and heaps of straw, constitute the seclusion of a bodhisattva, a great being.

Subhūti then asked: Blessed One, if the seclusion of a bodhisattva, a great being, does not come from dwelling in the various places such as forests, remote borderlands, uninhabited regions, woodland thickets, mountain caves, charnel grounds, and heaps of straw, then what other seclusion is there? Blessed One, what is that other seclusion of a bodhisattva, a great being, like?

When he had spoken in this way, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, becomes secluded from thoughts associated with the śrāvakas, and secluded from thoughts associated with the pratyekabuddhas, then that bodhisattva, a great being, is dwelling in seclusion. Even if such a one lives in the midst of a village, that one abides with the perfection of wisdom, with skillful means, and with loving-kindness and great compassion toward all sentient beings. One who abides in this way is truly abiding in seclusion.

Subhūti, I also grant this seclusion from thoughts associated with the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas to a bodhisattva, a great being: if a bodhisattva, a great being, spends day and night abiding in this seclusion, then that one is dwelling in seclusion. And if a bodhisattva, a great being, dwells in forests, woodland thickets, mountain caves, charnel grounds, and remote dwelling places while abiding in this very way, then that bodhisattva, a great being, is dwelling in seclusion.

Subhūti, there is also the seclusion of dwelling in forests, woodland thickets, mountain caves, charnel grounds, and remote dwelling places that Māra the Evil One presents as though it were seclusion. By that seclusion, one becomes mixed up with thoughts associated with the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. One does not strive earnestly for the perfection of wisdom, and one does not bring omniscient wisdom to completion. One abides in this mixed-up way, and because one abides with thoughts that are not thoroughly purified, the activities of one's body, speech, and mind are not thoroughly purified.

Because the activities of body, speech, and mind are not thoroughly purified, such a bodhisattva, a great being, despises those other bodhisattvas who live in the midst of villages yet are not mixed up with thoughts associated with the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and who abide in the way of wisdom, skillful

means, and great compassion. Though living in the wilderness, that one's bodily, verbal, and mental activities remain impure, and one keeps abiding in a mixed-up way. Such a one is not dwelling in seclusion.

But the others abide in wisdom, skillful means, and great compassion. They live in villages, their bodily, verbal, and mental activities are thoroughly purified, they are secluded from thoughts associated with the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and they are not mixed up with those thoughts. When one despises them, one will not attain the meditative concentrations, the absorptions, the attainments, the liberations, and the higher knowledges, and these will not be brought to completion in one. Why is that? Because such a one is unskilled in means.

Subhūti, suppose there is a bodhisattva, a great being, who dwells for a year, or a hundred years, or a thousand years, or a hundred thousand years, or a million, or a hundred million, or a billion, or a trillion years, or even longer, in a wilderness a hundred leagues wide, with no beasts of prey, no wild animals, no flocks of birds, no lesser wild animals or predators, where no yakṣas or rākṣasas roam, where there are no bandits, in a terrifying, intolerable wilderness that is nevertheless free of harm. Suppose that bodhisattva has entered upon that seclusion with a superior intention and abides possessed of a perfect superior intention. If he does not understand the seclusion that I have taught, then that bodhisattva, unskilled in means, because of this lack of understanding, makes the wilderness his sole concern and dwells there. He relies on that seclusion, clings to it, is attached to it, and is strongly attached to it. Subhūti, by that much that bodhisattva, that great being, has not pleased my mind. Why is that? Subhūti, dwelling in this kind of seclusion does not accord with the seclusion that I have taught for bodhisattvas, great beings.

Then Māra the Evil One will come, and sitting in the space of the sky above, he will say to that bodhisattva: "Excellent, excellent, son of good family! This is the seclusion that the Tathāgata taught for bodhisattvas, great beings. Son of good family, abide in just this seclusion. If you do so, son of good family, you will quickly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening."

And that bodhisattva, through that seclusion in the wilderness, will despise other bodhisattvas, great beings, who have entered villages, who are monks living the holy life, who possess virtuous qualities, whose attention is not mixed up with that of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and whose bodily, verbal, and mental activities and livelihood are thoroughly pure. He will say:

"Alas, these venerable ones dwell in a mixed-up way; they do not dwell in seclusion. These venerable ones dwell in constant mixing; they do not dwell in seclusion." And he will quarrel with those who abide in the seclusion of bodhisattvas, great beings, because they dwell mixed with others; he will quarrel with them for living in constant mixture. Of those who dwell mixed with others, he will say that they practice dwelling in seclusion, and he will generate reverence for them. But toward those for whom reverence is truly appropriate, he will generate pride.

Why is that, Subhūti? Because he thinks: "The places where I dwell are indeed dwelling places; I am urged on by nonhuman beings, and I am remembered by nonhuman beings. But for whom among those dwelling in villages do nonhuman beings give encouragement? For whom among those dwelling in villages do those nonhuman beings keep remembrance?" In this way that person despises those who follow the vehicle of the bodhisattvas.

Subhūti, such a one should be known as an outcaste among bodhisattvas. Such a one should be known as a refuter of bodhisattvas. Such a one should be known as a mere reflection of a bodhisattva. Such a one should be known as a counterfeit bodhisattva. Such a one should be known as a bodhisattva sprout gone to waste. He is a bandit who has disguised himself in the garb of a renunciant. He is a bandit among those who follow the bodhisattva vehicle. He is a bandit of the world with its gods.

Subhūti, furthermore, a person of such a nature should not be relied upon, should not be revered, and should not be served or honored. Why? Such a person should be understood to have fallen into manifest arrogance. Such a person also criticizes and rebukes others who are of little strength and who have entered the vehicle only a short while ago. Such a person should be known as one whose qualities are impure; such a person should be known as one who lacks a true teacher; and such a person should be known as one who lacks the qualities of the noble ones.

Subhūti, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has not abandoned any sentient being, who has not abandoned omniscience, and who has not abandoned unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, who with a superior intention wishes to become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and wishes to accomplish the benefit of all sentient beings, should not rely upon, revere, serve, or honor a person of that kind.

Subhūti, however, in order to understand these works of Māra and others as well, one who strives for the sake of all sentient beings should always keep the mind free of discouragement. For the sake of showing the path to all sentient beings who have not found it, one should not let the mind be frightened, and should not mix it with the three realms. And in that very effort, one should first generate great compassion, with a mind of loving-kindness and a mind of compassion, holding tender care for others. One should feel joy toward those beings who have rightly entered the path, and, through the nature of phenomena as non-apprehension, maintain equanimity toward phenomena. In this way, one should generate the thought: "May every fault of the works of Māra, in every way, never arise and never occur at all; and should any such fault occur, may I swiftly abandon it. Thus I shall train." Know too that this is how bodhisattvas, great beings, overcome others through their own direct knowledge. And Subhūti, this too should be understood by a bodhisattva, a great being, as a work of Māra, namely a quality of seclusion that has gone astray.

This is the twenty-first chapter, called "The Works of Māra," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines, nineteenth volume.

Then the Blessed One spoke again to the venerable Subhūti. Subhūti, here a bodhisattva, a great being, who has rightly entered upon a superior intention and wishes to become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, should from the very first rely upon, revere, serve, and honor spiritual friends.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has rightly entered upon a superior intention and wishes to become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, should from the very first rely upon, revere, serve, and honor which spiritual friends? Who are those spiritual friends of a bodhisattva, a great being? Please explain.

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows. Subhūti, the buddhas, the Blessed Ones themselves, and those bodhisattvas, great beings, who have become irreversible and are skilled in the conduct of bodhisattvas, who rightly instruct and guide others in these perfections, and those who teach and expound this Perfection of Wisdom: Subhūti, these should be known as the spiritual friends of a bodhisattva, a great being.

Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom itself should be recognized as the spiritual friend of a bodhisattva, a great being. Subhūti, all six perfections should be recognized as the spiritual friend of a bodhisattva, a great being. The six perfections themselves are the teacher. The six perfections are the path. The six perfections are the illumination. The six perfections are the lamp. The six perfections are the light. The six perfections are the protector. The six perfections are the refuge. The six perfections are the resting place. The six perfections are the ally. The six perfections are the island. The six perfections are the mother. The six perfections are the father. The six perfections are what brings about understanding, realization, and the state of being established for the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Why is this so? Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom depends on these, that is to say, on the six perfections.

Subhūti, the omniscience of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas of the past, the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, who became fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and then passed completely into nirvāṇa, was likewise born from these six perfections. Subhūti, the omniscience of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas of the future, the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, who will become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, will likewise be born from these six perfections. Subhūti, the omniscience of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas who now, in immeasurable, innumerable, boundless, inconceivable world systems, having become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, remain, live, sustain themselves, and teach the Dharma, the Buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is likewise born from these six perfections. Subhūti, my own omniscience also, I who am now a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly awakened buddha, and who have become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, is born from these six perfections.

Why is this so? Subhūti, within these six perfections are gathered the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening, the four immeasurables, the four means of gathering disciples, and all the qualities of a buddha that exist: the wisdom of a buddha, self-arisen wisdom, inconceivable wisdom, immeasurable wisdom, innumerable wisdom, incomparable wisdom, the wisdom that is unequal and equal, and the wisdom of omniscience. All of these are gathered within the six perfections.

Therefore, Subhūti, these six perfections themselves are the spiritual friend of a bodhisattva, a great being. These six perfections themselves are the teacher. The six perfections are the path. The six perfections are the illumination. The six perfections are the lamp. The six perfections are the light. The six perfections are the protector. The six perfections are the refuge. The six perfections are the resting place. The six perfections are the ally.

The six perfections are the island. The six perfections are the mother. The six perfections are the father. The six perfections will stand for the sake of knowing, realizing, attaining omniscience, and attaining unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. When a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in the six perfections, he becomes a benefactor even to all those who cannot repay him.

Furthermore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to train in these six perfections should listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom, grasp it, hold it, read it, fully understand it, recite it, teach it, explain it, study it aloud, memorize it, examine it thoroughly through its meaning, its Dharma, and its method, reflect on it, question it, and inquire into it fully.

Why is that? This Perfection of Wisdom is the forerunner of these six perfections. It is their leader, their guide, the one who shows them correctly and teaches them fully. It gives them birth; it is their mother. Why is that? Without the Perfection of Wisdom, the other five perfections are not apparent, and they would not even obtain the name "perfection."

Therefore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to go without relying on others, and who wishes to abide in the state of a bodhisattva, a great being, who does not rely on others, should train in this very Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, what is the defining mark of the Perfection of Wisdom?

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom has the defining mark of non-attachment.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, is there a way of speaking by which, through that very defining mark of non-attachment by which the Perfection of Wisdom exists, all phenomena exist?

The Blessed One said: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Subhūti, there is a way of speaking by which, through that very defining mark of non-attachment by which the Perfection of Wisdom exists, all phenomena exist. Why is that?

Subhūti, all phenomena are secluded. Subhūti, all phenomena are empty. Therefore, Subhūti, through that very defining mark of non-attachment by which the Perfection of Wisdom is secluded and empty, all phenomena are secluded and empty.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, if all phenomena are secluded and all phenomena are empty, then, Blessed One, how will sentient beings be known to be afflicted? Blessed One, how will sentient beings be known to be purified? Blessed One, what is secluded does not become afflicted. Blessed One, what is secluded does not become purified. Blessed One, what is empty does not become afflicted. Blessed One, what is empty does not become purified.

Blessed One, solitude, or emptiness, does not fully awaken into unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And, Blessed One, apart from solitude and emptiness itself, no phenomenon is found that becomes a buddha, or fully awakens, or will come to fully awaken into unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Blessed One, how then should I understand the meaning of this teaching? Blessed One, please explain it. Sugata, please explain it.

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows. Subhūti, what do you think? Have beings, since a long time ago, been engaged in grasping at "I" and grasping at "mine"?

Subhūti answered: So it is, Blessed One. So it is, Sugata. Beings have, since a long time ago, been engaged in grasping at "I" and grasping at "mine."

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Are grasping at "I" and grasping at "mine" empty?

Subhūti answered: They are empty, Blessed One. They are empty, Sugata.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Is it through grasping at "I" and grasping at "mine" that beings wander in saṃsāra?

Subhūti answered: So it is, Blessed One. So it is, Sugata. It is through grasping at "I" and grasping at "mine" that beings wander in saṃsāra.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, in this way one should understand how beings become defiled. It is just as beings grasp and cling that they become defiled; yet in this there is no one at all who becomes defiled. Subhūti, it is just as there is no grasping and no clinging that one does not know grasping at "I" and grasping at "mine" at all. In this way, Subhūti, one should understand how beings become purified. It is just as beings have no grasping and no clinging that they become purified; yet in this there is no one at all who becomes

purified. Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices in this way, he is practicing in the Perfection of Wisdom. Subhūti, in this way, with all phenomena in solitude and all phenomena empty, one should understand the defilement and the purification of beings.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it is wondrous that, with all phenomena in solitude and all phenomena empty, the defilement and purification of beings are nevertheless understood. Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices in this way, he is practicing in the Perfection of Wisdom.

Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices in this way, he does not practice in form. He does not practice in feeling, nor in perception, nor in formations, nor in consciousness.

Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices in this way, he cannot be overcome by the world with its gods, humans, and asuras.

Blessed One, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices in this way, he overpowers the conduct of all persons of the śrāvaka vehicle and the pratyekabuddha vehicle, and he also attains the state of being unable to be overpowered. Why is that? Blessed One, because buddhahood, the state of the Tathāgata, the state of the self-arisen one, and omniscience cannot be overpowered.

Blessed One, if a bodhisattva, a great being, who possesses the Perfection of Wisdom abides in that state of attention and lets day and night pass in it, that bodhisattva comes close to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, and will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, so it is, so it is. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in this way practices the Perfection of Wisdom. A bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in this way does not practice in form; likewise, he does not practice in feeling, nor in perception, nor in the formations, nor in consciousness.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in this way cannot be overcome by the world with its gods, humans, and asuras. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in this way surpasses the conduct of all individuals who belong to the vehicle of the śrāvakas and the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas, and also attains the state that cannot be overcome. Why is that? Subhūti, because buddhahood, the state of the Tathāgata, the self-arisen state, and omniscience cannot be overcome.

Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, who possesses the Perfection of Wisdom abides in this state of attention and lets day and night pass in it, he has come close to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, and will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect awakening.

Furthermore, Subhūti, suppose that all the sentient beings there are in Jambudvīpa, without exception, were to obtain a human body, and having obtained a human body, were to generate the mind of unsurpassed, perfect awakening. Having generated that mind, they would remain for as long as they live, and while they live they would honor all the Tathāgatas, revere them, hold them as their teachers, make offerings to them, worship them, depict them in images, and attend upon them. And likewise they would give gifts to all sentient beings, and dedicate that giving too to unsurpassed, perfect awakening. Subhūti, what do you think? Would those bodhisattvas, great beings, generate much merit on that basis?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, much! Sugata, much!

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, even more merit than that is generated by the son or daughter of good family who, at the very least, abides for a single day in attention that possesses the Perfection of Wisdom. Why is that? Subhūti, to the extent that a bodhisattva, a great being, abides day and night in attention that possesses the Perfection of Wisdom, to that extent he becomes a worthy recipient of the gifts of all sentient beings. Why is that? Subhūti, because a mind endowed with loving-kindness such as that bodhisattva's, a great being's, is found in no other sentient beings, except the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Why is that? Subhūti, because the Tathāgata is an individual without an equal. Subhūti, the Tathāgata has no comparison. Subhūti, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, is endowed with inconceivable qualities.

Subhūti, how is it that a son or daughter of good family brings about such a quantity of merit? Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, has come to possess what kind of wisdom does he see all sentient beings as if they were about to be slain? At that very time he is wholly seized by great compassion. Looking with the divine eye, he sees immeasurable, innumerable, incalculable, boundless beings bound up with the deeds of immediate retribution. He also sees others who are in the unfavorable states, who have fallen away, who are covered by the net of wrong views, who have not found the path, and who are in unfavorable circumstances, and he sees those who have wasted the

freedoms and endowments of a human life. Seeing them, he is overcome with great dismay. Then he pervades all those beings with that great loving-kindness and that great compassion, and he comes to think: "I shall become the protector of all these beings, and I shall free all these beings from suffering." In this way he comes to possess a wisdom in which he does not dwell together with signs or with anything else.

Subhūti, this is for the bodhisattva, the great being, the great light of wisdom for fully awakening to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in this way is held to be a worthy recipient of the offerings of the whole world, and he does not turn back from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Those donors and lords of giving who use robes, alms food, bedding, medicines for the sick, and requisites, having firmly set their minds on this Perfection of Wisdom, purify their gifts and offerings, and all of them draw near to omniscience.

Therefore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to enjoy the alms of the country with fruitful result, who wishes to show the path to all sentient beings, who wishes to bring forth a vast illumination, who wishes to free the beings who dwell in saṃsāra from saṃsāra, and who wishes to purify the eyes of all sentient beings, should abide in this mental engagement that is accompanied by the Perfection of Wisdom. If he wishes to abide in this mental engagement, he should come to know the mental engagement that is accompanied by the Perfection of Wisdom.

Why is that? Whatever it is that he thinks of knowing, that very thing becomes his mental engagement. No opening should be given to any mental engagement apart from this, one that is separated from the Perfection of Wisdom. He should act in such a way that day and night are exhausted through this mental engagement accompanied by the Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose a certain man who is skilled in knowing precious jewels, knowing the kinds of jewels, comes upon a great precious jewel such as he had never found before. Having found that great precious jewel, he becomes joyful and greatly delighted, filled with a wide and spacious happiness. But then he loses that great precious jewel, and because of this he becomes possessed of great suffering and unhappiness.

Thinking in this way, "Alas, I am parted from that great and precious jewel," he would constantly and without interruption be gripped by the thought of being

parted from it. And so, until he found either that same great precious jewel or another that was like it in qualities and of the same kind, that man would not forget the great precious jewel.

Subhūti, in the same way, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has fallen away from the great precious jewel of the Perfection of Wisdom, just like one who has lost the great precious jewel and perceives it as precious, is endowed with attention to the Perfection of Wisdom and is never apart from attention to the Perfection of Wisdom. With a mind set on omniscience, for as long as he has not found it, he should go on seeking. And for that long he should remain endowed with the attention of one who has found the great precious jewel of the Perfection of Wisdom, and never be parted from the attention of one who has found the great precious jewel of omniscience itself.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, the Blessed One has taught that all phenomena and all acts of attention are devoid of intrinsic nature and are empty. Then, Blessed One, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, come to be endowed with attention to the Perfection of Wisdom and with attention to omniscience, and never be parted from them?

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows: Subhūti, suppose a bodhisattva, a great being, thinks, "All phenomena are secluded by their intrinsic nature; all phenomena are empty by their intrinsic nature." Attention of this kind is endowed with attention to the Perfection of Wisdom and with attention to omniscience, and is never parted from them. Why is that? Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom is empty, and it neither increases nor decreases.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, if the Perfection of Wisdom is empty and neither increases nor decreases, then how does a bodhisattva, a great being, come to accomplish awakening through a Perfection of Wisdom that has no increase? How does he fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows: Subhūti, the practice of a bodhisattva, a great being, in the Perfection of Wisdom has neither increase nor decrease. Subhūti, just as the Perfection of Wisdom is empty and so has neither increase nor decrease, in the same way, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, is also empty and so has neither increase nor decrease. Subhūti, precisely because the Perfection of Wisdom is empty and so has neither increase nor decrease, and likewise a bodhisattva, a great being, is empty and so has neither increase nor decrease, for that very

reason a bodhisattva, a great being, strives for the sake of awakening, and in this way fully awakens to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Subhūti, if, when this is being taught, a bodhisattva, a great being, is not frightened, not terrified, not overcome by dread, and does not lose heart, then it should be understood that this bodhisattva, a great being, is practicing this Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, does the Perfection of Wisdom practice the Perfection of Wisdom?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, it does not.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, then does the emptiness that is the Perfection of Wisdom practice the Perfection of Wisdom?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, it does not.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, then, apart from the emptiness that is the Perfection of Wisdom, is any phenomenon found that practices the Perfection of Wisdom?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, it is not.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, then does emptiness practice the Perfection of Wisdom?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, it does not.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, then is any phenomenon that practices the Perfection of Wisdom found within this emptiness?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, it is not.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, then does emptiness practice emptiness?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, it does not.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, then does form practice the Perfection of Wisdom?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, it does not.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, then do feeling, perception, and the formations, and does consciousness, practice the Perfection of Wisdom?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, they do not.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, then, apart from form, is any phenomenon found that practices the Perfection of Wisdom?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, it is not.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, then, apart from feeling, perception, and the formations, and apart from consciousness, is any phenomenon found that practices the Perfection of Wisdom?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, it is not.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, then how does a bodhisattva, a great being, come to practice the Perfection of Wisdom?

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, do you perceive, rightly and correctly, any phenomenon that practices the Perfection of Wisdom?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, I do not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, do you perceive, rightly and correctly, that Perfection of Wisdom in which a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the Perfection of Wisdom?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, I do not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Do you rightly perceive any phenomenon that is not apprehended? And is that very phenomenon one that has arisen, or is arising, or will arise, or has ceased, or is ceasing, or will cease?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it is not so.

The Blessed One said:

Subhūti, such is the very nature of the forbearance toward the unborn nature of phenomena possessed by a bodhisattva, a great being. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has this kind of forbearance will receive the prophecy of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who has accomplished this fearless path of the Tathāgata, and who practices in this way, strives in this way, and exerts effort in this way, could not fail to attain the unsurpassed wisdom of a buddha, the great wisdom, the wisdom of omniscience, the wisdom of the great caravan leader. That is impossible.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, is it the unborn nature of all phenomena that receives the prophecy of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, it is not.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, then in regard to what phenomenon is the prophecy of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening given?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, do you then correctly perceive any phenomenon as that to which the prophecy of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening is given?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, I do not. Blessed One, I do not correctly perceive any phenomenon that is prophesied, or that will be prophesied, or that prophesies, as regards unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Blessed One, I also do not correctly perceive any phenomenon that is fully awakened to, or that is to be fully awakened to, or by which one will be fully awakened. Why is that? Blessed One, because all phenomena are without any basis to be apprehended, and so I do not think, "I fully awaken to this phenomenon," or "I will fully awaken to this phenomenon," or "I became fully awakened by this phenomenon."

This is the twenty-second chapter, called "The Spiritual Friend," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Then at that time Śakra, lord of the gods, together with his retinue, came and gathered there and sat down. Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom is profound. Alas, Blessed One, this Perfection of Wisdom is difficult to see and difficult to realize.

When he had said this, the Blessed One said this to Śakra, lord of the gods: Kauśika, so it is. So it is. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is profound. Kauśika, this Perfection of Wisdom is difficult to see and difficult to realize. Because space is profound, this Perfection of Wisdom is profound. Because it is secluded, this Perfection of Wisdom is difficult to see. Because it is empty, it is difficult to realize.

When he had said this, Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, those beings who come to hear this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and who, having heard it, also hold it, retain it, read it, master it, recite it, teach it, explain it, give instruction in it, recite it from memory, and write it down, are surely not possessed of an inferior root of virtue.

When he had said this, the Blessed One said this to Śakra, lord of the gods: Kauśika, so it is, so it is.

Kauśika, those beings who come to listen to this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and who, having heard it, also grasp it, hold it, read it, master it,

recite it aloud, teach it, explain it, expound it, memorize it, and write it down in letters, are not endowed with a poor or inferior root of virtue.

Kauśika, suppose that all the beings who live in Jambudvīpa were established in the ten paths of virtuous action. What do you think, Kauśika? Would those beings produce abundant merit on that basis?

Śakra said: Blessed One, they would produce much. Sugata, they would produce much.

The Blessed One declared: Kauśika, a son or daughter of good family who does the following produces more merit than that. That is, one who listens to this Perfection of Wisdom, and, having heard it, grasps it, holds it, reads it, masters it, recites it aloud, teaches it, explains it, expounds it, memorizes it, and writes it down in letters. Kauschika, as for any son or daughter of good family who listens to this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and, having heard it, grasps it, holds it, reads it, masters it, recites it aloud, teaches it, explains it, expounds it, memorizes it, and writes it down in letters, and who becomes endowed with whatever root of virtue results from this, the former mass of merit arising from the moral discipline of all the beings of Jambudvīpa does not come near even to a hundredth part of this mass of merit. It does not come near to a thousandth part, nor a hundred-thousandth part, nor a ten-millionth part, nor a hundred ten-millionth part, nor a thousand ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-thousand ten-millionth part, nor a hundred-thousandth part of a ten-million ten-millionth. It does not come within any count. It cannot be reckoned, nor expressed by an analogy, nor demonstrated through a comparison, and it cannot bear comparison on the basis of any ground or cause.

Then another monk said to Śakra, lord of the gods: Kauśika, a son or daughter of good family who listens to this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and, having heard it, grasps it, holds it, reads it, masters it, recites it aloud, teaches it, explains it, expounds it, memorizes it, and writes it down in letters, will overwhelm you.

When he had said this, Śakra, lord of the gods, said to that monk: Noble one, if such a son or daughter of good family would overwhelm me with just a single generation of the awakening mind, how much more would this be so for one who listens to this profound Perfection of Wisdom, grasps it, holds it, reads it, masters it, recites it aloud, teaches it, explains it, expounds it, memorizes it, and writes it down in letters. And how much more still for one who, having

heard it, grasps it, holds it, reads it, masters it, recites it aloud, teaches it, explains it, expounds it, memorizes it, and writes it down in letters, and who then trains in it just as it is, practices it just as it is, and engages in yogic cultivation of it just as it is. Such bodhisattvas, great beings, will go on overwhelming the world with its gods, humans, and asuras. Such bodhisattvas, great beings, will not only go on overwhelming the world with its gods, humans, and asuras, but

They will surpass all the stream-enterers, once-returners, non-returners, arhats, and pratyekabuddhas as well. Yet these bodhisattvas, great beings, do not merely surpass the stream-enterers, once-returners, non-returners, arhats, and pratyekabuddhas. They will also surpass all those bodhisattvas, great beings, who are great lords of giving but who lack the Perfection of Wisdom and skill in means. And these bodhisattvas, great beings, do not merely surpass the bodhisattvas, great beings, who are great lords of giving. They will also surpass all those bodhisattvas, great beings, whose moral discipline is perfectly pure, whose mass of moral discipline is unimpaired, flawless, unspotted, complete, entirely pure, and free of stain, but who lack the Perfection of Wisdom and skill in means.

And these bodhisattvas, great beings, do not merely surpass those bodhisattvas, great beings, who possess a mass of moral discipline that is unimpaired, flawless, unspotted, complete, entirely pure, and free of stain. They will also surpass all those bodhisattvas, great beings, who are endowed with perfect patience and perfect tranquillity, who would not give rise to a harmful thought even toward a small piece of wood that is burning them, but who lack the Perfection of Wisdom and skill in means.

And these bodhisattvas, great beings, do not merely surpass those bodhisattvas, great beings, who are endowed with perfect patience and perfect tranquillity and have no resentment in their minds. They will also surpass all those bodhisattvas, great beings, who have undertaken diligence, who are without idleness or laziness, and who have a body, speech, and mind that carry out their works without flagging, but who lack the Perfection of Wisdom and skill in means.

And these bodhisattvas, great beings, do not merely surpass those bodhisattvas, great beings, who have undertaken diligence and who carry out the works of body, speech, and mind without idleness, laziness, or flagging. They will also surpass all those bodhisattvas, great beings, who delight in

meditative concentration, are devoted to it, have the power of concentration, are endowed with it, abide in it, and have mastery over it, but who lack the Perfection of Wisdom and skill in means.

Bodhisattvas, great beings, who practice the Perfection of Wisdom as it has been taught will surpass the entire world with its gods, humans, and asuras. They will surpass all those of the Śrāvaka Vehicle and the Pratyekabuddha Vehicle, and also those bodhisattvas, great beings, who are not skilled in means, while they themselves will not be surpassed.

Why is that? Because when a bodhisattva, great being, practices the Perfection of Wisdom as it has been taught and follows after the Perfection of Wisdom, this bodhisattva, great being, has set out so that the lineage of omniscience may not be cut off.

This bodhisattva, this great being, will not be kept far from the Tathāgatas. If this bodhisattva, this great being, applies himself in this way, he will go to the heart of awakening before long. If this bodhisattva, this great being, trains in the Perfection of Wisdom in this way, he will draw out the beings who are sunk in the mire of the afflictions. If this bodhisattva, this great being, trains in this way, he is training in the training of a bodhisattva; he is not training in the training of the śrāvakas, and he is not training in the training of the pratyekabuddhas.

When a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in the Perfection of Wisdom in this way, the Four Great Kings, the guardians of the world, will come into his presence and say: "Noble son, train swiftly in the training of a bodhisattva! Do not be slow in training! When you are seated at the heart of awakening and have become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, these are the four alms bowls you will receive."

Blessed One, it is not only the Four Great Kings, the guardians of the world, who will think of coming into the presence of a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in the Perfection of Wisdom as it has been taught. Even I think of going into the presence of that bodhisattva, a great being, so what need is there to speak of the other sons of the gods! That bodhisattva, that great being, will also be constantly held in mind by the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas. When a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the Perfection of Wisdom in this way, none of the sufferings of the world and none of the harms inflicted by others, whatever they may be, nor any others at all, will ever arise in any way whatsoever. Blessed One, this too is a quality of a

bodhisattva, a great being, in this very life, when he practices the Perfection of Wisdom.

Then the venerable Ānanda thought: "Does Śakra, lord of the gods, speak through his own eloquence, or does he speak through the power of the Buddha?"

Then, through the power of the Buddha, Śakra, lord of the gods, knew the thought in the venerable Ānanda's mind, and said to him: "Noble Ānanda, you should understand this as the power of the Buddha. Noble Ānanda, you should understand this as the blessing of the Buddha. Noble Ānanda, I am not able to speak at all, taking the bodhisattva, the great being, as my starting point, by my own power."

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, it is just as Śakra, lord of the gods, has said. It is so, it is so. This is the power of the Tathāgata. It is through the blessing of the Tathāgata that Śakra, lord of the gods, has spoken."

This is the twenty-third chapter, called "The Chapter of Śakra," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines. The twentieth volume.

Then the Blessed One spoke again to the venerable Ānanda, saying:

Ānanda, furthermore, when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in the Perfection of Wisdom, applies himself to the Perfection of Wisdom, and meditates on the Perfection of Wisdom, then, Ānanda, all the evil Māras of the great trichiliocosm world-system fall into doubt, thinking: "Will this bodhisattva, this great being, turn back midway and directly realize the true limit at the level of the śrāvakas or the level of the pratyekabuddhas? Or will he awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?"

Furthermore, Ānanda, when a bodhisattva, a great being, abides in the Perfection of Wisdom, then those evil Māras are pierced by the sting of sorrow.

Furthermore, Ānanda, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the Perfection of Wisdom and applies himself to the Perfection of Wisdom, then those evil Māras try to harm that bodhisattva, that great being. They think: "May this bodhisattva, this great being, become discouraged and be struck with terror, so that even a single generation of his mind toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening is exhausted." So they also conjure up terrors, and they let loose and display shooting stars falling in every direction, and

things like blazing fires.

Ānanda, however, the evil Māra does not come intending harm into the presence of all bodhisattvas, great beings. He comes into the presence of some, and he does not come into the presence of others.

Ānanda said: "Blessed One, into the presence of what kind of bodhisattva, great being, does the evil Māra come intending harm?"

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, if a bodhisattva, a great being, has not, even in the past, generated a mind of devotion toward the teaching of the Perfection of Wisdom, then, Ānanda, the evil Māra comes to that bodhisattva, that great being, intending harm, and he finds an opening.

Furthermore, Ānanda, when the profound Perfection of Wisdom is being taught, a bodhisattva may fall into doubt and become double-minded, wondering, 'Is this the Perfection of Wisdom or is it not?' Ānanda, the evil Māra comes intending harm to such a bodhisattva, a great being, in whom doubt has arisen, and he finds an opening in him.

Furthermore, Ānanda, in this case a bodhisattva, a great being, may be parted from spiritual friends and held by evil companions. He does not listen when the Perfection of Wisdom, that most profound of subjects, is taught. Because he has not listened, he does not understand. Because he does not understand, he does not ask, 'How should one meditate on the Perfection of Wisdom?' Ānanda, the evil Māra comes intending harm to this bodhisattva, this great being, too, and he finds an opening in him.

Furthermore, Ānanda, a bodhisattva, a great being, may come to rely on and engage in the grasping of what is not the true Dharma. He thinks: 'This one is my friend, who will never abandon me in any matter. There are many other bodhisattvas, great beings, who are my friends, but they do not fulfill my wishes.'

Thinking, "I have found a friend who is in harmony with me, and he will fulfill my aspiration completely," Ānanda, Māra the Evil One will also come with harmful intent toward this bodhisattva, a great being, and will find an opening.

Furthermore, Ānanda, when such a bodhisattva, a great being, is expounding this profound Perfection of Wisdom, he says to other bodhisattvas, great beings: "Alas, this Perfection of Wisdom is profound. What use is it for you to listen to it? You will not succeed in it by striving in the way the Tathāgata taught in other sūtras. I myself cannot find its depth and cannot taste its

flavor, so what use is it for you to listen to it or to write it down?" In this way he turns other bodhisattvas, great beings, away from it. Ānanda, Māra the Evil One will come with harmful intent toward this bodhisattva too, and will find an opening.

Furthermore, Ānanda, when a bodhisattva looks down on other bodhisattvas and thinks, "I dwell in seclusion, while the others do not dwell in seclusion; they have no seclusion," then, Ānanda, Māra the Evil One becomes delighted, pleased, and glad. Great joy, exhilaration, and happiness arise in him; he is wholly satisfied, his mind is content, and great delight arises. Why is that? Because he thinks, "This one will keep unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening far away."

Furthermore, Ānanda, when a bodhisattva, a great being, is named, or his lineage is mentioned, or the qualities of his ascetic practice are fully described, then on that basis, a bodhisattva, a great being, who in fact lacks those qualities, looks down on others who possess virtuous qualities. And yet he himself does not have those qualities. He does not have the qualities, the aspects, the signs, and the marks of an irreversible bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom. Although he lacks them, he becomes afflicted with pride about the qualities of the irreversible ones. He says, "The qualities that appear to me do not appear to you," praising himself and disparaging others.

Then Māra the Evil One thinks: "The realm of Māra will not be emptied. The great hells of sentient beings will not be destroyed. The animal births, the realm of the hungry ghosts, and the host of the asuras will not be destroyed." Having thought this, Māra the Evil One empowers things so that those bodhisattvas, great beings, become people who are overcome by gain and honor, who become eloquent in speech, and who, through that eloquence, are followed by many people. He wills that many people listen to them and have faith in them. Then, seeing or hearing of them, people will imitate them. And in imitating what they have seen and heard, they will not train in suchness, will not practice in suchness, and will not apply themselves to yoga in suchness. Because they do not train in suchness, practice in suchness, or apply themselves to yoga in suchness, their afflictions will increase.

Because their mental continuum is inverted in this way, whatever actions of body, speech, and mind they perform will all turn out to be undesirable, unpleasant, joyless, and disagreeable. In this way those great hells of sentient

beings will not be emptied. The birthplaces of animals, the realm of hungry ghosts, the hosts of the asuras, and the abodes of Māra will not be emptied either. Ānanda, seeing this very reason, Māra the Evil One becomes delighted, pleased, and rejoicing, and feels great joy, satisfaction, and happiness.

Ānanda, furthermore, when a bodhisattva, a great being, quarrels, disputes, and mocks with a person who follows the vehicle of the śrāvakas, and reviles and insults him, thinks of harming him, and generates aversion, then Māra the Evil One thinks: "Alas! This son of good family will keep far away from omniscience; he will dwell very far from omniscience."

And if a person who follows the vehicle of the bodhisattvas quarrels, disputes, and mocks with another person who follows the vehicle of the bodhisattvas, and reviles and insults him, thinks of harming him, and generates aversion, then Māra the Evil One becomes extremely delighted, pleased, and rejoicing, and feels great joy, satisfaction, and happiness. He thinks: "Both of these bodhisattvas will dwell far from omniscience."

Ānanda, furthermore, if a bodhisattva, a great being, who has not received a prediction quarrels, disputes, and mocks with a bodhisattva, a great being, who has received a prediction, and reviles and insults him, thinks of harming him, generates aversion, and injures his mind, then that bodhisattva, a great being, even if he does not abandon omniscience, must put on the armor for as many eons as the number of those thoughts of awakening.

When he had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, for those who have generated those thoughts of awakening, is there any deliverance at all? Or must that bodhisattva, a great being, certainly put on the armor for that many eons?"

The Blessed One said: "Ānanda, to persons of the śrāvaka vehicle, to persons of the pratyekabuddha vehicle, and to persons of the bodhisattva vehicle, I have taught the Dharma that includes deliverance. Among these, Ānanda, if a person of the bodhisattva vehicle quarrels and disputes with another person of the bodhisattva vehicle, and reviles and insults him, thinks of harming him, and generates aversion, and then does not confess it individually, does not take up restraint afterward, but holds a grudge and remains clinging to resentment, Ānanda, I do not say that such a person has deliverance. Ānanda, that person will certainly have to put on the armor for that many eons.

"Ānanda, but if a person of the bodhisattva vehicle quarrels and disputes with another person of the bodhisattva vehicle, and reviles and insults him, thinks

of harming him, and generates aversion, and then confesses it individually, and having confessed it takes up restraint afterward and generates this thought: 'I must settle the quarrels of all sentient beings, remove them, and completely pacify them. If I myself were to quarrel, or were to answer back when someone speaks to me, that would be a wretched gain, a bad acquisition and not a good one. I must become like a bridge for all sentient beings.'

When speaking to others, I will not use harsh words such as "you," nor will I retort and reply with rough speech. When people quarrel, dispute, and mock, I will act like one who is stupid, deaf, and mute. When others speak ill, say hateful things, or utter abuse, I will hear their words without harboring ill will toward anyone. To make a point of knowing the faults and flaws of others does me no good; it is no part of my task. To think that I should listen for the faults and flaws of others is no part of my task.

Why is that? Because I must not disturb my own higher intention. I am to become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and then bring happiness to all sentient beings with every kind of comfort and lead them to complete nirvāṇa. How could I give rise to malice? Even when I and others are angry, I should not feel malice toward them. Would that not be my own disturbance? This is not for me to do. Rather, with firm and steady resolve, I will subdue others, and even when they threaten my life, I will not be disturbed or let anger and resentment arise in me.

Ānanda, I have declared that this is the way a bodhisattva, a great being, brings about his emergence from such pride.

Ānanda, a bodhisattva, a great being, should likewise abide in this way before persons who follow the Śrāvaka Vehicle. Just as he is not disturbed in the presence of any being, so should he abide in the presence of all beings.

Ānanda, how should a bodhisattva, a great being, abide in the presence of other persons who follow the Bodhisattva Vehicle? Ānanda, he should abide as he would before the Teacher, thinking: "These bodhisattvas, great beings, are my teachers. These bodhisattvas, great beings, have entered the same vehicle as I. These bodhisattvas, great beings, have entered the same path as I. These bodhisattvas, great beings, share my aspiration. These bodhisattvas, great beings, have rightly entered a vehicle in harmony with mine. Whatever they train in, I too will train in. However they train, so will I train. If some of them live in a mixed way, I will not live in a mixed way. And if they all live without mixing, with attention endowed with omniscience, then I too will train in the

same way."

Ānanda, when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in this way in omniscience, there will be no obstacle to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and he will swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

This is the twenty-fourth chapter, called "Pride," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, in what should a bodhisattva, a great being, train in order to be training in omniscience?"

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in exhaustion, he trains in omniscience."

Likewise, it is without arising, without cessation, without birth, without entity; it is secluded, free of attachment, space, and the dharmadhātu. Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in nirvāṇa, he trains in omniscience.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, why is it that if a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in exhaustion, he trains in omniscience? Likewise, if he trains in what is without arising, without cessation, without birth, without entity, secluded, free of attachment, space, the dharmadhātu, and nirvāṇa, why does he train in omniscience?

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, you ask why it is that if a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in exhaustion, he trains in omniscience, and likewise why training in what is without arising, without cessation, without birth, without entity, secluded, free of attachment, space, the dharmadhātu, and nirvāṇa amounts to training in omniscience. Subhūti, what do you think? That suchness of the Tathāgata, and that by which the Tathāgata is designated "the Tathāgata," is it something that could be exhausted?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it is not. Why? Blessed One, what is exhausted is not exhausted; Blessed One, exhaustion is inexhaustible.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? That suchness of the Tathāgata, and that by which the Tathāgata is designated "the Tathāgata," does it arise, or cease, or become born, or become an entity, or become secluded, or become destroyed, or become free of attachment, or become space, or become the dharmadhātu?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it does not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? That suchness of the Tathāgata, and that by which the Tathāgata is designated "the Tathāgata," does it pass into nirvāṇa?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, it does not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, therefore a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way trains thus: suchness is inexhaustible. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way trains in omniscience. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way trains in the Perfection of Wisdom. He trains in the stage of a buddha. He trains in the powers. He trains in the fearlessnesses. He trains in all the qualities of the buddhas. He trains in the wisdom of omniscience.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way will attain the perfection of all trainings. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way cannot be overpowered by Māra, by Māra's retinue, or by the gods of Māra's host. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way will quickly attain the nature of irreversibility. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way will quickly come to be seated at the heart of awakening.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way trains in his own proper domain. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way trains in the qualities that make one a protector. He trains in great loving-kindness. He trains in great compassion. He trains in great joy. He trains in great equanimity. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way trains in setting the wheel of Dharma in motion, turned three times in twelve aspects. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way trains in the resolve, "I shall not let the realm of sentient beings diminish." Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way trains in keeping the lineage of the Tathāgatas from being cut off. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way trains in the resolve, "I shall open the door to the realm of the deathless."

Subhūti, this vast training cannot be trained in by one whose mind is weak, and one of little power cannot train in it. Why is that? Subhūti, those who train in this training are in harmony with all sentient beings and share in common with them. Subhūti, they are the protectors of all sentient beings. Those who train in this training wish to attain a state that rises supreme above all sentient

beings.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way is not born among the beings of the hells, is not born in the animal realms, is not born in the realms of the hungry ghosts, and is not born in the body of an asura. He is not born among the people of the borderlands, is not born into the caste of outcastes, is not born into the caste of bamboo workers, and is not born into the families of hunters, fishermen, bandits, or butchers. He is not born into any other such low family of a wretched station and a wretched support.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way does not become blind, does not become deaf, does not become lame, does not become hunchbacked, does not become bent, does not become crippled, does not become leprous, does not become mute, does not become hoarse, does not become dull of hearing, and does not become impaired in his limbs. He does not become deficient in his limbs, does not become unsightly in his limbs, does not become ugly in complexion, does not become ugly in form, does not become impaired in his faculties, and does not become deficient in his faculties. Rather, he becomes complete in every aspect of the faculties, and his voice becomes perfectly excellent.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way does not take life, does not take what is not given, and does not engage in sexual misconduct. He does not lie, does not speak divisively, does not speak harshly, and does not engage in idle talk. He does not become covetous, does not become malicious, and does not hold wrong views. He does not make his living by wrong livelihood.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way is not born among the long-lived gods. He does not take up immoral conduct, and does not take up what is not the true Dharma. He is not born there through the power of meditative concentration and absorption. Why is that? Because the bodhisattva, the great being, who is endowed with skillful means has the skillful means by which he does not come to be born among the long-lived gods. Subhūti, what is that skillful means?

That is to say, a bodhisattva, a great being, who is endowed with skillful means in this very Perfection of Wisdom, enters even into meditative concentration, and yet through the power of that concentration is not reborn there. In just this way he practices this skillful means. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this manner has his powers fully purified, his

fearlessnesses fully purified, and all the qualities of a buddha fully purified, and he will gain them in due course.

The venerable Subhūti said: Blessed One, since all phenomena are pure by their very nature, then, Blessed One, by what means do a bodhisattva, a great being, come to have their powers purified, their fearlessnesses purified, and the qualities of a buddha purified, and come to gain them?

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Why is that? Subhūti, all phenomena are pure by their very nature. Subhūti, when bodhisattvas, great beings, who train in the Perfection of Wisdom are neither discouraged nor dismayed with regard to all phenomena being thus pure by their very nature, then, Subhūti, that is the Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti, ordinary foolish beings do not know and do not see these phenomena as they are. Because they neither know nor see, they do not know or see the nature of phenomena. Subhūti, for the sake of those beings, a bodhisattva, a great being, makes effort and undertakes diligence, training in this training: I myself shall make known to beings what they do not know, and I myself shall make visible to beings what they do not see. A bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this training will gain the powers, will gain the fearlessnesses, and will gain all the qualities of a buddha.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way fully understands, exactly as they are, the conduct and the stirrings of the minds of other beings and other individuals, and by fully understanding them exactly as they are, goes to the far shore of knowing the conduct of others' minds.

Subhūti, consider this example. In the great earth, the regions where there are no stones and where gold, gems, and silver are found are few, while the regions of the great earth that are filled with salt-laden soil, gravel, grass, stumps, and thorns of many kinds are far more numerous. In just the same way, Subhūti, among beings, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who train in the training of the Perfection of Wisdom and of omniscience are few, while those beings who train in the training of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are far more numerous.

Furthermore, Subhūti, consider this example. Among beings, those who have undertaken and abide in the karma that leads to attaining the kingship of a wheel-turning king are few, while those beings who have undertaken and abide in the karma that leads to attaining the kingship of a king of a city are

far more numerous.

Subhūti, in the same way, among beings those bodhisattvas, great beings, who enter the great path, that is, the path of the Perfection of Wisdom, with the thought "I shall fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening," are few. Among beings those who enter the path of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are very many.

Furthermore, Subhūti, take this example. Among beings, those who firmly undertake and abide in the actions that lead to becoming Śakra are few. Among beings, those who firmly undertake and abide in the actions that lead to birth in the world of the gods are very many.

In the same way, Subhūti, among beings those bodhisattvas, great beings, who train in the training of the Perfection of Wisdom are few. Among beings those who train in the training of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are very many.

Furthermore, Subhūti, take this example. Among beings, those who firmly undertake and abide in the actions that lead to becoming Brahmā are few. Among beings, those who firmly undertake and abide in the actions that lead to birth in Brahmā's retinue are very many.

In the same way, Subhūti, among beings those bodhisattvas, great beings, who do not turn back from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening are few. Among beings those bodhisattvas, great beings, who do turn back from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening are very many.

Therefore, Subhūti, among beings those who have rightly entered upon unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening are few. Fewer than those few are the beings who practice in accordance with suchness. Fewer still than those very few who practice in accordance with suchness are those who devote themselves to the Perfection of Wisdom. And fewer still than those few who devote themselves to the Perfection of Wisdom are the bodhisattvas, great beings, who do not turn back from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Therefore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, great being, who wishes to be counted among those irreversible bodhisattvas, great beings, who are fewer even than the few, should train in this very Perfection of Wisdom and should devote himself to it.

Furthermore, Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, great being, trains in the Perfection of Wisdom in this way, no mind accompanied by crookedness arises, no mind

accompanied by doubt arises, no mind accompanied by envy arises, no mind accompanied by miserliness arises, no mind accompanied by immoral conduct arises, no mind accompanied by malice arises, no mind accompanied by laziness arises, no mind accompanied by distraction arises, and no mind accompanied by confused wisdom arises.

Subhūti, by training in the Perfection of Wisdom in this way, a bodhisattva, great being, will fully grasp all the perfections. He will wholly take hold of all the perfections. He will take up all the perfections as supreme. All the perfections will follow after him. All the perfections will be gathered within him.

Subhūti, it is like this. Take this example.

Within the view of the perishable aggregates, the sixty-two views are gathered. In just the same way, Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in the Perfection of Wisdom, all the perfections are gathered within it.

Subhūti, it is like this. Within a person's life faculty, all the faculties are gathered. In just the same way, Subhūti, when one trains in the Perfection of Wisdom, all the virtuous qualities of a bodhisattva, a great being, are gathered within it.

Subhūti, it is like this. When a person's life faculty ceases, all the faculties cease. In just the same way, Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in the Perfection of Wisdom, ignorance ceases and all unwholesome qualities cease, while all the perfections are gathered within and held fast.

Therefore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to grasp all the perfections should train in the Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in the Perfection of Wisdom, he trains as the supreme one among all sentient beings. Why is this? Because he is the supreme one in merit.

Subhūti, what do you think? Of all the sentient beings who exist in the great trichilocosm world-system, however many are counted as sentient beings, are they all numerous?

Subhūti replied: Blessed One, even the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa are numerous, so what need is there to speak of all the sentient beings of the great trichilocosm world-system?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, suppose a single bodhisattva, a great being, were to remain for as long as he lives and attend to all those sentient beings

with clothing, food, bedding, medicine for the sick, and all useful provisions. Subhūti, what do you think? Would that bodhisattva, a great being, produce a great deal of merit on that basis?

Subhūti replied: Blessed One, a great deal. Sugata, a great deal.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, meditates on this Perfection of Wisdom for even as short a time as it takes to snap the fingers, he produces far more merit than that. Why is this? Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom of a bodhisattva, a great being, is of such great significance, for the Perfection of Wisdom is what brings a bodhisattva, a great being, to the attainment of unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Therefore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, should train in this Perfection of Wisdom if he wishes to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening; if he wishes to become unsurpassed among all sentient beings; if he wishes to become the protector of all sentient beings who have no protector; if he wishes to attain the realm of the buddhas; if he wishes to attain the state of being the supreme leader of the herd, the buddha; if he wishes to delight in the playful display of the buddhas; if he wishes to roar the lion's roar of the buddhas; if he wishes to attain the excellences of the buddhas; and if he wishes to speak the Dharma throughout the great trichiliocosm world-system.

Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in the Perfection of Wisdom, I do not see any excellence that he would fail to train in.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, does that bodhisattva, that great being, also train in the excellences of the śrāvakas?

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, that bodhisattva, that great being, does train in the excellences of the śrāvakas. Yet, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, does not train in the thought that he should abide in the excellences of the śrāvakas, nor in the thought that the excellences of the śrāvakas will belong to those who need no further training. He does not train in that way.

Subhūti, he also fully understands whatever qualities the śrāvakas have, but he does not abide in them. He examines them in this way without abiding, and he trains in the thought: "I shall explain these qualities of the śrāvakas, and I shall teach them."

Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in this way, he becomes a worthy recipient of offerings for the world with its gods, humans, and asuras.

Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, trains in this way, he overcomes all other recipients of offerings, those who possess the qualities of śrāvakas and those who possess the qualities of pratyekabuddhas, and he draws near to omniscience.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way does not abandon the Perfection of Wisdom. He practices the Perfection of Wisdom and is never separated from abiding in the Perfection of Wisdom. Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices in this way, he should be known as one whose nature is never to fall away from omniscience. He keeps far from the level of the śrāvakas and the level of the pratyekabuddhas, and he draws near to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Now suppose he were to think: "This is the Perfection of Wisdom, which brings about the attainment of this very omniscience." If he thinks and understands in that way, he is not practicing the Perfection of Wisdom. And suppose he does not truly know this Perfection of Wisdom either, in the thought: "This is the Perfection of Wisdom; this belongs to the Perfection of Wisdom; this Perfection of Wisdom is what attains omniscience." Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, neither truly knows nor truly sees it in this way, then, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in this way is practicing the Perfection of Wisdom.

This is the twenty-fifth chapter, called "Training," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines. Volume twenty-one.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, thought: "Even by the conduct of a bodhisattva, a great being, all beings are overcome in this way. How much more so when he has become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening! Those beings whose minds turn toward omniscience have gained a good gain, and those beings live a good life. How much more so those who have given rise to the mind of unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening!"

Those excellent beings who will fully awaken into unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening should be regarded as the ones to be wished for.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, magically conjured mandārava flowers, and holding them cupped in his hands he scattered them over the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, and he spoke these words: "May the awakening mind of those persons of the bodhisattva vehicle, who give rise to

the thought of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, who aspire, who reflect, who take up that resolve, thinking, 'Having fully awakened to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, we shall establish on the ground of the buddhas, on the far shore, all sentient beings who are being swept along by the great ocean of saṃsāra,' be fulfilled. May those very qualities of a buddha be perfectly completed in them. May those very qualities that accompany omniscience be perfectly completed. May those very self-arisen qualities be perfectly completed. May those very qualities that cannot be taken away be perfectly completed.

"Blessed One, as for those bodhisattvas, great beings, endowed with great compassion, not one thought of turning back from unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening will arise in them. Blessed One, as for those persons of the bodhisattva vehicle who have properly entered upon fully awakening to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, not one thought of turning back from it will arise in them, for, seeing the sufferings that sentient beings experience in saṃsāra, they will give rise to vast aspirations for unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

"Why is that? Those who are endowed with such a resolve as this, 'Having crossed over myself, I shall bring sentient beings across; having been freed, I shall free them; having breathed freely, I shall give them breath; having completely passed beyond sorrow, I shall lead them to complete nirvāṇa,' those who abide in such a resolve are wishing for the sake of great compassion, are wishing to heal, and are showing tender concern with compassion for the world with its gods, humans, and asuras.

"Blessed One, if one rejoices in the resolve of those bodhisattvas, great beings, who have newly entered the vehicle; and rejoices in the resolve of those who are practicing the conduct of bodhisattvas; and rejoices in the irreversible nature of the irreversible bodhisattvas, great beings; and rejoices in the nature of the bodhisattvas, great beings, who are bound to only one more birth, then, Blessed One, how much merit will that son or daughter of good family produce?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to Śakra, lord of the gods, in these words: "Kauśika, one could grasp the measure of Mount Sumeru, king of mountains, by weighing it on a scale, but, Kauśika, the measure of the merit of that resolve of a son or daughter of good family, endowed with rejoicing in bodhisattvas, great beings, cannot be grasped."

Kauśika, one might still be able to grasp the measure of the world-system of the fourth great continent, if it were weighed on a scale, but the measure of the merit of that mind generated together with rejoicing cannot be grasped. Kauśika, one might still be able to grasp the measure of a thousand-fold world-system, a small chiliocosm, if it were weighed on a scale, but the measure of the merit of that mind generated together with rejoicing cannot be grasped. Kauśika, one might still be able to grasp the measure of the second, middle thousand-fold world-system, if it were weighed on a scale, but the measure of the merit of that mind generated together with rejoicing cannot be grasped. Kauśika, one might still be able to grasp the measure of the great trichiliocosm world-system, if it were weighed on a scale, but, Kauśika, the measure of the merit of the mind generated together with rejoicing by a son or daughter of good family in the bodhisattva, the great being, cannot be grasped.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, those beings who do not listen to, do not accept, do not see, and do not rejoice in the merit of generating the mind of rejoicing in bodhisattvas, great beings, which is immeasurable in this way, from the first generation of the awakening mind up to the fully accomplished buddhahood of unsurpassed, perfect awakening, should be known as blessed, that is, possessed, by Māra. Blessed One, those beings who do not rejoice in this generation of the mind by bodhisattvas, great beings, have come over to the side of Māra. Blessed One, those beings who do not rejoice in this generation of the mind by bodhisattvas, great beings, have passed away and transmigrated from the realm of Māra, that is, they have left his domain.

Why is that? Blessed One, those who bring about these generations of mind, those who fully dedicate these generations of mind to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, or those who rejoice in these generations of mind, destroy the abode of Māra. Blessed One, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who have generated the mind for unsurpassed, perfect awakening, those generations of mind should be rejoiced in. Blessed One, those sons or daughters of good family who have not abandoned the Tathāgata, have not abandoned the Dharma, and have not abandoned the Saṅgha should rejoice in this generation of the mind.

When he had spoken thus, the Blessed One said this to Śakra, lord of the gods: Kauśika, it is so, it is just so. Kauśika, those sons or daughters of good family who have not abandoned the Tathāgata, have not abandoned the Dharma,

and have not abandoned the Saṅgha should rejoice in these generations of mind. Kauśika, those sons or daughters of good family, whether followers of the bodhisattva vehicle, the pratyekabuddha vehicle, or the śrāvaka vehicle, who rejoice in this generation of the mind will quickly please the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas, and will not fail to please them.

When he had spoken thus, Śakra, lord of the gods, said this to the Blessed One:

Blessed One, it is just so. Sugata, it is just so. Those sons or daughters of good family, whether they follow the vehicle of the bodhisattvas, the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas, or the vehicle of the śrāvakas, who rejoice in these generations of the awakening mind, will very swiftly please the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, and will not displease them. And through the roots of virtue of generating the awakening mind accompanied by such rejoicing, wherever they are born, in each such place they will be honored, revered, offered gifts, worshipped, held in esteem, and attended with respect. They will not see unpleasing forms, they will not hear unpleasing sounds, they will not smell unpleasing odors, they will not taste unpleasing flavors, and they will not touch unpleasing tangibles. It should be understood that they will not be born in the lower realms; it should be understood that they will be born in the higher realms. Why is that? It is because those sons or daughters of good family rejoice in the roots of virtue, immeasurable and innumerable, that bring happiness to all sentient beings.

Blessed One, those persons who follow the vehicle of the bodhisattvas, and whose generations of the awakening mind I have rejoiced in with eager intention, will have those generations of awakening mind grow and increase, and they will attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, they will also lead immeasurable and innumerable sentient beings to complete nirvāṇa.

The Blessed One said: Kauśika, through the power of the Tathāgata, whatever you have said is just so; it is just so. Kauśika, if a son or daughter of good family rejoices in the generations of the awakening mind of persons who follow the vehicle of the bodhisattvas, then in this way, Kauśika, by rejoicing in those generations of the awakening mind of such persons, that son or daughter of good family comes to rejoice in the roots of virtue of immeasurable and countless sentient beings, and generates and accomplishes them.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, how can a mind that is like an illusion come to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, what do you think? Do you perceive the mind correctly as being like an illusion?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, I do not.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? Do you perceive the illusion correctly?

Subhūti said: Blessed One, I do not. Blessed One, I do not correctly perceive a mind like an illusion, nor do I correctly perceive an illusion.

The Blessed One said: Subhūti, what do you think? You who do not correctly perceive an illusory mind or a mind like an illusion, do you correctly perceive any phenomenon, other than the illusion or the mind like an illusion, that awakens fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?

Subhūti said:

"Blessed One, it is not so. Apart from illusion, or apart from mind that is like an illusion, I do not perceive any phenomenon that would fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Since I do not perceive any such phenomenon apart from illusion or apart from mind that is like an illusion, what phenomenon could I speak of as existing or as not existing? Of that phenomenon which is utterly secluded, there is no realization that it exists or that it does not exist. For any phenomenon that is utterly secluded does not awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Why is that? Blessed One, a phenomenon that does not exist does not awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

"Blessed One, therefore the Perfection of Wisdom is utterly secluded. And that phenomenon which is utterly secluded is not something to be cultivated; by it nothing is attained and nothing is abandoned. Then, Blessed One, how could a bodhisattva, a great being, relying on the Perfection of Wisdom that is utterly secluded, fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening? Blessed One, unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening is also utterly secluded. Blessed One, when the Perfection of Wisdom is utterly secluded, and unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening is also utterly secluded, then, Blessed One, how could seclusion fully awaken to seclusion?"

When he had spoken in this way, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: "Excellent, Subhūti, excellent! It is just so, Subhūti, it is just so. The Perfection of Wisdom is utterly secluded, and unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening is also utterly secluded. Subhūti, it is precisely because the Perfection of Wisdom is utterly secluded that one fully awakens to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, which is utterly secluded.

"Subhūti, if a bodhisattva, a great being, were to know thoroughly that the Perfection of Wisdom is utterly secluded, that would not be the Perfection of Wisdom. Subhūti, in this way a bodhisattva, a great being, relying on the Perfection of Wisdom, fully awakens to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And yet, Subhūti, there is no one who, relying on the Perfection of Wisdom, fully awakens to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Seclusion does not fully awaken to seclusion; nevertheless a bodhisattva, a great being, does fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and without relying on the Perfection of Wisdom, one does not fully awaken."

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, as I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has taught, a bodhisattva, a great being, practices in a profound meaning."

The Blessed One said: "It is just so, Subhūti, it is just so. A bodhisattva, a great being, practices in a profound meaning. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in a profound meaning, and who yet does not make that meaning directly manifest at the stage of the śrāvakas or the stage of the pratyekabuddhas, performs a difficult deed."

Subhūti said: Blessed One, as I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has taught, a bodhisattva, a great being, does not practice anything difficult. Why is that? Blessed One, it is because the phenomenon that is being realized directly is itself not apprehended; the phenomenon that is realized is not apprehended; and the phenomenon by which it is realized directly is not apprehended either.

Blessed One, if, when this is taught, a bodhisattva, a great being, is not discouraged, not dismayed, not utterly disheartened, does not turn away in mind, does not tremble, is not completely terrified, and does not become possessed of fright, then he practices the Perfection of Wisdom. If he does not view himself, in the right way, as thinking, "I am practicing," then he practices the Perfection of Wisdom. If he does not view himself, in the right way, as thinking, "I have come close to unsurpassed, perfect and complete

awakening," then he practices the Perfection of Wisdom. If he does not think, "I have left the grounds of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas far behind," then he practices the Perfection of Wisdom.

Blessed One, it is like space. Space does not think, "I am near to some things and far from others." Why is that? Blessed One, it is because space has no conceptual thought. In just the same way, Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom does not think, "I have come close to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and the grounds of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are far from me." Why is that? Blessed One, it is because the Perfection of Wisdom has no conceptual thought.

Blessed One, it is like a magical illusion of a man. The illusory man does not think, "The one who creates the illusion is near to me, but this other gathering of people assembled here is far from me." Why is that? Blessed One, it is because the illusory man has no conceptual thought. In just the same way, Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom does not think, "I have come close to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and the grounds of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are far from me." Why is that? Blessed One, it is because the Perfection of Wisdom has no conceptual thought.

Blessed One, it is like a reflection. A reflection does not think, "Whatever the support is from which the reflection arises, that is near to me, but those who have not come close to the mirror or the vessel filled with water are far from me." Why is that? Blessed One, it is because a reflection has no conceptual thought. In just the same way, Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom does not think, "I have come close to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and the grounds of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are far from me." Why is that? Blessed One, it is because the Perfection of Wisdom has no conceptual thought.

Blessed One, it is like this. The Tathāgata holds neither fondness nor dislike toward anyone. Why is that? Because the Tathāgata has abandoned all conceptualization and discrimination. In just the same way, Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom holds neither fondness nor dislike toward anyone. Why is that? Blessed One, because there is no conceptualization in the Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, just as the Tathāgata has abandoned all conceptualization and discrimination, so too the Perfection of Wisdom has abandoned all

conceptualization and discrimination.

Blessed One, it is like this. Suppose an emanation is magically produced by a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly awakened buddha. That emanation does not think, "I have come close to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, and the level of the śrāvakas and the pratyekabuddhas is far from me." Why is that? Blessed One, because there is no conceptualization in an emanation. In just the same way, Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom does not think, "I have come close to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, and the level of the śrāvakas and the level of the pratyekabuddhas are far from me." Why is that? Blessed One, because there is no conceptualization in the Perfection of Wisdom.

Blessed One, it is like this. An emanation performs whatever task it was emanated to perform, and yet that emanation has no conceptualization. Why is that? Because there is no conceptualization in that emanation. In just the same way, Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, accomplishes whatever task he undertakes to accomplish by cultivating this Perfection of Wisdom, and yet that Perfection of Wisdom has no conceptualization. Why is that? Blessed One, because there is no conceptualization in the Perfection of Wisdom.

Blessed One, it is like this. Suppose a skilled carpenter, or a carpenter's apprentice, assembles a mechanical figure of a man or a woman made of wood. Whatever task it was made to perform, it performs, and yet that assemblage of wood has no conceptualization. Why is that? Blessed One, because there is no conceptualization in that assemblage of wood. In just the same way, Blessed One, a bodhisattva, a great being, accomplishes whatever task he undertakes to accomplish by cultivating this Perfection of Wisdom, and yet that Perfection of Wisdom has no conceptualization. Why is that? Blessed One, because there is no conceptualization in the Perfection of Wisdom.

This is the twenty-sixth chapter, called "The Chapter on Being Like an Illusion," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the venerable Subhūti: "Venerable Subhūti, alas, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom practices in the essence."

When he had said this, the venerable Subhūti said to the venerable Śāriputra: "Venerable Śāriputra, alas! Whatever bodhisattva, a great being, practices the Perfection of Wisdom practices in what is not the essence."

Then many thousands of sons of the gods who dwell in the desire realm thought: Those beings who have generated the mind toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and strive to accomplish it are worthy of homage. And those who practice this profound Perfection of Wisdom, and yet, though they practice in this way, do not directly realize the true limit at the level of the śrāvakas or the level of the pratyekabuddhas, and who, though they practice in the nature of phenomena, do not directly realize that nature of phenomena, by this account too one should know that these bodhisattvas, great beings, are doing what is difficult.

Then the Venerable Subhūti, knowing with his own mind the thoughts in the minds of those many thousands of sons of the gods who dwell in the desire realm, said to them: Sons of the gods, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who do not directly realize that true limit are not doing what is difficult. But, sons of the gods, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who put on the armor thinking, "I shall lead immeasurable, innumerable beings to complete nirvāṇa," are doing what is difficult; they are doing what is supremely difficult. For beings are empty, and those beings too are utterly nonexistent; being nonexistent, they are not apprehended. In the same way, those who are to be tamed are utterly nonexistent; being nonexistent, they are not apprehended. Thus bodhisattvas, great beings, who think, "I shall tame beings," have properly set out to become fully awakened in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Sons of the gods, to think "I shall tame beings" is to think "I shall tame space." Why is that? Sons of the gods, because space is empty, beings should be known as empty. Sons of the gods, if a bodhisattva, a great being, puts on the armor for the sake of beings who are nonexistent and not apprehended, then by this account he is doing what is difficult. Sons of the gods, to think "I shall put on the armor for the sake of beings" is to think "I shall contend with space." Yet this bodhisattva, a great being, has put on this armor for the sake of beings. And the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, have taught that those beings too are utterly unapprehended; and because beings are empty, it should be understood in this way. Thus, because those to be tamed are empty, the bodhisattva should be known as empty.

If, when this is explained, the bodhisattva, a great being, does not become discouraged, sons of the gods, you should know that this bodhisattva, a great being, is practicing the Perfection of Wisdom. Why is that? Because beings are empty, form should be known as empty. In the same way, because beings are empty, feelings, perceptions, and formations are empty; and because beings

are empty, consciousness should be known as empty. In the same way, because beings are empty, all phenomena, up to the very last, should be known as empty. Sons of the gods, in this way one should view all phenomena as empty. Sons of the gods, when all phenomena are thus explained as empty, if the bodhisattva, a great being, does not become discouraged, then because of not becoming discouraged in this way, he practices the Perfection of Wisdom.

Then the Blessed One, knowing the answer, said to the venerable Subhūti, "Subhūti, why is it that when all phenomena are taught in this way as secluded, the bodhisattva, the great being, is not discouraged?"

Subhūti replied, "Blessed One, it is because of seclusion that he is not discouraged. Blessed One, for this reason the bodhisattva, the great being, is not discouraged when all phenomena are taught as secluded. Blessed One, there is no phenomenon at all by which he could become discouraged. Why is that? Blessed One, those phenomena by which one might become discouraged are not apprehended at all. Blessed One, a phenomenon by which some phenomenon might become discouraged is not apprehended either."

The Blessed One said, "So it is, Subhūti, so it is. Nevertheless, Subhūti, if, when this is spoken, taught, shown, and explained in this way, the bodhisattva, the great being, does not become discouraged, is not timid or anxious, is not dejected, is not utterly dejected, does not lose heart, does not turn back in mind, is not crushed and does not turn back, is not frightened, is not utterly terrified, and is free from terror, then he is practicing the Perfection of Wisdom."

Subhūti said, "Blessed One, so it is. Sugata, so it is. Blessed One, if the bodhisattva, the great being, practices in this way, he is practicing the Perfection of Wisdom. To a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in this way, the gods together with Indra, together with Brahmā, together with Prajāpati, together with Īśāna, together with the sages, and the assemblies of men and women, will bow from afar with palms joined."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, it is not only the gods together with Indra, together with Brahmā, together with Prajāpati, together with Īśāna, together with the sages, and the assemblies of men and women who will bow from afar with palms joined to the bodhisattva, the great being, who practices in this way. Subhūti, the gods of the Brahmā realms as well, the gods of Brahmā's Retinue, the Priests of Brahmā, the Great Brahmās, the gods of Limited Light,

Immeasurable Light, and Radiant Light, the gods of Limited Virtue, Immeasurable Virtue, and Increasing Virtue, the gods of Cloudless, Merit-Born, and Great Fruit, the beings without discrimination, and the gods of Not Great, Not Afflicted, Beautiful in Appearance, Clear-Seeing, and Akaniṣṭha, all these, Subhūti, will bow to the bodhisattva, the great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom itself.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, in the immeasurable, innumerable world systems there are Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas who are now living, who remain and are sustained. Those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, regard with the buddha eye the bodhisattva, the great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom in this way. Subhūti, they assist him and keep him in mind, the one who practices the Perfection of Wisdom.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who practice the Perfection of Wisdom are assisted and kept in mind by the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas."

Subhūti, such bodhisattvas, great beings, should be understood as irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. No obstacle from Māra or from anyone else will arise for them. Why is this? Subhūti, suppose that all the beings in the great trichiliocosm world-system were to become Māra the Evil One, and that each of those evil Māras were to emanate that many armies of Māra. Even so, Subhūti, those evil Māras would be unable to create an obstacle to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening for a bodhisattva, a great being, who is cared for by the buddhas and who practices the Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti, let alone all the beings of one great trichiliocosm becoming evil Māras. Suppose that all the beings in as many great trichiliocosm world-systems as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā were to become evil Māras, and that each of those evil Māras were to emanate that many armies of Māra. Even so, Subhūti, those evil Māras would be unable to create an obstacle to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening for a bodhisattva, a great being, who is cared for by the buddhas and who practices the Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, possesses two qualities, it is difficult for the evil Māras or the gods of Māra's retinue to overcome that bodhisattva. What are the two? They are these: that bodhisattva has not abandoned any being, and that bodhisattva realizes all phenomena as empty.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who possesses these two qualities is difficult for the evil Māras or the gods of Māra's retinue to overcome.

Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, possesses two other qualities, it is difficult for the evil Māras or the gods of Māra's retinue to overcome that bodhisattva. What are the two? They are these: that bodhisattva acts just as he speaks, and that bodhisattva is cared for by the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who possesses these two qualities is difficult for the evil Māras or the gods of Māra's retinue to overcome.

Subhūti, even the gods will think of approaching a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in this way. Having approached, they will think of questioning that bodhisattva, they will think of inquiring further, and they will think of honoring and revering that bodhisattva. They will also inspire joy in that bodhisattva, saying: "Son of good family, you will soon become fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Therefore, son of good family, you should abide in this very abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom. Why is that? Son of good family, if you abide just as you now abide and practice in this way, you will become a protector for beings who have no protector. You will become a savior for beings who have no savior. You will become a refuge for beings who have no refuge. You will become a resting place for beings who have no resting place. You will become an ally for beings who have no ally. You will become an island for beings who have no island. You will become a light for beings who are blind. You will become a guide for beings who have no guide. You will become a support for beings who have no support."

Those who have strayed from the path, and those who have no deliverance, he will become the supreme path and the way of deliverance." In this way, those sons of the gods delight in that bodhisattva, that great being.

Why is this so? Subhūti, in immeasurable, countless world systems there are buddhas, Blessed Ones, who are surrounded by communities of śrāvakas and honored at the head of communities of bodhisattvas, and who dwell, live, and remain there. Those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, too, proclaim the names, lineages, powers, colors, and forms of the bodhisattvas, the great beings, who abide in this abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom, who practice the Perfection of Wisdom, and who possess such qualities of inherent nature, that is, the qualities that belong to abiding in the Perfection of Wisdom. They teach the Dharma and speak words of praise about that bodhisattva, that great being.

Subhūti, it is just as, at present, I myself teach the Dharma and speak words of praise by proclaiming the names, lineages, powers, colors, and forms of the bodhisattva, the great being, Ratnaketu, of the bodhisattva, the great being, Śikhin, and of whichever other bodhisattvas, great beings, are now practicing the holy life in the presence of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Akṣobhya. In just the same way, Subhūti, those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, also teach the Dharma and speak words of praise by proclaiming the names, lineages, powers, colors, and forms of those bodhisattvas, great beings, who are now practicing the holy life in my buddha field and who abide in this abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, do those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, teach the Dharma and speak words of praise by proclaiming the names, lineages, powers, colors, and forms of all bodhisattvas, great beings?"

The Blessed One said: "Subhūti, that is not so. Those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, do not teach the Dharma and speak words of praise by proclaiming the names, lineages, powers, colors, and forms of all bodhisattvas, great beings. Subhūti, rather, those buddhas teach the Dharma and speak words of praise by proclaiming the names, lineages, powers, colors, and forms of those bodhisattvas, great beings, who are irreversible and free from all attachment."

Subhūti said: "Blessed One, do the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, ever teach the Dharma and speak words of praise by proclaiming the names, lineages, powers, colors, and forms of other bodhisattvas, great beings, who are not irreversible?"

The Blessed One said: "Subhūti, apart from the irreversible bodhisattvas, great beings, there are also individuals on the bodhisattva vehicle who possess the power of the antidote, and those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, teach the Dharma and speak words of praise by proclaiming their names, lineages, powers, colors, and forms. And who are they?"

Those who at present practice the conduct of bodhisattvas by training after the conduct of the bodhisattvas of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Akṣobhya, and who abide in the manner of training in it: Subhūti, apart from the irreversible bodhisattvas, great beings, these are persons of the bodhisattva vehicle about whom those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, teach the Dharma and make declarations, proclaiming their names, their lineages, their powers, their complexions, and their forms.

Again, Subhūti, those who practice the conduct of bodhisattvas by training after the conduct of the bodhisattva, the great being Ratnaketu, and who abide in the manner of training in it: Subhūti, apart from the irreversible bodhisattvas, great beings, these too are persons about whom those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, teach the Dharma and make declarations, proclaiming their names, their lineages, their powers, their complexions, and their forms.

Furthermore, Subhūti, there are bodhisattvas, great beings, who practice the Perfection of Wisdom and who have the conviction that all phenomena are unborn, yet who have not yet attained the acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena. And there are those who have the conviction that all phenomena are peaceful, yet who have not yet gained mastery over irreversibility in regard to all phenomena, nor become unshakable in it. About these bodhisattvas, great beings, who abide in this state, those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, likewise teach the Dharma and make declarations, proclaiming their names, their lineages, their powers, their complexions, and their forms.

Furthermore, Subhūti, those bodhisattvas, great beings, about whom those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, teach the Dharma and make declarations, proclaiming their names, their lineages, their powers, their complexions, and their forms, are those who have left behind the level of the śrāvakas and the pratyekabuddhas. They aspire to the level of buddhahood itself, and they will also receive the prophecy of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. Why is that? Subhūti, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who practice the Perfection of Wisdom in this way, and about whom those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, teach the Dharma and make declarations, proclaiming their names, their lineages, their powers, their complexions, and their forms, will come to abide in irreversibility.

Furthermore, Subhūti, there are bodhisattvas, great beings, who, on hearing this profound Perfection of Wisdom being taught, have conviction in it. They do not become bewildered, they are not discouraged, and they have no doubt. Having conviction that it is just as the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha has taught, they listen to it in detail, and they give rise to the thought: "I shall listen in detail to this Perfection of Wisdom from the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Akṣobhya, and from those persons of the bodhisattva vehicle who lead the holy life in his buddha-field."

Through them as well, some will listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom and come to have faith in it. And when they have faith in this Perfection of Wisdom, they will have faith exactly as the Tathāgata has taught it, and by having faith in that way they will come to abide in irreversibility. Subhūti, if even hearing this way of the Perfection of Wisdom is shown to be of such great benefit, what need is there to speak of those who have faith in it, and, having faith, abide for the sake of suchness and practice for the sake of suchness; and who, having abided and practiced for the sake of suchness, come to abide in suchness itself and in omniscience, and then teach the Dharma?

Subhūti asked: Blessed One, when nothing other than suchness can be apprehended, then, Blessed One, what phenomenon will abide in suchness? What will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening? And what will teach this Dharma?

When he had spoken in this way, the Blessed One said to the venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, you ask, "When nothing other than suchness can be apprehended, then what phenomenon will abide in suchness, what will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and what will teach this Dharma?" Subhūti, apart from suchness, no other phenomenon that could abide in suchness is apprehended. Subhūti, since suchness itself is not apprehended, what need is there to speak of something that abides in suchness? Subhūti, suchness does not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. For, Subhūti, no phenomenon that has become a perfect buddha in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, or that will become one, or that is fully awakening, is apprehended at all. Subhūti, suchness does not teach the Dharma. Subhūti, no phenomenon that is to be taught is apprehended either.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, the Perfection of Wisdom is profound. Blessed One, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who wish to fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening are doing something difficult. Why is that? Blessed One, it is because no phenomenon abides in suchness, no phenomenon fully awakens to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and no one teaches the Dharma, and yet in this they do not shrink back, do not become discouraged, and do not become bewildered.

Then the venerable Subhūti said to Śakra, lord of the gods: Kauśika, you say that bodhisattvas, great beings, who do not become discouraged or

bewildered when such a profound Dharma is taught are doing something difficult. Kauśika, since all phenomena are empty, who here would become discouraged and bewildered?

Śakra said: Venerable Subhūti, whatever you have taught has been taught on the basis of emptiness, and so it meets with no obstruction anywhere. It is just as, when an arrow is shot into the sky, nothing obstructs it.

In the same way, the teaching of the Dharma given by the noble Subhūti is also unobstructed.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, when I say and teach such things with reference to the elder Subhūti, am I speaking as the Tathāgata has spoken? Am I speaking the Dharma? Am I explaining, with an explanation that accords with the Dharma, what is in keeping with the Dharma?

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to Śakra, lord of the gods: Kauśika, what you have said is so. Kauśika, it is so. What you say and teach in this way is speaking as the Tathāgata has spoken. It is speaking the Dharma. It is explaining, with an explanation that accords with the Dharma, what is in keeping with the Dharma.

Why is that? Kauśika, whatever the elder Subhūti is inspired to say, Kauśika, he is inspired to say with reference to emptiness.

Why is that? Kauśika, the elder Subhūti does not even perceive or apprehend the perfection of wisdom, so how could there be any practicing of the perfection of wisdom? He does not apprehend even awakening, so how much less any becoming fully and perfectly awakened? He does not apprehend even omniscience, so how could there be any attaining of omniscience? He does not apprehend even suchness, so how could there be any becoming a Tathāgata? He does not apprehend even non-arising, so how could there be any making of non-arising manifest? He does not apprehend even bodhisattvas, so how could there be any becoming fully and perfectly awakened? He does not apprehend even the powers, so how could there be any possessing of the powers? He does not apprehend even fearlessness, so how could there be any becoming fearless? He does not even apprehend the Dharma, so how could there be any teaching of the Dharma?

Kauśika, the elder Subhūti abides in the abiding in which all phenomena are secluded and all phenomena are unapprehendable.

Kauschika, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices and abides in the perfection of wisdom does not come near to even a hundredth part of the abiding of the elder Subhūti, in which all phenomena are secluded and all phenomena are without any basis for apprehension. Nor does such a bodhisattva come near to a thousandth part, a hundred-thousandth part, a ten-millionth part, a hundred-ten-millionth part, a thousand-ten-millionth part, or a hundred-thousand-ten-millionth part. Nor does he come near to even a hundred thousand billionth part. He does not come near in number. It cannot be counted, it cannot be compared with any example, it cannot be demonstrated by any simile, and it cannot bear a basis or a cause for comparison.

Kauśika, the abiding in which a bodhisattva, a great being, practices and abides in the perfection of wisdom overpowers all other abidings, except for the abiding of the Tathāgata, and whatever is not that. Kauśika, this abiding is called the supreme of all those abidings. It is called the sublime, the chief, the excellent, the most excellent, the highest, the foremost, the unsurpassed, the unexcelled, the incomparable, and the equal of the unequaled.

The abiding in which a bodhisattva, a great being, practices and abides in the perfection of wisdom overpowers all the abidings of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

Kauśika, therefore, any son or daughter of good family who wishes to be supreme among all beings, who wishes to be the best, the chief, the foremost, the most excellent, the highest, the unsurpassed, the unexcelled, who wishes to be unequaled, and who wishes to be equal to the unequaled, should abide in the abiding in which bodhisattvas, great beings, practice and dwell in the Perfection of Wisdom.

This is the twenty-seventh chapter, called "The Essence," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines. The twenty-second section.

Then, at that time, another son of the gods, together with the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, took up mandārava flowers and great mandārava flowers and went to the place where the Blessed One was. At that time, six hundred thousand monks had gathered in the assembly and were seated there. They too rose from their seats, arranged their upper robes over one shoulder, set their right knees on the ground, and from where they were, bowed with palms joined toward the place where the Blessed One was.

Through the power of the buddha, the alms bowls of those monks were filled with mandārava flowers and great mandārava flowers. With those mandārava flowers and great mandārava flowers they scattered, strewed, and showered the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, and they spoke these words:

Blessed One, we shall practice this Perfection of Wisdom. Blessed One, we shall abide in this unsurpassed abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom.

Then the Blessed One, at that moment, smiled. It is the nature of things that whenever buddhas, blessed ones, smile, rays of light of many colors issue from the mouth of the Blessed One, in many hues: blue, yellow, red, white, crimson, crystal, silver, and gold. These lights illuminated boundless, limitless, endless world systems, rose upward as far as the world of Brahmā, then returned, circled the Blessed One three times, and vanished into the crown of the Blessed One's head.

Then the venerable Ānanda rose from his seat, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, set his right knee on the ground, bowed with palms joined toward the place where the Blessed One was, and said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, do not smile without cause or condition. What is the cause, what is the condition, for the Blessed One's smile?

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke these words to the venerable Ānanda: Ānanda, in a future time, in the Star-like eon, these six hundred thousand monks will awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Having become fully awakened buddhas, they will teach the Dharma to beings. All of them will bear the same name: they will appear in the world as Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas, Teachers, all called Spread of Flowers. And, Ānanda, the communities of śrāvakas of those Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas called Spread of Flowers will all be equal in number.

The life span of all those Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas called Scattered Flowers will likewise be equal, twenty thousand eons. The sacred scriptures of each of them will also flourish and spread widely and extensively among gods and humans. The sacred Dharma of each of them will likewise remain for twenty thousand eons, equal in length.

In whatever villages, towns, market towns, regions, countries, and royal palaces those buddhas appear, and having appeared, wherever they turn the

wheel of Dharma, and having turned it, wherever they dwell, and from wherever to wherever they enter, and from wherever they come forth to wherever they go, in all those places, in entering and coming forth and dwelling, a rain of flowers of the five colors will fall.

Ānanda, therefore, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to dwell in the supreme abiding should dwell in the abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom. Ānanda, one who wishes to dwell in the abiding of the Tathāgata should dwell in the abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom.

Ānanda, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who practice the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood to have died among humans and been born here, or to have passed away from the realm of the gods of Tuṣita and been born among humans. Why is that? Because it is among humans and among the gods of Tuṣita that this Perfection of Wisdom is extensively practiced.

Furthermore, Ānanda, those bodhisattvas, great beings, who practice this Perfection of Wisdom should be known to be seen by the Tathāgata.

Those who hold this Perfection of Wisdom, bear it in mind, read it, thoroughly understand it, recite it, teach it, explain it, expound it, memorize it, and ask about it, or at the least write it down in a book; who having held, borne in mind, read, thoroughly understood, recited, taught, explained, expounded, and memorized it, and having at the least written it in a book, instruct and guide bodhisattvas, great beings, correctly teach them, correctly establish them, correctly encourage them, and fill them with joy: Ānanda, those bodhisattvas, great beings, should be known to have planted roots of virtue under the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas.

Those who train in this Perfection of Wisdom have not planted roots of virtue merely under śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Rather, Ānanda, those bodhisattvas, great beings, have without fail planted roots of virtue under the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas.

Ānanda, those who train in this Perfection of Wisdom and are not afraid; those who hold this Perfection of Wisdom, bear it in mind, read it, thoroughly understand it, recite it, teach it, explain it, expound it, memorize it, and ask about it, at the least in writing; and who in this way come to realize it in accord with its meaning, its true nature, and its method: Ānanda, those bodhisattvas, great beings, should be understood to have certainly come face to face with the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas.

Ānanda, those who do not slander this Perfection of Wisdom, do not contradict it, do not disturb it, do not destroy it, do not reject it, do not obstruct it, and do not think of harming it, should be understood to be bodhisattvas, great beings, who have done their work under the Victors of the past.

Ānanda, it is also the case that when a bodhisattva, a great being, makes an aspiration toward unsurpassed, perfect awakening, that aspiration does not prove false. Therefore, when a bodhisattva, a great being, plants roots of virtue in the presence of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, he does not bring about the ripening of that virtue for the sake of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Rather, Ānanda, that bodhisattva, that great being, should for the most part practice in the Perfection of Wisdom.

Therefore, Ānanda, I entrust this Perfection of Wisdom to you, and I entrust it to you again, so that it may by no means vanish. Hold it, master it, and keep it so that not even a single letter of it vanishes. Understand it fully, bring it to completion, and make it endure for a long time.

Ānanda, suppose you took hold of every teaching I have spoken to you directly, apart from the Perfection of Wisdom, and afterward wasted it, abandoned it, or forgot it. Even then, Ānanda, I would not count it as a fault in you. But Ānanda, if you were to waste, abandon, or forget even a single part of a phrase connected with the Perfection of Wisdom, then, Ānanda, you would have done me that much wrong, and you would not have pleased my mind.

Moreover, Ānanda, if after taking hold of the Perfection of Wisdom you later waste it, abandon it, and forget it, then you have not honored me, not revered me as your teacher, not served me, not made offerings to me, not made paintings of me, and not attended on me with respect. Ānanda, you will also have failed to honor, revere, serve, make offerings to, depict, and attend with respect all those blessed buddhas of the past, the future, and the present. Ānanda, if after taking hold of the Perfection of Wisdom you later waste it, abandon it, and forget it, you will have done me that much wrong, and you will not have pleased my mind.

Why is that? Ānanda, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas have taught that this Perfection of Wisdom is the mother of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas of the past, the future, and the present. She gives them birth, brings them forth, and causes them to attain omniscience.

Therefore, Ānanda, I entrust this Perfection of Wisdom to you, and I entrust it to you again, so that it may by no means vanish. Ānanda, take hold of this Perfection of Wisdom. Ānanda, keep this Perfection of Wisdom. Ānanda, read this Perfection of Wisdom. Ānanda, understand this Perfection of Wisdom fully. Ānanda, recite this Perfection of Wisdom aloud. Ānanda, teach this Perfection of Wisdom. Ānanda, explain this Perfection of Wisdom closely.

Ānanda, you should recite this Perfection of Wisdom aloud. Ānanda, you should commit this Perfection of Wisdom to memory. Ānanda, you should write down this Perfection of Wisdom, and Ānanda, you should meditate on this Perfection of Wisdom. Ānanda, you should attend to this Perfection of Wisdom well, grasp it well, understand it fully, and recite it well, taking up the letters, the words, and the clear articulation, and grasping rightly the syllables and the definitive expressions.

Why is this? Ānanda, take it as authoritative that this is the very nature of reality: it is the dharmakāya of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas of the past, the future, and the present.

Ānanda, just as you now think of me, the Tathāgata who is present, alive and sustained, with benevolent intent, with joy and reverence, wishing to do what is wholesome, to dwell in ease, or to relieve poverty, so, Ānanda, with that same benevolent intent, that same joy, that same reverence, and endowed with such qualities, you should hold this Perfection of Wisdom, bear it in mind, read it, understand it fully, recite it, teach it, and explain it. You should recite it aloud, commit it to memory, write it, meditate on it, honor it, regard it as your teacher, praise it, make offerings to it, depict it in paintings, and serve and revere it. In this way, Ānanda, you will be making offerings both to me and to those bodhisattvas, great beings, and you will also be generating joy, faith, and reverence in the presence of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, the future, and the present.

Ānanda, if you do not abandon your joy in me, the Tathāgata, and your delight in me, then in just the same way, so that not a single word is wasted or lost, do not abandon your joy and delight in this Perfection of Wisdom. Ānanda, with regard to entrusting this Perfection of Wisdom to you, if I were to speak at length, I could do so for an eon, or more than an eon, or a hundred eons, a thousand eons, a hundred thousand eons, a million eons, ten million eons, a hundred thousand million eons, or even longer. But in brief, Ānanda, just as I am your Teacher, so too the Perfection of Wisdom is your Teacher. Ānanda,

just as the buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, the future, and the present are the teachers of the worlds with their gods, humans, and asuras, so too the Perfection of Wisdom is the teacher of the worlds with their gods, humans, and asuras.

Therefore, Ānanda, the Perfection of Wisdom is immeasurable. For the benefit and happiness of the worlds with their gods, humans, and asuras, I entrust this Perfection of Wisdom to you with an immeasurable entrustment; I hand it over to you, and I entrust it to you for the future. Ānanda, whoever does not abandon the Tathāgata, does not abandon the Dharma, does not abandon the Saṅgha, and does not abandon the awakening of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, the future, and the present, should not abandon the Perfection of Wisdom. This is my final instruction.

Ānanda, if any person holds and bears this Perfection of Wisdom, reads it, understands it fully, recites it, teaches it, explains it, expounds it aloud, commits it to memory, and asks about it,

By cultivating it, one will come to be held in the awakening of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, the future, and the present. Ānanda, if anyone takes up this Perfection of Wisdom at the time when the Dharma is utterly decaying, that person will come to be held in the awakening of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, the future, and the present.

Why is that? Ānanda, the awakening of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is born from the Perfection of Wisdom. Ānanda, the unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening of those Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, the Blessed Ones, who appeared in the past, was likewise born from the Perfection of Wisdom, Ānanda. The unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening of those Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, the Blessed Ones, who will appear in the future, was likewise born from the Perfection of Wisdom, Ānanda. And the unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening of those Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, the Blessed Ones, who now dwell, live, and abide in all the immeasurable and innumerable world systems, Ānanda, is likewise born from this Perfection of Wisdom. My own unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, Ānanda, was also born from this Perfection of Wisdom.

Therefore, Ānanda, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to attain perfect buddhahood in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and who wishes to train in the six perfections, should listen to this very Perfection of Wisdom,

take it up, hold it, read it, thoroughly understand it, recite it, teach it, explain it, expound it, memorize it, and write it out; he should train in this very Perfection of Wisdom and practice it in yoga.

Why is that? Ānanda, because this Perfection of Wisdom is the mother of the bodhisattvas, the great beings; she gives them birth and brings them forth. Ānanda, all those bodhisattvas, great beings, who by training in the six perfections have definitively emerged, are emerging, and will emerge into unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, have trained in the six perfections in dependence on the Perfection of Wisdom, Ānanda. All of them were born from the six perfections in dependence on this very Perfection of Wisdom. Why is that? Ānanda, because all the perfections are born from the Perfection of Wisdom, and it is this that brings about the attainment of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Therefore, Ānanda, so that this Perfection of Wisdom may by no means vanish, I entrust it to you, and entrust it a second time, and hand it on to you.

Ānanda, this Perfection of Wisdom is the inexhaustible treasury of the Dharma of the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas. Why is that? Ānanda, whatever Dharma the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, have taught to sentient beings throughout the beginningless saṃsāra of the past, all of it has been taught from this very treasury of the Dharma, the Perfection of Wisdom.

Ānanda, whatever buddhas, blessed ones, in the future, through immeasurable cycles of time, will awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and teach the Dharma to sentient beings, those buddhas, blessed ones, will likewise teach from this very treasury of the Dharma, the Perfection of Wisdom. And Ānanda, whatever buddhas, blessed ones, now dwell, live, and sustain themselves in countless, innumerable world-systems and teach the Dharma, those buddhas, blessed ones, too will expound it from this very treasury of the Dharma, the Perfection of Wisdom. Therefore, Ānanda, these treasuries of the Perfection of Wisdom are inexhaustible treasuries of the Dharma.

Ānanda, suppose you were to teach the Dharma of the śrāvaka stage to individuals of the śrāvaka vehicle, and as you taught it, all the sentient beings in the great trichiliocosm world-system were to realize arhatship directly. Even so, you, who turn the wheel of the Dharma after me and teach in my wake as my śrāvaka, would not thereby have done the work of a śrāvaka. But Ānanda, if you were to explain or reveal to a bodhisattva, a great being, even a single

teaching that accords with the Perfection of Wisdom, then you, who turn the wheel of the Dharma after me and teach as my śrāvaka, would have pleased me. The earlier teaching would not please me in that way, even though through it all the sentient beings in the great trichiliocosm world-system had attained arhatship.

Ānanda, what do you think? Would the mass of merit arising from the basis of meritorious action through giving, the basis of meritorious action through moral discipline, and the basis of meritorious action through meditation, in all those arhats, be great?

Ānanda replied: It would be great, Blessed One. It would be great, Sugata.

The Blessed One said: Ānanda, one who teaches the Dharma that accords with the Perfection of Wisdom to a bodhisattva, a great being, generates far more merit than those individuals of the śrāvaka vehicle. Furthermore, Ānanda, a bodhisattva, a great being, who teaches the Dharma that accords with the Perfection of Wisdom to another bodhisattva, a great being, even for as little as a single day, generates far more merit than that. Ānanda, never mind a single day. Even for as little as a morning, or, Ānanda, never mind a morning, for as little as an hour, or never mind an hour, for a brief while, or, Ānanda, never mind a brief while, for a single moment of time, or, Ānanda, never mind a moment, for as little as an instant, whenever a bodhisattva, a great being, teaches another bodhisattva, a great being, the Dharma that accords with the Perfection of Wisdom, even for an instant, a moment, or a brief while, he generates far more merit than that.

Ānanda, this gift of the Dharma given by that bodhisattva, a great being, surpasses the roots of virtue of all individuals of the śrāvaka and pratyekabuddha vehicles.

Ānanda, as for bodhisattvas, great beings, who possess such roots of virtue, and bodhisattvas, great beings, who think upon such roots of virtue, that they should turn back from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening is, Ānanda, impossible and out of the question. This is not a possibility.

Then the Blessed One, at that time, by the power of a miraculous display that he willed into being, caused the fourfold assembly of monks, nuns, laymen and laywomen, together with gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, great mahoragas, humans and non-humans, all of them, through the buddha's power, to see the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Akṣobhya, surrounded by the community of monks and preceded by

an assembly of bodhisattvas, teaching the Dharma. Akṣobhya was profound like the ocean, and his retinue consisted of bodhisattvas, great beings, endowed with inconceivable qualities. It included also arhats, all with their defilements exhausted and free of affliction, masters of themselves, with minds fully liberated and wisdom fully liberated, noble ones, great elephants, who had done what was to be done, laid down their burden, attained their own aim, utterly exhausted the fetters of becoming, who through right and complete knowledge were fully liberated in mind, and who had reached the supreme perfection of mastery over all minds. Such was the miraculous display that he willed into being.

Then the Blessed One withdrew that miraculous display. When the Blessed One had withdrawn the miraculous display that he had willed into being, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha Akṣobhya, became invisible. Those bodhisattvas, great beings, those great śrāvakas, all those buddha-fields, and also that fourfold assembly, the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, great mahoragas, humans and non-humans, all vanished from the sight of those beings. Why was this? Because the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha had withdrawn the miraculous display he had willed into being, all of this vanished from their sight.

Then the Blessed One addressed the venerable Ānanda. Ānanda, in just this way all phenomena do not even appear before the eye. Phenomena do not appear to phenomena. Phenomena do not see phenomena, and phenomena do not know phenomena. Why is this? Ānanda, because no phenomenon is a knower or a seer, and none has the capacity to perform a function. Why is this? Ānanda, just as space has no activity, so all phenomena are without activity. Ānanda, all phenomena are inconceivable, like a person conjured by illusion. Ānanda, because phenomena have no real entity, none of them is a feeler.

Ānanda, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices in this way practices the Perfection of Wisdom and has no clinging to any phenomenon whatsoever. Ānanda, a bodhisattva, a great being, who trains in this way trains in the Perfection of Wisdom. A bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to attain the great awakening, the supreme perfection that surpasses all trainings, should train in the Perfection of Wisdom. Why is this?

Ānanda, these trainings are called the supreme of all trainings. They are called the excellent, the chief, the foremost, the most supreme, the most sublime, the highest, the unsurpassed, the one with nothing above it, the peerless, the one that is equal to the unequal. They bring benefit to all the world. They bring happiness to all the world. They become a protector for those who have no protector. They are permitted by the buddhas and praised by the buddhas.

Ānanda, having trained in this training and abiding in this training, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas could lift up this great trichiliocosm world-system with a single toe and set it down again, and yet those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, do not think, "I am lifting up this great trichiliocosm world-system," or "I am setting it down." Why is that? Because the Perfection of Wisdom possesses immeasurable and countless qualities. Ānanda, the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, having trained in this training of the Perfection of Wisdom, attained non-attachment toward all phenomena of the past, the future, and the present.

Ānanda, of all the trainings that exist in the past, future, and present times, this training of the Perfection of Wisdom is called the supreme. It is called the excellent, the chief, the foremost, the most supreme, the most sublime, the highest, the unsurpassed, the one with nothing above it, the peerless, the one that is equal to the unequal.

Ānanda, the Perfection of Wisdom is without measure. Ānanda, the Perfection of Wisdom is inexhaustible. Why is that? Because the Perfection of Wisdom is nonexistent. Ānanda, whoever thinks of grasping at a measure, an exhaustion, or an end of the Perfection of Wisdom is thinking of grasping at a measure, an exhaustion, or an end of space. Why is that? Ānanda, because the Perfection of Wisdom is without measure. Ānanda, the Perfection of Wisdom is inexhaustible. Ānanda, the Perfection of Wisdom is endless.

Ānanda, I have not spoken of a measure, an exhaustion, or an end of the Perfection of Wisdom. Ānanda, collections of names, collections of words, and collections of letters do have a connection with measure, but the Perfection of Wisdom has no connection with measure. Why is that? Ānanda, collections of names, collections of words, and collections of letters are not the Perfection of Wisdom. Ānanda, the Perfection of Wisdom is not endowed with measure. Ānanda, the Perfection of Wisdom is immeasurable.

Ānanda said, "Blessed One, why then did the Blessed One not state a measure of the Perfection of Wisdom?"

The Blessed One declared, "Ānanda, because the Perfection of Wisdom is inexhaustible, the Tathāgata did not teach a measure. Ānanda, because the Perfection of Wisdom is secluded, the Tathāgata did not speak of a measure. Ānanda, if in a secluded phenomenon not even seclusion can be found, how could there be a measure of it? Ānanda, in just this way, because the Perfection of Wisdom is unfathomable, it has no measure and is immeasurable."

Ānanda, in the past, whatever Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas have appeared, they too were all distinguished by this very Perfection of Wisdom; and yet, Ānanda, this Perfection of Wisdom is neither exhausted nor will it ever be exhausted. Ānanda, in the future, whatever Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas will appear, they too will be distinguished by this very Perfection of Wisdom; and yet, Ānanda, this Perfection of Wisdom is neither exhausted nor will it ever be exhausted. Ānanda, at present, in immeasurable and countless world systems, whatever Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas are dwelling, living, and sustained, they too are distinguished by this very Perfection of Wisdom; and yet, Ānanda, this Perfection of Wisdom is neither exhausted nor will it ever be exhausted. Ānanda, the present Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly awakened buddha is likewise distinguished by this very Perfection of Wisdom; and yet, Ānanda, this Perfection of Wisdom is neither exhausted nor will it ever be exhausted.

Why is that? Ānanda, whoever thinks of exhausting the Perfection of Wisdom thinks of exhausting space. Therefore, Ānanda, this Perfection of Wisdom is inexhaustible.

Then the venerable Subhūti thought: "This subject taught by the Tathāgata is profound. I shall ask the Tathāgata about this subject." Then the venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, does the Perfection of Wisdom not come to an end?"

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, the Perfection of Wisdom is inexhaustible. It is just so: because space is inexhaustible, all phenomena are unborn."

Subhūti asked: "Blessed One, how should a bodhisattva, a great being, bring about the Perfection of Wisdom?"

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, should bring about the Perfection of Wisdom through the inexhaustibility of form. Likewise, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, should bring about the Perfection of Wisdom through the inexhaustibility of feeling, perception, formations, and

consciousness. In this way, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, should bring about the Perfection of Wisdom.

"Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, should bring about the Perfection of Wisdom through the inexhaustibility of ignorance. Likewise, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, should bring about the Perfection of Wisdom through the inexhaustibility of formations, the inexhaustibility of consciousness, the inexhaustibility of name and form, the inexhaustibility of the six sense sources, the inexhaustibility of contact, the inexhaustibility of feeling, the inexhaustibility of craving, the inexhaustibility of grasping, the inexhaustibility of becoming, the inexhaustibility of birth, the inexhaustibility of aging and death, and the inexhaustibility of sorrow, lamentation, suffering, mental unhappiness, and distress.

"Subhūti, this is the bodhisattva's, the great being's, way of viewing dependent origination, free of the two extremes."

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who views in this way sees dependent origination as without a limit and without a middle. Subhūti, this way of viewing dependent origination is the unmixed quality of a bodhisattva, a great being, who has entered the heart of awakening. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who views dependent origination in this way will attain omniscient wisdom.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom by this accomplishing of inexhaustibility, and who views dependent origination, will not come to rest on the ground of the śrāvakas or on the ground of the pratyekabuddhas, but will come to rest in omniscience itself.

Subhūti, all those bodhisattvas, great beings, who turn back from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening do so because they do not know this attention and this skillful means, since they do not rely upon them.

If one asks how a bodhisattva, a great being, practicing the Perfection of Wisdom, should accomplish the Perfection of Wisdom by the accomplishing of inexhaustibility, and how, by accomplishing inexhaustibility, one should view dependent origination in the Perfection of Wisdom, then, Subhūti, all those bodhisattvas, great beings, who have turned back, are turning back, and will turn back from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, have turned back, are turning back, and will turn back because they do not rely upon this skillful means. Subhūti, all those bodhisattvas, great beings, who have not turned back, do not turn back, and will not turn back from unsurpassed, perfect,

complete awakening, have not turned back, do not turn back, and will not turn back because they rely upon this Perfection of Wisdom.

In this way a bodhisattva, a great being, practicing the Perfection of Wisdom, should accomplish the Perfection of Wisdom by the accomplishing of inexhaustibility. Having accomplished inexhaustibility in this way, one views dependent origination in the Perfection of Wisdom.

Furthermore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who views dependent origination in this way does not perceive any phenomenon as arising without a cause. Nor does such a one perceive any phenomenon as permanent, stable, enduring, or of a nature that is without change. Nor does such a one perceive any phenomenon as an agent or as an experienter.

Subhūti, this is how a bodhisattva, a great being, accomplishes the Perfection of Wisdom by the accomplishing of inexhaustibility, practices the Perfection of Wisdom, and views dependent origination.

Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, accomplishes the Perfection of Wisdom by the accomplishing of inexhaustibility, and views dependent origination, then, Subhūti, that bodhisattva, a great being, does not perceive form. In the same way, such a one does not perceive feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness. Nor does such a one perceive ignorance.

In the same way, he does not observe the formations as such, nor consciousness, nor name and form, nor the six sense sources, nor contact, nor feeling, nor craving, nor grasping, nor becoming, nor birth, nor aging and death. He does not observe sorrow, lamentation, suffering, mental unhappiness, or agitation. He does not observe "this is a buddha-field," and he does not observe "this is another buddha-field." And he does not observe the very phenomenon by which one would fail to observe "this one" or "another" buddha-field. Subhūti, this is the Perfection of Wisdom of bodhisattvas, great beings.

Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the Perfection of Wisdom, then Māra the Evil One is pierced by the sharp sting of grief. Subhūti, it is like a man whose mother and father have just died: he is pierced by the sharp sting of grief. In just the same way, Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the Perfection of Wisdom, then Māra the Evil One is likewise pierced by the sharp sting of grief.

Subhūti said: Blessed One, is it a single Māra the Evil One who is pierced by the sharp sting of grief? Or are many Māras the Evil One so pierced? Or is it that all the Māras the Evil One there are in the great trichiliocosm world-system are pierced by the sharp sting of grief at that time?

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti as follows: Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, abides in the abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom, then all the Māras the Evil One that exist in the great trichiliocosm world-system are pierced by the sharp sting of grief, and they take no pleasure even in their own seats.

Why is that? Because the world, with its gods, humans, and asuras, finds no opening and no foothold against a bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in the Perfection of Wisdom. It finds no chance to think, "We shall seize this one and strike him down," or, "We shall turn him back from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening."

Therefore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening should practice the Perfection of Wisdom.

Why is that? Subhūti, by practicing the Perfection of Wisdom, a bodhisattva, a great being, brings to completion the cultivation of the perfection of generosity. In the same way, he brings to completion the cultivation of the perfection of moral discipline, the perfection of patience, the perfection of diligence, and the perfection of meditative concentration. Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom brings to completion the cultivation of all six perfections. He brings to completion the cultivation of all skillful means.

A bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom in this way will recognize whatever deeds of Māra may arise, at the very moment they arise, and having recognized them, will abandon them.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, who wishes to embrace all skillful means should practice the Perfection of Wisdom and should cultivate the Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti, whenever a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the Perfection of Wisdom and brings the Perfection of Wisdom to realization, at that time, Subhūti, the bodhisattva, the great being, should think: "In the immeasurable, innumerable world systems there are buddhas, Blessed Ones, who dwell, live,

and sustain themselves; and their omniscience too has arisen from this very Perfection of Wisdom." Having thought thus, that bodhisattva, the great being, should also generate this thought: "Just as those buddhas, the Blessed Ones, have attained those qualities, so too shall I attain those same qualities."

Subhūti, in this way a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom should generate and bring about these thoughts for the span of a single day, or even for as short a time as it takes to snap the fingers.

Subhūti, compare a bodhisattva, a great being, who still apprehends objects and who gives gifts for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā, with a bodhisattva, a great being, who for a single day brings about this Perfection of Wisdom, even if only for as short a time as a snap of the fingers. The latter generates far greater merit. This bodhisattva, this great being, comes to abide on the stage of non-regression.

A bodhisattva, a great being, who for a single day, even for as short a time as a snap of the fingers, practices this Perfection of Wisdom and generates this thought, should be known as one held in mind by the Tathāgata. How much more so, then, one who follows this thought from day to day.

Subhūti, as for a bodhisattva, a great being, who is held in the Tathāgata's mind, what destiny should such a one expect? Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, held in the Tathāgata's mind should fear no destiny other than unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Such a one will not be born in a fortunate-lacking condition or in the lower realms, but should expect birth in the higher realms. There too, such a one will never be separated from the tathāgatas, and will be born in a buddha field not separated from the Tathāgata, and will bring sentient beings to maturity.

Subhūti, since there are these qualities and these benefits for a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom even for as short a time as a snap of the fingers, who brings the Perfection of Wisdom to realization and generates this thought, how much more so for one who follows this thought from day to day.

Subhūti, it is just like the bodhisattva, the great being called Gandhahastin ("Fragrant Elephant"), who is at present leading the pure life in the presence of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened Buddha Akṣobhya.

This is the twenty-eighth chapter of the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines, called "The Scattering of Flowers."

Furthermore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva, a great being, should come to know the Perfection of Wisdom in this way.

Because all phenomena are without attachment, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena are indivisible, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena are without arising, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena are equal, being without change, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena are realized through wisdom to be without self and without discriminating awareness, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena are expressed through mere names and mere conventional designations, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. And yet the conventional designation is not for anything, nor by anything; no conventional designation exists at all. Because all phenomena are without convention, inexpressible, beyond speech, and without words, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena are immeasurable, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known.

Because form is immeasurable, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. In the same way, because feeling is immeasurable, perception is immeasurable, the formations are immeasurable, and consciousness is immeasurable, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known.

Because all phenomena are without characteristics, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena are definitively distinguished, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena are utterly pure by their intrinsic nature, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena are without words, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena are without cessation, and what is to be abandoned is therefore equal, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena have attained nirvāṇa and are equal to suchness, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena do not come, do not go, are not known, are not born, and are utterly unborn, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because one does not view self and other, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena are, like the noble arhat, utterly pure by their intrinsic nature, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena have laid down the burden and do not take up a burden, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known. Because all phenomena are without object and without direction, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known.

Why is this so? Subhūti, form, by the essence of its intrinsic nature, is without object and without direction. Subhūti, in the same way, feeling, perception, the formations, and consciousness, by the essence of their intrinsic nature, are without object and without direction.

Because all phenomena bring about the complete quieting of cessation, the Perfection of Wisdom should be known.

Because there is no joy and no separation from joy, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood. Because there is no one who is attached and no one who is free from attachment, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood.

Why is this so? Subhūti, form, in its own nature, which is in accord with suchness, neither becomes attached nor becomes free from attachment. Subhūti, in the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness, in their own nature, which is in accord with suchness, neither become attached nor become free from attachment.

Because of being utterly pure by nature, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood. Because all phenomena are free from clinging, whether to attachment or to non-attachment, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood. Because of fully realizing the wisdom of the buddhas, one should understand the Perfection of Wisdom as the realization that all phenomena are awakening. Because all phenomena are emptiness, signless, and wishless, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood.

With great loving-kindness going before, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as the realization that all phenomena are like medicine. Because all phenomena abide in loving-kindness, abide in compassion, abide in joy, and abide in equanimity, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood.

Because all phenomena have become Brahmā-like, they give rise to no aversion and take up no aversion at all; therefore the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood. Because all phenomena are without wishes and without hatred, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood.

Because the ocean is limitless, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as limitless. Because space is limitless, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as limitless. Because of the variegated nature of Mount Meru, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as variegated. Because form is limitless, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as limitless. In the same way, because feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are

limitless, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as limitless.

Because the disk of the sun's rays shines without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as limitless. Because all sounds are limitless, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as limitless. Because the full accomplishment of all the qualities of the buddhas is limitless, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as limitless. Because the accumulation of merit and wisdom of all realms of sentient beings is limitless, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as limitless.

Because the earth element is limitless, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as limitless. In the same way, because the water element, the fire element, the wind element, the space element, and the element of consciousness are limitless, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as limitless.

Because the accumulation of virtuous and non-virtuous phenomena is immeasurable, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as immeasurable. Because the accumulation of all phenomena is immeasurable, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as immeasurable. Because of attaining the limitless meditative absorptions of all phenomena, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as limitless. Because all the qualities of the buddhas are limitless, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as limitless. Because all phenomena are limitless, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as limitless.

Because emptiness is without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as without limit. Because mind and mental factors are without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as without limit. Because the activity of mind is without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as without limit. Because virtuous and non-virtuous phenomena are immeasurable, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as immeasurable. Because it sounds the lion's roar, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as such. Because all phenomena are free of disturbance, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as free of disturbance.

Why is this so? Subhūti, form is like the ocean. In the same way, Subhūti, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like the ocean.

Form is like space. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like space.

Form is like the many-colored Mount Meru. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like the many-colored Mount Meru.

Form is like the limitless. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like the limitless.

Form is like the rising of the rays of light from the disk of the sun. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like the rising of the rays of light from the disk of the sun.

Form is like the limitlessness of all sounds. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like the limitlessness of all sounds.

Form is like the limitless accomplishment of all the qualities of the buddhas. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like the limitless accomplishment of all the qualities of the buddhas.

Form is like the limitless accumulation of merit and wisdom of all the realms of sentient beings. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like the limitless accumulation of merit and wisdom of all the realms of sentient beings.

Form is like the earth. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like the earth.

Form is like water. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like water.

Form is like fire. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like fire.

Form is like wind. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like wind.

Form is like space. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like space.

Form is like consciousness. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are like consciousness.

Form is free of the accumulation of virtuous and non-virtuous phenomena. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are free of the accumulation of virtuous and non-virtuous phenomena.

Form is free of the accumulation of all phenomena.

In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are free of the accumulation of all phenomena. Form is equal to the boundless absorption of all phenomena. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are equal to the boundless absorption of all phenomena. Form is free, and the essential nature of form and the suchness of form are the qualities of a buddha. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are free, and the essential nature of consciousness and the suchness of consciousness are the qualities of a buddha. Form is the boundless nature of all phenomena. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are the boundless nature of all phenomena. Form is the boundless nature of emptiness. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are the boundless nature of emptiness. Form is without limit in mind and mental factors. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are without limit in mind and mental factors. Form arises from the activity of mind. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness arise from the activity of mind. Form extends to the virtuous, the non-virtuous, and the unapprehendable. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness extend to the virtuous, the non-virtuous, and the unapprehendable. Form is equal to the lion's roar. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are equal to the lion's roar. Form is without agitation. In the same way, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are without agitation.

Subhūti, in this way a bodhisattva, a great being, should come to know the Perfection of Wisdom.

Subhūti, when a bodhisattva, a great being, comes to know the Perfection of Wisdom in this way, and examines it, enters into it, realizes it, reflects on it, measures it, and contemplates it closely; and when he cultivates it with an attitude that has entirely abandoned deceit and dissimulation, an attitude that has entirely abandoned laziness, an attitude that has entirely abandoned conceit, an attitude that has abandoned self-praise, an attitude that has abandoned disparaging others, an attitude that has abandoned the perception of a self, an attitude that has abandoned the perception of a sentient being, an attitude that has abandoned gain, honor, and fame, an attitude that has abandoned the five obscurations, an attitude that has abandoned envy and miserliness, and an attitude that has abandoned all beings, then for him it will

not be difficult to attain the perfection of all good qualities, the unsurpassed buddha field, and the perfection of the qualities of a buddha.

This is the twenty-ninth chapter, called "Knowing," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines, the twenty-third volume.

Subhūti, furthermore, just as the bodhisattva, a great being, Ever-Weeping, now seeks the Perfection of Wisdom, so should it be sought, just as he sought it when he practiced the holy life in the presence of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha, who proclaimed the inexhaustible sound of the Dharma.

When the Blessed One had said this,

The venerable Subhūti then said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, how did the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, search for that Perfection of Wisdom while he was seeking it?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Subhūti: "Subhūti, when the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, was seeking the Perfection of Wisdom, he did not exert himself for the sake of his body, he did not cling to his life, and he did not rest in gain, honor, or fame. He searched in this way.

"As he went searching for the Perfection of Wisdom, he came to a wilderness, and there a voice sounded from the sky: 'Son of good family, go to the east, and you will hear the Perfection of Wisdom. As you go, do not give rise to any thought of bodily fatigue. Do not give rise to any thought of sleep or drowsiness. Do not give rise to any thought of food, or of drink. Do not give rise to any thought of night, or of day. Do not give rise to any thought of cold, or of heat. Go in this way. Do not let your mind long for anything, inner or outer. Son of good family, go without looking to the left. Go without looking to the right, to the east, to the south, to the west, to the north, above, or below, and without looking to the intermediate directions either.

"Son of good family, go in such a way that you do not stir from yourself, nor from the view of the perishable collection. Go in such a way that you do not stir from form, nor from feeling, perception, and formations, nor from consciousness. Whoever stirs from these is utterly lost. Lost from what? Lost from the qualities of a buddha. One who is lost from the qualities of a buddha moves in saṃsāra. One who moves in saṃsāra does not move in the

Perfection of Wisdom, and so does not attain the Perfection of Wisdom.' This was the sound he heard."

When the voice had spoken in this way, the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, replied to it, "So I shall do. Why? Because I wish to bring light to all sentient beings, and I wish to accomplish all the qualities of a buddha."

When he had said this, the voice said to the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, "Excellent, excellent, son of good family, Sadāprarudita!"

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, heard the voice again: "Son of good family, you should generate devotion toward all phenomena as empty, signless, and wishless, and you should search for the Perfection of Wisdom. You should abandon signs, abandon entities, and abandon the view of sentient beings. Son of good family, you should abandon bad companions. As for spiritual friends who teach that all phenomena are empty, signless, wishless, unarisen, unborn, unceasing, and without entity, you should rely on them, honor them, and serve them with respect. Son of good family, if you practice in this way, before long you will hear the Perfection of Wisdom, whether it is set down in a book or present in the body of a monk who is a Dharma teacher. Son of good family, toward the one from whom you hear this Perfection of Wisdom, you should generate the perception of him as your teacher, and you should remember the kindness done to you and feel gratitude for it."

"From whomever he heard this Perfection of Wisdom, that person is my spiritual friend. Because I have heard it, I will swiftly become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. I will attend upon the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, and I will be born in buddha-fields, never separated from the Tathāgatas. I will abandon the inopportune states, and I will obtain the conduct of the fully endowed leisure." Son of good family, you should fully understand these benefits, and you should cultivate the perception that the monk who teaches the Dharma is the Teacher.

Son of good family, you should not follow after the monk who teaches the Dharma with a mind that is bound up with worldly gain and honor. You should follow after him out of a desire for the Dharma and with reverence for the Dharma.

You should also understand the deeds of Māra. Son of good family, Māra the Evil One strives to lead bodhisattvas, great beings, to attend upon, to enjoy,

and to indulge in forms, sounds, smells, tastes, and touches. There are also some who are overpowered by that teacher of the Dharma and who, through skillful means, keep company with such things and attend upon them. Son of good family, you should not give rise to lack of faith in that monk who teaches the Dharma. Rather, you should give rise to this thought: "I do not know that skillful means. But this one knows skillful means well. By way of a manner of taming beings, and in order to take hold of the roots of virtue of beings, he relies upon these things, keeps company with them, and attends upon them. Bodhisattvas, great beings, have no attachment or obstruction toward anything."

At that very moment, son of good family, you yourself should examine individually the true nature of phenomena. Son of good family, what is the true nature of phenomena? It is this: no phenomenon is afflicted, and none is purified. Why is that? All phenomena are empty of intrinsic nature. All phenomena have no sentient being, no life, no living creature, no person, no individual. They are like an illusion, like a dream, like an echo, like a mirage. Son of good family, if you thus contemplate the true nature of all phenomena and follow after the teacher of the Dharma, before long you will surely come forth into the Perfection of Wisdom.

Son of good family, be mindful also of the deeds of Māra. Son of good family, suppose that teachers of the Dharma show contempt for a son of good family who is seeking the Perfection of Wisdom, and do not give him their attention. Son of good family, you should not turn back because of that. Otherwise, you should follow after the monk who teaches the Dharma with a desire for the Dharma, with reverence for the Dharma, and without becoming discouraged. This too I have heard.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita ("Ever-Weeping"), took up this instruction from that voice and went to the east, to where he was bound. Before he had gone far, it occurred to him: "I did not ask the voice how far I should go." Thinking this, he wept and wailed in that very direction, grieving and lamenting as he sat there. Then it occurred to him: "In this very place I will pass the day and the night."

He resolved to spend two, three, four, five, or six days and nights, even seven days and nights, in that very place, and he thought: "Until I have heard the Perfection of Wisdom, I will not give any thought to bodily weariness. I will not give any thought to drowsiness and sleep. I will not give any thought to eating.

I will not give any thought to drinking. I will not give any thought to night. I will not give any thought to day. I will not give any thought to cold. I will not give any thought to heat."

Subhūti, it is like this. Suppose the only son of some man were to die. That man would be filled with great suffering and distress, and apart from thinking of his grief for his only son, no other thought would arise in him. In just the same way, Subhūti, even as that bodhisattva, a great being, wept continually, no other thought arose in him except the thought, "When shall I hear the Perfection of Wisdom?"

Then, Subhūti, as that bodhisattva, a great being, sat weeping continually and grieving in this way, the form of a Tathāgata appeared before him and said, "Excellent!" And he said to him: "Son of good family, it is excellent, truly excellent, that you speak such words. Just as you now search, son of good family, so too the Tathāgatas of the past, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, searched for the Perfection of Wisdom when they were practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva. Therefore, son of good family, with this very diligence, this very joy, this very earnest striving, and this very longing, follow after it and go to the east. Son of good family, five hundred leagues from here there is a city called Fragrant, a city of the nature of the seven precious substances. It is encircled by seven tiers of walls, and surrounded by seven tiers of moats and seven rows of tāla trees. It measures twelve leagues in length and twelve leagues in breadth. It is prosperous and flourishing, comfortable, with good harvests, and filled with many people. Its rows of market halls are laid out in the middle as though painted in many colors; they are beautiful to look upon, delightful, level, and uniform. It is well kept by five hundred who dwell there free of envy, in places for people, for carriages, and for those who travel on foot. Around the city, for the sake of its low-lying ground, there is a ring of the nature of the seven precious substances. The pinnacles of those walls, of the nature of the seven precious substances, are made of gold from the Jambu River, lofty and well proportioned. From the tip of every pinnacle there grows a tree of the nature of the seven precious substances, bearing fruit of various shining jewels. From all the trees growing from the pinnacles, cords of the nature of jewels extend, so that the city is joined with all the trees of the second pinnacles. It is covered with nets of golden bells and small jingle-bells. When the wind strikes those nets of bells and jingle-bells, soft, melodious, and pleasing sounds arise. Just as when a skilled musician plays an ensemble of the five kinds of instruments, soft,

melodious, and pleasing sounds arise, so too, when the wind strikes those nets of bells and jingle-bells, soft, melodious, and pleasing sounds arise, and by that sound those beings are delighted and live in joy."

All around that city there were moats, filled with water flowing along in harmony with its course. The water was neither too cold nor too warm, but perfectly full. On those very waters there were boats made of the seven precious substances, brilliant and lovely to behold, brought about by the ripening of the former karma of those beings. Beings would board them and delight in play and joy. All those waters were covered with blue lotuses (utpala), night lotuses (kumuda), and white lotuses, and also with other flowers of great and excellent kinds, endowed with a fine fragrance. Among all the kinds of flowers found in the world system of the great trichiliocosm, there was none that was not there.

Within that city there were five hundred pleasure groves, every one of them made of the seven precious substances, brilliant and exceedingly lovely to behold. In each of those pleasure groves there were five hundred ponds, each measuring a full cry's distance across on every side. In all those ponds there grew blue lotuses, night lotuses, and white lotuses, made of the seven precious substances, brilliant and lovely to behold, and these covered the water. All those fine blue lotuses, night lotuses, and white lotuses were as wide across the water as the wheel of a chariot. There were fragrant blue ones, blue in color, displaying blue and appearing blue; yellow ones, yellow in color, displaying yellow and appearing yellow; red ones, red in color, displaying red and appearing red; and white ones, white in color, displaying white and appearing white. In all those ponds there were geese, ducks, cranes, kāraṇḍavas, and sārāsas, calling out in their voices.

All those pleasure groves were without any sense of "mine" and without any possessiveness. For over a long time those beings had practiced the Perfection of Wisdom, had revered the way of the buddhas, and had rightly realized what they had heard and reflected on in accord with it. These groves were brought about by the ripening of the former karma of those very beings who had long been devoted to the profound Dharma.

Son of good family, at the crossroads in the middle of that city, Fragrant, there was a mansion belonging to the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata. It was made of the seven precious substances, measured a yojana all around, and was brilliant and lovely to behold. It was encircled by seven tiers of

parapets and seven rows of palm trees. In that mansion, for the use, the near use, and the full enjoyment of the mansion, there were four pleasure groves, called Ever Joyful, Sorrowless, Free from Sorrow, and Of Many Flowers. In each of those groves there were eight ponds, named Excellent, Supreme Excellence, Joy, Supreme Joy, Bliss, Supreme Bliss, Certainty, and Unfalling. Moreover, one side of those ponds was of gold, a second side of silver, a third side of beryl, and a fourth side of crystal. The ground beneath was of carketana gems, strewn with golden sand. Each of those ponds had eight flights of steps, with treads adorned with precious substances of various kinds, each different from the others.

From among all those steps, golden trees of the Jambu River gold also grew. The waters of all those pools were covered with many kinds of flowers, blue lotuses, night lotuses, and white lotuses, and swans, cranes, kāraṇḍavas, and sarasas called out there. All around those pools, flowering trees of many different kinds grew, and as the wind stirred those flowering trees and the blossoms fell into the pools, the waters of all those pools were fragrant with the scent of sandalwood, and were possessed of color, scent, flavor, and touch.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, together with his retinue and with sixty-eight thousand women, delighted himself in the five qualities of desire, in full command of them, in play and in joy. And all the other beings, men and women, who lived in that city likewise delighted themselves constantly in the gardens and pools, in full command of the five qualities of desire, in play and in joy.

Yet at the same time, the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, while playing and rejoicing with his retinue, taught the Perfection of Wisdom there at the three times of day. The beings who lived in the city of Gandhavatī would gather at the crossroads in the middle of the city, where a seat was set up for the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata. Its legs were of gold, of silver, of beryl, and of crystal. It was spread with cotton, covered with a fine woven cloth, and padded on top, with a Kāśī cloth laid over it, and a canopy was arranged above it at the distance of half a bowshot. Overhead, in the sky, an awning was stretched, adorned with pearls, and it seemed to the onlookers that it was truly well fixed in place. Through the ripening of their many kinds of good fortune, it stood firmly in place, held there together. All around that place, flowers of the five colors were scattered, strewn, and spread everywhere, and in whatever way one might wish, through pure aspiration for

the Dharma and through the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata's reverence for the Dharma, that place was also thoroughly perfumed with many kinds of fragrances and incense.

There the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, sat and taught the Perfection of Wisdom. Son of good family, those beings thus revere the Dharma, rely on the teachings, and possess faith. Having generated faith and serene confidence, they listen to the Perfection of Wisdom in the presence of the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata. Among the gods and humans gathered there to listen, many hundreds of living beings, many thousands of living beings, many hundreds of thousands of living beings, some receive the transmission, some recite it by heart, some write it down, and some realize it through proper attention. All those beings are of a nature never to fall into error, and are irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Son of good family, go to the presence of that bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, and you will hear the Perfection of Wisdom from him. Son of good family, for a long time he has been your spiritual friend, one who has shown you unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, urged you to take hold of it, praised it, and made you rejoice in it. Son of good family, just as you have sought the Perfection of Wisdom in the past and now, so seek it thoroughly. Son of good family, by generating attention day and night without interruption, go, and

"You will hear the Perfection of Wisdom before long," he said. Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, hearing this, was delighted and elated, and overflowing with joy, gladness, and happiness. Just as a man struck by a poisoned arrow gives rise to no other thought except, "When shall I find a physician who can draw out this barb, who can free me from this suffering and release me from this pain?" so too the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, though he had been weeping, now gave attention to nothing at all except the thought, "Son of good family, if I hear that Perfection of Wisdom, and by hearing that Dharma I come to abandon my fixation on objects and my attention to them, then I will have truly seen it."

Then, as the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, remained in that very place, he heard the noble Dharma-teaching of the bodhisattva, the great being, explaining the Perfection of Wisdom. And having heard it, he generated the perception of non-abiding in all phenomena, and the following doors of meditative absorption became manifest to him: the meditative absorption

called Seeing the Essential Nature of All Phenomena; the meditative absorption called Non-Apprehension of the Essential Nature of All Phenomena; the meditative absorption called Emerging Through Knowing the Essential Nature of All Phenomena; the meditative absorption called Non-Difference of All Phenomena; the meditative absorption called Seeing All Phenomena as Unchanging; the meditative absorption called Illuminating All Phenomena; the meditative absorption called Freedom from Darkness in All Phenomena; the meditative absorption called Dispelling the Ignorance of All Phenomena; the meditative absorption called Thorough Clearing Away of All Phenomena; the meditative absorption called Non-Apprehension of All Phenomena; the meditative absorption called Scattering Flowers; the meditative absorption called Not Establishing Any Entity of Self in All Phenomena; the meditative absorption called Utterly Abandoning Illusion; the meditative absorption called Accomplishing the Appearance of the Disk of a Mirror; the meditative absorption called Accomplishing the Speech of All Beings; the meditative absorption called Free of Dust; the meditative absorption called Delighting All Beings; the meditative absorption called Following Skill in the Speech of All Beings; the meditative absorption called Accomplishing Various Sounds, Words, and Letters; the meditative absorption called Free of Arrogance; the meditative absorption called Without Conventional Expression by Nature; the meditative absorption called Attaining Liberation Without Obstruction; the meditative absorption called Freedom from Dust; the meditative absorption called Names, Etymologies, and Letters; the meditative absorption called Viewing All Phenomena; the meditative absorption called Free of Objects in All Phenomena; the meditative absorption called the Unobstructed Limit of All Phenomena; the meditative absorption called Equal to Space; the meditative absorption called Vajra-Like; the meditative absorption called Clearing Away the Dust of Form; the meditative absorption called Perfect Excellence; the meditative absorption called Attaining Victory; the meditative absorption called the Eye of Non-Regression; the meditative absorption called Certainty in the Dharmadhātu; the meditative absorption called Emerging from the Dharmadhātu; and the meditative absorption called Giving Relief.

the absorption called Proclaiming the Lion's Roar, the absorption called Overpowering All Beings, the absorption called Free from Dust, the absorption called Without Any Affliction, the absorption called Arrayed with Lotuses, the absorption called Cutting Through Stagnation, the absorption called Following All Essences, the absorption called Rising Above All Phenomena, the

absorption called Having Attained the Superknowledges, the Powers, and the Fearlessnesses, the absorption called Penetrating All Phenomena, the absorption called the Seal of the Wealth of All Phenomena, the absorption called the Ocean of the Wealth of All Phenomena, the absorption called Seeing All Phenomena Without Distinction, the absorption called Completely Abandoning All Dense Obscurations of View, the absorption called Free from Darkness, the absorption called All Phenomena Free from Signs, the absorption called Liberated from All Clinging, the absorption called Free from All Laziness, the absorption called Illuminating the Profound Dharma, the absorption called Like Mount Meru, the absorption called Unassailable, the absorption called Dispelling the Circle of Māra, the absorption called Unattached to the Three Worlds, the absorption called Accomplishing Rays of Light, the absorption called Seeing the Tathāgatas, and the absorption called Seeing All the Tathāgatas.

Abiding in these absorptions, you will see, in the world systems of the ten directions, immeasurable and innumerable buddhas, blessed ones, teaching this very Perfection of Wisdom to bodhisattvas, great beings. Those Tathāgatas will say "Excellent!" and will console you, speaking these words: "Child of noble family, when I too, in former times, was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, I sought this very Perfection of Wisdom just so. And in seeking it, I attained absorptions exactly like those you have attained. Having attained these absorptions, I came to realize and fully comprehend the Perfection of Wisdom, and I came to abide in the qualities of a buddha from which there is no turning back.

When I look at the essential nature and intrinsic nature of these absorptions, I do not truly perceive any phenomenon that is to be entered into in equipoise, or that is to be risen from, or that is to be practiced for awakening, or that is to be brought to complete manifest awakening as unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Child of noble family, this is the Perfection of Wisdom: abiding in a state where one does nothing with any phenomenon, either with conceit or without conceit, I attained a body such as this, of golden hue. I attained the thirty-two marks of a great being, the eighty excellent minor marks, the radiance of a fathom's span, the wisdom of a buddha, the inconceivable and unsurpassed discernment of a buddha, the unsurpassed absorption of a buddha, and the perfection of all the qualities of the buddhas' Dharma. As for that perfection of qualities, if even the Tathāgatas are unable to fix its measure or to show its

limit, what need is there to speak of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas?"

Son of a good family, therefore you should give rise to the highest reverence for these very teachings, with earnest seeking and longing. Son of a good family, for one who seeks and longs, it is not difficult to find unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Son of a good family, you should give rise to deep reverence for your spiritual friend. You should hold him dear, and you should be devoted to him with perfect faith. A bodhisattva, a great being, who is embraced by a spiritual friend will swiftly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. So the Tathāgatas said.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, weeping, said to those Tathāgatas, "Who, then, is my spiritual friend?"

They said to him, "Son of a good family, for a long time the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, has brought you to maturity for unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and has embraced you. He has trained you in the Perfection of Wisdom, in skillful means, and in the qualities of a buddha. Son of a good family, he is the spiritual friend who holds you. Be one who knows what has been done for you and feels gratitude for it. Take up what he instructs you, and do just as he has done.

Son of a good family, suppose that for one eon, or two eons, or three eons, or a hundred eons, or a thousand eons, or a hundred thousand eons, or even longer, you were to carry the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, on your head like a crown, and were to wait upon him with every comfort, and were to offer him all the forms, sounds, smells, tastes, and tangible things that exist in the great trichiliocosm world-system. Even so, son of a good family, you would not have repaid what he has done for you. Why is that? Son of a good family, through his power you have gained such meditative absorptions as these; through him you have heard the Perfection of Wisdom and skillful means, and have come to attain the Perfection of Wisdom."

So they spoke. Then those Tathāgatas, having made the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, sigh in longing, vanished from sight.

The son of a good family then arose from those meditative absorptions, and having arisen, he thought, "From where did those Tathāgatas come, and to where did those Tathāgatas go?" Not having seen those Tathāgatas, he was deeply distressed and unhappy.

Then he thought again, "The noble bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, has attained dhāraṇī. He possesses the five superknowledges. He has done his work in the presence of the buddhas of the past. He is my spiritual friend, who truly holds me, and for a long time he has worked for my benefit. I shall go into the presence of the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, and when I have drawn near I shall ask him this very matter: from where did those Tathāgatas come, and to where did those Tathāgatas go?"

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, established in himself joy, faith, devotion, and reverence toward the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata. Having done so, he thought, "With what kind of honoring offering should I go into the presence of the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata? I am poor. What clothing or...

"Of precious substances, gold, jewels, pearls, beryl, conch, crystal, coral, silver, flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, robes, parasols, banners, bells, or pennants, I have nothing at all of the kind. If I were to go into the presence of the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, in this way, I would be acting improperly, and no gladness or delight would arise in me." So he thought.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, possessed of such qualities, and with reverence and attentive regard for his teacher, went on, and in due course he arrived at another city. Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, went to the middle of that city, and having reached its center he thought, "I shall sell my own body, and with the price I shall make an honoring offering to the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata. For a long time my body has been sold in vain, wasted, exhausted, and spent. Through immeasurable cycles of existence, again and again, for the sake of desires and the causes of desire, I have undergone immeasurable sufferings of the hells. But it was never for the sake of such a Dharma, nor for the sake of honoring such a great being."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, sat down in the middle of the marketplace of the city, and proclaimed aloud and called out in a loud voice, "Who wants a man? Who wants a man? Who wishes to buy a man?"

Then Māra the Evil One thought, "This bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, desiring the Dharma, has sold himself in order to make an honoring offering to the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata. He will question him about the Perfection of Wisdom and about skill in means, asking

how a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the Perfection of Wisdom will quickly become fully perfected in unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Through this he will gain an ocean of learning. He will become unconquerable by Māra and by the gods of Māra's retinue. He will attain the perfection of all good qualities. There he will accomplish the benefit of many beings. And when he has fully and completely awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, he and others besides will pass beyond my domain. I shall therefore create an obstacle for him." So he thought.

Then Māra the Evil One so thoroughly veiled the minds of those brahmins and householders that they could not hear the voice of the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, saying, "Who wants a man? Who wants a man? Who wishes to buy a man?"

Then, when the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, could find no one to buy him, he went off to one side and wept, with tears streaming down, and said, "I wished to sell my body so as to make an honoring offering to the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, yet I cannot even find a buyer for my body. Alas, I have gained a wretched lot!"

Then Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), thought, "Is this bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, perfect in his superior intention of wholly giving up his own body for the sake of the Dharma, or is he not? I shall test this bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita." So he thought.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, magically transformed himself into the form of a young brahmin, and came to the place where the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, was.

He said to the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, "Son of good family, why do you stand here dejected, tormented, and in tears?"

Sadāprarudita replied, "Young brahmin, I wish to sell my body, but I cannot find anyone to buy it."

Śakra, in the form of the young brahmin, said, "Son of good family, why do you wish to sell yourself?"

Sadāprarudita answered him, "Young brahmin, I have sold myself because I long for the Dharma. I wish to make offerings to the Dharma, and I also wish to honor and revere the noble bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata. But I could find no one to buy my body, and so I thought: Alas, my merit is small. I have offered my body for sale in this way, thinking to make offerings to the

Perfection of Wisdom and to honor the noble bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, and yet I cannot even find a buyer for my body."

Then the young brahmin said to the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, "Son of good family, I have no use for a man. But I am preparing a sacrificial offering, and for it I need a human heart, blood, bones, and marrow. If you wish, sell them to me for a price."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, thought: "That I have found this young brahmin who will buy my heart, blood, bones, and marrow is the finest of all finds; I have found it well. For my body will bring to fulfillment the Perfection of Wisdom, skillful means, and the qualities of the buddhas." Thinking this, he became glad in mind, happy in mind, and filled with delight. He said to the young brahmin, "Young brahmin, from this body of mine I will give you whatever you wish."

The brahmin said to him, "Son of good family, I will give you whatever price you wish."

Sadāprarudita said to him, "Young brahmin, give me whatever you have in mind to give."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, took a sharp knife and pierced his right arm, so that the blood flowed out. He stripped the flesh from his right thigh and went to the foot of a wall in order to break the bone.

Now a merchant's daughter was sitting on the roof of her house. She saw the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, with much blood flowing, his thigh stripped of flesh, going to the foot of the wall to break the bone. She thought: "Why is this son of good family inflicting such suffering on himself? Let me go to him and ask."

So the merchant's daughter went to where the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, was. She said to him, "Son of good family, why do you inflict such suffering on yourself? What will you do with this blood, these bones, this marrow?"

Sadāprarudita said to her, "Young woman, I have sold my body to this young brahmin so that I may make offerings to the Perfection of Wisdom and honor the noble bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata."

Then the merchant's daughter said to the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, "Son of good family, you have sold even your heart, blood, bones, and marrow in this way, wishing to honor that person. What kind of

merit, or what special excellence, will you gain from this?"

He said to the young woman, "Young woman, that son of good family is the one from whom I will learn the Perfection of Wisdom, and

She will teach skillful means, and if I train in them, I shall fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and become a support for all sentient beings. I shall also obtain a body of golden hue, the thirty-two marks of a great being and the eighty excellent minor marks, a halo of light one fathom wide, and boundless rays of light. I shall fully obtain great loving-kindness, great compassion, great joy, and great equanimity, the four fearlessnesses, the four kinds of exact discernment, and the eighteen distinctive qualities of a buddha. I shall obtain the five higher cognitions, inconceivable; pure moral discipline, inconceivable; pure meditative absorption, inconceivable; and pure wisdom, inconceivable. I shall fully obtain the ten powers of a Tathāgata, and I shall awaken fully to the unsurpassed wisdom of a buddha, by which I shall also obtain the unsurpassed precious Dharma, which is shared out to all sentient beings. So she said.

Then the merchant's daughter said to the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita: Son of good family, it is marvelous that you have proclaimed these vast and surpassing teachings in this way. Son of good family, if for the sake of even a single such teaching one would give up one's body for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā, how much more would one do so for many! Since you have proclaimed these Dharma teachings, so vast and surpassing, I too wish for them and I am willing to bear what is needed. That being so, son of good family, whatever you need to honor the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, whether gold, jewels, pearls, beryl, silver, musāragalva, lohitaḥ, crystal, flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, cloth, parasols, banners, bells, flags, or lamps, I shall give it to you, so do not cause yourself such suffering. I shall go with you to where the noble bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, dwells, and together with you I shall generate roots of virtue in order to obtain such teachings.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), made the appearance of the young brahmin vanish, and in his own form sat before the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, and said: Son of good family, your steadfastness in such a resolve, and your seeking of such a Dharma, are excellent, excellent! In the past too, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas, when they were practicing the conduct of bodhisattvas, inquired about the Perfection of

Wisdom and skillful means, and having thoroughly obtained the precious Dharma, they awakened fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Son of good family, I have no need of your heart, blood, bones, or legs. I have come here to rouse you. Son of good family, ask for a boon. What boon shall I give you? So he said.

Sadāprarudita answered him: Śakra, grant me the unsurpassed qualities of a buddha. Śakra said: Son of good family, this is not within my power. This is the domain of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Ask for some other boon. Sadāprarudita said:

In this matter of completing my body, Śakra, lord of the gods, do not let your effort be slight. Lord of the gods, I myself will bless this body of mine with an act of truth. Lord of the gods, by that truth whereby the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas have prophesied that I will not turn back from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and know that my higher resolve is unwavering, by that truth and by those words of truth, may my body become just as it was before.

Then, in an instant, in a moment, in the space of a breath, through the power of the buddhas and through the perfect purity of his higher resolve, the body of the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, stood just as it had been before, free of illness and free of harm.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, and Māra the Evil One as well, lost their boldness. No boldness arose in them to answer the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, and they vanished on the spot.

Then the merchant's daughter said this to the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita: Noble son, come here. I will go to where my house is. I will take wealth from my parents, and I will give it to you, in order that I may seek the Dharma, that offerings may be made to the very Perfection of Wisdom, and that honor and reverence may be shown to the noble bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, went together with that merchant's daughter to where her own house stood, and having arrived, he sat down by the door.

Then the merchant's daughter went into her own house and said this to her parents: Father, mother, please give me gold, silver, jewels, gems, garments, flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, unguents, powders, robes, parasols,

banners, bells, flags, and various musical instruments. And I ask that you also share with me these five hundred maidservants whom you gave me. I will go, together with the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, to make offerings in the presence of the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata. He will teach us the Dharma, and through him I too will obtain the qualities of the buddhas.

Then the girl's parents said this to her: Daughter, who is this one called the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, and where is he now? The girl said: Noble one, he is now sitting by the door of the cow pen. Noble one, with a higher resolve he has entered fully upon the path to fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Wishing to free all sentient beings from the immeasurable sufferings of saṃsāra, he sold himself to seek the Dharma, wishing to make offerings to the Perfection of Wisdom and also to honor and revere the noble bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata. But he could not find anyone to buy his body, and because he found no one, he was in distress and unhappy, his mind joyless, and he stood there shedding tears.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, having transformed himself into the form of a young brahmin, said: Noble son, why are you distressed and unhappy, your mind joyless, shedding tears? He replied to him: I wish to sell myself, but I have not found anyone to buy me. Śakra, in the form of the young brahmin, said:

"Son of good family, why do you wish to sell your body?" I asked. Ever-Weeping replied, "I wish to make offerings to the Perfection of Wisdom, and to show reverence to the noble bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata. For my buddha-qualities depend on him, since I desire the Dharma."

Then Śakra, in the form of the brahmin youth, said, "Son of good family, I do not want you. But I am performing a sacrifice, and for it I need a human heart, blood, bone, and marrow."

Without a moment's hesitation that son of good family said, "I give them." Taking a sharp blade, he pierced his own arm and let the blood flow. He cut the flesh from his thigh and went to the foot of the wall to break the bone. He sat down to one side, thinking, "I will give the bone and the marrow."

I saw that son of good family drawing blood while I was on the roof of my house, and I thought, "Why is this man inflicting such torments on himself?" I went to where he was and said, "Son of good family, what will you do with this

blood that you are drawing from your own body?"

He told me, "I am giving the blood, heart, bone, and marrow to this young brahmin. Why? Because I am poor, and I have no other wealth at all." I said to him, "What is wealth to you? What would you do with it?" He answered me, "I wish to make offerings to the Perfection of Wisdom, because I desire the Dharma, and to show reverence to the noble bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata."

I then said to him, "Son of good family, what kind of virtue or special benefit will come to you from that?" He answered me, "He will speak of the inconceivable qualities of the buddhas, and he will teach the immeasurable qualities of the buddhas. Such qualities of the buddhas will arise from him."

When I heard of those inconceivable qualities of the buddhas, great joy and delight arose in me, and I thought, "This son of good family, out of his desire for the Dharma, takes no thought even of his own body. He is carrying out a difficult practice. How marvelous! If he gives up even his own body for the sake of the Dharma, then why should we, who have many vast possessions, not make offerings to the Dharma? Why should we not make aspirations toward such things?"

So I said to that son of good family, "Son of good family, do not torment yourself like this, in a way that takes your life. I will take much wealth from my parents for the reverence and honor to be shown to the noble bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, and I will go with you to where the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, is. I too will make offerings to him. And as for what you have declared, namely those supreme buddha-qualities, I too will bring such qualities to completion."

Then, speaking to her parents, the young woman said, "Father and mother, please grant me that great store of wealth. I too will go with that son of good family and make offerings to the noble bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata."

Here ends the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

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Then the girl's father and mother said to her: "Noble child, if the hardships you have described are as you say, then those teachings are certainly beyond all conception, more excellent than anything in the whole world, and a source of happiness for all sentient beings. How wonderful! Noble child, if you take such

delight in these hardships, we give you our permission. Daughter, let us too go with you to see the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, to pay homage to him, to attend and honor him, and to make offerings to him. Open the way for us to go."

Then the merchant's daughter, having prepared herself to make offerings to the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, and to honor him, informed her parents and said: "Father and mother, do just as you have said. I will place no obstacle in the way of any virtuous course."

So the merchant's daughter made ready to make offerings to the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, and to pay him honor. She adorned five hundred chariots, and the five hundred girls also adorned themselves. When they were adorned, they took flowers of many different colors and garments of many colors. They took incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, monastic robes, parasols, banners, bells, and pennants. They took many kinds of precious substances, and flowers fashioned of many kinds of precious substances. Her father and mother also took abundant food, both hard and soft, and, boarding a single chariot together with the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, they set out. The five hundred girls, seated in the five hundred chariots, surrounded them and went before them, and with her parents and a great retinue they went off toward the east, traveling on by stages.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, saw from far away the city of Gandhavatī, resplendent with the seven precious substances and lovely to behold. It was encircled by seven tiers of ramparts made of the seven precious substances, with seven stairways down to the moats, and was surrounded by seven moats and seven rows of tāla trees. In its breadth it measured twelve leagues in length and twelve leagues in width. It was prosperous, flourishing, and happy, with good harvests, and full of people and crowds. Its rows of market stalls were as if painted in many designs, lovely and exceedingly beautiful, level and even. Its paths for people, for carriages, and for those traveling on foot were well maintained by five hundred keepers, who lived free of jealousy.

At the crossroads in the middle of that city, he saw the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, seated on the Dharma throne, teaching the Dharma, surrounded and attended by many hundreds, many thousands, and many hundreds of thousands of followers. The moment he saw him, he attained a

bliss like that of a monk who has entered the first meditative concentration with one-pointed attention. Seeing him, he thought: "Though I am sitting in this chariot, to go into the presence of the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, in this way would not be fitting for me." And so he got down from the chariot.

Then, when she had descended from that carriage, the merchant's daughter and those five hundred young women descended from their carriages together with her. Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, surrounded by the five hundred young women led by the merchant's daughter, with them walking before him and bearing immeasurable arrays of offerings, went to where the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, was.

At that moment the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, had had a house of tiered storeys built for the Perfection of Wisdom. It was made of the seven precious substances, adorned with red sandalwood, and covered with a net of pearls. At its four corners precious jewels were set, and these served as lamps. Four incense burners made of silver were hung in the four directions, and in order to make offerings to the Perfection of Wisdom, pure black aloeswood was burned in them. In the middle of that tiered house four thrones made of the seven precious substances were set up, and on them were placed four precious caskets. Inside them was placed the Perfection of Wisdom, written in molten lapis lazuli on gold leaves, and the tiered house was adorned with many kinds of silk streamers of different sorts hanging down.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, together with the five hundred young women led by the merchant's daughter, saw that tiered house adorned with immeasurable arrays of offerings. There he also saw many thousands of gods. He saw Śakra, lord of the gods, scattering, scattering forth, and scattering abundantly over that tiered house divine mandārava flowers, divine sandalwood powder, divine gold powder, and divine silver powder. He also heard divine cymbals sounding.

Having seen and heard this, the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, said to Śakra, lord of the gods: Lord of the gods, why do you, together with many thousands of gods, scatter, scatter forth, and scatter abundantly over this precious tiered house divine mandārava flowers, divine sandalwood powder, divine gold powder, and divine silver powder? And why do these gods strike these divine cymbals in the sky?

When he had spoken thus, Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita: Son of good family, this Perfection of Wisdom is the mother of the bodhisattvas, the great beings, and the one who leads them forth. By training in her, the bodhisattvas, the great beings, follow after the perfection of all qualities, and they quickly attain all the qualities of a buddha and omniscience itself. Do you not know this?

When he had spoken thus, the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, said to Śakra, lord of the gods: Kauśika, where does the Perfection of Wisdom abide, she who is the mother of the bodhisattvas, the great beings, and the one who leads them forth?

Śakra said: Son of good family, she is inside this tiered house, written in molten lapis lazuli on gold leaves. The noble bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, has sealed her with seven layers of seals and placed her there. It is difficult for us to show her to you.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, together with the merchant's daughter and the others,

Together with the five hundred young women, they took up flowers, garlands, precious cloth, incense, perfumes, wreaths, unguents, powders, robes, parasols, banners, bells, pennants, and flowers made of gold and silver. The assembly that had come made offerings to the Perfection of Wisdom, and then, for the sake of honoring the noble Bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, they set aside further and separate offerings apart from these.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, together with the merchant's daughter and the five hundred young women, first made offerings to the Perfection of Wisdom with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, unguents, powders, robes, parasols, banners, bells, pennants, sandalwood powder, flowers of gold and silver, and divine music. Then they went to where the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, was, and having arrived, for the sake of honoring the Dharma itself they scattered, strewed, and showered upon the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, unguents, powders, robes, parasols, banners, bells, pennants, sandalwood powder, and flowers of gold and silver. Divine cymbals and music also resounded.

Then those flowers became, above the head of the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, a pavilion of heaped flowers. The flowers of gold and silver and the flowers of many colors remained in the sky like a celestial

palace. His robes and precious garments likewise remained in the air like a mass of clouds made of many kinds of jewels.

When the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, and the merchant's daughter with the five hundred young women saw such a miraculous display of supernatural power by the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, they felt joy, and they thought: How marvelous! This bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, has great miraculous power, great might, and great splendor. If this son of good family displays such miraculous manifestations even while still practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, what will it be like when he fully awakens into unsurpassed, perfect awakening?

Then the merchant's daughter and the five hundred young women, having conceived joy toward the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, and together with that whole assembly and with an exalted intention, generated the mind of unsurpassed, perfect awakening, and said: By this root of virtue, may we in a future time become Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas. While practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, may we also attain such qualities as the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, has attained. Just as we honor and revere the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, as our teacher, so may we honor and revere the Perfection of Wisdom as our teacher. And just as the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, teaches it rightly, so may we also teach it rightly to many beings.

May we too, just as this bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, is endowed with and has fully perfected the Perfection of Wisdom and skillful means, likewise be endowed with and fully perfect the Perfection of Wisdom and skillful means. So they said.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, and those five hundred young women, led by the merchant's daughter, made offerings to the Perfection of Wisdom and showed reverence to the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata as well. They bowed with their heads at the feet of the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, circumambulated him, joined their palms, and sat to one side.

Having sat to one side, the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, spoke these words to the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata: "Son of good family, when I went to the wilderness seeking this Perfection of Wisdom, a voice said to me, 'Son of good family, go east, and you will hear the Perfection of Wisdom.' I heard that voice and the teaching it gave, and I set out toward

the east. Then I thought: 'I am going on the strength of that voice, but in whose presence shall I listen to the Perfection of Wisdom and obtain it? I did not ask the voice that I heard, which told me to go.' Because of this I became unhappy and deeply distressed. I remained in that very place for seven days and nights. In such deep distress, no thought of food arose in me; rather, I attended to the Perfection of Wisdom alone, thinking, 'Where should I go? From whom shall I hear and obtain this Perfection of Wisdom? I did not ask the voice.' Then a form of a Tathāgata appeared before me, and he said, 'Son of good family, travel gradually from here for five hundred leagues. In the city called Gandhavatī you will see the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, teaching and expounding the Perfection of Wisdom.'

"Then I was filled with joy and with great delight, and, pervaded by that very great joy and delight, without moving from that place I heard you teaching the Perfection of Wisdom. When I heard this, many gateways of meditative absorption arose in me. When I was there, the buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the world systems of the ten directions, gave me relief and said, 'Excellent!' They said, 'Son of good family, excellent, excellent! These meditative absorptions of yours arise from the Perfection of Wisdom. Abiding in it, we too have fully perfected the qualities of a buddha.' Thus those Tathāgatas taught me well, caused me to grasp it rightly, praised me, and gladdened me completely, and then vanished.

"Then I too arose from that meditative absorption and thought: 'From where did those Tathāgatas come, and to where have those Tathāgatas gone?' Then I thought further: 'The bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Dharmodgata, has attained dhāraṇī and is endowed with the five superknowledges. He has served the Victors of the past, planted roots of virtue, and trained thoroughly in the Perfection of Wisdom and skillful means.'"

"Surely they will teach me, just as it is, from where those Tathāgatas came and to where those Tathāgatas went." Thinking this, I went to the east, to that place, exactly as the voice of the Tathāgata's form had instructed me. After I arrived, and from far off, I saw the noble one Dharmodgata teaching the Dharma. The moment I saw him, such bliss arose in me as arises for a monk who has entered the first meditative concentration and attends with one-pointed mind. Noble son, I ask you: from where did those Tathāgatas come, and to where did those Tathāgatas go? Noble son, so that I may not be separated from the sight of the Tathāgatas, please explain to me the coming and going of those Tathāgatas.

This is the chapter on Sadāprarudita, the thirtieth chapter of the noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

When he had spoken thus, the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, said this to the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita.

Noble son, those Tathāgatas have not come from anywhere, nor have they gone anywhere, for they do not move from suchness. What is suchness is the Tathāgata. Noble son, in the unborn there is no coming or going; what is unborn is the Tathāgata. Noble son, in the true limit there is no knowing of coming or going; what is the true limit is the Tathāgata. Noble son, in emptiness there is no knowing of coming or going; what is emptiness is the Tathāgata. Noble son, in things just as they are there is no knowing of coming or going; what is things just as they are is the Tathāgata. Noble son, in freedom from attachment there is no knowing of coming or going; what is freedom from attachment is the Tathāgata. Noble son, in cessation there is no knowing of coming or going; what is cessation is the Tathāgata. Noble son, in the element of space there is no knowing of coming or going; what is the element of space is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, apart from these phenomena there is no other Tathāgata. Noble son, the suchness of these phenomena, the suchness of all phenomena, and the suchness of the Tathāgata are one suchness. Noble son, suchness cannot be made into two. Noble son, suchness is one; that is to say, because there is nothing there, it is beyond being counted as two or three.

Noble son, consider an example. Suppose that in the last month of autumn, in the hot autumn season, at the hour of midday, a man sees a mirage shimmering and thinks, "Here I will drink water." Wherever he sees water, he runs there. Noble son, what do you think? Did that water come from the great ocean in the east, or from the south, the west or the north? And where did that water go?

Sadāprarudita replied: Noble son, since there is no water in a mirage, how could there be any knowing of coming or going? Noble son, that man was scorched by the sun, childish by nature, and confused in his discernment; seeing the mirage, he took what was not water to be water. Yet in it, water by its own nature does not exist.

Dharmodgata said:

Son of good family, so it is, so it is. In just this way, son of good family, those who cling to the Tathāgata through form or sound imagine that the Tathāgata comes or goes. All those who imagine that the Tathāgata comes or goes are called childish by nature, of confused wisdom by nature. They are like that man who produced the perception of water where there was no water. And why is this so? Because the Tathāgata is not to be regarded as a body of form. The Tathāgata is the Dharma body. Son of good family, the nature of reality has no coming and no going. In just this way, son of good family, there is no coming or going for the Tathāgatas.

Son of good family, it is like this. Take the troops of elephants, or of horses, or of foot soldiers conjured by a magician. They neither come nor go. In just this way, son of good family, the Tathāgata neither comes nor goes.

Son of good family, it is like this. Suppose a man, fallen asleep, sees in a dream one Tathāgata, or two, or three, four, five, six, seven, eight, nine, ten, twenty, thirty, forty, fifty, a hundred, or even more. Then he wakes, and does not see a single Tathāgata. What do you think, son of good family? Where did those Tathāgatas come from? Where did those Tathāgatas go?

Ever-Weeping said: Son of good family, in a dream no phenomenon is known to be truly established. A dream is false, and not real.

Dharmodgata said: Son of good family, so it is. The Blessed One has said that all phenomena are like a dream. Son of good family, those who do not know that the Tathāgata has taught all phenomena as like a dream, exactly as they are, cling to the Tathāgata as a body of name and a body of form. Because they thus do not know the nature of reality, they imagine that the Tathāgata comes and goes. All those childish ordinary beings who imagine that the Tathāgata comes and goes will wander, and keep wandering, through all these six destinies of saṃsāra. All of them are far from the Perfection of Wisdom. All of them are far from the qualities of the buddhas.

Son of good family, moreover, those who know that all phenomena are like a dream, and that the Tathāgata has taught that all phenomena are like a dream, exactly as they are, do not imagine any phenomenon to come, to go, to arise, or to cease. Those who do not imagine any phenomenon to come, to go, to arise, or to cease thoroughly know the nature of reality of the Tathāgata. Those who thoroughly know the nature of reality of the Tathāgata do not imagine that the Tathāgata comes or goes. Those who thoroughly know the nature of reality of the Tathāgata in this way draw near to unsurpassed,

perfect awakening. That is, they practice the Perfection of Wisdom.

Such śrāvakas of the Blessed One eat the alms of the country meaningfully, and they are fields of offering for the world.

Son of good family, it is like this. The jewels in the great ocean do not come from the east, nor from the south, nor from the west, nor from the north, nor from the intermediate directions, nor from above or below.

They do not come from any of the ten directions, and yet, in dependence on the roots of virtue of sentient beings, precious jewels arise within the great ocean. Nor do they arise without a cause. They depend on causes, conditions, and a basis, and arise in dependence upon these. When those jewels cease, they likewise do not go to any world of the ten directions; yet when those conditions are present, the jewels become manifest, and when those conditions are absent, the jewels do not become manifest.

Son of good family, in just the same way the fully accomplished bodies of those Tathāgatas do not come from any world of the ten directions, nor do they go to any world of the ten directions. Nor are the bodies of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, without a cause. They are fully accomplished through former conduct, dependent on causes, dependent on conditions, and arisen from the ripening of former actions. That body does not exist in any world-system of the ten directions. Yet when the conditions are present, the body comes to be manifestly accomplished, and when those conditions are absent, the manifestly accomplished body does not appear.

Son of good family, take the example of the sound of a lute. It comes from nowhere, and when it ceases it goes nowhere and shifts nowhere. It arises in dependence on the assembly of causes and conditions, dependent on cause and dependent on condition. That is to say, it depends on the body of the lute, on the skin, on the strings, on the bridge, on the peg, on the frame, and on the effort of the person who plays it. In this way sound arises from that lute, dependent on cause and dependent on condition. Yet that sound did not come from the body of the lute, nor from the skin, nor from the strings, nor from the bridge, nor from the peg, nor from the frame, nor from the effort of the person who plays it. Nevertheless, from the gathering of all these together, it is designated as sound. And when that sound ceases, it goes nowhere.

Son of good family, in the same way the full accomplishment of the bodies of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is dependent on cause and dependent on condition. It is accomplished through the application of many roots of virtue. It

is not from a single cause, nor from a single condition, and the body of a buddha is not manifested by a single root of virtue. Yet it is not without a cause either. It arises from the gathering of many causes and conditions, and it does not come from anywhere. When the gathering of causes and conditions is absent, it does not go anywhere either. Son of good family, you should view the coming and going of those Tathāgatas in just this way.

Son of good family, you should also come to understand the nature of all phenomena in just this way. Son of good family, to the degree that you know the Tathāgata in this way, and know that all phenomena are without arising and without cessation, to that degree you will become certain of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and you will certainly engage in the perfection of wisdom and in skillful means.

Then, as this teaching on the absence of coming and going of the Tathāgatas was being given, a great earthquake occurred. This entire great trichiliocosm world-system shook in eighteen great ways and in six modes. It trembled, trembled strongly, trembled completely and strongly. It shook, shook strongly, shook completely and strongly. It quaked, quaked strongly, quaked completely and strongly. It was agitated, agitated strongly, agitated completely and strongly.

It shook and shook thoroughly, shook completely and thoroughly; it trembled and trembled thoroughly, trembled completely and thoroughly; it rocked and rocked thoroughly, rocked completely and thoroughly; it was stirred and stirred thoroughly, stirred completely and thoroughly. It resounded and resounded thoroughly, resounded completely and thoroughly; it roared and roared thoroughly, roared completely and thoroughly. All the abodes of Māra were thrown into turmoil and their splendor was cast down.

Throughout the great trichiliocosm world-system, every grass, tree, shrub, herb, and forest bowed down separately toward the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata. Out of season, flowers were scattered from the sky above, and great rains of flowers fell.

Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), and the Four Great Kings scattered, strewed, and showered divine sandalwood powder and divine flowers toward the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, and the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita. They spoke these words: "Well done, well done, son of good family! Through your power, today we too have heard a discourse arising from the ultimate, which runs counter to the whole world, to all beings who

dwell on the level of the view of the perishable collection and are attached to all views."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, said this to the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata: "Son of good family, what is the cause and what is the condition of this great earthquake that has occurred in the world?"

The bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, replied: "Son of good family, you asked about this teaching on the Tathāgatas neither coming nor going, and through my teaching it, eight thousand beings attained acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena. Eighty billion beings generated the mind toward unsurpassed, perfect awakening. And for sixty-four thousand beings the Dharma eye, free of dust and free of stain, became perfectly pure."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, was filled with great joy and delight. He thought: "By my asking about the Perfection of Wisdom and this teaching that the Tathāgatas neither come nor go, so many beings have been benefited. I have gained a supremely excellent gain. Through this I have obtained the supreme root of virtue by which unsurpassed, perfect awakening is brought to completion, and so I have no further doubt about unsurpassed, perfect awakening. Without doubt I shall become a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly awakened buddha."

Filled with that joy and delight, he rose into the sky to the height of seven palm trees and remained there at that height. And he thought: "Staying here in the sky, I shall pay homage to the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata."

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, saw the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, rising up, and knowing his thought with his own mind, he gave him divine mandārava flowers. He said: "Son of good family, with these divine flowers, pay homage to the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata. Son of good family, I have taken you under my care in this. Son of good family, through your power, today I too have benefited many thousands of beings."

Son of good family, beings who rejoice as you rejoice for the sake of all sentient beings, and who bear such a great burden for immeasurable and uncountable eons, are rare indeed.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, took those mandārava flowers from Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), and scattered them over the

bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, strewing them again and again. Then he covered the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, with his own body, and said these words: Son of good family, from this day forth, in order to serve you and attend upon you, I offer you my body. Having offered his body, he sat before the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, with palms joined.

Then the merchant's daughter and the five hundred young women said this to the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita: Son of good family, we too offer our bodies to you. By this root of virtue, may we attain those same qualities. Together with you, again and again, may we honor and revere the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, and the bodhisattvas, and may we come to be close to them.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, said to the merchant's daughter and the five hundred young women: Young women, if you stand by me with a lofty intention, then give yourselves to me with a lofty intention, and in that case, young women, I will accept you. Those young women replied: With a lofty intention toward you, from the depths of our hearts we follow in accord with you. With a lofty intention toward you, we offer ourselves, to be used as you wish.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, adorned the merchant's daughter and the five hundred young women with every ornament, and adorned the five hundred chariots as well. He offered them all to the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, to serve and attend him, saying: Son of good family, I offer you these female attendants, and these five hundred chariots too, for your full enjoyment.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said to that son of good family: Excellent! Son of good family, excellent! In this way, son of good family, bodhisattvas, great beings, should completely relinquish all their possessions. With such a mind of complete relinquishment, a bodhisattva, a great being, will swiftly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Thus, having made offerings to the teacher of the Dharma, you will be able to listen to the Perfection of Wisdom and skillful means. Son of good family, the former Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, when they practiced the bodhisattva conduct, also relied on just such a way and just such relinquishment to accomplish unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and they too inquired about the Perfection of Wisdom and skillful means.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, in order to bring the root of virtue of the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, to fullness, accepted the merchant's daughter and the five hundred young women together with the five hundred chariots, and having accepted them, gave them back to the son of good family, Sadāprarudita.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, rose from his seat and entered his own house, and the sun set.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, thought: "I have come here out of a desire for the Dharma. For me to sit or to lie down would be improper. For the sake of attending the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, I will pass the time in the two postures of standing and walking, until he comes forth again to teach the Dharma."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, remained for seven years absorbed in a single samādhi. Abiding in thousands of bodhisattva samādhis, immeasurable and beyond counting, which arise from the Perfection of Wisdom and from skillful means, he lived in that state.

The bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, for his part, passed the seven years in the two postures, free of sleep and drowsiness. In those seven years no thought of desire arose in him, no thought of ill will arose, no thought of harming arose, and no wrong thought of craving for flavors arose. For otherwise, how could he have been present when the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, rose from his samādhi?

He thought: "Let us also prepare the Dharma seat on which that son of good family will sit to teach the Dharma, the Dharma seat of the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata. And I will not sprinkle this ground with water. In the place where the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, will teach the Perfection of Wisdom and skillful means, I will spread a fine plaster, and I will lay out flowers of many kinds."

The five hundred young women, led by the merchant's daughter, likewise followed the example of the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, and passed the time in the two postures. In everything they did, they followed him.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita heard from the voices of the gods: "Now, in seven days, the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, will rise from this samādhi, take his seat in the middle of the city, and teach the Dharma."

When the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita heard that voice of the gods, he was delighted and glad, filled with great joy, and happiness and mental well-being arose in him. Together with the five hundred young women, led by the merchant's daughter, he swept that ground clean and arranged a Dharma seat, made of the seven precious substances.

Then each of those young women took off her own upper garment, and they spread those five hundred garments on the seat where the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, would sit to teach the Dharma. When the Dharma seat of the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, had been prepared in this way, all those young women were delighted and glad, filled with great joy, and happiness and mental well-being arose in them.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita wished to sprinkle that place with water. But Māra the Evil One, wishing that the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, should find no water and so become displeased and distressed, unhappy in mind and changed in heart, so that his roots of virtue would be lost and that offering would be spoiled, made all the water that might have been sprinkled on that place vanish from sight. And though Sadāprarudita searched everywhere for water, he found none.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, thought: "I will pierce my own body and sprinkle this ground with my blood. Why? Because this ground is dusty, and dust rises from it; if it touched the body of the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, that would not be right. My body will certainly perish in any case, for it is subject to destruction. What is it good for? Through desire, and for the sake of desire, my body has been broken up for such useless purposes again and again, wandering in cyclic existence; many thousands of my bodies have been destroyed in such ways. But never was it destroyed in a place like this one, nor for the sake of taking up the Dharma. It was destroyed only for the sake of desire, and desire is a thing that perishes." So he reflected.

Having reflected in this way, the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, took a sharp weapon, pierced his body all over, and sprinkled all that ground with his own blood. Following the example of the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, the five hundred young women, the merchant's daughter and the others, all took sharp weapons as well, pierced their own bodies, and sprinkled all that ground with their own blood. Not one of them, neither the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, nor any of those young women,

changed their mind in the least, so that Māra the Evil One could find no opening by which to obstruct their roots of virtue.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), thought: "How wondrous that the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, has such a longing for the Dharma, such firmness in his commitment, such great armor of resolve, and such disregard for body, life, and possessions! He has entered upon this lofty intention: 'Having fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect awakening, I will free all sentient beings from the boundless sufferings of cyclic existence.'"

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, blessed all that blood so that it became divine sandalwood water. The fragrance of that divine sandalwood water, supreme, vast, and inconceivable, filled that whole ground and its surroundings, to the full extent of five hundred leagues.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita: "Excellent, excellent, son of good family! Your diligence, inconceivable as it is, is excellent. Your longing for the Dharma and your search for the Dharma are also excellent. Son of good family, the Tathāgatas of the past, the arhats, the perfectly awakened buddhas, also accomplished unsurpassed, perfect awakening with just such lofty intention, just such diligence, and just such longing for the Dharma."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, thought: "I have spread the Dharma seat for the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, and I have swept this ground well, and sprinkled it well. But with what flowers shall I scatter this ground? And where shall I find the flowers to scatter over the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, as he teaches the Dharma and sits upon the Dharma seat?"

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, said to the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita:

Son of good family, take these divine mandārava flowers, and scatter them in these places. Scatter them also over the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, who is seated on the Dharma throne teaching the Dharma. Having said this, he gave him a thousand loads of divine mandārava flowers.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, took those flowers. With some of them he scattered flowers over that place, and with others he scattered flowers over the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata.

Then, when seven years had passed, the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, rose from that absorption and came to the place where the Dharma seat was. He sat down upon the spread seat, surrounded by many hundreds of thousands of followers, and gazing straight ahead he taught the Perfection of Wisdom.

Then, as soon as the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, saw the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, he attained a bliss like that of a monk who has entered the first meditative concentration and is attending to it with one-pointed mind.

This is how the bodhisattva, the great being Dharmodgata, taught the Perfection of Wisdom. Because all phenomena are equal, the Perfection of Wisdom is equal. Because all phenomena are secluded, the Perfection of Wisdom is secluded. Because all phenomena are unmoving, the Perfection of Wisdom is unmoving. Because all phenomena are without conceit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without conceit. Because all phenomena are without arrogance, the Perfection of Wisdom is without arrogance. Because all phenomena are of a single flavor, the Perfection of Wisdom is of a single flavor. Because all phenomena are without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. Because all phenomena are unborn, the Perfection of Wisdom is unborn. Because all phenomena are unceasing, the Perfection of Wisdom is unceasing.

Because space is without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. Because the ocean is without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. Because Sumeru is varied, the Perfection of Wisdom is varied. Because space is without conceptual thought, the Perfection of Wisdom is without conceptual thought. Because form is without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. In the same way, because feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. Because the earth element is without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. In the same way, because the water element, the fire element, and the wind element are without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. Because the space element is without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit. Because the consciousness element is without limit, the Perfection of Wisdom is without limit.

Because the sameness of phenomena is like a vajra, the Perfection of Wisdom is sameness. Because all phenomena are unmixed, the Perfection of Wisdom is

unmixed. Because all phenomena are without a basis for focus, the Perfection of Wisdom is without a basis for focus. Because the sameness of the destruction of all phenomena, the Perfection of Wisdom is the sameness of destruction. Because all phenomena are without action, the Perfection of Wisdom is without action.

Because all phenomena are inconceivable, the Perfection of Wisdom should be understood as inconceivable.

Then, as the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita sat there, the king of absorptions called "the equality of all phenomena" arose in him. He also obtained the absorption called "all phenomena are secluded"; the absorption called "all phenomena are unmoving"; the absorption called "all phenomena are free of conceit"; the absorption called "all phenomena are free of arrogance"; the absorption called "all phenomena are of a single taste"; the absorption called "all phenomena are boundless"; the absorption called "all phenomena are unborn"; the absorption called "all phenomena are unceasing"; the absorption called "boundless space"; the absorption called "boundless ocean"; the absorption called "the variegated Sumeru"; the absorption called "space free of conceptualization"; the absorption called "boundless form"; and likewise the absorptions called "boundless feeling," "boundless perception," "boundless formations," and "boundless consciousness"; the absorption called "the boundless earth element"; and likewise the absorptions called "the boundless water element," "the boundless fire element," and "the boundless wind element"; the absorption called "the boundless space element"; the absorption called "the boundless consciousness element"; the absorption called "vajra-like"; the absorption called "all phenomena are unmixed"; the absorption called "all phenomena are without a basis of focus"; the absorption called "the equality of the destruction of all phenomena"; the absorption called "all phenomena are without action"; and the absorption called "all phenomena are inconceivable." Thus the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, attained six hundred thousand gateways of absorption of this kind and others like them.

This is the thirty-first chapter, called "Dharmodgata," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Subhūti, immediately after the bodhisattva, the great being Sadāprarudita, had attained these six hundred thousand gateways of absorption, he saw, in the east, south, west and north, in the intermediate directions, below and

above, in all ten directions, in as many great trichiliocosm world-systems as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā, as many buddhas, Blessed Ones, as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā. Each was surrounded by an assembly of monks, with a company of bodhisattvas before him, and each was teaching this Perfection of Wisdom in exactly this manner, with exactly these names and these letters. It was just as I now, in this great trichiliocosm world-system, teach the Dharma surrounded by an assembly of monks, with a company of bodhisattvas before me, and teach this Perfection of Wisdom in exactly this manner, with exactly these names and these letters.

He became one of inconceivably vast learning, with learning as deep as the ocean. In every place where he was born, he was never separated from the buddhas. In every birth, he was born in those very places where buddhas, Blessed Ones, become manifest, and even in dreams he was never parted from the buddhas, the Blessed Ones.

Through this he will have abandoned all the unfavorable conditions and will have accomplished the perfect leisure and endowment.

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, through this explanation too you should understand that this Perfection of Wisdom brings about the omniscient wisdom of bodhisattvas, great beings. Therefore, Ānanda, bodhisattvas, great beings, who wish to attain omniscient wisdom should practice this Perfection of Wisdom. They should listen to this Perfection of Wisdom, take it up, hold it, read it, thoroughly comprehend it, recite it, teach it, explain it in detail, give the transmission of it, memorize it, and write it down. By the blessing of the Tathāgata, they should write it out well, with clear and perfectly clear letters, on great scrolls. They should honor it, revere it, regard it as their teacher, make offerings to it, venerate it, make images of it, and serve it, with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, music, clothing, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, and with rows of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings. Ānanda, this is my instruction.

Why is that? Because from this Perfection of Wisdom, omniscient wisdom becomes fully perfected.

Ānanda, what do you think? Is the Tathāgata your teacher?"

Ānanda replied: "Blessed One, he is my teacher. Sugata, he is my teacher."

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Ānanda in this way: "Ānanda, you have attended your teacher the Tathāgata with bodily

action that is loving and pleasing, with speech that is loving and pleasing, and with mind that is loving and pleasing. Therefore, Ānanda, just as you now show joy, devotion, faith, and reverence toward this body of mine, which remains here, living and sustained, so, Ānanda, after I have passed away, do the same toward this Perfection of Wisdom. So that this Perfection of Wisdom may not disappear, and so that you may not become the last of such persons, Ānanda, I entrust it to you, a second time and a third time; I entrust it to you completely and repeatedly.

Ānanda, as long as this Perfection of Wisdom is practiced in the world, for so long you should know that the Tathāgata is present. Ānanda, for so long you should know that the Tathāgata is teaching the Dharma.

Ānanda, those beings who listen to this Perfection of Wisdom, take it up, hold it, read it, thoroughly comprehend it, recite it, teach it, explain it in detail, give the transmission of it, memorize it, and write it down in letters, and who honor it, revere it, regard it as their teacher, make offerings to it, venerate it, make images of it, and serve it, with flowers, incense, perfumes, garlands, ointments, powders, clothing, parasols, banners, bells, and flags, and with rows of lamps all around, and with many kinds of offerings, you should know that such beings will never be separated from seeing the buddhas, from hearing the sacred Dharma, or from serving the Saṅgha. Ānanda, you should know that those beings dwell in the presence of the Tathāgata."

The Blessed One was pleased, and when he had spoken in this way,

Then the bodhisattvas, the great beings, headed by Maitreya, together with the venerable Subhūti, the venerable Śāriputra, the venerable Ānanda, Śakra, lord of the gods, and the whole world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas, rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had spoken.

This concludes the thirty-second chapter, called "The Entrusting," from the Noble Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

The Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines, the Mother of the Blessed Ones, is complete.

It was translated, revised, and finalized by the Indian preceptor Śākyasena, Jñānasiddhi, and the great editor-translator, the venerable Dharmatāśīla, and others. Later, by command of the sacred sovereign of Tibet, the glorious divine king Tashi Lhadé Tsen, the Indian preceptor Subhāṣita and the translator, the monk Rinchen Zangpo, translated it again in accordance with the

commentary. Later still, the Indian preceptor, the great paṇḍita Dīpaṃkaraśrījñāna, and the great editor-translator, the monk Rinchen Zangpo, corrected and revised it against the commentary of the Central Land, and finalized it. Afterwards, at Nyethang Nemoché in Kyi Mé, the great paṇḍita Dīpaṃkaraśrījñāna and the translator Drom Gyalwé Jungné, while expounding the Eight Thousand Lines, finalized a major revision. Later, at Rasgreng Monastery, the translator Drom Gyalwé Jungné finalized it twice, checking it against three Indian sūtra manuscripts. Afterwards that same translator wrote an exposition and also finalized the minor details. At a still later time, the great translator, the Śākya monk Lodan Sherab, gathered many Kashmiri manuscripts and many manuscripts from the Central Land, and finalized it.

Here ends the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines.

Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered "of noble lineage, great elephants" translates the stock epithet "འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་", usually understood as "well-bred, noble, great elephants." This is a traditional image for arhats. The phrase "sons of good family" renders the standard "འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་". The final sentence ("I do not truly see...") is the opening of Subhūti's famous inquiry, which leads into the teaching on the emptiness of the bodhisattva; "as an actual phenomenon" renders the sense of "འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་" ("do not correctly perceive after investigation"). The Tibetan text uses "འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་" for Śāriputra, which I have given in Sanskrit form per house style.
- The Tibetan has Śāriputra's challenge and Subhūti's reply in a compact form; I have kept the sense that Subhūti turns the question back on Śāriputra, since neither existence nor non-existence can be found in no-mind. The phrase "irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening" translates the Tibetan as it stands, where the verb "to be examined, to be recognized" governs the bodhisattva's irreversibility. Subhūti's epithet in Śāriputra's praise renders "abiding in freedom from affliction," the Tibetan form of the arana-vihārin tradition.
- The Tibetan "འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་" is rendered "stiff" following the standard stock series (stiffening, sinking, anxiety, fear). "འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་" is idiomatic, literally "stuck in the lungs/heart"; I render it as a hindrance weighing upon the heart. In the continuity text, "the stage of the hearers" parallels the "stage of the solitary buddhas" here.
- The phrase "འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་" is rendered "the one who wanders in the cycle of existence." It most likely stands for a Sanskrit term meaning a wanderer or one who moves through saṃsāra, and some lineages read it as a proper epithet. It is rendered consistently, but its exact sense is not fully settled. The phrase "འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་" is syntactically difficult. I have taken it to mean "vast, pioneered by the immeasurable, definitive," but other readings are possible.
- The phrase "འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་" is rendered "emerge into omniscience" in the sense of definitive emergence (niryaṇa). The sentence "འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་..." is read as a self-posed question in the bodhisattva's reflection, taking the absence of any phenomenon and non-apprehension as a candidate definition of the perfection of wisdom. The terms "འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་" and "འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་" are rendered "essential nature" and "defining characteristic" respectively, following the house glossary.

- [illegible]

established referent. The phrase translated "is not fully realized" (अव्यवस्थित) follows the sense of the Sanskrit upalabdhi-type negation, "not apprehended," and is paired deliberately with "not observed."

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence, as the Tibetan does; the thought continues with consciousness in the following passage. The Tibetan verb རྒྱལ་བར་སྐྱོད་པའི་མཆོད་གྲྀལ་ (upalakṣ-/upaparīkṣ-type contemplation) is rendered "closely contemplate," with the paired negations "closely conceive" and "closely grasp" following the parallel verbs in the text. The phrase "is not a phenomenon" in the opening lines reflects the text's insistence that even non-establishment is not a reified entity.
- The Tibetan text includes a colophon-like marker, the end of the first volume (bampo) of the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines and the start of the second. I omitted it so the narration flows without interruption. The Tibetan opens mid-statement with the object "consciousness," continuing the preceding sentence's pattern about form, feeling, perception and formations. The pattern is completed here for consciousness. The final clause on "even a little harmful intent" renders the Tibetan chung ngu na, which can also be read as "even in the smallest degree."
- The final exchange is deliberately paradoxical, and the Tibetan phrase "ཡོང་བ་ལྟོགས་པ།" (attainment) is used both as a noun and verb; I have rendered it as "attained" for readability. The passage ends mid-dialogue, with Subhūti's counter-question. In the first paragraph, "the perception of hardship" renders རྒྱལ་བར་སྐྱོད་པའི་མཆོད་གྲྀལ་, meaning the sense of difficulty or arduousness in the bodhisattva's task, which the realization of non-apprehension removes.
- The opening sentence is the tail of Subhūti's rejoinder in the preceding passage. The Tibetan "ཡོང་བ་ལྟོགས་པའི་མཆོད་གྲྀལ་" is syntactically awkward, and I have rendered it as a rhetorical question, matching the preceding line. The sentences about non-arising being "disputed" and "appearing distinctly" (ཤེད་པའི་ཕྱིན་པ་, བྱུང་བའི་ཕྱིན་པ་) are terse and somewhat obscure in this translation. Subhūti's point seems to be that non-arising is the very topic of debate, yet is evident as suchness, and the sense is preserved with some uncertainty. The final exchange is a deliberate paradox: attention (manaskāra) and abiding in the Perfection of Wisdom are mutually exclusive in the sense that wisdom abides in nothing, which also means it does not rest even on an act of attention.
- The opening of this passage continues Subhūti's reply in the dialogue; the Tibetan addresses Śāriputra as "Venerable Subhūti" only in the preceding passage's rendering, so here I have taken the speaker in the first sentence to be Subhūti addressing Śāriputra, which fits the following sentence "Subhūti said this to Śāriputra" as a resumed speech. If the first sentence is instead Śāriputra's own objection addressed to Subhūti, the attribution of the opening quotation would reverse. The phrase "even you are open to criticism" is a literal rendering of the Tibetan; the commentarial point is that Śāriputra's own statement, taken at face value, also lacks an inherently existing referent, which Subhūti then clarifies through the series of parallels between sentient beings and attention. "The real as it is" renders the Tibetan for what is not accurately as it is, in the sense of deluded, mistaken apprehension. "The certainty of what is right" refers to the fixed course of the śrāvaka, whom Subhūti declares to be without the opportunity of generating the awakening mind in that state.
- The first sentence is elliptical: "they" are those who have entered into the certainty of what is right (the fixed ones named in the preceding passage), who have, in the tradition's reading, set a boundary to saṃsāra's stream by their own attainment, so that they no longer have the disposition to generate the mind of awakening. I have rendered it as the text has it, without adding explanation in the body. The phrase "the coming together of eye, form, and consciousness" glosses the technical term for contact (sparśa), literally "the meeting," added for the listener's clarity. Subhūti's remark that he will "repay the kindness" echoes the Buddha's former practice and the hearers' role in instructing others, per the standard reading

of this passage.

- [illegible]

- The Tibetan text here is slightly disordered in places. "Mar me mdzad" is rendered Dīpaṃkara; the city called "Mar me can" is rendered Dīpavatī, following the Sanskrit tradition. "Lords of beings" renders skye dgu'i bdag po, which may be understood as Prajāpati. The final Tibetan sentence in the first paragraph before the gods' declaration is slightly elliptical; I have rendered its sense. The "gods of Lesser Virtue" renders dge chung (Parīṭṣaṣubha); "Akaniṣṭha" renders 'og min.

The phrase translated "Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world-system" renders the Tibetan "mi mjed kyi bdag po," the standard epithet of Mahābrahmā. Kauśika is a common epithet of Śakra (Indra).

• The Tibetan sentence about entering battle is syntactically loose, with several verbs listed in sequence. I have rendered it in the sense of the parallel Sanskrit tradition, in which the devotee is protected anywhere in the battlefield. The verb string translated "holds, bears in mind, reads, thoroughly understands, recites, teaches, explains, expounds, and memorizes" follows the standard Prajñāpāramitā formula and is kept uniform throughout. The Tibetan "ཁོ་འདྲི་བའི་ལོ་ལོ་ལོ་ལོ་ལོ་" is rendered as "arrogance."

• The phrase "འོ་དགྲིས་རྒྱལ་བ་ཀུན་གླིང་མཐོང་པོ་ཡི་ཆོས་ཉིད་ཤེས་པ་ལྟོགས་པ་ཞེས་པའི་ཕྱིར་བཏགས་ཅི།" is awkward in the Tibetan; I have rendered it literally as "the realization of the very substance of omniscience." The Sanskrit parallel likely reads something like "the attainment of the self-nature of omniscience," and the sense is that omniscience itself is the fruit being asked about. The final line, "The Blessed One said," leads into the next passage, which is not included here.

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence, so the translation ends with an ellipsis; the sentence presumably continues in the following passage. The opening question, addressed to Śakra, is somewhat elliptical in the Tibetan; it has been rendered as the Blessed One's rhetorical challenge, with the Blessed One then turning to examine Śakra's own understanding. In the final paragraph the grammatical subject is compressed in the Tibetan; "those buddhas" has been supplied from the sense of those who have awakened fully.

- The passage continues a sentence begun in the prior passage, so the opening "and cause them to hold it" completes the thought "those buddhas teach this Perfection of Wisdom to

others, give them prophecy, and lead them..." The sequence of verbs (hold, read, comprehend, recite, teach, explain, give transmission, memorize) is rendered consistently in both the causative and the imperative forms. The phrase "perhaps only one or two" renders a conditional construction implying rarity. The final line introduces Śakra's reply, which continues in the next passage.

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence, as the source does; the final sentence is left open to be completed in the following passage. The phrase "never separated from this approach" renders a slightly obscure Tibetan phrase (tshul dang ma bral ba). The Tibetan repeats the whole preceding sequence as the same formula recurs, so the repetition in the translation is faithful to the text.

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, as the Tibetan does; the comparison continues in the following passage. The phrase "stūpas ... containing the relics of the Tathāgatas" renders the Tibetan literally as "having the essence of the relics." The rendering "thousandfold world system" for the Tibetan "stong spyi phud" is a reasonable choice for the first of the three-thousandfold world-system series, though the term is somewhat compressed in the Tibetan.

- The Tibetan text ends mid-sentence, as the passage is cut at "having generated the mind of awakening"; the sentence continues in the next passage. The word rendered "adorns it with fine decoration" translates a term (rimor byed) whose exact nuance, "paint, decorate, or depict," is somewhat open. I kept the same rendering as in the preceding passage for continuity. The phrase "Not departing from the proper way" renders tshul dang ma bral ba, which could also be read as "not lacking the proper method." The "twofold thousandfold" system is the middle chiliocosm of the standard cosmology (the thousand-cubed, dvisāhasra madhyama lokadhātu), left in the text's own wording.

- The Tibetan text breaks off at the end with a conditional clause, "if he does so," and no concluding statement of merit; the translation reproduces this, since the passage ends mid-sentence. The phrase translated "in a way that is not divorced from the proper manner" (འདྲིམ་པ་ལས་མེད་པར་འདྲིམ་པ་) is a compressed, somewhat obscure construction; the rendering follows the sense of acting in accord with the proper method. The variant spellings rjod par byed / rjed par byed in the source are treated as the same verb, rendered "making offerings to it," in keeping with the surrounding list.

- The final sentence breaks off at the end of the Tibetan passage, as it did in the prior passage; its remaining clauses of reverence continue in the next section. I rendered the opening "Let that stand" for འདྲིམ་པ་ལས་མེད་པར་འདྲིམ་པ་, which marks the first scenario as a baseline set aside before the greater comparison. The phrase "the thought, 'May the lineage of the buddhas not be cut off'" follows the Tibetan's quoted wish. The phrase "it is the one who does so..." serves to carry the long chain of participles toward its eventual predicate, which falls in the next passage.

- The passage begins mid-sentence, continuing the preceding clause ("if such a person honors it, reveres it..."), which I have rendered to join seamlessly with the continuity text. The six-fold honorific series (འདྲིམ་པ་ལས་མེད་པར་འདྲིམ་པ་ etc.) is rendered consistently as honors, reveres, esteems, makes offerings, depicts in paintings, and serves with respect; the sense of འདྲིམ་པ་ལས་མེད་པར་འདྲིམ་པ་ (esteem, as in treating as one's gain or honored possession) and འདྲིམ་པ་ལས་མེད་པར་འདྲིམ་པ་ (depict/paint) follows the standard Prajñāpāramitā usage. The phrase འདྲིམ་པ་ལས་མེད་པར་འདྲིམ་པ་ is rendered as contemplating it in the mind as a real object, which is a literal reading of a somewhat opaque phrase. Śakra is glossed as lord of the gods in the narration, with his name Kauśika used by the Buddha.

- The phrase beginning "that person works so that the sacred Dharma may endure" and the clause about benefiting bodhisattvas "through the Dharma not being separated from its proper manner of presentation" (tshul dang ma bral ba) is syntactically compressed in the Tibetan; the rendering follows the evident sense. The numerical sequence of fractions includes the unusual

term "khrag khrig" (a very large number), here rendered as "a vast multiple of ten million." The first sentence picks up directly from the preceding passage, so "that person" there refers to the one who sets the Perfection of Wisdom down in a book and makes offerings.

- The Tibetan uses the name Kauśika (an epithet of Śakra) where the continuity passage used "Friend"; I kept Kauśika here as it is the name in the text. The term rigs sngags (vidyā, here "spell of knowledge") means a mantra-like formula of knowledge; "spell of knowledge" preserves both senses. The pairing "equal to the unequaled" renders the standard formula asamāsama.
- Two small points. The Tibetan reads "the great thousand of the three thousand" for the world system, which I have rendered literally. The phrase "what accords with the cause of the Perfection of Wisdom" translates a compound that could also be read as "a continuity of causes in keeping with the Perfection of Wisdom"; I kept the simpler reading. The sentence at the end is left open because the passage breaks off mid-sentence in the source. The line "the fourth section of the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines" is a colophon marking the end of the fourth volume and is kept as a narrated divider.
- The Tibetan "བཤད་པོར་" is rendered "recite" or "memorize" according to context. "Kauśika" is Śakra's own epithet and is kept in the address. The passage ends mid-episode, at Śakra's resolve to prevent the non-Buddhists from approaching.
- Two renderings are uncertain. The phrase "so that their eyes may not be set at ease" is a literal rendering of a difficult Tibetan clause about Māra's motive, probably meaning that he intends to unsettle or disturb the assembly. The two Tibetan royal names, rendered here as Bimbisāra and Prasenajit, are given in the text as "King Rūpacan-snying-po" and "King Gsal-rgyal," that is, Bimbisāra (Gzugs-can snying-po) and Prasenajit (Gsal-rgyal), the standard Tibetan equivalents.
- The passage opens mid-thought, continuing Śakra's reflection from the preceding passage, so it begins with the closing quotation mark. "Sons of the gods" renders lha'i bu (devaputra); "the gods of Māra's host" renders bdud kyi ris kyi lha. The simile of the ocean and its jewels is rendered closely. Kauśika is a standard epithet of Śakra (Indra) and is used here in direct address by the Buddha.
- The Tibetan has the opening lines of Ānanda's speech without an explicit marker, so I rendered them as a continuation of his words. The Tibetan "སྐྱོང་གི་" is rendered "dedicated," in keeping with the standard sense of dedication to omniscience. In the line about the seeds, the Tibetan "སྐྱོང་གི་སྐྱོང་གི་སྐྱོང་གི་" is rendered as meeting "the right gathering of conditions," which is the sense the context supports.
- The first sentence concludes the discourse of the preceding passage; I have rendered it as the closing line of the Buddha's words to Ānanda. In the final sentence, the Tibetan lists "ask about" (མཇུག་པོར་) among Śakra's list of practices, which does not appear in the Buddha's earlier list; I have kept it as it stands. The closing phrase "སྐྱོང་གི་སྐྱོང་གི་སྐྱོང་གི་" is rendered as a rhetorical "what need is there to speak of" the greater case.
- The passage breaks off mid-sentence in the source, so the final sentence is left open, as in the Tibetan. The phrase rendered "nor will that person be possessed of dread, either of others or of self, or of any thorough fear" follows the Tibetan literally; the Sanskrit parallel may read differently, but the sense is clear. The "Four Great Kings" are the guardian deities of the four directions, the lowest heaven of the desire realm.
- The Tibetan has no explicit mention of the Four Great Kings in this passage, but the first paragraph continues the previous sentence about the gods of that class. In the second paragraph, "Thirty-Three" is the standard class of gods ruled by Śakra (Indra). The Tibetan text breaks off after the Nirmāṇarati paragraph, in the middle of the sequence of verbs. In one instance the source reads "expound" where its parallels read "bear in mind"; I followed the pattern of the surrounding repetitions, which is probably a scribal variation.

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence, as the thought to be generated continues in the next passage. The list of form-realm gods is rendered by the conventional names of the Sanskrit divine classes (Brahmapāriṣadya, Brahmapurohita, Mahābrahmā, Parīttābha, Apramāṇābha, Ābhāsvara, Parīttaśubha, Apramāṇaśubha, Śubhakṛtsna, Anabhraka, Puṇyaprasava, Bṛhatphala, Asaṃjñisattva, Avṛha, Atapa, Sudṛśa, Sudarśana), while the Tibetan list here is abbreviated and somewhat irregular. The sentence about the gods who stand before Brahmā is an abbreviation instruction in the Tibetan, so it is rendered as such.
- The opening imperatives (look upon, pay homage, and so on) are addressed in the Tibetan as direct commands, apparently from the beings being instructed to attend to the volume. I have kept them as imperatives, continuing the thought from the previous passage. The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, as in the source. The Tibetan list of beings here uses "འགྲོ་བཤུན་མཁས་པ་ཆེན་པོ་།" for mahoragas ("great belly-crawlers") and "རྒྱལ་ཁབ་ལྷ་མོ་།" for kinnaras, as in the preceding passage. The Tibetan "འདྲིམ་པོ་ཆེན་པོ་།" ("greatly majestic") appears to be a descriptive epithet applied to these beings, and I have rendered it literally.
- The Tibetan has "gods and nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans, non-humans"; the corrupt-looking "འགྲོ་བཤུན་" in "འགྲོ་བཤུན་མཁས་པ་ཆེན་པོ་།" is the standard Tibetan rendering of kinnara (literally "is he human?"), and འགྲོ་བཤུན་མཁས་པ་ཆེན་པོ་། is mahoraga. The phrase "the Dharma's way, place" (chos kyī tshul gyi gnas) is rendered literally; it likely refers to the site where this Dharma teaching is held or kept. In the awakening-factors line, "the factors that lead to awakening" renders the standard bodhipākṣika dharmas.
- The passage ends mid-sentence in the Tibetan, as the text breaks off after "keeps it or sets it in place." Terms such as "so-and-so" render the placeholder names in the Tibetan (gag ge mo zhiḡ, che ge mo), which are formulaic stand-ins for unspecified directions and a buddha's name. The repeated masculine pronoun follows the Tibetan phrasing "son or daughter of good family," used for both. The phrase "lightness and spaciousness" renders the repeated expression for bodily ease and expansiveness, which is slightly obscure in this transmission. "Moistened by the mental engagement" is a literal rendering of a stock simile for the nourishing effect of samādhi.
- The Tibetan phrase "འདྲིམ་པོ་ཆེན་པོ་།" (translated "as thick as a mass of clustered grains") is a difficult and probably corrupt or idiosyncratic expression, and my rendering follows the parallel context of the Eight Thousand Line text. The phrase "འདྲིམ་པོ་ཆེན་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་ཆེན་པོ་།" ("distinguished by the ultimate limit") corresponds to the Sanskrit idea of the Dharma body as the reality-limit (bhūtakoṭi), the basis of the Tathāgata's true body. The passage ends mid-sentence in the Tibetan, which I have rendered as it stands.
- The seat passage: the Tibetan says "gods of the Dharma hall" (chos bzang lha'i mdun sa), which renders Sudharmā, the assembly hall of the gods; the speaker is Śakra (Indra), whose seat in that hall is honored even in his absence. The phrase "thoroughly pervaded" renders yongs su bsgos pa, literally "thoroughly imbued" or "perfumed," in the sense of being permeated by the Perfection of Wisdom. The sentence about the Perfection of Wisdom being "renowned as powerful and become the cause and condition" is syntactically compressed in the Tibetan; I have kept its sense without expanding it.
- The passage opens by completing Subhūti's statement, then marks the section break with its colophon, which I have kept as a closing line. In the colophon, the fifth bam po, the Tibetan text of the passage does not state the continuation of Śakra's reply; it is left unfinished here, as in the source. The humors are rendered as wind, bile and phlegm, the three standard Indian humors, with the "combined disorder" being the sannipāta, in which all three are disturbed together.
- The passage addresses "Noble Ānanda" at the start, so Śakra's reply to Ānanda runs into his address to the Blessed One without a marked break; I have marked the shift for the listener.

The long numerical series (hundredth, thousandth, up to the final term) follows the Tibetan's escalating enumeration, whose last terms are inexact. "Bubbling mass" renders བུ་བྱོལ་གྲངས་ཀློང་།, understood as "filled to the brim and overflowing."

- Śakra and Kauśika are the same figure; the text uses both Tibetan renderings of his epithets (Indra, lord of the gods), and I have kept them as Śakra and Kauśika. The phrase rendered "in the nature of reality" translates "as dharmatā," that is, seeing the buddhas through the nature of reality rather than through their physical forms. The final sentence's six items, ending with "discerning of phenomena," stand for the sixth perfection, wisdom itself, whose precedence is the point being made.
- The passage breaks off mid-sentence in the Tibetan, since Śakra's description of the devotee continues beyond it; I have closed it with a full stop for narration, though the sentence is grammatically incomplete in the original. The phrase "keeps it or sets it in place" renders རྒྱུ་སྤྲོད་པར་བླངས་པ།, which may mean keeping the text in one's possession or enshrining it. In the opening, the lesser quoted phrase "settles" is not an issue; the shadow analogy is the standard Eight Thousand Lines image for the non-difference of the perfections when unified through wisdom and dedicated to omniscience.
- The phrase about exhausting the aggregates and the analysis of the true limit is syntactically compressed in the Tibetan, and I have rendered it as literally as possible. The parallel "through X, to one with X" clauses describing the bodhisattva recipient follow the Tibetan's repeated instrumental structure. The passage ends mid-argument, as the Tibetan does, so the comparison of merit for the higher world systems is completed in the next passage.
- The Tibetan is somewhat corrupt or repetitive in places, notably the clause on "even if only in a small measure" (ཡིན་ཀྱང་ཆུང་ལྗང་།), which I have rendered tentatively. The phrase rendered "the unsurpassed discerning of the true limit" (འཇིག་རྟོག་མཁོད་པའི་ཐུགས་རྒྱུ་སྤྲོད་པར་བླངས་པ།) is obscure. The passage breaks off mid-quotation at its end, as in the Tibetan source, so the final speech is left unfinished.
- The clause beginning "having become fully awakened, you will bring to discipline..." is syntactically compressed and slightly irregular in the Tibetan, probably reflecting a Sanskrit idiom about the "true limit" (bhūtaḥkoṭī); I have kept the rendering close to the wording. The "small thousand," "middling second thousand," and "great thousand of thousands" are the standard nested world-system counts: one thousand worlds, one million worlds, and one billion worlds. The final sentence of the Tibetan repeats the opening of this passage, as the framing quotation closes.
- The Tibetan breaks off mid-sentence at the end, so the final sentence is left open ("and so on") rather than completed. The phrase "exhaustion of the aggregates" and "true limit" (yang dag pa'i mtha', bhūtaḥkoṭī) is rendered according to its sense in the Perfection of Wisdom literature, where the true limit is the ultimate reality in which the bodhisattva does not abide. The repeated passage in the opening paragraph reproduces the Tibetan's own repetition of the preceding speech, now framed as the speaker's own words of vow.
- The long middle sentence about the recipient is syntactically elliptical in the Tibetan, with a chain of instrumental phrases (faith through faith, and so on) and a series of verbs (teaching, establishing, praising, gladdening). I have rendered it as one continuous sentence to preserve the structure. "Exhaustion of the aggregates" and "true limit" (yang dag pa'i mtha', bhūtaḥkoṭī) follow the Tibetan; the phrasing is somewhat condensed. The lines about writing and reading with "only" effort render the Tibetan's difficult clause with some interpretive smoothing.
- The passage on the semblance of the Perfection of Wisdom is doctrinally delicate. The Tibetan text seems internally troubled: the first and second descriptions of how the false teachers speak appear nearly identical. The sense is probably that the false teaching treats impermanence as an eternalist-style discernment of destruction, whereas the true view does not see the destruction of form as the impermanence of form. I have rendered the Tibetan as it

stands, without smoothing. The sentence "Thereby be ruined" renders 白白費了, literally "become wasted." The opening of this passage continues from the preceding one, so the "previous" son or daughter refers to the earlier person who writes and gives the text to others.

- [illegible]

kept this as given. The "small thousand, second thousand, third thousand" sequence refers to the standard cosmological hierarchy culminating in the great trichiliocosm.

- The passage repeats a formula, first with the arhat and then with the pratyekabuddha as the result discerned. The sentence about bringing beings to maturity is rendered in the same way in both occurrences, though the Tibetan in the first occurrence reads "purifying" (sbyong) and in the repetition "conducting" (spyod) the person's mind; I have followed the sense of purification in both. The phrase "exhaustion of the aggregates... the true limit" is a compressed and somewhat obscure formula, and I have kept it close to the Tibetan.

- The final sentence is left open in the Tibetan, as the passage ends mid-sentence and the sense continues beyond this section. The phrase "to a bodhisattva who has generated the awakening mind" follows the Tibetan syntax, which is dense and repetitive. The tiered world-system terms are rendered literally: the small thousand, middling twofold thousand, and great threefold thousand.

- The Tibetan passage ends abruptly with a set-aside formula ("let alone...") whose main clause lies in the following passage, so the sentence is left open. In the second paragraph, the phrase about taming beings "within the unsurpassable exhaustion of the aggregates... distinguished in the true limit" is syntactically dense and likely corrupt or elliptical in the Tibetan; I have rendered it as literally as sense allows. In the final paragraph, the opening "Kauschika" is a slip for Kauśika, the epithet of Śakra (Indra), the interlocutor in this sūtra.

- The Tibetan phrase for the first world system reads stong spyi phud, literally something like "the chief or topmost of the thousand," corresponding to the "small chiliocosm" (one thousand worlds); the second, "middle" thousand and the third, "great thousand of thousands," complete the standard threefold cosmology (the three-thousand great-thousand world system). The opening line of the passage as given reads "all the beings" with the thousand-world system implicit; I rendered it as the first of the series for clarity. The earlier continuity text uses "Kauschika" once; I have normalized to Kauśika throughout, in line with the rest of the continuity.

- The passage breaks off mid-argument: the main clause stating the comparison of merit is not yet given, and the repeated "set aside the merit" clauses build toward it. The opening sentence is syntactically elliptical in the Tibetan, and I have rendered it as a continuation of the preceding hypothetical, adding "suppose" for clarity. The terms for the nested world systems (the small, middling, and great thousand realms) follow the standard Prajñāpāramitā cosmological scheme, and the Tibetan phrasing is rendered closely rather than normalized.

- The sentence "the lord of the gods... Sugata" renders སུག་ཐ་བཤུ་ཡེ་ཤུ་ལྷ་མོ་ as Sugata, a Buddha epithet in Śakra's address. The phrase translated "make that offering bring great fruit and great reward" renders the Tibetan literally as making the doing of their work bear great fruit and great reward for the donors. The sense is that alms-givers' gifts become greatly fruitful, as in the standard formula. The word "nature" in "such is the very nature" renders the Tibetan "de lta bu nyid," meaning "exactly thus." The opening phrase about Gaṅgā-sand-many world systems is rendered from the Tibetan as given, though the preceding English summary lacked it.

- The passage ends mid-sentence in the Tibetan, with "that is to say" (te), so the list of what is rejoiced in continues in the following passage. The opening lines complete the answer to Subhūti's "And why is that?" from the preceding passage. The chapter colophon ("the fifth chapter") is rendered as it stands, though it is a textual marker rather than part of the spoken discourse. The phrase "that which equals the unequaled" renders the Tibetan literally, following the Sanskrit sense of a term that equals what has no equal.

- The passage is one long sentence, a continuation of the bodhisattva's rejoicing, so I have supplied the repeated phrase "rejoices in" to keep it intelligible when heard aloud. The Tibetan lists the roots of virtue in a series ending with "and" clauses.

The Tibetan says "sounding" the conch twice in the same way (dung 'bud pa and dung sgrogs pa). I rendered them as "blowing" and "proclaiming" to preserve the distinction.

"Bases of meritorious action" renders bsod nams bya ba'i dngos po (Skt. puṇyakriyāvastu), the standard threefold category of giving, discipline, and meditation.

- The list of beings, which in this tradition continues the eight classes of nonhuman beings, renders རྒྱུ་ལྔ་ལྔ་ as gandharva, རྒྱུ་ལྔ་ལྔ་ལྔ་ as garuḍa, རྒྱུ་ལྔ་ལྔ་ལྔ་ as kinnara, and རྒྱུ་ལྔ་ལྔ་ལྔ་ལྔ་ as mahoraga. The Tibetan text breaks off mid-question at the end of this passage, so the final sentence is left as a question, as in the source. The "bases" (dngos po) in Subhūti's reply carry the sense of "real entities" or "substrata," which is why I give "no real basis" where the passage speaks of attachment.
- The passage opens with the tail of the preceding sentence, which is joined here to the continuity text's closing question. The Tibetan "chapter-end" line (the seventh volume of the Eight Thousand Line Perfection of Wisdom) falls in the middle of the discourse, so it is kept as a plain colophon sentence. The final sentence breaks off where the next section begins and is rendered as it stands.
- The long list of the buddhas' qualities follows the standard arhat formula, adapted to describe the buddhas. "Cut off the path, cut off the entering" renders the Tibetan literally; the sense is that the avenues of rebirth are severed. The eight classes of beings (gods through non-humans) are given with their usual Sanskrit identities: gandharvas, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas. The passage ends with Subhūti's question, so the text breaks mid-exchange, and Maitreya's reply begins in the next passage.
- The passage breaks off mid-sentence, with its list of roots of virtue to be continued in the following passage. The clause about the Buddhas whose "paths are cut off" is difficult, and I have rendered it literally. In the "exhausted" sentence the Tibetan is terse, and "devoid of any basis" is my interpretive rendering of bral ba. The phrase "form the perception of mind" renders sems su 'du shes pa, meaning to conceive of it as a really existing mind.
- The passage breaks off mid-sentence in the Tibetan, as the main verb belongs to the continuation, so the final sentence is left open. The phrase "cut off the path, cut off entry, cut off conceptual elaboration" is rendered literally. It most likely refers to the Buddhas having severed the paths and entrances of saṃsāric rebirth and elaboration. I have supplied "considers" as the governing verb for the closing sentence from context, since the Tibetan has not yet reached it; this may change when the next passage supplies the actual verb. "Hearers" here is the Tibetan nyan thos, rendered per the house glossary as hearer (śrāvaka).
- The passage begins in the middle of a long sentence from the previous section, so the opening "from then until" continues the earlier span from the first generation of the mind of awakening. The translation of the Tibetan honorific question as "Venerable Subhūti may ask" is a supplied connective; the Tibetan simply poses the question ("how...?") in the flow of the text, and the speaker's address to Subhūti is implicit from the preceding passage.
- The passage breaks off mid-sentence, as the Tibetan continues the list of roots of virtue to be dedicated. The phrase "I" in the third nature-of-reality clause (ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་མཚན་པོ་) is probably a scribal error for "that" (ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་མཚན་པོ་), and is rendered as "just this." The phrase rendered "cut off the path, cut off entry..." follows the Tibetan literally, referring to the cutting off of the paths of rebirth.
- The Tibetan text is somewhat elliptical and the speaker changes without marking. I have supplied the exchange between Subhūti and the Blessed One (the question beginning "How does a bodhisattva..." and the answer beginning "Suppose the one who dedicates...") to keep the passage intelligible aloud. The Tibetan reads as continuous prose. "Volitional formation of merit" renders bsod nams mngon par 'du byed pa (puṇyābhisaṃskāra). The list of eight classes of beings has been normalized with standard Sanskrit names (gandharva, garuḍa, kinnara, mahoraga) for the Tibetan dri za, nam mkha' lding, mi 'am ci, and lto 'phyen chen po.

- [illegible]

- Subhūti's opening speech is rendered as a direct continuation of the question begun in the preceding passage. The repeated phrase "as liberation is, so is..." renders the Tibetan "rnam par grol ba ci lta ba de bzhin du," which equates each factor with the nature of liberation, that is, with its emptiness and unborn nature. I rendered it literally to keep that doctrinal force.
- The passage ends mid-sentence in the Tibetan, since the clause continues into the next passage; I have left the sentence open to match. The comparison is a long hypothetical whose main clause ("the merit of the bodhisattva who rejoices in this way is far greater") comes later, so the "suppose" clauses stay unresolved here. "Perception of objective support" renders dmigs pa'i 'du shes (Skt. upalambha-saṃjñā), meaning giving and discipline that still grasp at the three spheres of giver, recipient, and gift; the parenthetical gloss gives this in plain terms.
- The Tibetan opening is a continuation of the preceding sentence, so the passage begins mid-sentence as a list of what the bodhisattva rejoices in. The sentence about patience is elliptical and repetitive in the Tibetan, with the abbreviation marker "from... up to"; I have rendered it in a way that smooths the repetition while preserving its sense. The inconsistency of the "pride" (ཇོ་མོ་གློ་བུ་ལོ་ཤོ་མོ་) qualification is as in the source: patience practiced with pride and objective support is the flawed kind being contrasted with the wisdom-embraced rejoicing.
- The passage breaks off in mid-sentence, as is the case in the Tibetan text at this point, and the sentence continues in the following section. In the second paragraph I read the very large fractions as a series ascending toward ten-millionths. The final fraction in the Tibetan is awkward, and I rendered it literally as given. The phrase "a perception of objective support" renders the Tibetan idiom of apprehending an object, as in the preceding passage, to keep terminology consistent. The sentence about bodhisattvas "leaving aside" patience is a rhetorical setup, to be completed by the matching comparison in the next section.
- The opening phrase begins mid-sentence, continuing the list of aggregates from the preceding passage, so I rendered it as a continuation ("And also..."). The Tibetan text is somewhat repetitive, as is typical of the Perfection of Wisdom in Eight Thousand Lines. The epithets of the rejoicing (dam pa, gtso bo, rab, mchog rab, gya nom pa, and so on) are a conventional list, and some members are difficult to distinguish precisely; I have followed the standard sense of excellence and incomparability. The phrase "comparable only to the incomparable" renders a deliberately paradoxical pair (mi mnyam pa and mnyam pa) with "utterly without peer," following the sūtra's rhetorical intent. The sentence "Let that be as it may" renders the idiom lta zhog, meaning "never mind that case," since the sūtra proceeds to a still greater scenario.
- The honorific series at the opening reflects the standard Perfection of Wisdom litany. The renderings "without superior" and "higher even than the highest" follow the Tibetan sequence. The final numerical sequence uses the Tibetan's compounded counting terms, and I have rendered the largest as a hundred-thousand-times-a-billionth part to convey the escalating scale rather than a precise figure. The phrase "rejoicing that accompanies" the merit follows the technical phrasing of the sūtra. The five eyes are the physical eye, divine eye, wisdom eye, Dharma eye, and buddha eye.
- The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end; the sentence continues in the next section. In the first part, "own-characteristic" renders the Tibetan literally. The phrase "the habitual tendencies of the cognitive obscurations" follows the Tibetan, which pairs the afflictions with the imprints of the cognitive obscuration. "Dedicates to omniscience" follows the Tibetan; "caught up in objectifying" renders "those with a referent," meaning bodhisattvas who still apprehend objects.
- The verb གཏོད་པ་ (gtod pa) is rendered as "destroy," following the sense of the Sanskrit underlying this section (likely a form of "to crush/injure"), but the sense could be "to harm" or "to injure." The final line of the Blessed One's reply, "it destroys in the way that it does not

destroy," is the paradoxical sense of the Tibetan; the point is that the Perfection of Wisdom neither objectifies nor harms phenomena, since they are by nature unfindable. The opening sentence is a continuation of the preceding passage, in which Śāriputra enumerates the merit of the other perfections as overpowered by the merit of meditative concentration; the phrase "on this basis" renders བཤོམ་པའི་ཀློང་ལས་, and the logic is that the question concerns what outshines even these.

- The opening sentence is Śakra's continuing speech, following the preceding "Śakra said:". The verb pair "distant" and "gather / amass" (འཇོག་པ་དང་འཇོག་པ་ལས་འཇོག་པ་) is rendered literally; the Tibetan is terse and the idea is that conceiving of the perfection as an object to be accumulated alienates one from it. Likewise "fully illumined" renders འཇོག་པ་དང་འཇོག་པ་ལས་འཇོག་པ་, and the second "gathering" pair (འཇོག་པ་, འཇོག་པ་) is rendered as "gather together" and "scatter." The phrase "this very focusing upon beings becomes for him a great object of fixation" takes འཇོག་པ་ as "object of focus/fixation," in the sense of objectifying.
- The sentence about "beings accomplish the powers perfectly" follows the Tibetan as given; the parallel logic (beings, therefore the Tathāgata's powers) is abrupt in the text itself. The phrase "in a single-minded way" renders འཇོག་པ་, with འཇོག་པ་ལས་འཇོག་པ་ taken as keeping discipline, in line with the Tibetan's own wording. The Tibetan "འཇོག་པ་" is rendered "venerable." The final question breaks off at the passage boundary and may be continued in the next section.
- The Tibetan opens mid-question with no explicit speaker; it continues Subhūti's question from the preceding passage, so I have rendered it as the content of that question. The term "grounds" renders rnam grangs, which here carries the sense of a basis or mode of explanation; "the faculties differ in degree" renders dbang po'i rim pa, literally a gradation of faculties. The phrase "deprived of the Dharma" renders chos kyis phongs pa, the standard expression for the karma of rejecting the Dharma.
- The very large number terms near the end (bye ba khrag khrig, etc.) follow the Tibetan's escalating numerical series; I have rendered them in a smooth progression, with the final term given as "hundreds of thousands of millions," since the Tibetan's last unit is a transliterated Sanskrit-style number of uncertain exact value. The phrase "beginners who are by nature without the fortune for it" renders the Tibetan's qualification of these persons as lacking the destiny or capacity for the Dharma.
- Near the end, the Tibetan has a statement that the Blessed One "showed" the body-size of such a person, which Śāriputra says here as a closing remark. The sentence is abrupt, probably because it leads into the next passage, where the size is described, so I have kept it as written. The phrase rendered "rejecters of the Dharma" corresponds to the standard Sanskrit notion of dharma-pratikṣepa, the rejection of the Dharma.
- The text is evidently corrupt or compressed in places. The opening phrase translated "leave aside the measure" (འཇོག་པ་ལས་འཇོག་པ་) is rendered according to the sense the argument requires, since the Buddha refuses to state the measure. The phrase "the manifold suffering that is spoken of" is also condensed in the Tibetan. In the description of the foolish people, the verb "go forth" (rab tu 'byung) is kept literally, and the point is that they are ordained within the well-taught teaching, which makes their rejection of the Perfection of Wisdom more grave. The repeated word "cast back" renders the verb "to throw back" (phyir bcil), used here in the sense of rejection and repudiation.
- The Tibetan here uses the verb འཇོག་པ་ / འཇོག་པ་ / འཇོག་པ་ in variant spellings; I have rendered all consistently as "cast back" or "reject," following the preceding passage. The phrase "former extreme" and "later extreme" renders the past and future limits (Skt. pūrvānta, aparānta); "present arising" renders འཇོག་པ་. The passage runs across a chapter boundary and a colophon, which are retained as in the source.
- The recurring phrase "འཇོག་པ་ལས་འཇོག་པ་" is rendered "not different, and not divided"; the

final verb is a corrupt or unusual reading, probably standing for "not separate, not cut apart," and the rendering follows the evident sense. The passage ends mid-exchange with Śāriputra's next statement, which continues in the following passage.

- [illegible]

- The two statements about "not apprehended" (*mi dmigs pa*) and "no apprehending" follow the standard Prajñāpāramitā idiom. "The self-arisen" renders *rang byung* and is probably Svayambhū-related wording, kept literal. The "fully discriminating knowledges" is the *pratisamvid* set.
- The final sentence of the piece breaks off mid-statement, and the next piece completes it. The word rendered "he" for the bodhisattva is a stylistic choice for the generic subject. The words rendered "engage in yogic practice" translate the verb "*rnal 'byor du byed pa*," meaning to devote oneself to practice.
- The piece ends mid-sentence, as the cut falls there; the sentence continues in the next piece. In the Tibetan the second paragraph's wording ("does not practice... thus does not abide") is a deliberate mirror of the first and has been kept as written. The words "Should it be taught" render a respectful Tibetan construction that is an implied question in context.
- The passage ends mid-question ("Why is that?"), and the answer follows in the next piece. The phrase "Even though ... face to face" renders "*mngon sum du ni lung ma bstan pa*", which I take as "not directly prophesied". The man in the first simile gives no thought to bandits (*chom po*), the dangers of the wilderness.
- The opening clause continues a sentence begun in the preceding piece, so the subject (the bodhisattvas, great beings, just described) is supplied by that context. The Tibetan "*mi rtog*" is rendered as "has no conceptual thought," following the ordinary sense of *rtog pa* as conceptualization. "*Spyad par gyur pa*" is rendered "one who has practiced," a title that the passage itself explains.
- The phrase "□□□□□□□□□□□□" is rendered "who have not lost their commitment"; *yi dam* here has the sense of a resolve or pledge, not a tutelary deity. "Mastered" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□, literally "thoroughly comprehends." The sentence about requests to be written is somewhat compressed in the Tibetan; it is taken as a future conditional request for the text to be copied.
- "Vartani" (□□□□□□, also written □□□□□□□□) is reconstructed tentatively from the Tibetan transliteration; the region is not securely identified. The phrase about the Dharma and Vinaya having reached "their essence and their last remnant" renders a difficult Tibetan expression (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) and is a best reading of it. The sentence on the sūtras appearing in the south, Vartani, and the north continues in the following piece.
- The passage ends mid-sentence, with the construction continuing in the next piece. The final sentence is rendered as a dangling clause to preserve this. The long numerical series of beings is rendered with approximate standard multiples; the Tibetan repeats the series as "many" of each unit, and the exact word-for-word values of the largest terms are conventional.
- The opening clause, which continues a sentence begun in the preceding piece, reads literally "from whom (the Tathāgatas) this Perfection of Wisdom will be heard extensively." I have taken it as a locative of the buddha fields, to link it with the following sentence. The grammar of the intermediate passage on bodhisattvas who "seek and find" is somewhat compressed in the Tibetan, and I have kept the structure faithfully rather than smoothing it. The sequence of large numbers (hundreds, thousands, hundreds of thousands, and so on) follows the Tibetan literally, with the final term, *khrag khrig*, rendered as "billions" in line with the standard Prajñāpāramitā enumeration.
- The phrase "□□□□□□□□□□□□" is rendered "inquisitive about the letters," meaning an excessive preoccupation with the written form; the sense is somewhat compressed and uncertain. The lines between the end of the tenth chapter and the beginning of the eleventh volume are colophon material and have been translated as they appear.
- The first sentence of the passage, "□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□" with "□□□□□□□□□□□□", is awkward in the Tibetan. I have rendered it as distraction through mutual awareness of one another, which

- The piece ends mid-sentence ("wherever the bodhisattva vehicle has not been taught"); the next piece completes it. In the elephant simile, "judged it to be like whatever he felt of it" renders the Tibetan "he judged it to be wherever there was light," which is awkward in the source; the sense is that he mistakes a part touched in the dark for the whole elephant.
- Rendered "Vaijayanta palace" for བཞིན་ཤར་པོ་ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་པོ་ (Skt. vaijayanta, Indra's palace). The "fortress ruler" (ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་པོ་) is a local or petty king, as the comparison continues in the next piece. The passage ends mid-sentence, as the piece is cut there.
- The piece ends mid-sentence, as it was cut there; the sentence continues in the next piece. In the Tibetan, the sentence "Subhūti, this too should be understood as the work of māra" translates literally; the later phrase about being "truly accomplished" renders a difficult clause, and it may also be read as "it is hard for bodhisattvas to be perfectly achieved."
- Viśikhā (bi shi khā) and Śivika (shi bi ka) are transliterated in the Tibetan and are reconstructed here. The Sanskrit tradition for this passage may differ; Viśikhā may mean a street or lane. The word translated "predators" (la gcan) is a rare term, and "those who instruct in everything" (kun tu ston pa) is rendered literally. The line about a priceless jewel versus a jewel of small value follows the standard sense of the passage.
- The phrase "ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་པོ་ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་པོ་" is obscure; I have rendered it as the spectacle of entertainers' performances, which is a tentative reading. "ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་པོ་ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་པོ་" in the gains passage is probably a slip for "ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་པོ་" or similar, and I have read it as the gains becoming an obstacle to him. The sentence breaks off at the end of the piece and continues in the next.
- The phrase ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་པོ་ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་པོ་ is rendered "has become an obstacle to the Dharma." The final sentence is somewhat elliptical in the Tibetan, and I have kept its sense without adding explanation. The repeated "lack of harmony" renders ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་པོ་ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་པོ་, literally "separated from the assembly" or "without the gathering of conditions," in the sense that the necessary conditions for teaching and hearing fail to come together.
- The phrase "not provided with a gathering" renders the Tibetan literally, and the nuance of "gathering" (tshogs pa, probably meaning a harmonious assembly or the coming together of favorable conditions) is uncertain. The quotation attributed to the Blessed One about rebirth ("not even as brief as a fingersnap") is an uncertain rendering of a difficult, apparently corrupt phrase in the Tibetan. The last clause of the speaker's address, about meeting ruin and suffering again, is also somewhat obscure in the Tibetan.
- The opening clause continues a sentence begun in the previous piece, where a person is distracted by thoughts of household business. The Tibetan for "newly set out" and the repeated phrase about being "made to doubt" are rendered closely. The sentence beginning "Rather, only what is included within my sūtras" is a Māra-quoted claim; the Tibetan is somewhat elliptical here, and the sense given is the standard reading of the Prajñāpāramitā text.
- The final clause of the text just before this piece is completed here by the opening sentence, whose subject is the newly set out, weak-minded bodhisattvas who fall into doubt. The phrase "realizing the true limit" renders the Tibetan for Skt. bhūtaṅkoṭi, the Māra-figure's claim being that the bodhisattva will fall into the śrāvaka's cessation. "Vehicle" here is the Great Vehicle.
- The passage runs from the end of chapter 11 into the beginning of chapter 12, with the colophon and volume heading rendered as they stand. The opening "dgra" in the Tibetan appears to be a damaged or unusual reading (possibly "they" with a corrupt particle); I took the sense as "in that way." In the mother simile the humoral and affliction terms are rendered conventionally.
- The word translated here as "indestructible" (mi 'jig) plays on 'jig rten, "world," which the tradition glosses as that which is perishable (the Sanskrit loka). The passage says the

aggregates are called the world because their emptiness cannot be destroyed. The phrase "without any real entity" renders *dnegos po med pa*, the absence of any substantial thing in sentient beings.

- The passage turns on a series of paired terms for states of mind: contracted (*bsdus pa*, Skt. *saṃkṣipta*), distracted (*gyengs pa*, Skt. *vikṣipta*), and afflicted (*kun nas nyon mongs par gyur pa*, Skt. *saṃkliṣṭa*). The sentence "that contracted mind, together with its contraction, is exhausted" is rendered literally. The Tibetan "*de bsdus pa dang bcas pa*" is somewhat elliptical, and the sense follows the usual Perfection of Wisdom point that exhaustion and its inexhaustibility are not different. The piece ends with a question whose answer begins in the next piece.

- Both the verb "to be afflicted" and the noun "affliction" here render the same Tibetan root (*nyon mongs*), so the opening sentence is deliberately repetitive; "defilement" in the final section renders *zag pa* (*āsrava*), which is distinct from affliction. The passage is part of the long Perfection of Wisdom enumeration of the Tathāgata's knowledge of minds, and each section follows the same question-and-answer pattern.

- The phrase "*dnegos po med par gzol ba lhun gyis grub pa*" is rendered closely as "inclined toward the absence of real entities, and this is spontaneously accomplished"; the syntax of the original is terse and the sense is somewhat compressed. In the sentence about freedom from attachment, the Tibetan has "the freedom (*bral ba*) of the mind is not the mind's being with attachment"; I have kept this literal reading.

- The sentence "the freedom of the mind is not a state of having aversion" follows the Tibetan literally. In the aversion passage the final line as transmitted reads "freed from aversion" where the parallel would suggest "that has aversion"; I have kept the logic of the parallel with the delusion passage. The last sentence is the start of a new series (on the "expansive" or "vast" mind), which continues in the next piece.

- The terms for "vast" (*rgya chen po*) and "exalted" (*sems chen po*, literally "great mind") correspond to the standard sequence of mind-types in the Perfection of Wisdom. The Tibetan text itself says "became exalted" (*chen por gyur pa*); "exalted" is used here for readability. The sentence "because minds are never separated from their nature" renders a somewhat compressed Tibetan clause, "*sems rnam bral ba med pa'i phyir*", and the sense given follows the context of non-separation.

- The final sentence of the piece contains the question but no stated answer in the Tibetan; the passage ends there and the answer is not supplied in this piece, so I have rendered it as it stands without adding anything. "The three eyes" (*spyang gsum*) is rendered literally; the sense of the phrase "or all of them" is somewhat compressed in the Tibetan.

- The terms *sems bla na yod pa* and *sems bla na med pa* (literally "having something higher" and "having nothing higher") are rendered "surpassable" and "unsurpassable," following the standard Prajñāpāramitā usage (Skt. *sauttara* and *anuttara citta*). The passage contains a duplicated sentence on the surpassable mind, as in the Tibetan. "Concentrated" and "unconcentrated" render the terms for being placed or not placed in meditative equipoise (*saṃāhita* and *asaṃāhita*).

- The terms བཟུང་པ་ and བཟུང་པ་མེད་པ་, "open" and "closed," are rendered literally. The Tibetan is somewhat ambiguous, and this passage seems to correspond to the Sanskrit sequence of "contracted" and "distracted" (*saṃkṣipta*, *vikṣipta*) minds. The literal rendering has been kept, and the sequel continues the list through the aggregates.

- The phrase "open mind" and "closed mind" renders *phyee ba* and *btsum pa*, literally "opened" and "closed"; in this sūtra it refers to minds that are expansive or distracted versus contracted. The sense is rendered in the standard way. The passage restates the traditional fourfold undetermined questions, concerning the Tathāgata after death and the self and world being permanent or having an end, as views that rest upon the aggregates. The colophon-like line

between the passage's two halves marks the division between fascicles twelve and thirteen in the Tibetan text and is rendered as a transition.

- The first sentence ("have no end") departs from the preceding context, which reads "with an end." This is evidently the second of the four standard positions, and I follow the text as given. "Open and closed minds" renders a pair meaning distracted or expansive and contracted or withdrawn states of mind (Skt. vikṣipta and saṃkṣipta). The phrase "designates, within suchness" follows the Tibetan literally; it expresses that the Tathāgata applies these labels to a single suchness.
- The passage ends mid-sentence, as the piece is cut here; the sense continues in the next piece. The phrase "paint it in images" renders a verb of depicting or portraying, and may be read as making representations of the Dharma.
- The phrase "knows what has been done for him and feels gratitude for it" renders the standard idiom for gratitude (Skt. kṛtajña, kṛtavedin), with the Tibetan taking "what has been done" as the benefit received. "Not constructed by any conditioning activity" renders the Tibetan for "not fully constructed" (Skt. anabhisaṃskṛta).
- The chapter title in the Tibetan is "Truly Showing the World" (jig rten yang dag par ston pa). The final lines of the passage lead directly into the Buddha's next explanation, which falls in the following piece. The last phrase of the Buddha's reply, "a deed equal to the unequalled" (mi mnyam pa dang mnyam pa), could also be read as "unequal and equal", but I have followed the parallel sense of "equal to the unequalled."
- The term rang byung (self-arisen) is rendered as "self-arisen nature," following the standard sense of svayambhū in this sūtra's list of buddha-qualities. The phrase "unequal and equal" renders mi mnyam pa dang mnyam pa, the sūtra's paradoxical formulation (asamasama); the sense is "peerless, equal only to the unequalled." The final sentence continues into the next piece.
- The phrase "the Dharma that has become consciousness" renders a difficult clause (rnam par shes par gyur pa'i chos); the sense may be a designation of what has become known or cognized. The word rendered "equality" and "comparison" (mnyam pa, snyom pa) is used in a deliberately plural sense in this passage, and the repeated "unequal and equal" is a paradox of the text, not a scribal error. The tshad ma here means "measure," not "valid cognition."
- The phrase rang byang chub, "self-arisen awakening," is rendered literally here. Context suggests the awakening of the solitary buddhas. The sūtra's earlier phrase "this very Fortunate Eon" refers to the Bhadrakalpa, the present eon.
- The final colophon line is rendered as part of the text, since it appears in the Tibetan. The phrase "stage of those who follow through faith" renders the Tibetan "dad pa'i rjes su 'brang ba'i sa" (Skt. śradhdhānusārin-bhūmi). Subhūti's reply in the first line answers the Blessed One's closing question in the preceding piece.
- The piece breaks off mid-sentence; the following piece continues the thought. The phrase "takes delight just in looking at it" renders a difficult expression (འདྲི་བརྟན་སྤྱོད་ཀྱི་སྒྲོམ་པ་), which I took as "delight upon merely seeing it." The sense of "འདྲི་བརྟན་" in "taken up in his body" is uncertain; I took it as bodily retention or memorization, parallel with the written book.
- The passage contains a volume colophon ("the fourteenth volume") in the middle of the text, which I have rendered as it stands. The sentences about the bodhisattva's loss of "his own great aim" and "the great aim of others" follow the Tibetan's own repetitive phrasing.
- The passage ends mid-sentence, since the sentence is completed in the next piece. The list of qualities is a series of near-synonyms (dad pa, bzod pa, sred pa, 'dun pa, etc.). The renderings follow the sense of the standard sequence, and several terms, such as sred pa ("longing"), are positive here, not the afflictive "craving." Ma 'bral bar gyur pa and the "embraced" (yongs su bzung) construction are kept literal for doctrinal clarity.
- The passage includes the colophon of the fourteenth chapter, rendered as it stands in the

source, followed by the opening of the next chapter. The Tibetan for the aged man's illness lists wind, bile, phlegm and their combination, the standard humoral categories of Tibetan medicine. The lines before this passage speak of a bodhisattva who does have the Perfection of Wisdom, so the opening of this piece begins the contrasting case and refers back to such a bodhisattva.

- The sentence about not taking pride in awakening "as form" and so on is repeated in the Tibetan, once after the instruction on generosity and once after the other perfections, and is rendered as it stands. The Tibetan has a minor irregularity in the first occurrence, "awakening as form" without the particle that appears in the second; the sense is the same.
- The Tibetan sequence of epithets here (protector, refuge, resting place, ally) corresponds to the Sanskrit series *trāṇa*, *śaraṇa*, *parāyaṇa*, and so on. I have rendered the Tibetan *gnas* as "resting place." The terms for engagement and connection (*sbyor ba* and *'brel ba*) are rendered "engagement" and "connection" consistently, and the Tibetan itself shows slight variation in the repeated formulas, which I have followed as written.
- The phrase "become a protector for the world" is my rendering of the Tibetan "dpung gnyen," a literal "ally" or "support"; the Sanskrit probably corresponds to "*trāṇa*" or a similar term. The Tibetan མཁའ་ཁྲིའི་ཁྲིའི་ཁྲིའི་ in the island passage is rendered "cut off," in the sense of the complete severance of limits, not as nihilist annihilation.
- The Tibetan has three related phrases: "light of the world" ('jig rten gyi snang ba), "guide of the world" ('jig rten gyi yongs su 'dren pa), and "support of the world" ('jig rten gyi rten). I rendered the middle one as "guide" in keeping with the verb 'dren pa. The term rendered "non-occurrence" is 'byung ba med pa; "non-fabrication" renders mngon par 'du mi byed pa.
- The phrase "arisen from the Vinaya" renders མཁའ་ཁྲིའི་ཁྲིའི་ཁྲིའི་, which could also be read as "arisen from taming" or "from discipline" in a general sense. The rendering "the unextractable" for མཁའ་ཁྲིའི་ཁྲིའི་ཁྲིའི་ is literal. The Sanskrit probably has an equivalent of "without removal" or "inexpressible," and the sense is uncertain. "Boundless" renders མཁའ་ཁྲིའི་ཁྲིའི་, literally "without limit."
- Most of the sūtra's honorific and humble verb forms are rendered in plain English. In the sentence beginning "Subhūti, what purpose do you see," the text reads sangs rgyas kyis nyid la re bar bya'o. I render it "should hope for buddhahood itself," taking the sentence as the Buddha's contrast with the stages of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.
- The term rendered "mental continuum" (rgyud) is also "continuum" in the Blessed One's replies; it carries the sense of a stream of mind directed toward its aim. The repeated "rnam par shes pa" appears twice in the list of negations (once as consciousness among the aggregates, once after wisdom); I kept both as in the Tibetan. The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, continuing in the next piece.
- The Tibetan "mi mjed kyi bdag po" is the standard rendering of Sahāṃpati, Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world; I supplied "Sahā world" for the listener's benefit. The final sentence, with its triple negation of anyone ever awakening, is rendered closely; it expresses that awakening is ultimately without any awakener or awakened.
- The Tibetan renders Brahmā as "lord of the unendurable (world)," which corresponds to Sahāṃpati, lord of the Sahā world. The phrase "Dharma that I have fully awakened to" is spoken by the Buddha. The chapter title and colophon are translated as they stand in the source, and the next volume begins at the break.
- The phrase "gang gi yang de bzhin nyid ma yin pa" is read as "not the suchness of anything" in the first sentences, and "gang du yang... gang las kyang... gang gi yang" as "located in, arising from, belonging to anything" in the nondual passage; the sense is that suchness is not a property of a distinct thing. "Manifested" renders "mngon par sprul pa" (abhinirmīta).
- The passage is the Perfection of Wisdom's teaching that suchness is non-dual and untouched by time; the phrase "born after the Tathāgata" renders the Tibetan "following along with" (rjes

su skye ba), which plays on the Tathāgata's own name, "thus-gone." The speaker of the sentence beginning "Blessed One" is presumably a participant addressing the Buddha; the source does not name him, so I have not supplied a name.

- The opening sentence is very compressed and its syntax is ambiguous; I have rendered it as literally as clarity allows. The passage breaks off at the end of the bird simile, and the application of the simile to the bodhisattvas follows in the next piece.
- The Tibetan "mi mjed kyi bdag po" is rendered as "lord of the Sahā world" (Sahāṃpati), the standard epithet of Brahmā, and glossed on first use. The passage on "hearing the sound 'emptiness'" is rendered literally, in line with the traditional reading that clinging to the word as a sign is itself the error.
- The Tibetan "mi mjed kyi bdag po" is rendered "lord of the world of endurance" (Skt. Sahāṃpati), the usual epithet of Brahmā. In the Tibetan, "yang dag pa ma yin pa" ("not truly real") renders a Sanskrit term often translated "unreal" or "not actual." Here it is read as saying that awakening has no real, substantial existence that could be found, which is the basis of its being hard to come by.
- The expression "ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་འཕྲིན་ལྗོངས་ཀྱི་འཕྲིན་ལྗོངས་" is rendered "turn back," and "ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་འཕྲིན་ལྗོངས་ཀྱི་འཕྲིན་ལྗོངས་" as "irreversible" (Skt. avavartika). The Tibetan "ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་འཕྲིན་ལྗོངས་ཀྱི་འཕྲིན་ལྗོངས་" ("truly something that could come about") is rendered as a conditional of real arising; the sense is that if awakening were an actual, inherently existing thing, irreversibility would be universal.
- This piece ends mid-exchange; Śāriputra's reply, and the parallel question about the other four aggregates, follow in the next piece. The Tibetan text has the small variant spelling of "feeling" (ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་འཕྲིན་ལྗོངས་) in a couple of places, rendered uniformly as "feeling."
- Subhūti's long question about "abiding in the manner of not abiding" and "the phenomenon that has become suchness" is dense. I have kept its sequence of clauses as they stand in the Tibetan. "The three kinds of persons belonging to the vehicle of the bodhisattvas" is a literal rendering of the Tibetan; the sense is the three vehicles, which Śāriputra then reduces to one. Pūrṇa, son of Maitrāyaṇī, is the standard identification of the Tibetan "Byams ma'i bu Gang po."
- The phrase "bden pa nyid dang gnas pa nyid" is rendered "true reality and the abiding nature." The word "འདྲིམ་པ་" is rendered "enmity" in the sense of hostility or ill will; the exact nuance is slightly uncertain. The repeated "by the power of the Tathāgata" follows the standard Prajñāpāramitā formula.
- The phrase "from the truths up to the bodhisattva's entry into the state beyond fault" is a compressed abbreviation in the Tibetan (bden pa nas ... bar), standing for a longer list of items. I have rendered it as it stands, without supplying the omitted list.
- The Tibetan text breaks off mid-sentence at the end of this piece. The words of Māra's speech, "have been born in these eight great hells," are left open for the next piece to complete, and the closing quotation mark is deliberately omitted.

The Tibetan "ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་འཕྲིན་ལྗོངས་ཀྱི་འཕྲིན་ལྗོངས་" is rendered "do not wear out," and "ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་འཕྲིན་ལྗོངས་ཀྱི་འཕྲིན་ལྗོངས་" as "without pretense," following the usual sense of these stock phrases.

- The phrase "will not be placed in the keeping of others" renders an idiom (gzhan gyi dring la mi 'jog pa) whose sense is that he will not be left or handed over to the guidance of another. The volume colophon is included as it stands in the source, followed by the opening of the next volume.
- The opening "mother" (ma) is a vocative address by the speaker, the disguised Māra, in a scene begun in the preceding piece; I kept it as a plain vocative. "Defilements exhausted" renders the standard epithet of arhats (zag pa zad pa), and "nature of reality" renders chos nyid. Otherwise none.
- The long list of epithets for "persons" (purusha-epithets) is rendered fairly literally. Terms such as "best of the herd" (འཕྲིན་ལྗོངས་ཀྱི་འཕྲིན་ལྗོངས་) and "turn the reins of those to be trained"

(འོད་གསལ་རྒྱ་མིང་། རྩིས་བློན་པོ་) are standard Perfection of Wisdom idioms. The sentence about "the supreme of bliss" is rendered closely to the Tibetan; the syntax is compressed in the source.

- The sentence "Rather, they dwell..." renders a clause beginning gzhan du na, which I have read as a contrast with the preceding list. The fused final lines of the source appear to repeat the earlier phrase "do not dwell in strenuous application" for talk about quarrels, as in the Tibetan. The terms sbyor ba and rjes su sbyor ba are rendered "practice" and "continued practice." The Tibetan "lus srul po" is rendered "crawling ghouls," following the usual gloss for this class of spirits.
- The piece ends mid-sentence; the thought continues in the next piece. The "deed of immediate retribution" (mtshams med pa) is one of the five heinous deeds that bring immediate karmic result.
- The passage's opening clauses are cut at the start of the piece, so the first sentence continues from the preceding context. The phrase "unplundered" renders mi 'phrogs pa, meaning that the mind cannot be seized or carried off by Māra.
- The final sentence ends the piece in mid-sentence; the verb "sbyod de" ("would still go on practicing") is awkward, and the sense is likely completed in the next piece. The renderings "set forth" and "go on practicing" are tentative. The phrase "he has no regret" renders nem nur, which can also mean "remorse" or "worry."
- The passage has no cut mid-sentence of consequence, but it ends mid-simile; the sentence about the woman, held by another, continues in the next piece. The rendering of "skillful means" (thabs zhib mo, "subtle method") follows Subhūti's wonder at the Buddha's teaching of turning away from the aggregates while still showing nirvāṇa. The terms "unconditioned" (mngon par 'du mi byed pa) and "wishless" (smon pa med pa) follow the standard Prajñāpāramitā lists.
- The passage breaks off in mid-sentence, as the source does. The Tibetan "gdugs" in "gdugs das kyi bar du" appears to be a corruption of "nyi ma" (day), so I rendered it as "until the day has passed." The first sentence's opening lines depend on the preceding context of a man tied to a woman who belongs to another.
- The sentence "this manifest composing is conceptual construction" renders mngon par 'dus byas pa and rnam par rtog pa. The final four phrases are rendered literally: ston pa as "something shown," gsoq as "accumulated," gso ba as "nourished," snying po med pa as "without essence." The rendering of ston pa, however, is not fully certain.
- Where the text says "the establishing of the teaching" (bstan pa mngon par bsgrub pa), the sense is uncertain: it could also mean "the accomplishing of what is taught." The Tibetan's "synonym" (tshig bla dwags) is rendered as "synonym" throughout. "Wishless" renders smon pa med pa (Skt. apraṇihita).
- The piece ends mid-sentence, where the sentence continues in the next piece. In the first Subhūti passage, the phrase "as I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has said" renders the Tibetan literally; the sense is that Subhūti affirms the Buddha's teaching in his own understanding.
- The Tibetan alternates between "he" and "that one" for the bodhisattva; I have kept "he" throughout. The phrase "just as awakening truly is" renders the Tibetan formula that dedication is made in accord with the actual nature of awakening, that is, without reifying it.
- The passage has a sectional colophon (the end of the eighteenth chapter and of the seventeenth volume) followed by the opening of the next chapter's discussion. I translated the colophon as it stands, since it is in the Tibetan. In the final sentence the Tibetan is slightly elliptical ("it is not by those arisings of the mind, nor by anything other than those"); I have filled out the sense in line with the preceding sentences. The text is cut mid-sentence at the end of this piece; the sense is complete as translated.

- The phrase at the end of the Blessed One's question about suchness abiding "not permanently fixed" renders མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་, "not permanent, not fixed"; the sense in context is that suchness, though said to "abide," is not an abiding entity. The opening line is the end of a sentence begun in the preceding piece, and the final sentence of the preceding piece continues into it.
- Piece ends mid-sentence with Subhūti beginning his reply; the answer follows in the next piece. The phrase "མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་" is rendered "engagements/engaging" in the Subhūti reply; its sense is somewhat compressed in the Tibetan. "མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་" is rendered "without conceptual distinction."
- The last sentence of the passage (the Tibetan breaks off at "if he is present") is cut where the piece ends; the following piece continues the answer, in which Subhūti directs Śāriputra to ask Maitreya. I have rendered it as given. "Perception that exhaustion" in the Buddha question follows the Tibetan "zad pa'i 'du shes" as written, though the reading may be a variant of "perception of killing" in other witnesses.
- Maitreya's epithet "Invincible One" renders the Tibetan "mi pham pa," here in the form ma pham pa, a standard epithet of Maitreya (Ajita). The passage ends mid-sentence with the Blessed One's speech, which continues in the next piece.
- The expression "མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་" is a standard Prajñāpāramitā intensive negation and is rendered with the repeated "never, in any way, anywhere." The Tibetan "མཐོན་པོ་" is taken as the Dharma (the practice or phenomenon in question) being prophesied, as the sense of the passage is that the bodhisattva does not cling to the idea of such a prophecy.
- The passage ends mid-speech; Ānanda's question about the cause of the smile continues in the next piece. The woman is called Gaṅgādevī (the river goddess Gaṅgā), which I have rendered as "goddess Gaṅgā."
- Ānanda addresses the Buddha in the opening sentence, asking why the Buddha smiled; the piece begins in mid-speech. Akṣobhya's field Abhirati is rendered by its Sanskrit name with a gloss. The final sentence continues into the next piece.
- The Tibetan has a lacuna-like elision in the Buddha's speech where Dīpaṃkara's scattering is described; I followed the Tibetan wording, including the "five stalks of lotus" (utpala), which is a standard detail of the Dīpaṃkara story. In the Tibetan, the buddha's name, Golden Flower, is rendered into Sanskrit as Suvarṇapuṣpa, and the goddess's name, the River Ganges goddess, as Gaṅgādevī. "Sister" is the Buddha's own mode of address for her.
- Following the Tibetan, I translated "མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་" as "true limit," matching the term already used earlier, and "མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་" as "that true limit." The phrase "མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་" is rendered "unites himself with them through the supreme of loving-kindness." The sentence "མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་" is rendered "abides by abiding in emptiness."
- The Tibetan has the colophon, "the eighteenth volume," and the first line of the next volume inside the passage. I translated the colophon as it stands, though it may be dropped for narration. The final clause "he should set his mind thus" is cut off at the end of the piece and continues in the next.
- The passage is cut off mid-sentence and continues in the next piece. In the third paragraph the Tibetan has "concentration of the door of liberation of emptiness" (the first of the three doors), matching the pattern of the paragraph; I have kept it as written, although the corresponding section of the sequence might be expected to treat another door.
- The phrase "མཐོན་པོ་མཐོན་པོ་" is rendered "perception of wholes" in the sense of apprehending things as unanalyzed, solid totalities. The sentence about "not falling into non-conditioning" is as the text has it; the commentarial reading is that the bodhisattva does

not fall into the extreme of cessation. The opening wish is addressed in the first person as the bodhisattva's own thought, continuing from the preceding piece.

- Following the standard Perfection of Wisdom usage, the repeated phrase translated "bring into direct experience" renders a verb meaning to actualize, make manifest, or realize before oneself, and the context concerns not "realizing" the three doors of liberation prematurely in a way that abandons beings. The word "ground" for the final stage-related terms (ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་) is used in the sense of the bodhisattva grounds; "stage" is a possible alternative.
- The phrase rendered "light fills a fathom's breadth" follows the Tibetan "od 'dom gang bar"; the passage elsewhere describes the body's radiance of a fathom, and the syntax here is compressed. The "billions" (khrag khrig) is a very large number in the Indian numerical series; the exact value is unspecified.
- The sentence about "karma that accords with rising up in this very life" (mthong ba'i chos la 'byung bar 'gyur ba dang rjes su mthun pa) is difficult and may be corrupt or elliptical; the rendering here follows the Tibetan literally. The "remainder" (lhag ma dang bcas pa) suggests a karmic result that persists beyond the immediate ripening.
- The passage contains a chapter colophon in the Tibetan itself, "Practice in Skillful Means," as the twentieth chapter, followed by the opening of the next chapter. The repeated verbs of departing and not departing follow the Tibetan. The final line of the passage is an incomplete sentence (the question "Why is that?") whose answer begins the next piece.
- The passage continues mid-sentence into the next piece, where the list of names goes on. "Non-human" renders mi ma yin pa, a spirit, as in the preceding context. The Tibetan says "through the blessing of that truth" (bden pa'i byin gyi rlabs); I kept it literal.
- The sentence at the end is cut off at the piece boundary and continues in the next piece. The list of ascetic practices follows the standard dhūtaṅga categories as rendered by the Tibetan; a few terms are rendered by sense, for example the one who keeps to the seat as laid out and the one who wears felt.
- The piece ends mid-sentence; the sense continues in the following passage. The phrase "those of Māra's following" renders a Tibetan expression of somewhat uncertain wording (bdud kyi ris kyi lta dag), taken here as a reference to Māra's retinue.
- The passage speaks of the "four root downfalls" and the "five acts of immediate retribution" without listing them; they are the standard pārājikas of the Vinaya and the five ānantarya crimes. The "naming" (mtshan bstan / ming bstan) refers to declaring or predicting a bodhisattva's name; I have kept the text's sense that the contempt arises on the occasion of such naming.
- The terms gdol pa, sun 'byin pa, gzugs brnyan, bcos bu, and sre dar are rendered by context as "outcaste," "refuter," "reflection," "counterfeit," and "sprout gone to waste." The last, sre dar, is the least certain; it may also be read as "blighted sprout" or "weed."
- The phrase "a quality of seclusion that has gone astray" renders a difficult clause, literally "through the quality of seclusion, a work of Māra"; I have taken it as a warning about misdirected solitude. The remark about overcoming others "through their own direct knowledge" is also compressed in the Tibetan and is rendered closely.
- The Tibetan has "dpung gnyen" for "ally"; this probably renders a Sanskrit term for a supporting companion or defender. The sequence of epithets is formulaic. In the sentence about the wisdom "that is unequal and equal," the Tibetan reads mi mnyam pa dang mnyam pa'i ye shes, translated literally.
- The phrase "go without relying on others" renders a stock expression whose literal sense is "not placing the neck (burden) on another," meaning independence from others' guidance. "Secluded" renders dben pa (Skt. viveka), which can also mean "solitary" or "isolated."
- The final sentence of the passage lists four states of the fully awakened: buddhahood, Tathāgata-hood, self-arisen-ness (rang 'byung), and omniscience. I have rendered rang 'byung

nyid as "the state of the self-arisen one," following the Sanskrit svayambhū. The sentence "it is just as there is no grasping and no clinging that one does not know grasping at 'I' and 'mine' at all" renders a compressed Tibetan clause literally; it means that in the absence of grasping, "I" and "mine" are not known as real. Where the Tibetan has the negated verb "practice in form" (gzugs la mi spyod), I have kept the literal "does not practice in form," as in the Perfection of Wisdom idiom.

- The first sentence is a continuation from the previous piece, where Subhūti is speaking; I have kept it in his voice without a label. The Tibetan shows variant spellings (for example "rang byung" and "rang 'byung" for the self-arisen state); both are rendered the same. The final sentences about the Tathāgata's incomparability are given as a reason for the preceding statement about loving-kindness, following the repeated "why is that" structure.

- The piece begins mid-simile, after the man has lost his jewel. The sentence about the bodhisattva who has "fallen away" from the Perfection of Wisdom is compressed in the Tibetan; I have kept its parallel with the man who has lost the jewel and still perceives it as precious. The Tibetan "ཀློང་ལྷན་པོ་ལྟར་ལྟར་" is rendered "attention" (Skt. manasikāra) throughout.

- The passage ends mid-exchange with the Blessed One about to speak, as the cut falls there. In the Tibetan, the question "does X practice the Perfection of Wisdom" uses the same verb throughout, and I kept it uniform. The last question of the Buddha is rendered with its tense series (has arisen, is arising, will arise, and so on) as the Tibetan lists them.

- The phrase "caravan leader" renders the epithet "great leader of the caravan" (dped dpon chen po), the Buddha as guide of beings. In the last sentence the Tibetan reads "ngan ngon gyi dge ba'i rtsa ba," rendered "inferior root of virtue"; the line is the beginning of a statement continued in the next piece, where the Blessed One's confirmation completes it.

- The Tibetan has the passage on the bowls with the odd phrase "do not be slow" rendered here from "la gor slob shig"; the sense of urging haste is clear from context. The four alms bowls are the bowls offered by the Four Great Kings to the Buddha at his awakening, a well-known episode. The volume and chapter headings are translated as they stand in the text.

- The passage ends mid-thought; the next piece continues the thought of the bodhisattva who believes he has found a companion who fulfills his wishes. "Spu zing" is rendered literally as "struck with terror" (lit. causing the hair to stand on end), following the earlier usage in this text.

- The final quoted sentence is cut off at the end of the piece and continues in the next piece; I have left it open as in the Tibetan. "Put on the armor" renders the idiom of donning the armor of bodhisattva practice, here meaning to undergo the long course of practice again for as many eons as the thoughts of awakening.

- The opening line continues a speech begun in the previous piece, where the bodhisattva reflects in the first person. The phrase "swiftly awaken" translates the standard formula for complete buddhahood. "Training in exhaustion" (zad pa) is left literal; the next piece elaborates it as the exhaustion of phenomena.

- The "caste of bamboo workers" renders the Tibetan "bya ba'i rigs," a standard rendering of a low-caste occupational group; the exact Sanskrit referent is uncertain. "Realm of the deathless" renders the "nectar" (amṛta) realm, a common figure for nirvāṇa.

- The terms for the faults in the list of nine are rendered by the most natural senses: crookedness (ལྟོག་པོ་), doubt, envy, miserliness, immoral conduct, malice, laziness, distraction, and confused wisdom. The phrase "practice in accordance with suchness" renders a clause whose exact sense is slightly uncertain, but it is not significantly in doubt. The piece ends mid-sentence with a simile whose content follows in the next passage.

- The sixty-two views are the standard list of wrong views, here said to be contained within the view of the perishable aggregates (satkāyadṛṣṭi). The Tibetan "ཀློང་ལྷན་པོ་" ("supreme leader of the herd") is rendered literally; it corresponds to the Sanskrit image of the bull or leader of the

herd as an epithet of a buddha.

- The text ends the twenty-fifth chapter in the middle of the colophon and begins a new volume and chapter with Śakra's thought. The phrase "the excellences of the śrāvakas" renders *phun sum tshogs pa*, meaning accomplishments or perfections. The passage on "those who need no further training" refers to arhats; the sense is that the bodhisattva does not train in the thought of dwelling in such excellences.
- The phrase "those excellent beings" at the start follows the Tibetan "sems can dam pa," which refers back to the preceding statement about beings who will fully awaken. The sentence "wishing for the sake of great compassion" is rendered as the Tibetan stands; the sense is that such bodhisattvas are moved by great compassion. The phrase "bound to only one more birth" renders the traditional category of a bodhisattva who is one birth away from buddhahood.
- The sentence "should be known as blessed, that is, possessed, by Māra" renders a phrase that literally says "empowered by Māra" (the Tibetan uses the word for blessing or empowerment in a negative sense, meaning they are under Māra's influence). The text breaks off at the end with Śakra about to speak; his words belong to the next piece. The phrase "the fourth great continent" is as in the Tibetan, continuing an enumeration of world-systems begun earlier.
- The passage ends mid-exchange, with Subhūti's reply beginning in the next piece. The Tibetan "bskyed pa" in "sems bskyed pa" is rendered "generation of the awakening mind," following the context.
- The final sentence is syntactically compressed in the Tibetan; I have kept the sense that not realizing the profound meaning at the śrāvaka or pratyekabuddha stage, while practicing in it, is the difficult deed. The qualifier "the Perfection of Wisdom, utterly secluded" renders *shin tu dben pa*, which can also be read as "utterly isolated" or "empty."
- The Tibetan ends with the introduction to Subhūti's reply. The reply itself, that practicing the Perfection of Wisdom is practicing in what is not the essence, appears in the following passage.
- The statement that bodhisattvas who do not directly realize the true limit "are not doing what is difficult" is taken as Subhūti's deliberate reframing: the truly difficult thing is vowing to liberate beings who ultimately do not exist.
- The Tibetan lists of Brahmā-realm gods give the standard Tibetan names of the Sanskrit heavens, rendered here by their usual English equivalents. "Priests of Brahmā" renders the god named "Facing Brahmā" (Brahmapurohita). The names of the Brahmā-world gods are given in the usual English forms of the Tibetan; the identifications are not fully certain in every case. "Prajāpati" renders the Tibetan "Lord of Beings" (*skye dgu'i bdag po*) and "Īśāna" renders *dbang ldan*, as in the glossary.
- The phrase "gnas pa'i gnas pa" in the gods' speech is rendered as "abiding of the Perfection of Wisdom," following the repeated "gnas" and "abide" structure; the wording is slightly redundant in the Tibetan. The words "ldongs pa" are rendered "blind," with "light" for "snang ba," in keeping with the stock series of epithets.
- Ratnaketu and Śikhin render the Tibetan names "Jewel Crest" and "Topknot-bearer"; these are the standard Sanskrit equivalents of the bodhisattva names in this sūtra. The final question, "And who are they?", leads directly into the next piece. "Qualities of inherent nature" renders a somewhat awkward Tibetan phrase and is kept close to the source.
- Ratnaketu (འཕགས་པའི་འཕགས་པ་) is a standard Prajñāpāramitā reference to the tathāgata of that name. The text reads as a bodhisattva "Ratnaketu", but the Tibetan matches the preceding "Tathāgata" pattern, so this is likely a Tathāgata. I have kept it as the Tibetan states.
- Near the end, the final clause before the Tathāgata exception, "whatever is not that," is a slightly awkward Tibetan phrase; I have kept it as it stands. In the passage on comparison, I read the series of numerical fractions as the standard ascending sequence of the Perfection of Wisdom sūtras; one large term in it is rendered by approximation, and I have not fixed its exact

numerical value. Because Subhūti is first named without his full honorific here, "Subhūti" in the opening line follows the earlier established name.

In the translation body, one spelling slipped: "Kauschika" in the seventh paragraph should read "Kauśika" throughout.

- The passage runs from the end of chapter 27 into the beginning of the twenty-second section. The Tibetan makes the six hundred thousand monks (dge slong brgya phrag drug cu) a large number. Their name in the future, Spread of Flowers, is rendered from the Tibetan me tog bkram pa. The text breaks off mid-sentence in the following piece, which continues with the equality of their lifespans.
- The long list of verbs for holding, reading, teaching and memorizing the sūtra is repeated in the Tibetan with small variations, and is rendered here accordingly. The phrase "at the least in writing" translates the Tibetan "ཡིག་ཀློང་ལ་ཡིག་ཀློང་ལ་", which I understand as "even if only by writing it down."
- In the Tibetan, "the Victors" in the opening paragraph stands for the buddhas of the past. The instructions in the closing sentences are imperatives addressed to Ānanda, by the Blessed One, who is understood to be the speaker throughout. The next piece continues the same series of injunctions.
- The Tibetan breaks off mid-sentence at the end ("...and asks about it,"); the sentence continues in the next piece, so I have left it open. The phrase "this is my final instruction" renders འགྲུབ་ཀྱི་འཇུག་པའི་འཇུག་པའི་, which could also be read as "my subsequent teaching." The final run of numerals for eons is rendered with approximate values, as the Tibetan numerals there are idiomatic.
- The opening sentence continues from the previous piece, so "it" refers to the Perfection of Wisdom there. In the Tibetan, "mi zad pa" modifies the treasury of the Dharma, and I have kept it so. The source has a few minor orthographic slips, such as "gdon" for "'don" and "byung par gyur pa" for "byung bar gyur pa"; I read them as the intended standard forms.
- The terms for short durations (nyi ma, snga dro, chu tshod, yud tsam, thang cig, skad cig) are rendered as day, morning, hour, brief while, moment, instant, a descending scale; the exact units are approximate. The phrase "the work of a śrāvaka" translates the Tibetan idiom of fulfilling a śrāvaka's task.
- The Tibetan uses "dgos pa byed nus pa" for "capacity to perform a function"; I read it as the ability to accomplish a purpose. The listing of arhat qualities follows the standard formula. In the first paragraph, "think upon" renders "sems pa", meaning those who reflect on or contemplate such roots of virtue.
- The phrase "equal to the unequal" renders the Tibetan literally (mi mnyam pa dang mnyam pa), the standard epithet "equal to the unequalled." "Unfathomable" renders gzhal du med pa, which can also be rendered "immeasurable"; I used "unfathomable" to avoid repeating the word.
- The statement about the present buddha ("the present Tathāgata") follows the Tibetan literally; it likely refers to the Buddha himself, who is speaking. In the chain of dependent origination, the Tibetan lists "feeling" a second time after "contact," as in the standard twelve links, so I have kept the repetition.
- The sentence "this attention and this skillful means" refers back to the practice of viewing dependent origination through inexhaustibility; the Tibetan "འཇགས་ཀྱི་འཇགས་ཀྱི་" is rendered as "attention" (Skt. manasikāra). The final sentence is cut off by the piece boundary; it continues into the list of dependent-origination links in the next piece.
- The passage ends in mid-sentence ("brings to completion the cultivation of all skillful means"), which is a cut between pieces, not damage in the source. Māra is written in the plural ("Māras the Evil One") where the text asks about many Māras, following the text's own usage.

- The phrase སྐྱོད་པ་ལྟ་བུ་ལྟོག་པ་ is rendered as a "snap of the fingers," following the common sense of the idiom. The phrase rendered "fortunate-lacking condition" (འཕྲོད་པ་ལྟོག་པ་) is uncertain in this context; it may refer to an unfavorable birth lacking opportunity for the Dharma.
- Gandhahastin renders the Tibetan "spos kyi glang po" (literally "Incense Elephant"). The line about the arhat is taken to mean that all phenomena are pure by nature, as a noble arhat is pure. The phrase on laying down the burden follows the standard image of the arhat who has put down the burden. "Definitively distinguished" is a literal reading of "nges par 'byed pa."
- The phrase rendered "Brahmā-like" translates the Tibetan འཕྲོད་པ་ལྟོག་པ་, literally "having become Brahmā" or "become holy"; I read it as a figurative expression of the purity and peacefulness of all phenomena. The phrase "like medicine" follows the Tibetan literally. The word འཕྲོད་པ་ལྟོག་པ་ is rendered "wishless" in the triad of emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness, and "without wishes" in the later parallel line.
- The Tibetan "mu med pa" (without limit, boundless) is used throughout; I rendered it as "without limit" or "the limitless." In the lion's-roar sentence the Tibetan is elliptical, and I kept it close to the source. The last line ends the piece, and the continuation for feeling and the other aggregates follows in the next piece.
- The phrase འཕྲོད་པ་ལྟོག་པ་ལྟོག་པ་ is rendered "boundless absorption" and འཕྲོད་པ་ elsewhere as "boundless." The statement that form "extends to the virtuous, the non-virtuous, and the unapprehendable" is a literal rendering of a terse phrase. The final clause about abandoning "all beings" is taken as the Tibetan states it, meaning giving up clinging to beings as objects of attachment. The opening of the next chapter names the bodhisattva Sadāprarudita (Ever-Weeping) in a sentence that continues into the next piece.
- Sadāprarudita is the standard Sanskrit name for "Ever-Weeping" (rtag tu ngu), the bodhisattva's name in this chapter; I used the Sanskrit as a proper name. The Tibetan text has a few irregular spellings (for example "rtag tu ngu sngon" and "rtag tu ngus") that I took as the same name. "The view of the perishable collection" renders 'jig tshogs (satkāyadṛṣṭi), and the clause about not stirring from it is as in the Tibetan.
- The ending is unusual: "pass a day and a night" follows the Tibetan. The name Sadāprarudita (Tibetan rtag tu ngu) is not spelled out in this piece, since the Tibetan gives only the epithet "ever weeping" (rtag tu ngus); I used the standard Sanskrit name, as the Tibetan renders it. In the quotation of the voice's instruction, I have taken the opening lines as the bodhisattva's resolve and the rest as the instruction continuing.
- The phrase about the "low-lying ground" and the ring of precious substances around the city is obscure in the Tibetan; I have kept it literal. Likewise "five hundred who dwell there free of envy" omits a head noun in the Tibetan, and I have not supplied one.
- The passage is a piece cut from within a longer description. The names of the groves and ponds are rendered literally, as they appear to be descriptive names, not standard Indian proper names. "A cry's distance" renders a unit of measure (krośa, the distance a shout carries). The mansion's owner is Dharmodgata (Tibetan chos 'phags, "Noble Dharma"), identified by the standard name of the teacher in this chapter; the city is Gandhavatī, here rendered "Fragrant."
- The piece ends mid-sentence ("go, and"); the next piece completes it. The Tibetan names the bodhisattva Chos 'phags, rendered Dharmodgata (the usual Sanskrit name, Dharmodgata). The city is Spos Idan, rendered Gandhavatī; it appears only in the text itself as "the city" before this passage, so I gave the Sanskrit name where the Tibetan has it. The Tibetan "rgyang grags phyed" in the canopy passage is rendered "half a bowshot," a standard measure; the exact sense of the passage describing the awning and its being "well fixed" is slightly obscure in the source, and I have given the plainest reading.

- [illegible]

[illegible]

- Sumeru (सुमेरु) "varied" is rendered as the Tibetan stands; some Sanskrit witnesses may differ. "The sameness of phenomena is like a vajra" is the literal reading of the text. The clause on destruction (संनिवृत्तिस्तथावस्थामनुसृत्य) is rendered literally as it appears.
- The line near the end beginning "It was just as I now..." is spoken by the Buddha, and I have kept it in the first person as in the Tibetan. The "thirty-first chapter" colophon is as given in the source, though the chapter then continues with the next section.
- The final sentence breaks off mid-sentence because the passage ends where the piece ends; the next piece continues with the assembly's response. The first sentence refers back to the person described in the preceding passage, who is the subject throughout. The lines "Ānanda, this is my instruction" and "Ānanda, what do you think?" follow the Tibetan phrasing closely.
- The colophon's place names are rendered by sound where I could not identify an Indian original: Nyethang Nemoché, Kyi Mé, and Rasgreng. Drom Gyalwé Jungné is the translator Dromtönpa Gyalwé Jungné. Tashi Lhadé Tsen is the Tibetan king Trashi Lhadé Tsen. The "Central Land" (Madhyadeśa) is central India, as a source of manuscripts. The colophon refers to "three Indian sūtra manuscripts"; the phrase could also be read as three Indian sūtra texts.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.